Exploits of Power

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/28966512.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
Major Character Death

Category:
F/F

Fandoms:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018), Harry Potter - J. K. Rowling

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Mara (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Pining, Alternate Universe - Harry Potter Setting, dark Catra, Dark Adora, Blood, Violence, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner's A+ Parenting

Language:
English

Series:
Part 2 of Exploits of Power

Stats:
Published: 2021-01-24 Completed: 2023-01-22 Words: 131,808 Chapters: 22/22

Exploits of Power

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/28966512.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
Major Character Death

Category:
F/F

Fandoms:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018), Harry Potter - J. K. Rowling

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Mara (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Pining, Alternate Universe - Harry Potter Setting, dark Catra, Dark Adora, Blood, Violence, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner's A+ Parenting

Language:
English

Series:
Part 2 of Exploits of Power

Stats:
Published: 2021-01-24 Completed: 2023-01-22 Words: 131,808 Chapters: 22/22

Exploits of Power

by Drawinganimemaster

Summary

Three members of the golden quartet take the Floo Network out of London after Adora is put on Holiday after a trying case she's been working. Bow and Adora thought it wise to warn the unsuspecting party, but Glimmer doesn't want to take no for an answer, and so, that's how Catra spills her wine at the door—shocked, and bewildered—as Glimmer shoves her way into Catra's flat in New York with a sheepish Bow and Adora in tow.

And Catra thought the Americans were the dramatic ones.

Harry Potter AU (post graduation)

How Longs it Been...?

0

Downtown in some leaky alleyway on the upper west side in England isn't where Adora thought she was going to be spending her Friday night; with all the tourist attractions, roaring traffic on the streets and sidewalks, Adora is surprised when her suspect breaks into a sprint giving her quite the chase. And of course she can't use any magic to clip him at his heels or stun him with a hex because she can't risk the muggles bearing witness—she's also on the job and doubts Mara will be forgiving if Adora drops another incident report on her desk which will result in the Obliviator team to do some memory fixing. Mara trained Adora to become an Auror but favoritism can only get her so far. So Adora keeps her wand in the holder sewn into her coat lapel and doesn't whip it out until she backs him into a dead end alley on the edgier part of town.

"Stop!" Adora shouts, aiming her wand at his back. Light shines from the crooked tip of her wand, she can easily see it fight off the dark as she stares down the jagged lines of the beech wood. The man stops, having no choice but to because of the brick wall blocking his path—the natural red hue has wilted overtime and is clearly visible under the cheap paint job. Adora walks closer until she is just five feet away. She demands, "turn around and keep your hands where I can see them."

"...you think you've got me caught?"

Adora grits her teeth. She doesn't have the time or the patience for small talk. Her legs are all but throbbing, being a witch has made her daft to the muggle myth that is exercise. "I know I do. And so do you, it's why you're trying to stall...you think you can waste time for your back up to arrive but my Auror's are circling our location as we speak. No one is getting in or out of here, not even for a bloody roll of tissue, so just give it up so I can clock out."

“You sound confident.” There should be a hint of humor, maybe a small lift to his voice, but the tone never changes—it remains passive, eerily so. The effect of his voice causes the hair on her neck to stand on end but what makes her wary is the fact that he still hasn’t turned around; instead, he speaks to her while staring at the wall with his limp arms swaying to the tides of the wind. He says, “maybe you’re allowed a bit of confidence...I know who you are. You’re the best beater in Gryffindor history, you were one of the hell raisers for poor Angela who was just trying to do her best as the Headmistress back when you went to Hogwarts...you’re a member of the golden quartet, you took on Lord Prime and so you are deemed as the girl who lived...Adora Grayskull.”

“So you’ve picked up a newspaper. Still going to need you to come with me.” Adora wishes he’d make a move so she can finish him with a lethal blow but, again, lots of paperwork for Mara. “Next time don’t try stealing from someone who works in the Ministry of Magic.”

“...a bit much, yes...but a huge part of the plan.”

Adora can’t stop the curiosity that causes her throat to bubble and then spit out a question. “You broke into an Unspeakable's flat. Did you really think she would tell you anything? She swore a vow that can never be unbound.”

“There are ways.”

Adora’s heart spikes. She bites the tip of her wand into his back and growls. “Don’t even try it, I’ll have you locked up in the coldest cell in Azkaban where the Dementors get the most rowdy if you ever—“

“It’s already been done.”

Adora snaps at the invisible work protocol ties that have been holding her back. She spins him around with her free hand with a spell ready on her tongue but she falters. “What the…”

His face tilts to the side with a grin that splits across his face, stretching his chapped lips so much that blood slips from the cracks and spills into his mouth. And his *eyes* . She should have noticed the magic radiating off him before but her senses are seemingly dulled by a powerful force. Adora staggers back a step, stunned with shame and disgust when she realizes his eyes are glazed over.

Adora recollects herself. "I will find you," she promises before whispering a spell to remove the Imperius curse from the unsuspecting victim. The glaze subsides, leaving behind unnatural black that soon fades into whimsical blue—his face and body begins to contort as the Polyjuice potion wears off as well. Adora leans him against the wall for her junior Auror's to deal with while she apparates back to the loft.

She lands on a pile of garbage bags tossed out in the backyard, it's not her best apparate but she doesn't see any splinching so it's deemed good enough. Adora runs to the front. The door is unlocked. She keeps her wand ready but nothing prepares her for the pungent metallic smell that punches her in the face when she cracks the door open. Her knees wobble, and suddenly she feels faint—it has nothing to do with her lack of exercise. Bile races up her throat but she forces it down...she can't disturb the crime scene.

"Lonnie...no," her voice cracks at the weight of the name. Lying on the white carpeted floor is Lonnie; an old friend, somewhat of a sister, who lived at the orphanage with her as a child before they all got drafted to attend Hogwarts. She hadn't kept in touch with Lonnie after the war but she heard through the Ministry grapevine that Lonnie was thinking of becoming an unspeakable for the Ministry of Magic's Department of Mysteries; an esteemed job...and now Adora's looking at where it got her. On her back surrounded by a pool of her own blood, eyes stripped of life, with her throat slit open from a vicious spell.

It's almost poetic , a sick part of her thinks. Unspeakables are hush-hush about their work so for him to strike the finishing blow

at her throat...Whoever did this, he wants to leave a message. He wants Adora to know that he got whatever answers he needed from Lonnie, and it cost her life.

Upstairs, a floorboard creaks. Fueled by anger, Adora races up the spiral staircase towards the noise. It leads her to a hall closet on the second floor. She rips the door open, almost taking the knob off, and aims her wand at whoever is foolish enough to think she'd let them out alive after what they did to Lonnie. A spell slips and tumbles to a halt—the words get stuck on her tongue, she closes her mouth as shame, once again, tickles at her throat.

Little Lucy, three years old going on four, is backed into the farthest corner of the closet with her knees tucked into her chest. Little Lucy who Kyle probably takes time out of his busy schedule with to have tea parties with, who Rogelio probably taught how to ride a bike, who Lonnie—

"...auntie 'Dora?" Lucy sounds lost, innocent, and afraid all at once. She looks up, squinting at the sudden light. Lucy must recognize Adora's face from the old group photographs taken after the war; she shakes at the thought of Lucy's parents telling Lucy about her while Adora wasn't concerned for them one bit in all their years apart. "Where's my mum?"

Adora tucks her wand behind her back and falls to her knees and engulf Lucy in a hug. She stays with the girl until Mara arrives with a few Auror's and an Obliviator. The Obliviator alters Lucy's memory of the night, keeping the real one tucked away in a vial for the investigation while the Auror's take record of the murder scene. By the time Kyle and Rogelio floo into their loft Adora makes herself scarce.

No one tells them she was the one working the case.

"...even listening."

Adora blinks out of her seeping darkness and finds herself back at the office with Mara looking at her across from her desk with worried eyes. Adora clears her throat. “I’m sorry come again?”

Mara throws a folder on her desk with a heavy sigh. She leans back in her comfy office chair and examines her best student. Adora wants to apologize for wasting her time on a hubris driven Auror who got an old friend killed because of a job that should’ve been another textbook case. “Adora. This isn’t your fault.”

“I should’ve known.”

“With any other case I would agree, but my team retraced your steps and they couldn’t detect any dark magic from when he would have cast the Imperius curse. We’re dealing with someone who can move undetected. It makes it harder for us to catch him, but you were the one who noticed his activity in town so you should be proud.”

“Proud.” Adora mutters in disdain.

Mara frowns. “I know this is hard...Lonnie was an old friend to you and even knew her partners but try not to worry. They’ll catch the man who did this.”

Adora sits up. “What do you mean... *they* ? You’re taking me off the case? You can’t!”

“You’re too close to this, Adora.” Mara raises her hands. “And no one is taking you off the case.”

“Then why…”

“Our suspect was seen walking the streets of New York City just a couple minutes ago.” Mara gestures to the file she threw on her desk. Adora picks it up and scans it even as Mara sums up the majority of the details. “We don’t know what his magic signature is so we can’t be alerted when it turns up in the system and so he managed to use the Floo Network and escape us.”

Adora shakes her head. “We can still—“

“He’s in America now. Out of our jurisdiction.” Mara sighs. “We have no choice but to trust the Americans.”

“ *Americans* ?” Adora makes a face. “But they’re dreadful, the lot of them, frying anything with a pulse and serving it as a high class meal.”

Mara smiles for a brief moment. “They have a great group of Auror’s in New York. A few of them graduated from Hogwarts, I trained them myself, so when I say they are going to catch him you better believe me.”

There isn’t much else she can do so Adora gets up. She asks, “will you at least inform me with any updates?”

Mara nods. “I’ll send over some paper clippings from the states whenever a case is made. But in the meantime, get some rest. You’re getting assigned to a new case starting tomorrow. I have some junior Auror’s who could use some help.”

“Translation?” Adora asks.

“They can’t lead their way out of a brown paper bag.”

Mara gives her the rundown on the idiot junior Auror’s she’ll be working with tomorrow before letting her go with not even a slap on the wrist for breaking protocol and leaving a civilian, slowly coming out of the influence he was in, alone in an alleyway. Adora deserves to be reprimanded for what she’s done, Mara shouldn’t have been the one to speak with her; it should have been Micah—the Minister of Magic himself—to land the finishing blow. Adora didn’t even have the courage to face Kyle and Rogelio, she hid her face like a coward, she was too arrogant and let herself get distracted and it was enough time for—

Alcohol. Adora needs a lot of alcohol to make it through this night.

She makes it to her flat in Paddington around 1 o'clock in the morning. The building is five stories with only a few occupants on each floor so she doesn't have to worry about a busy elevator as she takes it all the way up to the penthouse: and it is in no way a luxurious flat, a nice wide open space with room to fit her bed and space for a kitchen but not much furniture because Adora likes to keep clutter out just in case she needs to relocate for work. She once went an entire month without coming home; she was running down a lead a couple towns over and it just made sense to stay close to the action without risking the suspect following her home.

Adora leaves her shoes at the door and puts up her protective wards before going for the liquor cabinet. She doesn't even know what it is, something with a dark amber hue, she thinks maybe Glimmer bought it for her years ago when she first moved in, but it doesn't stop her from cradling it into her living space. She pops the cork and takes big gulps. It burns going down. Adora drinks until her mind wanders to better days when she was the *chosen one* at Hogwarts, when everyone kissed the ground she walked on —except for a select few: Bow and Glimmer were always good friends who saw behind the mystic the school built around her. Them and…

In her liquor induced state, Adora scrambles to dig through her bedside drawer for the handheld two-way mirror she has kept tucked away for years. She hasn't used this thing since she got into Hogwarts. Back when she got into Gryffindor with no choice that was her own. It was something that cost her best friend and it was of no fault of her own but it took time for her to realize it. And while they eventually did make up (having to save the world together will do that) Adora hasn't spoken to Catra with this thing since they were kids—she doubts Catra even has her piece—so she doubts she'll answer.

"Hey Catra…" she sighs as she sinks down to her wood floor with her back pressed against the side of her bed. "You probably threw this thing away...probably a good thing if you don't respond to this

but, fuck, I've had a shitty day and the only person I want to talk to is—"

"Adora?"

"Catra?" She shoots back. Her mouth is dropping to the floor as the one and only hell raiser from Hogwarts, the final edition of the golden quartet, Catra D'riluth stares at her from the other side with a baffled expression. It's been a little over six months since Adora's seen her, they're both busy with work, so forgive her if she's at a loss for words at the beautiful woman Catra has become overnight. No, not overnight. Adora has seen first hand the evolution of Catra's maturity; the sharpening or her jaw (and wit), the wisdom in those mismatched eyes, and so much more she's written about in her diary (turns out she never hated Catra, but she was a bit obsessed).

Catra smirks. "Are you drunk right now?"

"...no." Adora's tongue suddenly fails her, making her words come out runny like the egg she had for breakfast.

"Merlin's beard you are." Catra looks impressed. "I never thought you'd drunk dial me."

"What does a bar of soap have to do with this?"

Catra rubs at her tired eyes. "Sorry, I've been hanging around a lot of muggles these days. Work related. They have these phones that they use instead of mirrors and owls. It's actually a huge waste of time, I swear, they have all these pointless apps...but I'm angrily ranting at you. Are you okay?"

Adora shakes her head.

"Do you want to talk about it?"

"I picked up the mirror didn't I?" Adora frowns. "Didn't think you'd answer."

“Didn’t think you’d call. I keep a piece of the mirror in my wallet just in case.”

“Really?” Adora’s stomach flutters.

Catra looks away. “I mean, obviously. The last time I didn’t answer you almost got eaten by a werewolf. Good thing Bow and Glimmer were there.” She looks back at her with a frown. “Don’t they live close by? You should get them before you do something stupid.”

“I just want to talk to you.”

A soft look comes across Catra’s face. “Okay.” Something green flashes behind Catra. It’s some kind of spell, a powerful one, because suddenly Catra’s pupils are dilated—she always gets excited by exploits of strong magic. It makes her itch for a fight.

“Where are you?” Adora asks.

“Nowhere important.” Catra looks at something over her mirror, and if Adora wasn’t absolutely out of it right now she would ask if anyone was with her but Catra is looking back at her again so her worry ebbs away. “I’d floo over but I’m in between flats at the moment.”

“It’s okay.”

Catra whispers, “you said something about a bad day.”

It’s Adora’s turn to look away.

“That bad?”

Adora tells Catra just how bad this night has been. The rest of the night is blurry; but Adora ends up falling asleep on the couch with the mirror tucked between her arms after Catra wakes her up a couple times when she drifts between consciousness on the floor.

“I had it handled.”

“You knocked Victor out with a stunning hex at a muggle bar in front of dozens of people *after* you apparated in!” Mara’s shouting at her for doing a poor, borderline horrific job, and all Adora can think is *good, someone should have yelled at me weeks ago.* Mara rubs her temple and plops back into her chair. “This is going to be a nightmare for the Obliviator team.”

Adora crosses her arms. “Those junior Auror’s couldn’t keep up, Victor nearly slipped from our fingers a dozen times because they weren’t battle ready.”

“Adora...you were being reckless. And the only reason I’m not reporting this incident to Micah is because he has known you since you went to Hogwarts and you’re best friends with his daughter so I doubt he’ll do anything rash and because of what happened to Lonnie. You were too connected to that case.”

“I should’ve been there to save her.”

“We can’t save everyone, Adora.” Mara sighs. “I’m putting you on paid Holiday—“

“What?”

“Just for three weeks, and then we’ll have a councilor check your mental state before you’re allowed back in the field.”

Adora huffs. “I can’t believe this. What am I supposed to do for three weeks?”

Mara gets up and gently guides Adora to the door. “Take up gardening maybe? Muggles say plants are good for the human condition. Or you can spend time with your friends. Maybe check up on Hogwarts to see what your professors are up to; they might be willing to let you teach a demonstration to their class.” Mara perks up. “And what about that girl you brought to my Holiday party a while back? Catra, right? Maybe you should finally make a move and stop acting daft.”

Adora flushes from head to toe and splutters. “We’re not...Catra is...we’re just friends.”

“Whatever the case may be, get some rest.”

Adora sulks back to her flat after basically getting kicked out of Mara’s office. She tries to take Mara’s advice but relaxing isn’t something she’s known for. But she grabs the daily paper and makes a cup of tea, it tastes nothing like the brew Perfuma would make for them back at school but it soothes her throat in a way alcohol never could.

She skims the news until one caption catches her attention.

The Times: Midnight Burglar Flees From the Scene

The line of recent burglaries that have haunted our cities have ceased. According to an anonymous picture brought to our attention it appears the suspect has taken up refuge in New York City. The picture matches the assailants description and not long after the picture was taken a series of burglaries have occurred in Manhattan…

The rest doesn’t matter. All that matters is Adora’s seen his face before—she wasted time backing an innocent civilian in an alley just because they wore his face. He’s going to regret showing it to her once she—

“ *Squawk!* ” Glimmer’s owl, Glitter (somehow Catra’s name stuck), flies in through her window and drops a letter on her lap. Glitter looks up at her expectantly with her large brown eyes. Adora grabs a slice of bread from the kitchen and breaks it up into smaller pieces for Glitter to nibble on while she opens the letter.

Adora,

Don’t be livid but, Mara told us she put you on Holiday for a couple weeks. You’re joining Bow and I for dinner at our flat tonight, 7 o’clock sharp. Don’t say you’re busy with work because we all know that’s a lie.

And bring wine!

Love Glimmer.

Adora doesn't send a letter back but she does get her shoes back on so she can head to the store for a bottle of red wine.

At 7 o'clock Bow almost knocks her to the ground with the force of his hug. "Adora! It's been ages."

"Hey Bow," she wheezes into the crook of his shoulder. He pulls away with a sheepish look but keeps his arm wrapped around her as he ushers her inside. Their flat is just as she remembered, almost identical to hers but there is a homey feeling about it like it's actually been lived in. There are various photographs of Bow and Glimmer together, some apart, and some with their friends and family. She passes a vintage photograph taken at Hogwarts with the golden quartet tangled up in a hug, their clothes are soaked with soot and their faces are littered with scars; it was taken right after the final battle with Prime so the school is in ruins behind them but somehow they found a moment of peace.

"She's arrived." Bow says, feeding Adora to the beast and leaving her to fend for herself. Glimmer sets aside the big spoon she was using to stir the pot on the cooker. Glimmer wraps her in a hug just as quickly as she pulls back to flick her forehead.

Adora winces. "Bloody hell, Glimmer!"

"You work too much."

"I'm here aren't I?" Adora snaps.

"Only because we dragged you by your feet and you've got nothing better to do now that Mara's put you on the bench." Glimmer takes a spoonful from the pot and carries it over to Adora. It's Chicken Tikka Masala, she can tell by the rich smell and

the orangey color. “Taste this, let me know what you think. I might have left it on too long.”

Adora takes the spoon and tries it. She makes a show of tasting the curry on her tongue. She concludes, “it’s a bit naff…”

“You arse.” Glimmer snatches the spoon with a huff. “Go settle down, supper should be finished soon.”

Adora leaves the kitchen to help Bow set the table despite his protest; they get everything set up quickly as they work together and soon Glimmer is centering the main dish and handing out wine glasses. Adora wants to fill her glass to the brim but fights the urge to do so by shoveling Shepard’s pie in her mouth. Adora eating everything in her path is normal—safe—so Bow and Glimmer don’t question it. If Catra were here she’d notice Adora’s shifty eyes that glance at her wine glass throughout the night.

“So?” Adora mutters into her napkin as she dabs at her mouth. “What’ve you two been up to? Any interesting cases?”

Bow grins, he shoots over the table like he’s waited for someone to bring up his work. “You’ll never believe what Glimmer and I found in the Mediterranean…” he goes on about an exciting story about a trio of sirens his team discovered.

Bow is a freelance magical creatures breeder. When he isn’t breeding for local witches and wizards he explores the world in search of rare magical creatures that are at risk of being extinct and then moves them to a secure location so repopulation can occur naturally. Glimmer is an investigator, she works cases involving magical creatures, so her work lines up with Bow’s quite a lot. The sirens Bow ran into were actually destroying boats, when a questionable amount began washing up on the beach Glimmer and her team of investigators were sent out to scope the scenes. She ran into Bow at the docks and they decided to complete the case together; they hadn’t seen each other in a couple days so it worked out well.

Bow continues, “they get a bad reputation but they’re actually lovely creatures.”

Glimmer nods. “It’s not their fault they were cursed all those years ago.”

“So you just let them go?” Adora asks. “Despite all the things they’ve done? All the people they’ve killed.”

Glimmer sighs. “It’s complicated. The Ministry knows the sirens have little control over their actions but there’s also no known way to reverse the spell so we can’t just let them go. The people in the big office will probably send them to the Bermuda triangle but I swear one day that place is going to be overpopulated. We need a better solution.”

“We have all this magic but can’t cure a curse.” Bow shakes his head. “This is making me sad. Can we talk about something else?”

Glimmer hesitates. “This’ll probably make you even sadder…”

Bow takes a hefty sip of wine.

“...but can we talk about the elephant in the room?” Glimmer looks at her with worry seeping from the sems. “Mara put you on Holiday a few weeks after Lonnie’s murder...I know you grew up with her so it must’ve been hard for you. Why didn’t you reach out to us?”

Adora grabs her wine but doesn’t drink just yet. “I was still processing.”

“Do you know which Auror’s were put on the case? Maybe they can give you some closure. They’ve probably caught the person who did it by now.”

Adora takes a sip of wine and then swiftly says, “no...I don’t, wish I did but sometimes Auror’s are worse than Unspeakables, you know? And even if they did catch the person who did it, they don’t broadcast it in the papers when the death involves someone in

the Ministry. It would cause a panic if the public knew how easy it is for someone in such a high power to be taken out." Glimmer likely learned about Lonnie's death from Micah but not because he wanted to tell her but because he was worried about Adora's wellbeing.

Glimmer looks solemn all of a sudden, probably thinking about Micah, and his job as the Minister of Magic, and all the secrets he has to keep from his family. After a short pause she mutters, "I get it."

Adora marvels at herself while Bow places a comforting hand atop Glimmer's. Adora remembers there being a time where she was a terrible liar.

"Moving on to a less dreary subject," Bow says, "I ran into Catra a few weeks ago."

Adora almost spills her wine. "Really? Where?"

"New Zealand." Bow laughs at her baffled expression. "I know! It was so random. I was chasing down a lead on some poachers who were hunting a magical creature we've never dealt with before. The two guys split up so I chased one of them into a corner down by the quarry. Let the record show, I could've taken him out but I was taking extra precaution because of the neighboring town a few miles down when Catra stuns the guy with a nasty hex—out of nowhere!

"She told me she was doing New Zealand's Ministry a favor because they were short on Obliviators and she happened to be there. She said she stopped for some lunch when she felt an invisible force breeze past her on the street. She followed it to the quarry and saw me backed into a corner, helped me tackle the rest of the poachers and followed the magical energy while I stood back to wait for the investigators to arrive. Catra said the magic called out to her; turns out, we discovered a new species of Kryten. They shift to take the form of those they imprint on,

relaying their hosts emotions through their appearance—they even turn invisible when they feel threatened!

"Melog is the last of its kind, as they know of, Catra seems to be the only one who can communicate with them for now. Melog said a lot of their kind got scattered across the globe when the wizards took over and hunted them for their personal gain. Melog was so fond of Catra the investigators took down whatever information they could and let Catra leave with them. Wasn't much we could do when Melog was raging at anyone who tried to take them away from her. So, long story short, Catra has a familiar now and it takes on the form of a cute Tom-cat."

Adora can imagine the chaos Melog is wrecking in Catra's life. She laughs so hard her stomach starts to burn. "It only took her what...eleven years for her to find a familiar who can handle her attitude."

Bow whispers, "and guess what else."

Adora doesn't hazard a guess, Catra is wonderfully unpredictable, but she does raise a questionable brow.

"She's living in America now."

Adora chokes out, " *what* ?"

Bow throws his head back and laughs. "I know, right? I can't imagine her there either but...you know Catra, she can pretty much adjust to anything."

Adora looks down at her unfinished meal. She asked for seconds but during Bow's telling of his encounter with Catra her plate grew cold from the draft leaking through the kitchen window—the steam long gone. Adora mutters, "I didn't know that."

"It's not a permanent address," Bow says softly. "I don't know if she did it or not but, back when I last saw her in New Zealand, she told me she was stepping away from being an Obliviator...she mentioned becoming an Unspeakable."

Glimmer shivers. “After what happened to Lonnie? Is she mental?”

“She said she’s sick of getting to the party late.” Bow confesses, “she’s tired of seeing all those bad memories, being forced to relive them like she was actually there, said it’s hell not being able to change them because...it’s too late. I’ve never considered the work that goes into being an Obliviator but it makes sense that the memories being altered or destroyed are so dreadful someone would want her to literally extract them. It takes its toll.”

Adora looks into her wine glass—a flashback of Lonnie’s blood seeping into the white carpet shoves past her subconscious—she swirls the dark liquid until the memory fades, and then drinks the leftovers until the metallic taste is burned off her tongue. But it continues to linger like an ill smell.

Bow continues. “It’s a dangerous job but it makes sense, if she’s out on the field at least she’ll have a chance at stopping the events that can lead to the memories that haunt her the worst.”

“It’s admirable,” Adora whispers to herself. It isn’t low enough; Bow and Glimmer are giving her knowing looks. Adora huffs, “what?”

Glimmer grins. “You’re smitten.”

“This again…” Adora pours herself another glass.

“Yes. Again. And it will continue to be until I’m allowed to tell this story at your and Catra’s wedding.” Glimmer throws her hands up. “You two have been tiptoeing around this since you were first years!”

“We’re just friends.” Adora fails to mention the love confession she and Catra shared when they thought Adora was on her deathbed only for her to be resurrected by such love and given the power to finish Prime once and for all. But it’s irrelevant, it has to be— why else hasn’t Catra brought it up in the last three years? In her defence, Adora can attribute their busy work schedules to the lack of communication but not to the multiple slips they’ve had; like

making out in Perfuma's spare bedroom during game night, or hooking up on the beach during a joint vacation right after graduation, and...the list goes on. "Friends," she repeats with a shiver.

"Since we're all such good friends," Glimmer says "we should surprise Catra with a visit."

Adora flinches. "She hates surprises."

"I'm gonna have to side with Adora on this one. Remember what she did to Sea Hawk's face when we tried to throw her a surprise birthday party? And we don't even know her address."

Glimmer holds up a worn mitten. She shrugs. "Locator spell."

Adora blinks. "Why...why do you even have—"

"Then it's settled!" Glimmer stands up with a maniac smile. "Best friend squad reunion!"

Miles away, somewhere across the country, Catra accidentally breaks a vintage wine glass. She waves a hand to silently piece the shattered glass back together but when she holds it up there is a piece missing. Catra stares at the jagged crack left behind and then turns to Melog who is lounging in the windowsill after the daunting day they've both had.

Catra mutters, "I have a bad feeling about tonight."

2

Glimmer insists on them leaving as soon as possible. "When is the last time we just dropped everything and went on a little trip?"

"When Prime sent his Dementors to—"

“Rhetorical Bow.” Glimmer says, “but the correct answer would’ve been when we were at Hogwarts. Now we’re old and in our twenties playing the role of the boring adults. We’re so focused on work we don’t really do anything spontaneous anymore.”

Bow drops their bags at the door, frowning. “I work as a breeder for magical beasts, *you* investigate crimes they commit, Adora takes down the most lethal criminals, and Catra...she’s an unspeakable so who knows what she’s up to. Spontaneity isn’t an issue for us, love.”

“I hate when you’re right.” Glimmer deflates. “I just...I miss us all being together. Those two are always working and you and I get lucky when our cases align. I want to pretend, just for a little while, that things are the way they used to be...but, you know, the time frame where Catra stopped hating us and became our best friend and not the one where she made me throw up slugs.”

Bow stifles his laugh and hugs her. “We’re all here. We’re not going anywhere.”

In her bedroom Adora swiftly folds the newspaper she enchanted to show magical news about what’s happening in Manhattan. On the front page is the exact same picture of the man she chased down the alley way a couple weeks back. Adora places the news clipping into a safe, placing protective wards on it, before slipping it beneath a secret compartment under her floorboard.

“Adora!” Glimmer shouts from downstairs, “are you ready?”

Adora rushes down the steps without a hair out of place. She smiles. “No need to yell, I’m right here Glimmer. Are we good to go?”

Bow nods. “Car’s out front.”

“This is going to be a great vacation for all of us.” Glimmer squeals. “I can’t wait to try American cuisine. I want those fried Oreos I’ve heard so much about. And you,” she points a menacing finger at Adora “...you are not allowed to focus on work.” Adora holds her hands out with a sheepish smile.

“Of course not.”

It’s getting harder for Adora to believe there was ever a time she thought herself to be a terrible liar.

Coming to America

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

0

Drip, drip, drip… the noise brings Catra to the brink of anger, but it does not drive her mad—it only delivers the finishing blow. She grips her wand so hard she worries about it splintering, but it's a foolish thought cultivated by her overzealous pride because, no, Blackthorn wands do not bend easily. Especially not at her ungodly hand. She takes a single step—moments away from letting loose on the unconventional warlock who she is trying to pry information out of—when she hears an Angel's voice. Calm washes over her.

"...there?"

Catra digs out the piece of the two-way mirror she keeps tucked in her wallet. She smiles, sharp fangs and all, as she finds Adora's surprised, tentative, smile. It's goofy, and completely moronic, and so Adora; she's still shocked that Catra has their two-way mirror they used so many years ago to escape the world.

"Hey, Adora." Catra flirts a bit, glancing at the warlock who is tied up at the moment before giving Adora her full attention. Catra waves her hand blindly, casting a silencing spell on the warlock when she hears him struggle to croak out words that get lost in the blood that's spilling out his mouth.

"What was that?"

"Just my cat. They got into something nasty." Catra says. "What's going on? This isn't another drunk call, right?" Not that she's complaining. It was interesting to see Adora in her playful bout—it's been absent these past few years—but, ever since the eventful night, they have made a habit of talking through their mirrors. Not

about anything serious, just to chat about their days or to complain about work.

Adora makes a face that wrinkles up her brow. “You have a cat?”

“...it’s a long story.” It is. It also involves Bow, and a new species of magical creatures that may or may not be extinct, and Catra is not in the mood to delve into it. Plus, she’s worried about Adora getting sullen about her spending time with Bow instead of her; like they made a trip of meeting each other in New Zealand to hang out behind her back. It’s a dramatic conclusion to draw but Catra hasn’t eaten since noon and she has a grudge to carry out with her captured prisoner.

“I am very curious, but I don’t have time for a long story right now.”

Catra sighs, relieved. “Oh? Do my stories bore you? I am wounded.”

“Nothing to do with you.” Adora mutters, “Glimmer is forcing me to have dinner with her and Bow tonight.”

“The horror.”

“I’m serious.”

“So am I. The last time I had one of Glimmer’s meals I was stuck on the loo for—“

Adora cuts her off quick. “I remember.”

“A cautionary tale you fail to heed the warning to, so I must keep retelling it.” Catra breaks the act with a chuckle. “But really, it sounds like a swell time. What’s the issue?”

“Nothing really...I’ve just, recently, received some extra time off work and I know Glimmer already has a bloody itinerary ready for me the moment I step into her flat. She didn’t even give me a choice in attendance tonight.”

“Hey. Sparkles is just trying to help in the best way she knows how, and if that means she has to plan your entire Holiday then so be it. Planning is too much work anyway.”

Adora laughs. “Yes. We all know how much you dread planning.”

“Planning is dreadful, but..” Catra looks over at the warlock she has bound to a wooden chair by an invisible-rope charm she’s been wanting to test out for weeks. She looks back at Adora and shrugs. “The rewards are plentiful.”

“Sure.” Adora isn’t convinced but she lets it go. “Well, just wanted to fill you in on what’s happening tonight just in case I go missing —“

“Adora.”

“—who knows what Glimmer has planned. Last time we took a Holiday together I lost her on the hike during one of the worst storms of the year and I had to set up in some cave til morning.”

“Our senior trip. Are you still on that?”

“Magic was forbidden at the resort...”

“You were the only lunatic who fell for that bullock. And we told you where to meet us, you're just bad at directions.”

“Ark!”

“What was that?”

“Glitter.” Adora turns the mirror so Catra can see Glimmer’s owl—she’s pecking at the window, pausing to stare at them with her wide eyes before going back to pecking. “That’s my cue to go. Wish me luck.”

“Hope you have a horrible time.” Catra says. She waits for Adora’s side of the mirror to go dim before she puts it back in her pocket.

The calm fades. Catra waves her hand and removes the silencing spell.

"Hrrrk." He's choking on his own blood now. Before it was just a tiny clog but now it's keeping him from breathing—she can tell by how wide his eyes are, glazed over with the fear of seeing what's on the other side if even for just a moment. Catra sighs. She palms his chest and heals a few of his internal wounds, not enough to stop the blood from trickling down his lips but enough to keep him alive for questioning. "...what...are you?" He jumps away from her hand but doesn't get far. His chair clips on its hind leg and Catra watches him fall on his back in the chair with a *thud* .

She stands over him. "I'm a lot of things. None of them concern you. What does concern you is answering my questions."

"I told you...I can't."

"Why don't I believe you?"

"Because you're mental!" He shouts with terrified eyes. "...if you've given me...a truth cerium then...my word is not void."

Catra teases the point of her wand with her clawed finger. She says, "there are ways of hiding the truth. For instance, if you for some reason have no recollection of the events that transpired then obviously a truth cerium won't work. But deep, deep, down in… *there* ," she jabs his forehead with her wand, "...the truth resides. It may be buried but it's there. I'll just have to find it."

He shakes his head, muscles straining against the invisible ropes as he struggles to break free. His face drains as she draws closer in her kneel. Her wand starts to glow a luminous red hue as she prepares a controversial spell in the Wizarding world. "No...please don't…" a wet spot forms in his pants, true terror engulfs him as he shuts his eyes so as to not see the face of his tormentor. "Don't do this!"

“Funny” Catra mutters with a blank expression, “Lonnie said the same thing.”

The extraction spell does the trick. Catra delves deep into the depths of his mind until she finds the truth, and even after that, she keeps searching, consumed by greed and desire, until she has all the information she can get. The trade favors her; she gets access to secret meeting placing, espionage witches and wizards who have infiltrated the Ministry, and so much more, and yet—she can not rely on any of it. If working as an Obliviator has taught her anything, it’s that memories can easily be manufactured. Catra left the Obliviator gig when she learned all she could and mastered the art of mind manipulation, however, pride has gotten her in trouble in the past so she uses the memories she has extracted for reference and not a solution.

She frees him from the shackles of his mind before she remains too long—it can lead to brain damage and insanity, both too good of a death for the things this man has done. Catra twirls her wand in hand, thinking of a good way to end this, something that will send a message, when he comes to. He looks up at her, groggy, words a messy slur.

“Speak up.” Catra snaps.

He smiles, teeth stained with his blood. “He’ll find you...you’ve declared war…”

“No, I didn’t.” Catra presses her foot on the leg of the chair hard enough that it brings the chair upright. The man’s body lunges forward at the motion. He keeps his body sagging with his head down but Catra doesn’t allow him the pleasure for long. She tilts his head up with her wand and says, “he started this. But make no mistake...I will end it.” Catra grabs a fistful of his hair and keeps his head up. Her other hand rises as a spell begins to leak through the tip of her wand.

He struggles on his final breaths. He spits, “you won’t get...away with this…and still live...”

Catra hums. “What do the Americans say about Karma?” Catra mutters, and then nods when it comes to her. “Oh yeah. They say —“

Catra swings her arm in a fluid motion and lets the spell rip from her wand, chaotically in control. Blood splatters across her face and body as she slits his throat.

“—it’s a bitch.”

“Meerrw.” Melog utters, in their true form, as they stalk towards her with a disapproving look.

“Nah,” Catra waves her hand and the blood vanishes from her skin and clothes. “...I’m in the mood for pizza instead. We can get Chinese another time.”

Melog huffs.

“Just give me a minute.” Catra says. She looks back at her soon to be masterpiece. She could send the corpse to the Ministry, a little gift for those espionage fools who think they can tear apart all that they’ve built from the inside out, or she can send it to the next randevu location he was supposed to meet his boss at. The issue is whether she gives any credit to the memories she obtained. If they are not altered then she can go to the randevu spot and meet this bastard once and for all, but it’s too dangerous so she barely considers it.

No, she should make him come to her. Back him into a corner by making him think she herself is in one.

“...to Manhattan you go.” Catra decides. It risks driving him out of New York but it’s worth getting a reaction. And by the time he reacts Catra will be long gone. The city was nice while it lasted, she enjoyed getting her shoulders knocked on the busy streets (who said sarcasm was dead?), but it’s time to leave. Catra never stays in one place long. She already has a loft ready in Italy so she can tie up some loose ends and work on finishing this case.

Melog hisses.

“He has to come with us! I can do a lot of things but apparating his body without accompanying him is yet to be seen. Besides, Manhattan isn’t far from us.”

Melog huffs, unimpressed and hungry, but wraps their tail around Catra’s leg for the ride.

When the body is disposed, Catra apparates to an empty alleyway in NYC just a couple blocks from her loft. Melog transforms into a Tom-cat to appease the muggles and walks beside her as they step out of the shadows and into the fluorescent lights. She grabs a pizza (as promised) from her favorite spot on the way home. The guy working the oven is a shaggy looking teenager with a pencil mustache, he’s dressed in loose sweatpants and a faded work hoodie. He looks as grim as the weather (misty and damp) but when he hears her voice he grins and runs up to the counter.

“Catra! Hey!” He clears his throat and tries to deepen his voice. “What’s up?” She does not miss puberty.

“Hi, Finn.” Catra smiles an honest one. Finn is annoying, always flirting with her even though she repeatedly tells him she’s gay, but there’s something about him that makes her want to root for him so he quickly became her favorite American when she first touched down in the city.

“The usual? I can throw in some extra fries for Melog.”

“Won’t your boss give you trouble?”

Finn snorts. “As if. I practically run this place—“

“Oh, hi Mr. Sal,” Catra says.

Finn whirls around and finds no one but his disgruntled co workers slumped against the wall going through their phones as they wait for the orders to finish. Finn turns around with a red face. “I wasn’t scared.”

“Sure you weren’t.” Catra laughs just to loosen Finn up. It works, he looks more at ease but the red in his cheeks doesn’t fade. “But I will take some extra fries for Melog.”

Melog slips under the sliding door between the counter and rubs against Finn’s leg. He says, “your cat loves me. Come on. This is a sign. I think you should go out with me.”

Catra shakes her head. “There are so many things wrong with that sentence. You’re only seventeen and I’m in my twenties…”

“Age is just a number.”

“Not according to the law. And Melog is not fond of you, they’re just drawn in by that bloody cologne you seem to bath yourself in. Probably smells like fish to them.” Melog chirps at her. Catra corrects herself, “not fish, sorry. Shrimp.”

Finn looks more lovesick than before. “You can keep bashing me but everything you say fuels me. I love the accent.”

Catra gives up. “Can I just get food? Please.”

Finn pulls a personal pizza-pie-box from under the counter and then drops another bag on top of it. He slips her a receipt and hands her a pen to sign. “Had a feeling you’d be stopping by so I had it premade a couple minutes ago.” Catra makes a face. She’s getting too comfortable here if Finn, of all people, is starting to predict her actions.

Catra decides on moving out tonight instead, she was going to wait until the end of the week but she can’t risk the enemy picking up on her next move. The randevu is happening tomorrow night so they’ll surely find the present Catra left on their doorstep

and she doesn't want to be anywhere near Manhattan when they find it.

"On the house." Finn grins.

"Are you sure?"

"Yeah. You basically keep the lights on in this place."

"...which is why I should—"

"Have a good night, Catra." Finn says, shutting down any of her rebuttals with a gentle smile and a kind nudge. Muggles in this city are kind, nothing like the vindictive—and destructive—witch she was at Hogwarts. The kindness she gets from Finn and the people of this city remind her of those three goofballs she left behind in England.

Catra takes her food and returns the smile. "You too, Finn."

"Don't forget to visit me in my dreams tonight!" Finn shouts, practically sprawled out on the counter. His blonde hair slips into his face a bit and Catra thinks (if he wasn't a fool and could take a hint) that he looks kinda cute.

"...had to go off and ruin it."

1

When Catra gets to her loft it's a little past nine at night. She doesn't bother with putting up wards because she plans on packing everything up and heading to the nearest Floo Network and booking it to her flat in Italy, but she has some time so she settles in a bit. Catra grabs a marble plate and dumps Melog's fries on top and then sets it down on the windowsill. Melog dives in while she washes her hands and gets a slice for herself. When she's done she gets a bottle of red wine out the pantry and sits it on the living room table.

Catra wonders. "Can you drink wine?"

"Meerp."

"Huh? Shentaug?" Catra mutters as she gets a glass and walks back into the living room. She concludes, "so it's exactly like wine but you just have another name for it? Can you get drunk off it at least?"

Melog doesn't bother responding.

"Right. Magical creature...you have like a crazy high tolerance level. Mine is like that too, since I'm a hybrid and such, but it sucks when all of your friends are pissed while it feels like you've barely had a shot."

"...meerp."

Catra gasps in outrage and betrayal. "There are bars for magical creatures and you've never told me?"

"Meerp!"

"For the last time, I wasn't pissed when I ran my bike into that stop sign. My body just spazzed, it's a side effect from all those spells I took from the war. You arse...getting laughs off a war veteran." It's bullshit and Melog knows it but neither of them call her out on it.

Catra goes to fill her glass to the brim when suddenly her vintage wine glass falls to the floor in a heart tingling shatter. She watches, helpless, as the shards scatter across the wood floor in wild directions. She waves a hand to silently piece the shattered glass back together (no harm done) but when she holds it up there is a piece missing right in the center of the curved side. Catra stares at the jagged crack left behind and then turns to Melog who is still lounging in the windowsill after the daunting day they've both had. Melog meets her gaze, they share in her skepticism and unease.

Catra mutters, "I have a bad feeling about tonight."

Knock. Knock.

Catra turns to the door, immediately on edge. No one visits her. The only neighbor she speaks to is Mrs. Johnson and it's only in passing during the early morning; the old woman should be sleeping right now, Catra knows because she has a hefty pile of sticky notes with various noise complaints from the old bat.

Catra gets another glass and fills it to the brim with wine. She drinks half of it, teases the tip of her wand that's discreetly tucked inside her pants leg, and then answers the door. There's a spell ready on her lips when—

"Finally! We were knocking on the door for hours."

Catra spills her wine at the door—shocked, and bewildered, as Glimmer shoves her way into Catra's flat in New York (when she should be in England) with a sheepish Bow and Adora in tow carrying the bags.

"It has not been hours." Catra mutters.

"Well it felt like ages."

And Catra thought the Americans were the dramatic ones.

"What are you lot doing here?" Catra groans, falling back into the door as she slams it shut. She waves her hand to clean up the mess she made while she's at it. When she looks up Bow and Adora have the sense to look guilty but Glimmer's having none of it as she makes herself at home by sitting on the couch and serving herself some of Catra's wine. "A little far from home, yeah?"

Adora whispers to Catra, "remember when I said she'd have an itinerary planned? Well...you were the first stop."

Catra groans. She glares at the ring leader behind this. "You can't just show up here, Sparkles!"

Melog pounces from the windowsill and lands on Bow's shoulder. They purr affectionately and rub against his neck before doing the same with Glimmer's leg and then making their way to Adora. They stay with Adora too long for Catra's comfort. Glimmer's grin is nothing less than shit eating.

"You can't be too mad about it if your cat is practically wearing your emotions on it's sleeve."

Catra scoops Melog up and hugs them into her chest. She huffs, "they aren't my *cat* . They're a highly intelligent magical creature. Not a pet." She lets Melog down and then settles into the one seater while the rest of the golden quartet take up the longer couch. Glimmer slouches back, twirling the wine in her glass, watching the liquid ripple, while Bow and Adora sit upright looking very uncomfortable. Catra slouches too and gives them the permission to do the same. At her relaxed gesture the duo calms down a bit but Adora still looks lost in thought. No helping that one.

Catra keeps her voice calm. "Not that I'm not thrilled to have you all in my living room but, why are you here?"

"Well," Bow says after neither of them speaks up, "Adora was put on mandatory Holiday—"

" *Really* ?" Catra leans forward with a devilish grin. "That must be driving you mad."

Adora's left eye twitches just a bit. She gives Catra her best smile. It twitches as well, lips curling up in somewhat of a snarl. "...I'm splendid."

"I'm sure."

Bow clears his throat and doesn't speak again until Catra finally pries her eyes away from watching Adora squirm. He smiles nervously. "We're all on Holiday. And there was a lot going on back home...so we thought—" Glimmer interrupts him with a tipsy

squeal (*Merlin's beard,* Catra thinks, *when did she get so pissed in just a couple minutes?*).

"Best friend squad reunion!"

Chapter End Notes

I didn't want to make this chapter super long. I was going to include the events that take place after the golden quartet hangs out for the day but it would have been a lot and this gives me time to plan/outline. And I don't want to rush this like I feel like I've done my other story. Also, Coming to America is a play on the Eddie Murphy movie (it's great, check it out if you can).

Some of the scenes/atmosphere of this story was inspired by Grace and Favour, a great Catra/Adora story set in an Angel/Demon universe that I'm super into right now. Check it out!

Thanks for reading and let me know what you think!

Declaration of War

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

3

"I get it already." Catra says after listening to Glimmer's lengthy rant. "...you want to eat something fried. There's a ton of spots in the city where we can go. There's a pizza place I go to all the time so we can stop by tomorrow." Catra weighs her options out before she says, "I was actually heading out to Italy for—"

"Italy?" Bow gasps. "Who do you know there?"

Catra thinks. "No one. But I have a loft there and I was planning to leave tonight for a bit of a Holiday myself. There's plenty of space if you guys want to come." They came all this way; she doesn't want to push them out so soon.

Glimmer squeals. "I wouldn't mind a trip to Italy…but can we stay here for at least one day? I really want some fried Oreos."

"Sure." Catra decides. "I only have one guest room available right now, the other one is stacked with boxes I haven't sorted since I moved in, but someone can take the couch."

Adora takes one for the team. "I'll take the couch. You and Bow can have the guest room."

"You sure?" Bow asks, worried.

Adora nods. "It's only one night. I've slept on worse."

"My couch isn't *that* bad," Catra mutters.

"Okay, as long as you're comfortable. Sleep well on the *couch* ," Glimmer says, giving Catra a glare. It's odd—and sudden—but

Catra doesn’t put it past Glimmer.

Catra shows Glimmer and Bow the guest room before leaving so they can get situated. Back in the living room she brings out a pile of blankets and a pillow for Adora. When Adora’s made herself comfortable under the blankets Catra hovers awkwardly, not quite sure how she should approach this. “Are you sure you’ll be alright out here?” She feels the need to double check.

“I slept in the woods when Prime was on our trail. I think I’ll be fine.” Adora grins.

Catra smiles, suddenly feeling foolish for thinking Adora would have a hard time about this. Part of her thought, maybe, Adora would offer to… “Alright tough guy, I’ll see you in the morning. Sleep tight.”

Adora calls her back before she turns the corner. “Hey, I’m sorry for showing up unannounced. I know you hate surprises.”

“Yeah well,” Catra smiles “you’re a welcome surprise.”

Adora sends her a goofy smile in return. “Goodnight, Catra.”

“G’night.”

The rest of the night drags out. Catra stares up at the ceiling until she’s brought out of thought by a familiar creak outside her door. She’s not too concerned. Melog sleeps right outside and they wouldn’t let anyone this close to her if they didn’t think it was okay. Her intuition is spot on. Adora slips inside without knocking; she closes the door behind her, leaning against it with a sheepish grin that sends a flutter to Catra’s stomach. “Hey. Sorry if I scared you.” Adora says, trying to keep her voice low.

Catra sits up and leans on the backboard of the bed. She says, “you didn’t, I could hear you walking over. You were never good

at sneaking around at night. Remember when Angella caught us trying to open the Chamber of Secrets? You stepped on a creaky floor board and blew our cover."

Adora huffs, "how many times do I have to be shamed about that?"

"Until you learn to use a silencing spell on yourself." Catra's smirk softens into something lighter. "You couldn't sleep either?"

Adora shakes her head.

"Come on, let's have insomnia together then." Catra pulls the blankets back and scoots over as Adora slips in beside her. They cuddle up under the covers like they used to when they were just kids at the orphanage. Some things never change. "Why can't you sleep?"

Adora blinks away the scene that feels like it's forever imprinted in her brain—Lonnie, on the white carpet, throat slit open. Adora clears her throat. "I keep seeing her, Lonnie." And Adora really shouldn't be disclosing case sensitive information to Catra, especially when she was taken off said case. But Catra is someone she can always talk to. Someone she can tell anything to without getting judged for it. "She was killed at her house…Lucy was hiding in the closet when I found her." Suddenly Catra's wrapping an arm around her. She must've started shaking halfway through her confession.

"Did she see it happen?"

Adora shakes her head. "No. I don't think so. But the Obliviator team wiped her memory of the forced entry so I think maybe she heard something…"

"Did she hear a voice?" Catra asks, running her fingers through messy blonde locks.

"I didn't listen to the recording. That's why we're here, I was taken off the case because of my personal involvement with the

victim.” Adora scoffs. “How can they expect me to go on Holiday and act like nothing happened?”

“If they saw Lucy’s memory then they should be close to apprehending the person in charge.” Catra says, trying to give her some comfort. “I know it sucks being benched but maybe you can get some closure when they find the asshole.”

Adora notices something off about Catra’s reaction. She looks over at her and asks, “aren’t you surprised? Lonnie’s gone.”

Catra purses her lips. “We grew up with Lonnie, she’s practically family—she *was* family—but I’ve been working as an Obliviator for three years now and the memories I’ve sorted through…some of the things I’ve seen would disturb even you. And with Lonnie becoming an Unspeakable, it just seems like it was inevitable. Don’t you think so?”

Adora sits up. “Bow told us you’re considering it. Becoming an Unspeakable.”

“I am.” Catra doesn’t deny it. She grabs Adora’s hands and tucks them close to her chest. “Does that bother you?”

Adora’s face twists up. It does bother her. She knows better than to worry about Catra—she’s a talented witch, skilled with various forms of wandless magic and healing properties—but Adora’s heart seems to ignore those facts. And it’s not like Adora can beg Catra not to get into a dangerous career when Adora’s an *Auror* for fucks sake. Still, she whispers “yes.”

“It bothers me too.” Catra looks up at the ceiling—something Adora notices she does out of habit whenever she’s about to reveal something truly personal. “Unspeakables can’t share secrets about the cases they work on. Their loyalty lies with the Ministry of Magic. And…you’re obviously an idiot…”

Adora laughs despite the tense atmosphere they’ve cloaked themselves in. “Obviously.”

Catra smiles for a moment but it falls almost entirely. She whispers, “I don’t like the idea of not being able to tell you everything.”

Adora is very close to saying something she shouldn’t, not like this, so she combats the feeling to tell Catra everything with a kiss. She remembers the last time they kissed, it was in the car on the way back from a wizarding convention her team of Aurors were assigned to guard. Catra had been there with the Oblivator squad, demonstrating some new and efficient techniques they cultivated, when the end of the night had them getting lost in each other. It’s been far too long. Adora guides Catra’s hand to the hem of her sweatpants. She bites back a moan when Catra’s fingers brush the skin of her pelvis.

Catra pulls back from the kiss with a gasp. Her pupils are dilated, eyes struggling to meet her gaze as they keep drifting down to her lips. “Are you sure?”

“You don’t want to?”

“I do.” Catra says quickly before Adora can spiral. And with confirmation that Catra is *very* much okay with this happening, she starts kissing at her neck. “You just seemed upset, like, not even two minutes ago. And Bow and Glimmer are next door.”

“Silencing spell.”

Catra nods. “Right, obviously, that’ll work.”

Adora laughs, waving her hand to cast a spell on the room that’ll keep them from worrying. She says, “I love how stupid you get when I’m distracting you.”

“I can’t think of anything snarky to say right now but, seriously, are you okay?”

Adora starts mapping out the constellations she made out of the freckles on Catra’s nose. She says, “I’m still upset about it, and I’ll

still be upset tomorrow, but I know that I want this. I want you. That'll never change."

Catra's face heats up. She slips a hand down Adora's pants and mutters, "a yes or no would've been fine, *fuck* ."

They don't do much talking for the rest of the night.

4

The next morning Adora sneaks out of Catra's room before Bow and Glimmer get up. Catra opted to tuck herself deeper into the covers—she was never much of a morning person—so Adora welcomes herself to a glass of water while she looks around the kitchen for something edible.

"Didn't see you on the couch last night."

Adora startles. "What?"

Glimmer crosses her arms behind her back and approaches her with a sly grin. "Last night. I got up for water but I didn't see you. Interesting, don't you think?"

"What's so interesting about me using the bathroom in the middle of the night?" Adora asks with a shrug. She hopes her voice is calmer than she feels.

"Wouldn't it be interesting if you weren't in the bathroom and instead you were in Catra's room last night."

"Wouldn't it."

Glimmer whines. "Come on, just admit it already!"

"Admit what?"

Glimmer double checks they're alone before she says in a hushed whisper, "admit that you and Catra are hooking up in secret."

Adora chokes on her water. Glimmer has to pat her on the back just so Adora can shoot her a very unconvincing glare. “We are not!”

“Really?” Glimmer doesn’t look impressed. She leans her hip on the kitchen sink and starts listing evidence—that Adora *never* knew she had—off her fingers in chronological order. “You two were making out while you were basically on your deathbed during our fight with Prime—“

Adora balks. “How do you even—”

“Bow and I came back to help out once we took out a couple Dementors but it looked like you two had things handled.” Glimmer continues, “you two also *disappeared* this one time at Perfuma’s game night and when you came back your face was all flushed—you looked like you’d just ran a marathon—also you *definitely* hooked up during our Holiday to Seychelles—do I need to go on?”

Adora reaches back to steady herself on the counter. This is not how she planned for this trip to go. At first she was apprehensive about Catra—how she *hates* surprises (even if it’s her three favorite people showing up on her doorstep)—but then Adora saw the opportunity. With Lonnie’s number one murder suspect lurking in the city it was perfect—while the others were busy site seeing, and while Catra was busying reigning in their antics, it left Adora with ample time to get to the bottom of this.

Unfortunately, she didn’t factor in Glimmer’s lust for answers as well.

Without much of a choice Adora confesses, “okay…all of that’s, more or less, true…”

“I know.” Glimmer says without surprise. “Well, *we* know.”

“ *Bow* knows too?” Adora shakes her head. “Duh, of course he knows. You two are basically married.”

"You know there isn't a set date on that yet. But," Glimmer nervously twiddles her fingers, "I wasn't just talking about Bow… the others know too."

Adora's heart almost stops. " *What* ?" She must be freaking out because suddenly Glimmer is rubbing her shoulders and looking back at the door to the kitchen like she's worried someone might barge in any second. But Adora could give a shit about who comes in because, "what do you mean the others know too? Did you say something to them?"

"I didn't have to. You two are really obvious." Glimmer says, "I know you two kept it a secret because the press was watching us after graduation like my mother during our first year but, there's no reason to hide anymore. We're all successful in our careers, and even though Catra was unbearable at Hogwarts everyone's come around to her, hell, she and Mermista go out for wine whenever Catra's in Lee Valley. And the four of us are war *heroes* , Adora, once they find out you and Catra are dating they'll eat it up—"

"We're not dating."

Glimmer appears to be malfunctioning. "I'm sorry?"

Adora rubs her forehead as a headache comes on. "I said—"

"I heard what you said!"

"Then why did you ask?" Adora shoots back.

"I'm sorry, I just…" Glimmer frowns. "I don't understand. Is this because of the distance? We have magic for fucks sake."

Adora feels humiliated. Not only has everyone in their friend group been aware of her and Catra's complicated relationship, but now she has to explain to Glimmer that she's a pining idiot who has been settling for scraps for the past three years instead of having a simple conversation. But it's not as easy as it sounds. "It's not

the distance we just, we've never really had a conversation about what we're doing."

Glimmer's voice drops, "are you joking?"

"We've just been—wait. Where are you going?" Adora frantically pulls Glimmer by the arm when she starts walking towards the door.

"I'm going to slap the hell out of Catra and ask her what her problem is and then I'm going to do the same to you."

"Please don't, it's complicated okay?"

"Do you love her?"

Adora feels her face heat up, "of course I do."

"And she obviously loves you back. What's so hard about it?"

"What if this is as good as it gets? I don't want to bring this up, it's been *three years* , what if I'm wrong and I spook her? If this is all I can have then I'm fine with that."

Glimmer asks, "and if she's seeing other people?"

Adora's stomach turns. She hadn't thought about that before. With her busy schedule she can admit that Catra's the only person she's been with during their three year tryst but she hadn't considered— "She's not…she wouldn't do that."

"How do you know if you've never—"

"Because I know her. She wouldn't, okay?"

Glimmer looks at her—the pity in her gaze makes Adora turn her head. "You two should talk. I won't make a scene because we're on Holiday and I want you to relax, but you should get some answers. I think you'll be happy to find out you two might actually want the same thing."

Glimmer heads back into the living room. When she's out of sight Adora lets her shoulders drop and with it so goes the tension—but, it still lingers. She doesn't have the time or the mental space to confront Catra about this. She needs to find out who killed Lonnie and punish them for it.

Adora shakes off her conversation with Glimmer and picks up the daily paper and scans it for any clues.

When Catra finally gets out of bed it's nearly noon and Glimmer is sulking on the couch giving her another weird *look* so Catra hurries to get dressed so she can show them the highlights of the city. They stop for some early lunch at a place nearby, taking the food to go, before Catra takes them sightseeing. They go for a walk in Central Park and take pictures by the trees; Catra even gets around to showing them the Statue of Liberty before they see a Broadway Show that has Bow crying near the end.

"I need a drink." Glimmer says once they exit the theater around nine at night.

Catra remembers, "there's a bar for Magical Creatures around here."

"They have a bar for *Magical Creatures* ? In *New York* ?" Bow exclaims with glee. "Okay, I take everything back. I see why you live here now."

Catra doesn't correct him; instead, she gestures to the cat leaning on her leg. "I had no idea this place existed. Melog only *just* told me about it yesterday."

Glimmer asks, "doesn't it still suck for you here? You have to use a glamor spell so the muggles don't realize you're a hybrid. If you moved back to London—"

"I'd still have to wear it unless I'm in a town without muggles. Nice try, Sparks."

Bow gasps. "But it's a magical creature bar so you can take off your glamor. Oh! Maybe we'll meet some creatures we've never seen before. Melog, are you gonna transform too?"

Melog stretches their legs out. *Mwr.*

Catra shrugs. "They said *why not* ?"

The bar is closer than they think it is and soon it feels like they've never left London. Catra feels comfortable enough to lose the glamor while Melog does the same by transforming into their primitive form. The alcohol is laced with magic so it actually does make Catra a little tipsy which is nice. She likes the buzz. Bow is knocking back shots at a hefty pace but he's holding his own pretty well; it's Adora and Glimmer who are near shit faced. Catra had to stop them *twice* from jumping on top of the bar and singing songs from the show they just saw.

"Catra!" Glimmer whines, draping an arm around her. There's a glass with some kind of purple drink in her free hand. "You promised— *you* —promised me some fried food. Where's it at?"

Catra takes the glass from her and drinks whatever's left. Glimmer pouts but perks up when Catra says, "I know a place nearby actually. Bow, let's get these two a sobering drink so we don't have to carry them on our backs. Adora's already a golden retriever when she's sober, we don't want her getting hit by a car."

Bow blinks. "There's a spell that can make you sober?"

"What can I say?" Catra smirks, "it's the American dream."

Once Adora and Glimmer sober up, Catra takes them over to her favorite pizza spot in the city. It's getting late, a little close to two

in the morning, but Catra knows Finn will keep the lights on for a bit longer if she asks him. The bell to the door *dings* upon their entry. The fresh smell of bread and sauce welcomes her with open arms. She spots Finn at the counter with his head in his arms—probably exhausted from the shift he's had.

"Mind if we drop in?" Catra asks, getting his attention as she walks up to the counter.

"Catra?" Finn's head shoots up and suddenly he's full of energy. He looks over her shoulder after checking her out, grinning. "Are we finally at the point in our relationship where you introduce me to your friends?"

Catra groans. "This was a mistake."

"What's he talking about?" Adora asks, confused.

Finn leans over the counter, gleeful. "Are you gonna…?"

"Guys this is Finn and, yes, he's always like this." Catra says, "these are my friends from London: Adora, Glimmer and Bow. We went to school together."

Finn does a lame bow. "A pleasure to meet you. Honestly, Catra barely talks about London so it's cool to finally meet her friends. I was starting to think she only had her cat."

Glimmer laughs. "I like him."

"So, what can I get you guys?"

Glimmer cheers, "do you have fried Oreos?"

Finn nods. "Of course."

"Then I'll take that."

Finn gives her a strange look. "You won't get full on just that. I'll make you guys a pepperoni pie with some wings on the side. My

treat.”

This time Catra refuses. “No way. You already gave me a free meal yesterday.”

“Come on,” Finn grins, “the man is expected to pay on the first few dates.”

“I’m definitely paying then.” Catra deadpans.

“I love when you tease me.” Finn laughs. “Seriously, sit tight while I get everything ready.”

Catra knows it’s pointless arguing with a crazy person so she leads them to an open booth across from the counter while Finn gets the food ready. Catra sits on the outside with Adora to her left with Bow on her opposite.

“He’s friendly.” Glimmer says with a wiggle of her eyebrows.

Catra drops her face in her hands. “He’s *seventeen* !”

Bow smiles. “No offense—”

“I’ll be the judge of that.” Catra frowns.

“—but I didn’t think you’d have any friends around here. You haven’t been here long and you’re always so quiet about everything you do.”

Glimmer laughs. “Your only friend is Melog and some seventeen year old.”

“He’s not my friend!”

Finn shouts back, “we’re so much more!”

Catra sulks as they all laugh at her expense. Even Adora is holding her stomach from laughing too hard. At least Adora seems happier than earlier. Catra takes the teasing in stride if it means Adora is put at ease; it doesn’t last long though and soon the

subject is switched. They talk about the sights they saw earlier and reminisce until Finn finally comes over with their food. Glimmer's eyes widen as Finn hands over her fried Oreos first.

"Let it cool off," Finn says with a laugh. "And here's some soda and water if you get thirsty. Anything else you guys need before I close up the kitchen?"

Catra shakes her head. "This is all great. Thanks, Finn."

Finn winks. "Anything for you."

Glimmer says, "I like this kid. He should hang out with us!"

"Next time." Catra reminds her. "We're heading out of town for awhile. But, sure, next time."

Finn's smile widens. "I'll hold you to it. You guys enjoy."

They dig in once the food cools off. Glimmer engulfs her fried Oreos and Catra has to listen to her go on and on about how amazing it is. Bow and Adora are fans of the pizza so Catra sticks with the wings and lets them get extra helpings—she isn't much of a big eater anyway.

The bell at the front door rings while they're finishing up. Catra looks away from her half eaten wing when she feels Melog run up to rub against her leg. She frowns. Melog never gets this clingy. She starts to ask what's wrong when Melog lets out a frantic *Mwr.*

Catra's head shoots up as she pays the new intruder attention. It's a lanky man in a black trench coat with a classic fedora—it's tilted at the front, hiding his eyes. Finn notices the man as well but he has none of the urgency or instinct that Catra welds. "Sorry dude, I'm closing right after they leave. I think Steve is still open if you're that hungry." Finn says.

The man stops somewhere in the middle of the room. He's half a distance away from Finn and half a distance away from their table. Catra uses her left hand, the one that's hidden from the

man's view, and slowly reaches for her wand. Suddenly the table gets quiet. She doesn't look over to see if Bow and Glimmer have caught on—she doubts they haven't—but she does feel Adora go still at her side. She and Adora are always in tune, sometimes more than she and Melog.

Finn repeats, "I said we're closed, man. I turned off the oven and wiped everything down. Sorry but I can't serve you right now. Come back tomorrow or go see Steve, their pizza isn't as good as ours but they make due." Finn gives him a nervous smile.

The man tilts his hat up with a bony finger. His eyes are black as night and they turn to look at Catra—the angle is unnatural. Catra feels bile rise at her throat as if she's already experienced what's about to happen. The man opens his mouth, teeth yellow and crooked, his voice is just as ghastly. " *He* got your message—"

Catra jerks up and draws her wand with a shout.

"—here's his response."

"—confringo!"

"—avada kedavra!"

Catra's spell hits the man at his side—it's a bombarding one that explodes anything in its path. It's vicious enough to cripple him but also directed at the right area on the body to keep him alive so Catra can torture answers out of him. But the spell he cast is not so forgiving. Catra makes sure the man in the fedora isn't getting up anytime soon before she whips around and looks over Bow and Glimmer. She runs up to Adora, checking her for any wounds, in a frenzy. "Are you okay—"

"Catra." Adora's voice cracks. Her eyes are wide and faraway—it reminds Catra of the hollow gaze she had on her deathbed.

"Catra…what…" Finn's voice trembles behind her. Catra doesn't want to turn around, she almost doesn't but Adora's steady hands are doing it for her. When she's turned Catra feels that bile from

earlier rear its ugly head. Finn is on the floor near the divider of the counter. “What was…” his voice trails off as his eyes stay on Catra until the light quickly fades from them.

Catra falls back into Adora’s arms. She whispers, “Finn…I’m so sorry…”

Bow slides out of the booth and looks around frantically. “What… who *is* he? Why would he want to kill Finn?” Catra’s eyes clench at the reminder of who’s laying on the floor in a heap. “Why a muggle?”

Glimmer mutters, “I think I’m gonna be sick.” But there’s no sound of her doing any such thing. They’re all familiar with this from their time during the war—back then they were just kids, clumsily fumbling around with what little skill they could summon. But Catra’s not a child anymore.

With a steadying breath Catra pulls away from Adora’s arms. “Nox,” Catra says swiftly. The lights go off—just a way to keep curious eyes off them. Catra uses the tip of her wand as a flashlight to guide her around. “Adora, destroy the camera. There’s only one, they keep it behind the register.”

Adora is quiet for just a moment—a second of hesitation—before she does as she’s told.

Bow stands at her side as Catra kneels down and grabs the man by his collar. “Catra, what’s going on?”

Damn it...he knows my name , Catra looks at the man. His eyes meet hers with recognition. *Now I can’t let him out alive.*

“Catra,” her name on his tongue sends chills down her back but she makes no show of the effect. He flinches as she gets rid of her glamor—no point in hiding now—and with her claws out she doesn’t handle him gently. “ *Hybrid* ,” he spits out.

“You’re a genius.” Catra deadpans. “Now how about you tell me who sent you.”

He laughs. “Like I’d tell you. Isn’t this what you wanted? What did you expect after sending us that message?”

Catra isn’t going to get any answers out of him right now—not when she has to worry about playing nice in front of her friends—so she looks over at Melog. “Take him,” she says knowing Melog will know where.

Melog transforms and wraps their tail around the troublesome man. They give her a nod before they start to consume the man in a cloak of invisibility but before that can happen the man starts to convulse. Melog backs away, turning a vivid red as they hiss—Catra has a similar reaction. Bow steps in front of Glimmer and backs them away. “You really think he’s going to let you keep me alive for questioning?” It’s his last words before life is sucked from him. Before he goes something unnatural happens—a bright flash erupts from his stretched open mouth and from the whites of his eyes.

A projection shoots up and the image confirms what Catra already knew. This was indeed a message for her. The image presented to them is the same warlock Catra tortured a couple nights ago—with his throat slit open.

The image lasts a minute before it dies out with the man. Catra nods at Melog to dispose of the body and soon Melog is engulfing the man again. They apparate away. Adora returns right on time with the damaged tape. Catra grabs Adora by the arm before doing the same with Bow and Glimmer.

Bow splutters as she manhandles him. “I’m sorry but what is—“

Catra uses apparition to teleport them out of the diner. She leaves Finn for the NYPD to deal with.

“Catra,” Bow doesn’t waste time when they land in the living room of her loft, “what is going on?”

Catra waves a hand and suddenly her items around the house start organizing themselves into her suitcases and storage boxes. She goes into the kitchen and makes herself a drink to stop her hands from shaking. This is not how this night was supposed to go. She was supposed to be in Italy, far away from this mess—she only wanted to draw him out so the ministry could take care of him but now she's involved directly. This makes things complicated.

Catra takes a big sip of wine. When she comes back to the living room Bow is ranting while Glimmer pacing carefully. Adora is the only calm one, surprisingly, as she sits on the couch deep in thought.

Bow rounds up on her when she comes back. "Catra. I love you like a little sister, but I'm going to need you to answer my question. What was *that* ?"

"It was a message." Adora answers. Her voice makes them turn to her. "The image…the man in the image had his throat slit. It's the same way Lonnie went out..."

Glimmer frowns. "Adora, you're not on the case anymore. How do you know that?"

Adora says after a moment, "I was there…I was the one who found her."

"Holy shit," Bow mutters as he slides down to the floor with his back pressed to the wall.

Glimmer scoffs. "Is that why you came here? You've been following the case and got a clue. I should've known it was weird when you didn't object to coming."

"I'm *not* following the case. It's in almost every newspaper—" Adora shuts up when Glimmer glares at her.

Bow says, "that still doesn't make any sense. They went after Finn, and Adora, you've never met them before." Catra can feel

his eyes on her. “So, I’ll ask again. Catra, what have you been up to?”

There’s no use in lying. Catra goes with as much of the truth as she can get away with. “I’m not living in America because I like fried food. I’ve actually been working on a case of my own.”

“I don’t think it’s in your job description to slit a warlock's throat.” Bow says.

Catra smirks—it lacks any true humor. “It’s not. But I’m also not working as an Obliviator anymore, this mission qualifies me as an Unspeakable. I was supposed to leave the city after delivering the message, we’re trying to draw out Lonnie’s killer, but I got a little side tracked when you guys showed up. I’m supposed to be in Italy laying low right now. I wish I could tell you more.” She’s already said more than she should.

Bow stands up with a nod. “Okay. This vacation is over.”

Adora says, “but—“

“Adora. You’re supposed to be getting *away* from this, and Glimmer and I aren’t qualified for this mission level. We’re leaving.”

Adora huffs. “Oh yeah, we only saved the world when we were *teenagers* —who’s to say you two aren’t qualified? We set the bar for those qualifications!”

“There are rules in place for a reason.” Bow says with a frown.

Glimmer offers, “even if we wanted to help we can’t. It’s out of our hands.”

“Catra.” Adora’s voice makes her look over at her, curious. There’s a maniac glee in Adora’s eye. Like she’s found the answer to a difficult question. “Catra can still look into the case, she has jurisdiction here. And as the Unspeakable on this case she can appoint a support staff if she needs to.”

Bow looks at them like they're crazy. He asks, "are we really doing this?"

Glimmer asks, "can you really let this go? Someone's after Catra. You know what happened to Lonnie, we can't let the same thing happen to her."

"So?" Adora asks. Her leg is bouncing up and down nervously. Catra has no say in anything as the trio decides for her.

"I guess we're staying in New York. But we can't stay here." Bow looks at Catra and asks, "who can we stay with? I know you have contingency plans in place."

Catra rubs the back of her neck. She really doesn't want to but she doesn't have much of a choice. They need to find a place in New York—so they can apprehend the criminal if he shows up—no matter how much she wishes she could kick her feet up on the beaches of Sardinia. "Scorpia's got a place with Perfuma in upstate. It's not close to the city but it's better than being in a different country."

Glimmer perks up. "They're living here too?"

"They're just on Holiday like the rest of us. I told her I would visit them anyway so I guess this works out." Catra sighs.

Bow walks to the guest room. "I guess we'll start packing." He doesn't look too happy with her but Catra knows it's only because it's been a rough roller coaster of a night.

"He gets grumpy when he's tired but he'll come around," Glimmer confirms with a pat to Catra's back. "We'll figure this out. We've got your back, okay?"

Catra nods. "Thanks." She means it. Even though the thought of getting them involved fills her with dread, she's glad she's not alone. She watches Glimmer follow Bow into the guest room before she turns to Adora. "Hey, I'm sorry about all—"

“Were you going to tell me?”

Catra fumbles with her words. “Adora, I *couldn’t* . I’m on a case.”

“I told you about mine.”

Catra snaps. “That’s different and you know it.”

Adora’s voice shakes. “Did you even *want* to tell me?”

Catra can’t find it in herself to lie to Adora twice in one week. Because the truth is, she didn’t. She didn’t want to tell Adora any of this—or Glimmer, or Bow—she doesn’t want any of them knowing what she’s involved in. She hopes her expression reveals how much she cares about Adora, and how she’d do *anything* to keep her safe, but Catra’s never been good at showing them. She must be doing that thing where she shields herself—keeping her face hard—because Adora’s throat bobs and she looks away with glossy eyes.

“Okay.”

“Adora it’s not—“

“Thanks for telling me,” Adora says—her tone chilling. It’s not fair and completely understandable all at the same time. Catra is helpless as Adora decides, “I think we should stay in separate rooms once we get to Scorpia’s place.” Adora gets off the couch and shuts herself in the bathroom.

Catra doesn’t try to stop her.

Chapter End Notes

RIP Finn

Promises

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

5

It's close to 1 o'clock in the morning when Catra cautiously knocks on Scorpia's flat door in upstate NY with a very disgruntled set of friends behind her. When Catra mentioned Scorpia she didn't expect them to leave the very same night; she thought they'd let things cool off at a hotel but Bow was adamant about getting out of the city.

"Wildcat?" Scorpia blinks twice before squealing and pulling Catra into a hug with enough force it lifts her off the ground. "Wildcat! You're actually visiting me!" Of course *Scorpia* is excited to have friends show at her door at 1 o'clock in the morning. She gasps when she notices, "oh my Merlin—Fuma! Make some tea, the *golden quartet* just showed up at our doorstep. Come in!" She ushers them inside, clutching on Catra's arm like she hasn't seen her in years when in reality it's only been a couple months.

Perfuma looks like a zombie as she joins them in the living room. "Ah…so it's true," she mutters meekly.

Bow smiles at her sheepishly. "Good to see you two again. It's been a while."

"Adora too?" Perfuma says, shocked. "Something big must be happening for you to be away from work."

Glimmer deflects, "the only thing that's big is our Holiday."

Scorpia gasps. "Awe, best friend squad Holiday? That sounds awesome. And we were on your itinerary?"

Catra nods when Bow sends her a look. "Of course, I told you I'd visit you…surprise. Do you mind if we hang out here for a day or two?"

Perfuma looks exhausted but she politely says, "of course. You're all welcome here whenever you need, but we only have two guest rooms available so you'll have to double up."

"I'll just take the couch," Catra says before Adora can offer. It's only fair with their current situation. And she doesn't want to make Adora anymore uncomfortable than she already is. "I kick a lot in my sleep, so I'm actually doing everybody a huge favor."

Scorpia isn't too happy about her answer but she digs up the most comfortable blankets and pillows she can find. Bow and Glimmer stalk off to their room while Adora lingers—for just a second—before she goes to the empty guest room. "Sweet dreams," Scorpia says, turning the lights out.

"Night." Catra whispers.

And when the house grows quiet, Melog appears at her side. Catra glances at them before turning to stare up at the ceiling as her mind races.

6

"Morning."

Adora looks up as Glimmer joins her in the kitchen while the rest of the house sleeps. "Morning Glim." She takes a sip from her mug and when she pulls it away she sees Glimmer staring at her with wide—expectant—eyes. Adora cringes. "What's with that face?"

"What face?"

"Your *gossip* face."

Glimmer can't hold it in anymore. "Did you talk to Catra about what happened with Finn?"

Adora tightens her grip on the mug. “Why would I?”

Glimmer frowns. “I know you’re still mad at her for keeping this mission a secret but she didn’t have much of a choice. Adora…her friend died last night, right in front of her and she couldn’t stop it. She didn’t even have time to process it…she just moved on autopilot and cleared the scenes. And we kind of…fucked everything up by showing up at her door, I keep asking myself, if we would’ve just stayed in London, would Finn still be—”

“There was nothing we could do.”

“Exactly.” Glimmer whispers, “Finn was taken in an instant…he must’ve been so confused and scared…just, give Catra a break. Okay?”

Adora stares into the mug like the answers to all her problems will reveal themselves. She can sympathize with what happened to Finn—he seemed like a great guy, and Catra doesn’t make new friends often—but something about Catra keeping this mission from her just feels *off* . But, despite what she’s feeling, Adora gives Glimmer an appeasing nod.

“I guess I shouldn’t worry too much.” Glimmer says with a teasing smile, “at least you two made up.”

“What do you mean?” Adora asks, frowning.

Glimmer rolls her eyes. “You don’t have to keep it a secret. I know she snuck into your room last night. She wasn’t on the couch when I came to check up on her, Scorpia said it gets really chilly out here at night and Bow wanted to make sure she…”

Adora zones out. *Did Catra leave last night?*

“Guys,” Bow says, interrupting them as he sneaks inside without alerting the other residents. He holds up the daily paper. “Check out what’s on the first page.”

Glimmer read it aloud. " *Ted Allister is suspected of breaking-and-entering into an elderly, Joanne Bennett's, flat just last night. Neighbors heard Allister trying to sneak in through the window and managed to scare him off while others called the NYPD* …how does a random breaking-and-entering help us?"

"Doesn't Joanne Bennett sound familiar to you?" Bow asks.

Adora realizes, "she works with the Ministry of Magic. Her department focuses on keeping muggle-borns from mixing with magical entities that manage to slip out of their magical bounds. More specifically, she alters the memories of muggle-borns who've seen something they shouldn't have."

"So, not so random." Glimmer decides.

Bow frowns. "It's not a lot, but it's too much of a coincidence. Someone tries to break into Bennett's flat the night after Finn dies. Maybe they're trying to run us out of the city and this was another warning."

"And maybe the *last* warning we'll get," Glimmer mumbles.

Bow nods. "We have to check it out."

"Where's Catra?" Adora asks suddenly.

"Right here," Catra says swiftly as she joins them. "I caught the gist of it. So, when are we heading out?" Before they can answer, Scorpia and Perfuma interrupt them with barely contained smiles. Catra feels her fur bristle up all of a sudden. She has a bad feeling about whatever they're about to suggest. Catra asks wearily, "what's going on?"

"We had an idea." Perfuma says with a squeal. "It's been a while since we've been together and we think it would be nice if we had a—"

"Beach day!" Scorpia exclaims.

Catra hisses.

Catra stays far away from the water once they get to a beach; it's just a couple minutes from Scorpia and Perfuma's flat. She sets up her beach chair, grabs a book, and plans on staying under her umbrella during the entirety of their stay. Bow and Glimmer try to get Adora into the water but she settles for sitting a distance away from Catra on her own chair.

"You sure you're okay?" Scorpia's shadow gets to her before her question does.

Catra looks at her behind the lens of her shades. "I'm fine, don't worry about me. You should be worried about Perfuma, I think she's explaining the beauty of plant life to some confused little kid over there."

"Yeah, she does that." Scorpia says with a chuckle. She pulls up a beach chair and sits on the edge of it to give Catra her full attention. "Seriously though…you doing okay? Not that I'm not thrilled to have you here, but, it seems a little sudden. You're not working too hard right?"

Catra never stops working. "Of course not. I'm on Holiday aren't I? And it was about time I came to see you and the wife."

"Speaking of," Scorpia asks with controlled glee, "when are *you* getting married?"

Catra chokes on her breath. Her face goes red as she stutters, "I can't think about things like that!" Not when there's so much going on.

"I know, I know, work gets in the way." Scorpia gives her a break. "Thanks for the flowers you sent during our housewarming by the way. Perfuma loves them."

"No problem. It's the least I could do for not showing up."

Scorpia waves her off. “Nah, it’s fine, it was kind of weird to have a housewarming for our vacation house but…you know me.” Scorpia glances over to Perfuma again and winces when she sees the child she’s talking to start to cry. Scorpia shoots up saying, “uh oh, I think she’s telling him about global warming…Fuma!” Scorpia exclaims frantically, racing over to stop the chaos.

Catra smiles, watching Scorpia try to smooth things over. She feels eyes on her but, when she looks over, Adora's getting up from her chair to join Bow and Glimmer in the water.

7

“We would cancel but we scheduled our reservation weeks in advance, and it’s *so* hard to get a table at this place.” Scorpia explains nervously.

Bow reassures her, “it’s fine Scorpia. We’ll find a way to entertain ourselves.”

Perfuma says from the door, “flower, our ride’s here.”

Scorpia sends them one more worried look. “We’ll bring you all back some fancy wine,” she promises before closing the door behind her. They barely wait for the car to drive off before they’re grabbing their wands and gathering in a huddle.

“They should be gone for a couple hours so this is the perfect time to follow up on our lead.” Bow pulls out the newspaper clipping. “Glimmer and I are gonna do some recon around the area where Allister frequents, you and Catra can handle going to his house and seeing if he’s home, right? I doubt he’ll be hanging around but you never know.”

Adora nods. “His house is pretty isolated, I looked up the address and it’s in the middle of nowhere. With all that land, he has to be keeping something there.”

“Be careful.” Glimmer tells them.

Adora says, “you too.”

They don’t waste anymore time.

Adora drops Catra’s hand once they’ve landed safely outside Allister’s house. Isolated seems to be an understatement—there’s nothing but forest for miles. They pull out their wands and use them as flashlights to get a better look at the terrain. Catra says, “we should—”

“Split up.” Adora decides, “you check the house and I’ll see if he’s out back.”

Catra scoffs. “Are you insane? Splitting up is a terrible idea.”

“It’ll be faster this way.” Adora says resolutely. And maybe she’s still a little on edge about Catra’s intentions—she knows she just lost a friend—but Adora can’t just flick off her emotions like a switch. Luckily, Catra doesn’t argue with her.

“Come on, Melog.” Catra grunts, walking at a brisk pace with her magical companion at her side. Adora watches her go with a grimace. Catra’s right, they should stay together, but Adora just needs some space. She didn’t sleep much last night—tossing and turning as she overanalyzed every scene from the crime. She just can’t help but feel like they’re missing something. Something important.

Adora shakes the thoughts from her head. She’s on a mission right now so she needs to focus on finding Allister; if he’s connected then maybe some of their questions will be answered. Adora takes a steady breath and cautiously walks around the house. There’s a familiar trace of magic trailing behind her and to her despair—it comforts her.

The back of the house quickly comes into view. Adora spots an old wooden shed further back, but not much else is going on in the yard. There are logs of firewood stacked randomly in the center of the grass but aside from the shed, nothing screams out at her.

Adora slowly approaches the shed, the door opens with a spine-tingling *creak* . “Allister,” she whispers at the shadow of a hunched over man on the floor. *Is he dead?* Adora clutches her wand as her emotions start to flare. Her mind is racing with all kinds of possibilities when—he *moves* .

Adora aims her wand at him. “Don’t get any ideas.”

The man pushes himself up on steady arms. A cruel laugh slips from his mouth. His body moves at an inhumane angle as he swirls around to face her with a smile stretched across his face. Adora flinches at how *dark* his eyes are. His coat flaps under a sudden gust of wind, he sounds cheerful as he says “you came.”

Adora frowns. This seems familiar. It’s almost identical to the night she was chasing the man down the alleyway—he’d kept her distracted during Lonnie’s murder—but when she caught up to him it was just a hoax. The true culprit had placed an innocent man under an Imperius curse, controlling his actions, all while disguising them under a Polyjuice potion. But Allister, despite his actions, seems far too lucid. He knows what he’s doing. “How are you connected to all of this?” Adora asks, hoping to buy time so Catra can meet up with her. This mission just got *much* more complicated; Allister was found too quickly, someone directly involved in the murder wouldn’t given themselves up so easily. Which means, this whole interaction is just a—

“You’re zoning out,” Allister pouts, “...I thought you wanted answers…”

Adora gives, “why would you tell me anything?”

“You’re smarter than you look.” Adora’s frown deepens. He says with a wave of his hand, “consider this a gift for your last moments on this earth.”

Adora tenses up. She didn’t spot a wand on him so from what she can tell, he’s defenseless. Unless he can perform wandless magic. “What are you—”

"This is about *him* and you know it…it *always* goes back to him," Allister whispers.

"He… *Prime* ," she spits out because she isn't afraid of his name—not anymore. "...he died years ago, I made sure of it."

Allister squeals. "It's what you'd like to believe, isn't it? But the truth is, you could never get rid of him completely…not in this life, not in the previous, and not in the next—"

Adora's done with his foolish riddles. "We destroyed all the horcruxes! There is no bringing him back."

Allister turns serious. "His desires will continue to live on as long as *we* still exist. The *Prime Alliance* will continue to uphold our Dark Lord's wishes even in his death! And imagine *me* , a simple disciple, having the honor of carrying out his will by killing the very thorn in his side—the *golden girl* …chosen for greatness…but what have you really accomplished? Even if I die here with you—"

Adora backs away slowly as she feels a dark energy seep away at her from all angles.

"—there will still be more of us to finish his will. Release!" he shouts. Adora staggers out of the shed but her attempt is futile—she falls right into his trap. The logs of firewood stacked in the yard glow—vibrant purple—before they explode in a puff of smog. Adora's breath leaves her as a dozen *dementors* spring forth. She thinks Allister runs out of the shed to avoid the disaster, but she isn't sure—everything is happening so fast.

Adora trips and falls on her back. She closes her eyes and tries to summon a happy memory to combat the darkness—she can feel them ripping at her soul. But she can't think of one. All that fills her mind is Lonnie's dead body—staining the white of the carpet—how Mara took her off the case...she thinks about the lies Catra told her—even thinks about the killing curse Finn took, and how quick Catra was able to slip into a different persona immediately after his death.

Adora can feel herself slipping into cold nothingness. And, for a second, she starts to accept—

"Expecto patronum!"

A bright light encases the wooded area. Adora is too busy sucking up a desperate breath of air—of *life* —to cover her eyes. The dementors dissolve in a hiss. Adora staggers to her feet and watches as Catra's panther Patronus graces them with protection from the darkness. "You okay?" Catra asks, walking up to her side with frantic eyes.

"It was so bright," Adora whispers in awe. She stares off at the panther and wonders how Catra can find so much light in such a dark world.

"I thought about you." Catra admits softly, answering Adora's question as if she'd voiced it all along. And the revelation makes Adora snap; because, how can someone so convoluted and secretive make her feel so—

Adora draws her wand.

Catra stares at her with a neutral expression and calmly asks, "what're you doing?" Catra seems composed on the outside, seemingly unbothered by this turn, but Adora knows better—it's telling in the way Melog's fur stands on end, transforming into something red and jagged. Melog's growl makes the ground vibrate around them, and for the first time—it's directed at Adora. Melog circles her like the threat she is. Part of this hurts because, no matter how fond Melog is of her—their loyalty lies with Catra. Always.

"What took you so long to help me?" Adora asks, not taking her eyes off Catra.

Catra slips her hands into her coat pockets. It seems like a subtle move but nothing Catra does these days is for nothing. Catra says, "I didn't notice something was off until I felt—"

“I’m going to need you to stop *fucking* lying to me.” Adora snaps.

Catra presses her lips together.

It pisses Adora off even more. She shouts, “I know what your magic feels like, Catra. You used Melog’s invisibility cloak to keep a close eye on me when I said we should split up. You were here the whole time…just listening. So, why did you wait so long to help me?”

Catra raises an eyebrow. She’s far too calm for a person with a wand pointed at her face. Catra explains the situation like she’s talking to a five year old, “we found out their motive for breaking into Lonnie’s house that night and possibly for more. Now we know they’re part of the group of Prime loyalists dead set on keeping his memory alive; they’re probably trying to find out where the Death Eaters who weren’t sent to Azkaban are being kept so they can gain their numbers again. We can start narrowing our search by looking into the dementors and other Death Eaters who worked with Prime during the war…I don’t get why you’re so upset. It was just a good strategy.”

“Using me as bait sounds like a good strategy to you?”

Catra frowns. “Tell me you wouldn’t have done the same with me.”

Adora can’t find an easy answer. She hates how Catra’s right about this—how *well* she knows her.

“You and I are willing to do what it takes. It’s why we work.” Catra says, “but we can’t work if we’re aiming our wands at each other.”

Adora lowers her wand, and not soon after Catra takes her hands out of her pockets. Adora makes a note to remember the location where Catra keeps her spare wand in case she finds herself in this situation again. But it’s futile. Catra will just switch up the location now that someone’s noticed it. Adora tells her, “no more lies.”

Catra's face twists up. "I'm an Unspeakable, Adora, you know I can't tell you everything—I'm physically incapable." Adora does know the power behind the magical tie that binds an Unspeakable to their vows. Maybe she's being irrational in thinking Catra is strong enough to break through the bond—but she'll hold onto her hope. Catra's the strongest person she knows.

"No more lies," Adora repeats.

Adora…Catra…are you there? Bow's magic presses at their minds. They let down their mental guards to let his message flood through. *Not sure if you've had any luck with Allister, but Glimmer and I heard some plastered man talking about Lonnie's case. Don't freak out, but he's kind of tied up in the bathroom right now. We'll wait for you guys to interrogate him but please hurry and get here before Scorpia and Perfuma show up. Not sure we'll be able to talk our way out of this one if they do.*

Adora glances out into the woods where Allister escaped to. If they don't chase after him soon they might lose his magical signature while it's still fresh. Then they'll never find him. He might not be connected to Lonnie's case, but he still had access to a dozen dementors so it raises some questions and is worth the authorities looking into.

"I know you want answers," Catra says. "I'll catch Allister. Go."

Adora nods. "Be careful."

Catra says, "you too."

Even if their relationship is scarred—marked with an array of lies—Adora still has confidence in Catra. So, for now, she'll give her the benefit of the doubt.

When Adora makes it to Scorpia's flat she has to take a moment to steady herself before walking inside. Glimmer's at the bottom of the steps waiting for her when she gets inside. She ushers Adora to the stairs and says, "there you are. Where's Catra?"

Adora sighs. “She’s taking care of Allister. The arsehole decided to send a dozen dementors after us before escaping.”

Glimmer gasps. “What? Are you guys okay?”

Adora nods. “Catra’s Patronus took care of them, turns out the guy is a Prime loyalist who was just acting as a decoy to lead us away from the truth. Hopefully this guy you found knows something. How’d you two find him anyway?” She asks, following Glimmer upstairs.

“We were at some bar doing recon when we heard him, piss drunk, boasting about a job he did for Prime’s old organization. Says he was sent to get some documents from Lonnie’s house the night she was killed. So, we think—”

“He might be involved.”

Bow says, “no way” as they reach the top of the stairs. “This guy couldn’t kill a fly, but we think he might’ve seen something.”

“Let’s ask him.” Adora says, opening the bathroom door swiftly. The man in question is tied up on the toilet. He seems sluggish—probably still plastered—he blinks at them slowly but sobers up quickly when he notices the situation he’s in.

“What’s going on?” He stammers.

Adora demands, “what were you doing the night Lonnie was murdered? And before you try lying, do us a favor and don’t, my friends already heard you gossiping about it at the bar. So tell us, what were you doing there and what did you see?”

The man sweats under their gaze. He confesses, “please don’t tell my wife…I lost my job a couple…days ago…” he trails off with a whisper, “...déjà vu…”

Adora draws her wand and aims it at his face. It shuts him up fast. “Enough games. Tell us.”

“I was sent on a job!” He exclaims, “by some corporation, they wanted me to steal some documents from her so they could find some of their members who fought with them during the war. But I didn’t see anything!”

“This is getting us nowhere—”

Bow tries to stop her, “Adora!”

“Legilimens!” Adora shouts with vigor. The spell catapults her into his mind, she digs through his childhood memories, and skates past his wedding until she finds the memory she’s been seeking. And suddenly, it’s like she’s there. She can see through his eyes. She’s sitting in a car late at night, parked outside Lonnie’s house, she watches Lonnie run up the stairs into her house—in a rush, like she’s racing the clock—the memory flickers, for a moment, and then Adora sees herself running into the house and soon after so does her team of Aurors. When she’s seen all she can Adora pulls herself from his mind with a curse. “Damn it!” She shouts, frustrated with yet *another* dead end.

Bow hisses, “Adora. What the hell?”

Adora glances over at the man. He’s seizing from having someone invade his mind at such a rapid pace—saliva drips down his chin and soaks the collar of his shirt. Adora says, “he didn’t see anything” before she excuses herself from the bathroom. Bow and Glimmer don’t try to stop her.

Adora steps outside the house and takes a deep breath of air in. “Fuck!” she shouts into the night, not caring much for the neighbors, as she collapses on the steps of the porch. She drops her face into her knees to stop herself from blowing up the flower pots set up on the brick lining the porch. She’s just so *tired* of getting nowhere. Lonnie was family, and for her murderer to be roaming free…it *can’t* happen.

She won’t let it be true.

Catra and Melog—in their tomcat form—walk up to Scorpia's flat sometime later. Catra pauses when she finds Adora on the porch with her face between her knees. She nods at Melog, suggesting they take a walk to give her and Adora privacy despite how tense they were just a couple minutes ago. Still, Adora looks devastated; Catra can't help but sit down beside her. Adora doesn't look up, she's familiar with Catra's presence by now. Once she's settled, Adora leans into her side. Adora mumbles something Catra can't make out.

"What?"

Adora lifts her head and whispers, "he didn't know anything…not anything important." Adora runs a hand through her hair so roughly it makes her ponytail come undone. She mumbles, "I just can't…I'm *sick* of getting nowhere with this. Someone *has* to know something. But our last lead was fucking right outside and still didn't see anything…I don't know what else I can do."

Catra runs a hand through her hair. She says, "you're not alone. We're with you."

Adora's laugh is rough. Catra doesn't want to think about how Adora might've been crying before she showed up. "I think I would go crazy if you weren't with me…"

"So do I," Catra confesses.

A small flicker of Adora comes back, for a second, as she teases "I can tell…I'm what you think about to form your Patronus, huh?"

Catra's face flares but she keeps her cool. That's one thing she can't afford to lose. "Don't worry," Catra says, pressing a gentle kiss to Adora's forehead, "we'll find whoever's responsible."

Adora tightens her grip on Catra's arm, she says "I'll hold you to that."

Scorpia's Flat, New York

(moments before Adora's arrival)

Catra sneaks back to Scorpia's flat while Adora thinks she's tying up loose ends with Allister. And while Catra can't be in two places at once, Melog serves as a nice substitute for moments like this. It's just too good of an opportunity for Catra to let slip through her fingers so of course she finds a way to get past Scorpia's protective wards—it's not a difficult feat, they dormed together at Hogwarts so Catra knows Scorpia's magic signature and how to manipulate it—so it takes no time at all for Catra to slip in through the bathroom window where Bow and Glimmer locked up their only lead. The man is tied to the toilet seat when she slips inside; he startles at her entrance.

"What the hell—"

Catra waves her hand, placing a silencing spell on the bathroom. She teases her wand, pressing her ear to the door and listens. Bow's voice sounds muffled on the other side but she hears him ask, "did you hear something?"

"Shit." Glimmer says, "maybe Scorpia and Perfuma came home early. You stay here and watch him while I check out the front. Adora better get here quick so we can question this guy." It's not a surprise Catra made it here before Adora; while the blonde has always been stronger, Catra's always been faster.

"I'll make this quick." Catra digs the tip of her wand into the side of his neck. The man shakes under the crooked wood and meets her eyes wearily. "What do you know?"

"I didn't do anything! I swear! I didn't kill her!"

Catra hisses, "obviously."

He calms down just a bit, but the sweat trailing down the side of his forehead is telling. He stammers, "so then...what do you want with me?" He jumps as Catra digs into his pants pocket. She pulls out his wallet with a triumphant smile; she skims through its contents and gets exactly what she needs for her interrogation.

"I just need the truth. And fast before this turns ugly for you, *Alexander* ," Catra recites the information, "you have a wife, she just finished nursing school, and two twin daughters who just got accepted into their dream school. Thanks for the cliff notes you wrote behind their pictures. Now, your daughter's aren't exactly going to *Cornell* but—"

"Please," he begs, drowning in tears and choking on saliva, "leave my family out of this...I got fired from my job, I couldn't tell my wife, so I just took on this surveillance job...I didn't think she would die."

Catra asks, "what did you see?" She doesn't want to risk reading his mind with Legilimency, if she delves too deep she might leave him in a coma induced state and that'll be difficult to explain when Adora and the others find him. So Catra supposes she has to play nice for now.

He scrambles to say, "I didn't see anything important...I was hired by some cooperation to get some documents from a case the girl was working on—"

"Lonnie." Catra clarifies.

He nods. "She was the Unspeakable on the case, I don't know everything about what she was working on, just that they needed the information to find out where some of their warriors—who weren't sent to Azkaban after the war—were being held. They thought she might've known something."

"Walk me through the night. Like I was there."

He tenses up for a moment, and Catra pinpoints the exact moment when *realization* strikes. He tries to play it off but Catra's been studying people for years. He says with a shaky sigh, "I wanted to make sure no one was in the house when I went looking for the documents so I stayed in my car to keep an eye out. I saw her—Lonnie— *that* night, she was in a rush…she ran

inside, I think she was in there for maybe half an hour before some Auror showed up, she had blonde hair—”

Adora, she deduces.

“—she ran inside and then a few minutes later another team of Auror’s showed up behind her. That’s all I know. All I *saw* .”

Catra demands, “what else did you see?”

He shakes. “Nothing!”

“I know you’re lying.” Catra is careful not to leave a mark as she digs her wand into his throat. “Is this really worth your family—”

“ *You* ,” he says in a gasp, closing his eyes and turning his head away from her. “I saw *you* go in after Lonnie, before the blonde showed up.”

Catra pulls away from his neck once she has the truth she’d been expecting. She had her concerns of someone witnessing her enter Lonnie’s house—she should’ve snuck through the back window like she originally planned, but she had already been pressed for time that night and Melog was handling another issue so she couldn’t show up invisible. Her sloppy work is going to cost her if she doesn’t tie up these loose ends.

“Was that so hard?” Catra asks. She backs away from him as she hears the front door open. Adora must’ve just arrived.

He looks at her confused. “But…I thought you wouldn’t want me saying anything about you being there…”

“I don’t, but it's easier to ask you than scramble your brain in search of the memory. A bit less invasive.” Catra looks away from the door and turns back to him, “in one minute my friends are going to come in and interrogate you, and I’m a very private person, so I’d like to keep business separate from pleasure—well, aside from the pleasures I get from interrogating assholes.”

“Please, don’t do this…” he flinches as her wand digs into the side of his head with purpose. “I won’t tell them I saw you there! I swear!”

Catra makes a face. “I’m not so good with promises.”

He whimpers, “what are you going to do to me?”

“You’ll see your family soon, calm down, there’s not much penalty for peeping Toms. Although, you *were* purposely injecting yourself into a classified investigation so there might be some drawback from that. Nothing too serious, just a couple nights in solitary.”

He asks, “then why are you…”

“I can’t let anyone see your precious memories.” Catra explains, “don’t worry, I won’t take anything, I’ll just do a little...altering. Hold still.”

He shakes under her wand so Catra uses her free hand to hold him still. First she’ll need to make him forget—then she’ll begin the healing process. Catra steadies herself as the footsteps grow louder on the other side of the door. She whispers—

“Obliviate.”

Chapter End Notes

Next chapter will be up around the same time next week. Keep an eye out.

Here's the chapter title as of now: Revelations

Revelations

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

7

By the time Catra makes it back to Scorpia's flat it's close to midnight. After consoling Adora on the porch, it was up to Catra to alter Alexander's memory of the night—a bit difficult to explain to his wife and kids how he'd been kidnapped by a guy in a crop top and tied to a toilet—so, Catra took it upon herself to drop Alexander off at the bar like nothing happened. Melog volunteered to take the load off her shoulders but the house has been a bit tense since Catra came back. Bow is struggling between who he's more angry with, Adora—for leaving Alexander near comatose after reading his mind—or Catra, for getting them involved in all of this. Glimmer is barely holding him together.

Catra sighs, feeling the weight of exhaustion, as she walks into the living area. The hair on her neck stands up as she notices a shadowy figure leaning against the hallway wall. Catra slowly pulls her wand out. "So tense all the time," Adora sounds just as exhausted, but somehow she still manages to tease her. Catra drops her wand, all the fight leaving her, as Adora reveals herself from the shadows. She thought Adora would be asleep by now.

Catra snorts, enjoying the light atmosphere that's been absent as of late. "You're one to talk."

Adora rolls her eyes. However, the mood doesn't last—it never does—and Adora turns serious. "Is everything taken care of?"

Catra nods. "Yeah, he won't remember anything about this, and he's a common drunk around his town so his family won't be surprised when he shows up to the house all confused. Works out for all of us, we don't need him—"

"And they won't miss him if he disappears for a while," Adora finishes with a far off look.

"Exactly." Catra says as she starts arranging her pillows on the couch the way she likes it. After a moment she realizes something—it's *quiet* . Instantly suspicious, Catra looks around the living area and asks, "did Perfuma and Scorpia get back from dinner?"

Adora mutters, "they sent Perfuma's owl, Blossom, saying they won't be back until late tomorrow. They met this couple who invited them to a show so they're gonna get a hotel over there and have breakfast with them the next day, kind of like a double date I guess? I could tell how sorry Scorpia was about the late notice, she promised to bring us *six* bottles of wine to make up for it."

"Sounds like her." Catra asks with a mischievous grin, "how long do you think it'll take them to realize the couple they're hanging with are swingers?"

Adora laughs—it's nice to hear, especially when Adora looks like she's near the point of giving up on life. Adora says, "probably when they wake up to breakfast in bed."

Catra shakes her head. "They have to learn eventually." Tired of standing, she makes a move to sit on the couch when Adora holds out a hand—stopping her. Catra raises an eyebrow. "What's wrong?"

Adora looks away, mumbling "the couch probably isn't the best…" Adora trails off, stopping herself abruptly. Catra watches, not quite understanding what's happening. Adora closes her eyes and takes a deep breath in, then out, before turning to her with a look of determination. "You should stay with me. *I* would like it if you stayed with me," she corrects.

Catra has to stop herself from agreeing right away; being with Adora is exactly what she needs after the hectic day they've all had. But, at the same time, after everything that's happened she

would hate to think Adora is only doing this because she's in a vulnerable position—Catra doesn't want to take advantage of her so she asks, "are you sure? I don't want to make you uncomfortable—"

"You could never." Adora whispers, "please."

Catra's face grows hot under the reassuring gaze. She gives Adora a stiff nod before slowly walking around the couch to follow her lead. Catra gestures for Melog to make themselves scarce for the rest of the night. It takes some encouragement to do so. After their showdown outside Allister's yard, Melog has been a bit apprehensive about Adora—but, if they truly are emotionally connected to Catra, Melog will understand why she can easily forgive Adora for pulling a wand on her.

With a lingering look Melog settles down—feeling the emotions racing through Catra; all the ones she could never exactly put into words.

8

"Adora!" Glimmer shouts, frantically knocking on the door—waking Adora and Catra not too soon after. Adora begrudgingly removes herself from the bed. She rubs the sleep from her eyes, taking her time to prepare for her best friend's interrogation. The knocking gets louder. Glimmer demands, "Adora, open up!"

This time the noise completely jars Catra from her slumber—at first she'd just been hissing in her sleep, blindly clawing towards the sounds of discomfort. Catra looks around wildly—quickly understanding the position they're in. Adora holds a hand out to stop her before Catra can make a move. Catra looks at her, she hisses, "Glimmer's outside."

Adora spoils herself by pressing a lingering kiss to Catra's forehead. "It's fine, she already knows." Adora doesn't give herself the pleasure of seeing Catra's reaction—it would just end up distracting her, and then Glimmer would bust down the door out

of impatience. Instead, Adora slips a nearby hoodie over her sports bra clad self. Glimmer shoves her way in once Adora opens the door. "Good morning," Adora mumbles.

"Hey, good morning, I've got some— *Catra* ?" Glimmer falters for a second. She blinks twice at Catra who waves sheepishly at the intruder. Glimmer looks back to Adora with an expression that says *we'll talk about this later* before she snaps back to action. "I skimmed the paper and last night there was another break-in, but this time it was a set of flats instead of just one. And guess who's flat was listed." Glimmer hands over the newspaper clipping to Adora.

"235 West—wait," Adora goes cold as she realizes, "Catra, isn't this your address?"

Catra nods, curling her leg into her chest while the other sways over the edge of the bed. She drops her chin on her knee and says, "yeah, that's my place. Looks like they're getting tired of us involving ourselves in this."

"How can you be so calm about this?" Glimmer asks. "They *know* where you live."

Catra frowns, seeming unbothered by it all. "New York was never my home, and I never planned on staying there for the long haul. Besides, they won't find anything. I made sure of it."

"When do you mean by that?" Glimmer questions.

"I never keep anything important out in the open," Catra says like it's obvious, "the space I have in the city is just a decoy. I have other estates."

Glimmer leaves it alone for now and addresses a more pressing issue, "we've exhausted all our leads. We still have Allister but if he's really a Prime loyalist then he won't be doing much talking, and Alexander was a dead end even though he was *right* outside in his car the night everything happened—I still don't understand how he didn't see anything."

“Where is Allister?” Adora asks suddenly. When Catra said she would take care of him Adora never questioned what it would intel.

“Locked up in one of the properties I own. He won’t be getting out until I question him myself, then we can hand him over to the Ministry for all I care.” Catra says with a wave of her hand.

“You think he played a role in it?”

Catra shrugs. “Won’t know until I ask.”

Adora can think of a few unorthodox methods to get Allister talking, but she doubts Bow will be up for it after she left their last victim reeling from her mind invasion. But Glimmer is right, it’s not likely Allister will talk—especially if he fought during the war and is strong enough to resist their interrogation—no matter how *persuasive* Catra may be.

“If our only whiteness leads to a dead end then we’ll make our own lead.” Adora decides.

“What do you mean?” Glimmer asks wearily.

Catra looks at Adora, cautious as something flashes behind her eyes—realization. Adora isn’t surprised Catra caught on to her plan so quickly. “Adora...Mara took you off the case, you can’t just go back there...“

“Would someone care to fill me in?” Glimmer asks, looking between the two with barely contained irritation.

Adora holds her ground and says, “Lonnie’s house is still under investigation until they find the culprit—“

“Adora.” Glimmer tries to stop her once she realizes where this is going.

“—if I use a Polyjuice potion to disguise myself as one of the case workers then we might be able to find what documents Alexander

was sent to steal that night. And whatever's on them might point us in the direction of who had the *motive* to kill Lonnie." Adora explains it all in a rush before anyone can disagree. "What other options do we have?"

Glimmer shakes her head. "The place is probably *swarming* with Auror's—"

" *I'm* one of them! I know how they operate; it'll be easy for me to blend in."

"...if anyone catches you, you could lose your license."

Catra snorts, drawing their attention. She smirks, "I doubt they'll fire the *golden girl* ...but there will be some reprimanding—"

"Exactly," Glimmer exclaims.

"— *if* we get caught."

Glimmer splutters. " *We* ?"

"It'll be safer if she has company; I'll bring Melog with us in case we need to make a fast slip." Catra crosses her arms over her chest and raises an eyebrow at Glimmer's baffled look. "You can't be *that* surprised. We should honestly count ourselves lucky she told us about her plan before doing it alone."

Glimmer can't argue with Catra's logic. She sends them each a fierce glare that rivals *anything* Angella used to throw at them during their years at Hogwarts. "I *swear* , if you two die I'll personally bring you back to life and kill you myself...but seriously, I think this is crazy but we don't have any other leads..."

Catra says, "we'll just be sitting ducks if we do nothing. And if they found my flat there's no telling how long it'll take them to find us here." Adora sends a weary look Catra's way; she knows this wasn't Catra's idea—them camping out in Scorpia's flat—but it doesn't change the fact that they intentionally put their friends in danger. Adora stops herself from crossing the room and wrapping

Catra in a hug—a hug so tight it can protect her from the horrors of this world. There's still so much they have to talk about—so much Catra isn't telling her—but, she can't ignore how *safe* she feels when they're together.

For now, it's enough to outweigh her doubts.

"Well," Glimmer says with a sigh, "I guess you two are going back to London then."

"Yeah, I guess we are," Adora says, smiling at the thought of being home again. In all honesty, Adora had almost forgotten that doing an espionage mission in Lonnie's home would mean going back to London where it all started. All the fake leads have made her forget the reason they came to America in the first place.

"We should leave for London soon... *all* of us." Catra says, "but the only way we'll be able to go back is if we find something at the house, then we won't have a reason to stay here unless the evidence suggests otherwise."

"I'll go fill Bow in." Glimmer says, giving Adora one more *look* before she leaves them alone in the room.

Catra falls on her back in the bed and stares up at the ceiling with narrowed eyes, she mumbles "if we do this, infiltrate the house, then we can't second guess each other."

Adora whispers, "I know."

Catra glances at her, not buying it, and Adora supposes she deserves the skepticism. The last mission they did together ended with Adora aiming her wand at Catra's face. The memory makes her flush with shame, Adora reiterates, "I trust you."

Catra looks away when she has what she needs. Catra takes a deep breath before she leaps off the bed and starts moving around the room to grab a spare change of clothes. She mutters, "I'll make the potion since you've always been *shit* at them—"

"I wasn't *that* bad," Adora pouts.

Catra snorts. "You nearly blew your eyebrows off."

Adora shudders at the memory.

"...once I'm done with the potion we'll decide who to go as, I'm thinking we should be one of the junior Auror's you complain about, what're their names—Jeff and Kenny." Adora's surprised Catra remembers something she said in passing so long ago. Catra continues, not aware of Adora's tiny heartache, "they always give the junior Auror's the grunt work so I won't be surprised when they make us look through Lonnie's work files."

Adora sighs, "let's just hope they haven't already been stolen...a lot of people have been in and out of that house in the past couple of weeks."

"Don't worry," Catra says, "I'm sure we'll find something."

"Get out of there if anything goes wrong," Bow says, "I mean it. Don't be reckless…are you sure one of us shouldn't go with you?" Bow asks, second guessing the plan once he remembers how *terribly* reckless the *both* of them are.

Adora sends him a reassuring glance before she gets distracted by figuring out how to put on a tie. *Why does Kenny have to wear these damn things anyway?* Adora huffs, seconds away from wringing her own neck when Bow politely brushes her hands away and takes over. Adora pouts at how he adjusts it in a couple of seconds. "Thanks," she mumbles. "And this is the best option, you and Glimmer haven't been in the field in *years* —"

"Not liking the exaggeration on the years part," Glimmer comments from the couch.

"—but Catra and I literally do stuff like this for a living."

"And for fun." Catra grins.

Adora nods. “And for fun.”

Bow shakes his head. “Sorry, what part about sneaking into a murder investigation is fun for you and—never mind. Just, please, be careful. If they find out you're involved in this…”

“Catra’s got my back.”

Catra says, “and Melog is coming with us, if anything we’ll just turn invisible and slip out. Trust us.”

Bow still looks apprehensive but he lets up. “Okay. What do you need us to do while you’re away?”

“Distract Scorpia and Perfuma if they ask questions.” Catra looks at the clock, “they should be here soon once they find out about the swingers—“

“The *what* ?” Bow asks.

Catra says, “so just try to make up something about Adora and I sneaking around to do something.”

Glimmer interrupts her with a sly smile. Adora turns her back to the group to hide her face—it flushes before Glimmer even starts speaking. She knows where this is going. “Don’t worry, I’m sure they won’t think too much about it.”

“Alright!” Adora exclaims, wincing at the pitch of her voice. “Let’s hurry before we miss our window. Kenny and Jeff always smoke right before a shift so they should be in the backyard when we get there. You ready?” Adora asks, holding her hand out for Catra.

“Let’s go,” Catra says, clasping their hands together. Melog joins them, wrapping their tail around Catra’s leg just as Adora leads them out of the flat with a *crack* .

When the effects of the teleportation wears off, Catra takes a look around—they’re in the backyard, just far enough from the house

to not draw any attention to them. She doesn't have time to take in the fresh air of London—can't embrace the feelings of finally being back home—they have a mission to do. Adora meets her eyes—she presses a finger to her lips and gestures her head to the men squatting on the porch. A cloud of smoke engulfs them as they take slow drags.

Jeff (Catra recognizes the poorly grown beard Adora described with surprising detail) gets up from the porch with a yawn. He stretches his limbs and groans, "I'm sick of this case. All we do is hang around this house waiting for something to turn up, if it was anyone else they would've boxed everything up and labeled it a cold case."

Kenny frowns, "exactly, it *isn't* an ordinary case. She was an Unspeakable—"

"Yeah, yeah," Jeff waves him off, "so the information her killer got has to be found before they use it against the Ministry. I've heard it all before," he takes another drag. "Come on. We should get back before Octavia blows a fuse."

Kenny sighs, "yeah we should."

"Stupefy." Adora whispers the spell, but the effects are fierce—Kenny gets hit in the chest, the force of the spell knocking him on his back. Adora quickly aims at Jeff—shooting off the same spell—he buckles to the ground in seconds. Stupefy will only stun them temporarily so Catra runs over and places a sleeping spell on them so they have enough time for what they have planned. Melog cloaks them as she and Adora quietly carry the boys on their backs. They slip in through the back door and utilize the empty pantry closet in the kitchen. They lay the boys on the floor with their backs pressed to the wall.

"Bottoms up," Adora cheers, holding up her potion. She downs it in one go, face turning sour at the awful taste. Catra follows her lead, but her potion goes down with *practiced* ease. It makes Adora wonder just how often Catra's used this trick. There's no

time to ponder. The potion takes full effect—their bodies snap at odd angles, fighting against the norm, until they resemble the boys they've ensnared. Adora adjusts her tie and slicks her hair back to play the part. "What're you doing?" Adora asks, flushing as Catra uses her wand to remove the clothes from Kenny and Jeff until they're left in nothing but their boxers.

Catra shrugs, hiding the clothes somewhere nearby—out of sight, but not completely out of view that they can't find them if they need to. "Just in case we need a distraction," is all she says. Adora doesn't ask any follow up questions.

Once they're presentable they sneak out from the closet and slowly make their way into the living area.

"What're you two doing?"

Adora spins on her heel. Octavia, Chief of the Auror's—Mara's right hand—stops them in their tracks. Catra turns around and crosses her arms at her back; she doesn't try improvising like she normally does—one wrong move and they'll have the Ministry on their backs.

"Chief," Adora says without wavering. She straightens her posture and explains, "we were going to head out front and make sure no one gets past the premises."

Octavia hums, easing up at the display of obedience, "no need for that, we've got some men on the clock already."

"What can we do?"

Octavia seems to appreciate the initiative; she gestures to the office on the second floor. "I need you two in there; we have some files that need sorting," she shoves a box full of documents and binders into their arms respectively.

Catra hopes she isn't pushing her luck when she asks, "anything to look for in particular?"

Octavia waves her off. “Honestly...this goes beyond a stack of papers, but the big boss wants us to keep an eye on these until she gets the chance to take a look herself. Just organize them so she doesn’t have to do so much searching, got it?”

Adora nods. “Yes, Chief.”

Octavia grunts, “get to work, scouts.”

They offer their compliance by giving Octavia a dutiful nod before making their way to the second floor. Catra closes the door upon entry to the office, she stays pressed against it until she’s sure Octavia is out of earshot. Adora doesn’t have the patience for it; she dumps her box on Lonnie’s mahogany desk and starts pulling out stacks of papers. Catra joins her once she’s made sure the coast is clear.

“Melog,” Catra says, making the magical creature reveal itself to the room, “let us know when you see someone coming.” Melog gives her a dutiful *Mwr* before they turn their cloak on to fulfill the task as lookout.

Adora hands Catra half a stack of papers from one pile she made, “check this stack. Look for anything that’s worth having someone break into Lonnie’s house for…or worth—”

“I know,” Catra says softly.

Adora’s glad Catra stopped her before she had to say it out loud. It was already enough having to *see* it with her own eyes. Adora swallows back a lump of something vile that tries to crawl up her throat. Adora shakes her head. *Focus.*

Adora tears through the papers with a new ferocity as she gets closer and closer to the end of the pile—stack after stack—until her fingers start to bleed from the papercuts she’s injecting upon herself. “Damn it,” she curses once she reaches the bottom of the box, “I’ve got nothing, please tell me you’ve found something.” Adora begs while she starts scouring through the desk drawers.

Catra shakes her head. She tosses the stack she'd been skimming and mumbles, "not yet."

Adora's groan of frustration is telling, but Catra ignores it for now and grabs the box Octavia gave her to carry. Catra blindly hands a couple stacks to Adora and takes a smaller pile for herself. They don't even know what they're looking for. Catra *hates* going in blind—she's normally two steps ahead of the game but now...she's never felt so helpless. Catra doesn't go digging for information right away. She closes her eyes and takes a second to breathe. She just needs time to *think.* They're obviously not going to find anything the rest of the Auror's haven't already, but...the fact that they're still *searching* Lonnie's house—weeks after the murder—tells Catra that they must be looking for the same thing.

They're close.

Catra opens her eyes and slowly skims through the documents she'd grabbed. *Boring…not important..* Catra's nearing the end when something in particular makes her freeze. Her hands shake. *Impossible.* It can't be true—Catra re-reads the same paragraph over and over again until she's forced to address the truth. Adora looks up in the silence—always tuned into Catra whether she likes it or not. Adora frowns, "what is it?"

Catra almost crumbles the paper in her tight grip. Thankfully, she doesn't need to lie her way out of this one because Melog is suddenly reappearing before them looking frazzled. *Mwr,* Melog alerts her of the approaching company. Catra folds the paper into her coat pocket—aware of Adora's watchful gaze—before she says, "it's time to go."

Adora is thirsting for answers, "but…what did you—"

" *Adora* ," she growls, "it's time to go. Now." She prays that Adora will hold onto the promise she made yesterday—to trust her with everything she has—and thankfully, she does. Adora snaps her mouth shut and latches onto Catra's shoulder as Melog cloaks them with invisibility just in time for the door to swing open.

Octavia barges inside, she startles when an empty room greets her. Octavia shrinks in on herself, "I'm *so* sorry Director, they were just in here...I don't know where they went." Octavia hisses under her breath, "I'm gonna *kill* those idiots, never trust a junior Auror to do anything simple."

Mara calms her frantic right-hand down with a gentle smile. "It's no problem."

"They had the easiest job," Octavia huffs, looking around the room at the scattered pages and folders.

"This case has been quite the hassle, with the American's taking the lead on this it's left everyone on our end a bit restless." Mara's easy going smile never falls. Despite the situation Adora feels herself calm—Mara has always had that effect on people; it's one of the reasons why she's the Director of Magical Security—she brings a feeling of peace and reassurance. "Maybe they got pulled somewhere else."

"They're out here, Chief," one of the lead Auror's shouts from down the hall.

Octavia is fuming as she stomps out of the office. "Where are they?"

Catra swiftly guides Adora out of the office while the Auror's are distracted. Catra quickens her pace—careful not to make a sound—when Adora's grip tightens on her shoulder. *Just a few more steps…*

"Well?" Octavia demands, "where are they?"

"Chief…they're—uhm—in the closet."

Octavia snarls, " *what* ?"

Catra barely holds back a laugh as the entire night crew of Auror's huddle around to see the mess she and Adora left behind. Octavia shoves her way to the front, when she reaches the door her face

flares—she takes a steadying breath but it still looks like she's about to blow steam from her ears any moment now. Octavia kicks at one of the dosing scouts and exclaims, "would someone like to explain to me why these junior cadets are passed out in the closet in nothing but their underwear?"

Catra hears a round of laughter just as she and Adora slip through the front door.

They don't stop running until they reach an empty alleyway, Adora slows her sprint into a trot as the light from Lonnie's house fades further with the distance. The potion starts to wear off. Adora slumps against the wall to catch her breath, looking down at the baggy clothes—they seem out of place now. Catra leans on the wall adjacent to her. Her mixed colored eyes—something that's always drawn her to Adora—flicker under the moonlight. Adora sends her a goofy smile, fueled by the rush of adrenaline from being back in the field, but it slips when Catra returns it with a grimace. Something's off. Adora stands up straighter as Catra merely gives Melog a *look* before the creature is disappearing from her radar—magic and all.

They're alone.

Adora feels doubt eat away at her mind and she has to ask, "what's in your pocket?" She remembers seeing Catra slip a piece of paper into her coat just before Octavia and Mara came inside the office. Catra only has a couple bodily cues alerting Adora when something's caught her attention; one of those cues is her eyes narrowing into slits. Adora's pretty sure she noticed the cue earlier.

Catra doesn't deflect like Adora expects her to—or maybe, in a way, she does—because suddenly Catra's holding out her hand.

"Do you trust me?"

Despite everything—she does. And so, Adora silently takes Catra's hand—an act of blind faith—and, in an instant, they disappear with a *crack* .

Adora holds onto Catra long after they've arrived at their destination, she tries to get an idea on where they might be but she knows it's futile—Catra is so *secretive* about work related things so it doesn't surprise Adora when she doesn't recognize the warehouse space. The room may be bigger than it appears but one too many of the ceiling lights are dead while the rest of them flicker on and off—cloaking them in blotchy shadows. Catra holds her grip on Adora's arm when Adora tries to step away to look around. Adora turns to her—confused by her actions—when she realizes Catra hasn't taken her eyes off whatever she's staring at in the distance. Adora squints in the direction but it's futile without the enhancement Catra has from being a hybrid.

"Seriously?"

Catra's ear twitches, she looks sheepish as she says "sorry, but this just got a *lot* more complicated." She pulls out the slip of paper she stole from the office as proof of her claim.

Adora's blood goes cold as a lone figure emerges from the shadows. Adora almost chokes on the shark inhale she takes before she whispers—

" *Lonnie* ?"

Chapter End Notes

Have I mentioned that Catra is an unreliable narrator?

Interlude

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Downtown New York isn't where Catra wants to be right now, especially with the downpour of rain that's not set to let up until early tomorrow morning. Unfortunately, her curiosity has peaked.

It takes a lot to get Catra on a case, with her extensive expertise in mind manipulation (thanks to her years working as an Obliviator) so when an employer wants her, it isn't cheap. And she told Bow the truth—it had been a pleasant surprise when she ran into him in New Zealand but, most importantly—she wanted to step away from being an Obliviator. The memories she has to subject herself to—unable to change the past—has chipped away at her bit by bit. Her experience has left her jagged. Catra's feeling of having a low locus of control drove her into becoming an Unspeakable; this way, maybe she could make a real difference out on the front lines like Adora.

So, when Catra first received an owl from the American Ministry of Magic in New York—practically begging for her assistance—she was inclined to accept but only because of her own personal agenda.

"Thanks for coming."

Catra pushes back her hood, shaking off the drops of rain that persists from her walk over. Melog—the new addition to the disaster that is Catra's life—leaves her side to scope out the strange warehouse she's been called to.

"You don't trust me?"

Catra shrugs, looking over at the strange crates piled up in the corner of the warehouse instead of paying her accomplice any attention. Catra mumbles, "can't be too careful."

“Catra, I’ve seen you in diapers.”

Catra can’t help but shoot back, “you wore them too.” A brief silence overcomes them before a shower of laughter. Melog trails back over, stopping their inspection, and playfully nudges Lonnie’s leg in passing. Catra walks closer so she can see Lonnie more clearly under the beam of light above their heads. She asks, “are you doing okay? You know, aside from the whole somebody trying to kill you thing.”

Lonnie looks away, hiding the broken expression Catra manages to catch a glimpse of anyway. Lonnie confesses, “I miss my family...it’s only been two days but I just can’t...Luce must be asking Kyle and Ro where I am, and don’t think I can—“

“Hey, it’s gonna be okay.” Catra promises, holding Lonnie by the shoulders to stabilize her. “We’ll catch the arsehole and then you can be with your family again.”

Lonnie nods shakily before composing herself. She gives Catra a look of appraisal saying, “I’m just glad your glamor charm was enough to fool him—whoever was controlling him.”

Catra mutters, “you noticed it too?”

“Yeah,” Lonnie says with a scoff, as if she’s annoyed at Catra for thinking she wouldn’t notice such a spell. “Whoever was sent to kill me was under an Imperius curse so it means—“

“Someone else is pulling the strings on this.” Catra asks, “but you’re sure the one who was under the spell is somewhere in this city? I already purchased a flat here so you’d better be sure.”

Lonnie frowns. “I am. I wouldn’t have come here if I wasn’t.” Her shoulders drop a little as she confesses, “and no matter how annoying you are—“

“You do say the sweetest things.”

“—I’m glad the Ministry put you on this case.”

Catra asks, “how’d you find out they were going to reach out to me?”

Lonnie smirks despite the situation. “I’ve been an Unspeakable for a couple years now, and when you work in the Ministry for as long as I have you learn how to...manipulate things in your favor when it warrants.”

“You fixed it.” Catra hums in admiration. It’s something she would’ve done, and it’s impressive how Lonnie was able to sneak into the American Ministry of Magic’s headquarters—fixing the data—so they’d reach out to Catra, ultimately putting her on Lonnie’s murder investigation.

“Why me?” Catra asks after a moment.

Lonnie says, “because I know you’re willing to do whatever it takes.”

Catra wishes she wasn’t the right person for this job—wishes she wasn’t hardened by the war and haunted by the memories she’s seen. Still, someone has to do it.

Catra decides to move this along by asking, “why are we here? Melog said they saw something in the back. You have a gift for me?”

Lonnie gestures for her to follow, she leads Catra further into the warehouse space until they reach a bolted door; Lonnie quickly works at removing the protective wards before opening it. Catra’s eyes go wide—pulse growing quick—as she spots a warlock chained to the floor by the wrists. He shouts at them but nothing comes out his mouth. *Silencing spell* , Catra deduces with ease.

Catra pulls out her wand and twirls it like a baton. Catra grins, “you shouldn’t have.”

Lonnie leans against the wall with a frown—it’s directed at the man. “I was doing some recon in the city when I noticed him

following me. I hit him with a hex once I was able to get him alone."

Catra frowns. "You can't be out in the city, people think you're—"

"This was before I knew for sure you'd be working on my case, and I was in disguise." Lonnie says exasperated, "I was getting restless doing nothing. I won't do it again."

Catra nods. "Okay."

Lonnie waves her hand asking, "you gonna question him or what?"

"I doubt he's involved in your case, he's probably just a thief who was trying to catch you off guard." Catra glares at the warlock when he fights against the chains again. She spots a familiar tattoo on the side of his neck. "He's got an Azkaban tattoo."

Lonnie grunts, "I noticed, it's why I couldn't let him go."

"How the hell did he get out?"

"Don't ask me." Lonnie says, growing a tad bit impatient. It's an odd look for her. Catra's just about to ask Lonnie to remove her silencing spell when she hears a muffled voice coming from her coat pocket. *The two-way mirror* .

Catra puts her finger up saying, "give me a few minutes."

Lonnie sees right through her and asks in disbelief, "are you two *still* not together?"

"Can you just," Catra huffs, face growing hot, "put a silencing spell on yourself."

Lonnie rolls her eyes but does as she's told. Catra pulls out the mirror just in time to hear—

"...I've had a shitty day and the only person I want to talk to is—"

“Adora?” Catra can’t help the surprise seeping from her voice. She never thought Adora would actually hold onto their mirror after all these years.

“Catra?” Adora sounds just as baffled, though, there’s a slur in her voice.

Catra smirks because, “are you drunk right now?”

Adora tries to deny it and Catra catches her in the lie. Somehow their conversation drifts to talking about bars of soap and werewolves before Adora says—

“I just want to talk to you.”

Catra’s stomach flutters. “Okay,” she whispers. The mood is cut short when something green flashes behind Catra. *Damn it, Lonnie.* Catra glares at her friend, watching the warlock fall to his side from being hit by a powerful spell Catra isn’t familiar with; she makes a mental note of asking Lonnie to teach it to her.

“Where are you?”

“Nowhere important.” Catra says, distracted for a moment as Lonnie mouths: *I got tired of waiting.* Catra steps further away from the battle zone and looks back at Adora. Catra says, “I’d floo over but I’m in between flats at the moment.”

“It’s okay.”

Catra whispers, “you said something about a bad day.”

Adora looks away.

“That bad?” Catra asks, not entirely prepared to listen for just how terrible Adora’s day has been. She leaves the interrogation to Lonnie. It’s only when Adora drifts off to sleep does Catra gently place the mirror back in her pocket to join in the twisted affair.

Lonnie removes the silencing spell with her wand. She says, "he's not involved, he's just an arse who thought I'd have some money on me. I say we drop him off at the nearest Auror's office and let them deal with him. Azkaban is too good for him."

Catra pulls Lonnie away from the warlock and lowers her voice saying, "sorry I took so long."

"I get it," Lonnie frowns, "but next time I expect you to give my case your *complete* attention. I can't have half of your best. I need to know you're serious about this."

Catra argues, "I am...but what if—"

"Getting more people involved will only screw things up." Lonnie's face softens just a bit. "You want Adora to be safe don't you?"

"Of course I do."

"Then you can't involve her." Lonnie gestures to the warlock saying, "let's get rid of him while it's still dark."

Catra takes a moment to steady herself. Images of *that* night—the cause of all of this—flash through her mind like an explicit movie. It's still stuck in her mind. Catra remembers being in London on one of her rare occasions after finishing a job in Europe when Lonnie reached out to her from the fire under the mantle in Catra's living space.

Catra slumps over on the couch with a content sigh. It's been a while since she's been home and it definitely shows; looking around the vacant space, Catra is starting to appreciate her decision of having Melog explore London for the night. Maybe while they're gone she can make this place seem a bit more lived in.

Catra contemplates going food shopping when a better idea pops up. She's just about to reach out to Adora and the others when her fire rages as it distorts into a familiar face.

Catra smiles in surprise, "I never expected you of all people to make house calls."

"Hey," Lonnie's tone is unusually stiff—it puts Catra on edge right away. Catra slowly sits up as Lonnie says, "sorry, I know I'm running a little late, but I'll be there soon…"

Catra's mind starts racing—she never planned anything with Lonnie tonight. Catra slowly stands, she teases the wand in her coat pocket and pays attention to any important cues Lonnie may have for her.

"...I'm at some bar not too far from your place."

Catra asks calmly, "do you want me to meet you there? What's the address?" If Lonnie needs backup for whatever situation she's in, then Catra will be there in a second.

"No, don't worry about it...I just have to stop by my house and grab a few things." Lonnie glances over her shoulder before saying in a rush, "but I've gotta go, I think there's a line forming outside the loo. I'll see you soon."

Catra doesn't wait for the flames to dissipate into its normal form before she races to Lonnie's house.

When Catra got to the house she and Lonnie barely had any time to manipulate the crime scene in their favor. The worst part of the night was when Catra saw Adora running into the house—always the first Auror on the scene—eager to stop what had already been done.

Guilt starts seeping into Catra's chest; Adora hasn't specifically told Catra what's been bothering her, but Catra knows it's Lonnie's *death* causing Adora this inner turmoil. Catra can stop her pain, but she won't—can't. She's bound by the Unspeakable vow, and by her own promise to Lonnie.

And so, with her mind made up, Catra shakes away her nerves and pulls out her wand. The warlock shakes as she approaches

him with a slanted grin. It’s not fair for Lonnie to have all the fun. Catra gears up a spell of her own—it burns on her tongue but not as much as it’s going to eat away at her victim.

For this story, she supposes she’ll play the role of the villain—Catra just hopes Adora can forgive her.

Chapter End Notes

The conversation between Catra and Adora was taken from Chapter 1, but now we're getting it from Catra’s perspective in this short little Interlude.

Also, I threw in an psy/soc term for you guys: locus of control- our perception of whether something is within our internal control (if I do bad on a test it’s because I should’ve studied longer) or based on external factors outside our control (if I failed the test it’s because the teacher hates me).

New chapter will be up next week hopefully, and I'll be back to writing the chapter in my normal lengths (5k ish). This was short but it seemed like a nice break from all the crazy stuff that's going on.

The Failsafe

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

9

A chill creeps over the warehouse as Adora looks at Lonnie and wonders if she's seeing a ghost—something conjured up from her mind to help her cope with the loss—but when she reaches out for Catra's arm, in a failed attempt to steady herself, Adora quickly realizes it's not an illusion. *Lonnie* is here, standing right in front of her. Adora's body shakes as an array of emotions rush through her, all the while Lonnie steps further into the light wearing a slight grimace; as if Adora's presence is unwanted. The rush of emotions subsides—for a moment—and Adora finds herself focusing on the *anger* she's feeling in this moment. Something red and hot bubbles to the surface. Catra takes a shaky step back as if she can feel the approaching storm, even Melog slithers into the shadows to seek shelter.

Lonnie sounds exhausted as she says, "Catra...what were you thinking?"

Adora's hands tighten into fists, they shake at her side as she glares at the woman she once thought of as her sister—with all the shit they've been through growing up at the orphanage with Weaver before finding solace at Hogwarts. Adora doesn't recognize her own voice as she asks, "is that all you have to say?"

Lonnie finally looks away from Catra and gives Adora a stern once over. "This doesn't concern—"

"Adora..." the plea is weak and jagged—Adora is too caught up in her own feelings to notice the distress in Catra's voice.

Adora's too busy drawing her wand; she aims it at Lonnie and shoots a nasty stinging hex at her side. It's nothing lethal, just

something to show Lonnie how pissed off she is with this entire situation.

“Ouch!” Lonnie gasps, nearly falling to her knees as she grips her side in agony. Seeing the pain etched on her face fills Adora with slight comfort; it’s nice seeing Lonnie experience pain because it means she’s *alive.* Adora’s eyes start to fog as the revelation echoes in her mind.

The sound of Adora’s wand hitting the floor fills the warehouse. Lonnie barely has any time to react before Adora is engulfing her in a hug.

“You’re alive,” Adora whispers in awe.

Lonnie nods when she pulls away. Lonnie looks sheepish as she says, “look, I didn’t mean it like that...I’m glad to see you, but this doesn’t concern you Adora, and *Catra* shouldn’t have brought you here.” There’s an underlying issue hidden beneath her tone but Adora ignores it for now.

“I can help,” Adora declares. “I was there—“

“I know.” Lonnie says, “we saw you.”

Adora grows still. “ *We?* ”

Lonnie runs a hand through the locks of her hair, she looks off to the side as if she’s reliving the moment in her head. She confesses, “the night you were on the case, an hour prior, I was running some errands when I noticed someone following me. I went to this pub to get some space from them and contacted Catra for backup. They were under an Imperius curse; they came to my place looking for something, and they were willing to kill me for it…”

The documents, Adora recalls the slip of paper Catra is still in possession of.

"...I barely had time to hide Lucy in the closet before they broke inside." Lonnie's face looks ashen as she says, "Catra placed a glamor spell on a clone of Prime's she had locked up at one of her estates to make it look like me. That's the body they have at the morgue."

Adora laughs, because of course Catra of all people would hold onto one of the Prime clones from the war without anyone noticing. She wouldn't be surprised if Entrapta has a few of them as well, maybe that's where Catra was able to get it under such short notice.

"So wait," Adora says when she realizes with a start, "you've *known* from the start?" Adora feels sick to her stomach, she turns to Catra—unsure if she wants to hit her or question her—when she suddenly takes a *look* at Catra.

There are beads of sweat racing down the side of Catra's ashen face—she can hardly keep her eyes open as she grips her arm with a grimace. And suddenly nothing matters. Adora inspects Catra frantically, she grabs her by the shoulders with a gentle grasp and asks softly, "Catra what's wrong?" In her peripheral Adora can see Melog pacing anxiously.

Catra's eyes meet hers with a fierceness—as if she's fighting whatever illness is overtaking her body. Catra digs into her coat pocket and pulls out the crumbled slip of paper she stole from the crime scene only moments ago. Adora frowns as Catra eagerly slips it between her fingers—Catra's hands are shaking throughout the encounter—Adora demands again in panic, "Catra, what's going on?"

"I don't have much time so just *listen* to me for once," Catra says, gripping Adora's shoulder tightly. She explains in a rush, "Lonnie didn't want me to get you involved because she —*we*— didn't want anyone else getting hurt in all of this...you *saw* what they did to Finn…"

Why does this feel like a goodbye? The thought makes Adora tighten her grip on Catra's wrists—refusing to let her go without a fight.

Catra shakes her head and says, "I would have kept you in the dark until I found the real killer even if it meant seeing you torn up about Lonnie—I don't take any of that back and I'd do it again to protect you—but this goes beyond just Lonnie and I now." She nods towards the paper, "this is an invoice, someone was getting wireless money sent to them from Prime's alliance—"

"A *death eater,"* Lonnie realizes with a growl.

Catra corrects her, "a double agent."

Adora shakes her head. "What does any of this have to do with me?"

"Adora," Catra says, "I'm gonna have to go away for a while—I don't know how long—but while I'm gone I need you to be careful."

"Catra what—"

"The Ministry of Magic."

An invisible jolt passes over Adora and Lonnie as Catra's confession hits them like a vicious stunning spell. Adora almost doesn't believe her but honestly after all this, why would Catra lie now? Surely Lonnie being alive is the pinnacle of Catra's lies.

Adora whispers shakily, "what?"

"Lonnie didn't know about the invoice in her office, it was in a box she was supposed to go through—for a case she'd just got assigned to, she was supposed to look into where the rest of Prime's death eaters are hiding so they can be sent to Azkaban for their crimes. But the invoice shows someone in the Ministry is profiting off being a member of Prime's group," Catra says. "It's enough reason for them to want Lonnie dead—imagine getting

away with being a death eater—taking dozens of innocent lives without facing repercussion—only to have this information resurface and ruin the reputation you've managed to build under everyone's nose."

Too much information is running through her mind, but Adora wonders "how does this involve me?"

Catra confesses, "the invoice is addressed to someone in the Ministry of Magic—the *Auror* division."

Adora's heart nearly stops. "What?"

Catra looks apologetic—as if she wishes she could do something to make it untrue—but she continues with the long awaited truth. "It would've been impossible for me to keep *this* from you…if I kept leaving you out of the dark, it would get harder for me to move freely—especially now that this case is tied to your department."

Adora let's Catra's hands slip from her grasp as a mental whirlwind hits her with enough force to leave her speechless. *Someone in my division tried to kill Lonnie…someone in my division is a death eater and I never knew…* Adora feels her body shake—she isn't sure if it's from anger or shame; anger for the possibility of a death eater getting away with all the harm they've caused, and having the nerve to pretend to be their ally, and shame for wearing an Auror's cloak, a symbol of protection, when her department is full of greed and corruption. Maybe the system truly is broken, *who was I to think I could make an actual difference.*

A spine tingling grunt snaps Adora from her inner turmoil. The reality of the moment returns when Catra is no longer able to hold herself together, and in a moment of weakness—Catra falls. Adora is still shaken from everything, but her body moves on its own. Adora holds her arms out and soon she and Catra collapse to the floor. Adora looks for any wounds Catra could have gotten from their brief mission but there's nothing.

“Catra,” she hates how weak she sounds.

Catra says in between a grimace, “Melog.”

The magical creature looks stable—it comforts Adora a little—as they race to Catra’s side eagerly. Melog nudges Catra’s shoulder and awaits instruction.

Catra smiles softly at her trusted ally as she says, “keep her safe.”

Adora’s eyes go wide. “Catra wait—”

A bright spark erupts within the warehouse, Adora turns around to protect her eyes and when she turns back around she wishes she hadn’t. The warmth is gone from her hands. *Catra* is gone. Melog whimpers, nudging the area where Catra was just at with their nose.

Adora turns to Lonnie with a shout, “where is she?”

“Adora—“

“Don’t bullshit me,” Adora demands, jumping to her feet in a flash. She points at Lonnie and says, “I know this has something to do with her being an Unspeakable, so tell me.”

Lonnie’s face pinches up—it’s not what Adora wants to see.

“Tell me,” Adora repeats. “She’s gone. So that means I’m the only one who can help you solve this case.”

Lonnie sighs. “I don’t know where she is.”

“I fucking swear—”

“She took on my case as an Unspeakable,” Lonnie explains, “and involving you in this case must’ve been connected to her vow.”

Adora shakes her head. “What…what happens when a vow is broken?”

Lonnie frowns. “Usually, you die.”

Adora flinches.

“...but Catra managed to explain the lead to us with time to spare so they probably won’t be killing her,” Lonnie says, “she seemed like she was struggling to stay here so I’m guessing they were using some kind of magic to pull her to another location so they can talk with her about the case. She didn’t really *tell* you anything but there could be a penalty for involving you. Either way, there’s nothing we can do now but wait until she gets back.”

Adora asks, “have they ever done this to you? Called you to another location?”

Lonnie shakes her head. “No, but I’ve heard about it. No one knows where the location is, and only the person who’s being called can be sent there…it’s why Melog can’t follow their magical connection.”

Adora is reminded of the creature as Melog paws at the ground again—mourning Catra’s disappearance. *They must feel so alone without the connection bonding them to Catra.*

“Have some faith in your girl,” Lonnie says with a grin, “she’s stronger than you know.”

Adora huffs, “I know that.”

“Do you?” Lonnie frowns. “Because she kept my secret even when you and the golden crew started doubting her, even when Finn was killed in front of her…”

Adora clutches her chest—she doesn’t know how Melog feels directly, but Adora bets they feel just as empty as she does right now. Normally she can at least feel a small trace of Catra’s magic, but now—there’s nothing. Wherever Catra is, she has left this world entirely.

Adora, she feels Bow knocking at her mind; she lowers her mental shields to let the message in. *Something crazy just happened, Blossom came with a letter from Mermista; it's addressed to Perfuma and Scorpia but they're still not back yet so Glimmer and I were just going to give Blossom a snack—we weren't snooping I swear—but there was a newspaper from London attached to the letter. I don't think I should tell you this when you're away so just hurry back. I know you're not still at the crime scene, but if you are—get out of there. Now.*

"Bad news?" Lonnie asks, carefully reading Adora's expression.

Adora frowns. "Don't know yet."

Lonnie nods. "Let me know if it's anything important. While you're out, I'll do some research on the people who work in the Auror division and see if I can make a connection."

Adora grunts in approval, not sure if she's capable of speaking without breaking down to tears with everything that's going on. *Catra was able to handle this,* she reminds herself, *now it's my turn to.* As if they're thinking the same thing, Melog bumps their head into her leg. Adora smiles softly, scratching behind their ear gently.

"Looks like it's just you and me for a while, buddy." Adora says. "You ready?"

Melog mewls—low in their throat—before wrapping their tail around Adora's leg. Adora scoops up her wand and slides it back into its protective holder just in time for Melog to encase her with their magic and soon they disappear with a *crack* —Adora doesn't even have to tell them where she needs to go.

Adora lands outside Scorpia's flat and without wasting any time she invites herself inside. She barely has time to close the door before Bow and Glimmer are running up to her looking frantic.

Melog bristles at her side, slipping away from the approaching duo so they can sulk alone in peace.

Adora asks, "what's going on?"

"Where's Catra? She's supposed to be with you," Bow says urgently.

Adora swallows a lump in her throat. Telling them what happened to Catra would involve her having to explain how Catra managed to fake Lonnie's death—explaining how Lonnie's *alive*— how coming with Adora to America was somewhat for nothing. She isn't ready for the backlash she'll get from them knowing the truth so she decides to stretch it for as long as she can.

"She had to step out for a second but she'll be back," Adora tells them. "But seriously, what's going on?"

Glimmer asks, "did you find anything at the crime scene?"

Adora looks away, sullen. She pushes back the shame and instead pulls out the crumbled slip of paper. "Catra found this invoice, it's addressed to someone in the Ministry of Magic…the…the *Auror* division." Adora looks up—the eyes of pity they send her cue her in quick that they're already aware of the truth. Adora frowns, "you already know…how do you—"

"I think you should see this." Bow says, handing her the newspaper they received in the mail from London. "Mermista sent it over for Scorpia and Perfuma."

Adora nearly drops the paper, "what?"

Glimmer places a comforting hand on her shoulder and says, "this is circulating all over London."

Adora asks in a whisper, "how long ago? Catra and I were *just* there a half hour ago."

Bow does the mental math and guesses, "probably fifteen minutes ago…the news is spreading quick."

Adora walks backwards until her back hits the door. She shakes her head as she tries to process what she's looking at.

On the London newspaper—right on the front page—is a moving image of *Octavia* being escorted into Azkaban. Adora skims the front cover—

Breaking news: Chief of Auror's, Octavia Stronghold, has been sentenced to Azkaban on temporary hold after being accused for the murder of Lonnie Grimely, Unspeakable, and war hero. Authorities found evidence of invoices sent to Stronghold's mailbox, implicating her as a possible death eater…

Adora shoves the newspaper to Bow, not wanting to read anymore. Not when she and Octavia have fought side by side multiple times—not when Octavia gave her pointers when Adora was just a junior Auror afraid of messing up…

"Octavia killed Lonnie," Glimmer says, approaching her like she's a wild animal. "They arrested her while they were inspecting the—"

"I know," Adora says, voice surprisingly calm. "Octavia was there tonight…Catra and I were in disguise when she told us to sort through some files about the case."

Bow nods, "that's probably why she had you two look through the files, so she could destroy them once you found them for her…all the evidence points to her being a death eater during the war, we never *saw* her but there were a lot of death eaters who weren't on the front lines. Maybe she's been a spy from the start."

Glimmer sends him a look before saying, "but there's no way to be sure until the trial. The date for it isn't set yet, but they say it's going to be soon."

Adora lets herself fall to the floor. She hugs her knees to her chest, not caring much for the eyes on her. Melog comes out from

their hiding spot to nuzzle up beside her. They still have traces of Catra's magic on their fur—it gives her some comfort. Bow and Glimmer follow her lead and each sit beside her until they have her sandwiched in the middle. Melog moves to give them room and instead sits in front of Adora to protect her from the cold.

Bow asks, "you doing okay?"

Adora runs a hand through her hair, tussling it until her ponytail comes loose and strands are falling in her face. She whispers, "...when I became an Auror I vowed to protect the world from anyone who wants to do it any harm…how can I be proud of wearing this crest when the same system I'm part of is tainted?"

"It's not tainted," Glimmer frowns, "it just…has a couple bad eggs. Just because Octavia did all these awful things, it doesn't downplay the contribution you've made to protecting this world."

Adora mumbles, "she still managed to get away with it for so many years…how did nobody notice?"

"Things were hectic after the war…it was hard to keep track of things," Bow offers her solace but it's not enough. Nothing about this feels right. As if on cue, Melog backs away and gives Adora space to stand up and break away from the comfort her friends are trying to give.

Adora asks, "now what?"

Glimmer tries to smile but it looks strained. "The case is solved… so, I guess we should head back to London? It doesn't feel right to finish this *vacation* with everything that's going on. And I'm sure they'll need Adora for the trial, someone will be contacting her soon about the case to see if she had any clues on Octavia's… extracurriculars."

Bow rubs the back of his neck saying, "we can't just leave without saying goodbye to Scorpia and Perfuma. They'd never forgive us."

“Then we’ll stay until they get home.” Glimmer looks at the clock. “They’ve been gone all day…should we check on them?”

Bow shakes his head. “I’m sure they just lost track of time with their new *friends.* ”

Glimmer squeals. “Do you think they actually realized the couple they’ve been hanging out with are swingers?”

“I have no idea,” Bow says, sounding exhausted with life. When Adora starts walking towards the guest room he asks, “Adora…are you sure you’re okay?”

“I’m fine,” the lie slips from her mouth with ease. Adora mumbles, “I’m gonna lay down for a while.”

She’s grateful they don’t try to stop her.

Adora manages to keep her composure all the way to the guest room. When she closes the door behind her—within the privacy of the guest room—she allows herself to fall to the ground. Melog waves their tail and a rush of magic engulfs the room—silencing spell.

Adora drops her head into the space between her knees. Lonnie’s alive, and Octavia has been caught, but somehow Adora feels worse off than before. Maybe it’s because the Ministry is full of corruption—and she feels ashamed to represent them—maybe it’s because she wasn’t there when Octavia was arrested—wasn’t able to demand answers in person. Everything runs through her mind but in the end she knows what has her the most shaken.

An idea springs to her mind. Adora jumps up and digs through her suitcase until she finds the two-way mirror. She holds it up and whispers, “Catra…are you there?” Adora keeps searching for some kind of sign, but all she finds is her own weary face on the other side. Adora cups the mirror between her hands and presses it to her forehead. “I know you probably can’t hear me, but…I really wish you were here.”

Adora lets the confession hang in the air as she collapses in the center of the bed with the mirror tucked to her chest.

Waiting Room

Location: Unspecified

A gasp echoes the white halls as Catra finds herself on a bench in an empty hallway. The pain she'd suffered from bending the rules and finding a way around her Unspeakable vow dissipates quickly. Catra looks around and tries to get an idea of where she is but there's *nothing* but an endless hallway encased with white walls and cream concrete floors. Even the walls are void. It's easy to lose any sense of being in this place so Catra closes her eyes and tries to focus on her magic—tries to remember how it feels to manipulate it between her fingers when—

"That won't work. I've tried."

Catra jumps out of her meditation at the voice. *I didn't even notice someone was here,* she looks to her right and nearly falls to the ground. A couple spaces from her—sitting on the other side of the bench with their arms thrown behind their head—is a person who looks *exactly* like her. Catra blinks once...twice...before she screams.

Her doppelgänger looks at her, unimpressed, as Catra falls to the ground with a hiss. "Yeah, I've *definitely* been *there* too."

Catra backs away and asks, "w-what the hell?"

"Will you calm down? Don't look like such a loser when you're in my body."

Catra growls, forgetting her shock for a moment. She leans forward on the balls of her feet with her elbows pressed to her knees. Catra scoffs, " *you're* body? *I'm* the real one."

"We're *both* the real ones, you idiot." Her doppelgänger sighs, gesturing to the empty seat beside her with a soft smile. "Look, I'm sorry I freaked you out. Just sit down and be quiet before they separate us for being too loud."

Catra blindly reaches into her coat pocket—

"They've taken our wands," her clone says, "again, I've *been* there before."

Catra weighs her options and finds they're very slim. She keeps her eyes on the clone and awkwardly sits back down. Catra mumbles, "who are they? The ones who took my wand without me noticing? And *who* are you?"

"Finally asking the right questions," the clone looks pleasantly impressed—Catra has never wanted to hex herself so badly before. The clone leans further into the wall and says, "they're basically the most powerful Unspeakable ever to exist, after they died I guess Merlin thought it would be dumb to let them waste away in death…so he sent them up here, to this realm, to oversee those who break their Unspeakable vow. It's kind of like a trail before they decide what to do with you. And because it's their realm, it was pretty easy to swipe our wands upon our arrival."

"Why do you know so much about this place?" Catra huffs, "you make it a habit of breaking your vows?"

Her clone shoots her a glare, but Catra can see the blush rising to her freckles. "It was for a good reason."

Catra hums, not sure if that's true. "And who are you anyway? Why do you look like me?"

"Hey," the clone looks outraged, "I'm from Universe alpha, so you're the one who looks like *me* ."

"Universe alpha?"

The clone nods. “I think it’s pretty much the same as your world. I've met other versions of myself in this waiting room and we've figured out the Universal world rankings during our time here. So, what’re you in for? Did you jump ten years into the past to try and fix something even though Angella told you not to?”

Catra blinks. “No…did *you* do that?”

“I asked you first,” the clone bristles.

Catra mumbles, “I found a way around my vow. I didn’t *say* anything, but I guess I got someone involved who I shouldn’t have. It's your turn.” She leans forward, suddenly delighted with an endless sea of possibilities because “am I gonna be able to travel through time?”

“No.”

Catra sulks. “Then how come *you* can?”

The clone explains, “during our senior year at Hogwarts my friends and I had to go back in time to save someone…important to me…I stole the Time Turner and went back, I saved her—them—but when I went to jump forward in time it broken in my hands on the way back. My blood—”

“Mixed with the essence within the Time Turner and now it’s in your actual blood?” Catra gapes. “Incredible…you’re a walking Time Turner.”

The clone shrugs. “Not as fun as it sounds.”

Catra nods sullenly. She isn’t sure what this version of herself has been through, but she can only imagine the horrors of time travel—especially if it gets into the wrong hands. Catra looks back at the clone and realizes, “isn’t it bad for me to meet another version of myself?”

“Nah,” the clone says with the shake of her head. “This is just the waiting room, so they can make us sweat for a bit and think about

what we did wrong and all that bullshit…don't worry, you won't remember any of this once you leave this realm. But, if you ever do return, so will your memories."

Catra hums. "You said our worlds are kinda the same. And you went to Hogwarts too."

The clone nods.

Catra frowns. "Then, aside from you being a walking Time Turner, how is your world different from mine?"

She says, " *I'm* in Gryffindor."

Catra whispers in horror, " *no* …"

"I was as shocked as you."

"No wonder you're so *stupid* ," Catra whispers to herself.

The clone frowns, "what did you—"

A yellow light engulfs the room and a large door—the size of the giant Catra and Adora faced during their first year at Hogwarts—appears from nowhere. A *click* echoes, letting them know the door is unlocked. Catra feels an invisible call to the door. She takes a deep breath before standing from the bench to face whatever's behind those doors.

Catra nods at her clone, "guess I'm up."

"Don't worry, they're not so scary."

Catra says, "I'm not worried."

Neither of them call her out on her lie.

"Catra D'riluth," a tall woman with long brown hair greets her on the other side. She towers over Catra in not just height, but *power* . It seeps from her like an endless river. Her eyes are a

steely blue—as fierce as she looks—but somehow she looks down at Catra with something *tender.* "I've been watching you for some time."

Catra makes a face. "I've only just broken my vow."

The woman says, "long before you became an Unspeakable."

"...why would you be watching me for so long?"

The woman changes the subject with ease, "you're here because you've broken your vow and I am the overseer of such breaches in magical contracts. While you didn't *verbally* give anything away, you've lied by omission; hiding key information from the Ministry of Magic *and* getting Auror Grayskull involved in a classified case."

Catra stands her ground, "the Ministry can't be trusted."

"I know."

Catra falters, "then why am I here wasting time with you when I can be down there solving this thing?" Catra snaps, not sure where she summoned the courage—somehow she feels *comfortable* with this stranger.

"...you're right," a flash of hurt streaks across the woman's face—Catra doesn't know why it makes her feel ashamed. She's never met this woman before. "I apologize, it seems like I've made this a personal affair by calling you up here. You clearly broke your vow, but based on your actions everything you've done has been for the betterment of the wizarding world. The vow should be made only in protecting the truth, and I can't punish you when the Ministry is part of what you're trying to fight."

Catra freezes as the woman stands in front of her, she looks down at her with a soft smile and whispers a confession "...but you can't blame a mother for wanting to see how her daughter's doing."

Catra's body goes cold. "You're my—"

"I know you'll do what's right." She presses a hand to Catra's shoulder. A wave of magic washes over Catra—she feels her body being pulled away. Catra grips the woman by the arms—she feels so *warm* —but she can't hold on, not when such a powerful force is tugging at her. Telling her she doesn't belong here—not yet—there's still work for her to do.

"Time moves differently up here, but you're right, they need your help down there."

Catra shakes her head, "wait—"

"Until next time, Cat."

10

There's a light rain shower when Catra lands outside of Scorpia's flat sometime in the morning. Instead of stepping out from the downpour, Catra let's it run down her face—letting it sink into her clothes—as she gains her bearings. Catra rubs the side of her head and whispers, "how did I get here?" Suddenly the memories of being called to the Unspeakable office at the Ministry of Magic fills her mind—they were pissed about her breaking her vow, but as long as she hasn't gone rogue and plans on seeing the case through they'll let it slide; especially when the Ministry is part of the problem.

Catra shakes her head—something about her memory of the meeting feels *off* but there's no time to dwell. She runs into the house and shakes the rain droplets from her body before she remembers she's a witch and waves her hand to dry her clothes with ease.

"Wildcat?"

Catra looks up in surprise as Scorpia walks into the living room with a glass of tea. Catra waves, "hey, when did you guys get back?"

"An hour ago," Scorpia says. "Where have you been?"

Catra raises an eyebrow. “Me? You’re the one who's been gone for almost two days now.”

Scorpia blinks before nodding sheepishly, “yeah, we had a blast with the Feldermans! Sorry I didn’t tell you how late we’d be...I think I meant to but...guess I just lost track of time.”

Catra hums. “No worries,” she swiftly pulls out her wand when Scorpia turns her back.

“Hey, how about we have another beach day?”

“Stupefy,” Catra whispers, shooting the spell as Scorpia turns around with her question. Before she can fall to the floor and alert the others, Catra uses a floating spell to carry her safely to the couch. Catra mumbles, “the Scorpia *I* know would have left me *at least* five letters in advance apologizing for leaving her guests alone for so long.”

Catra presses her wand to Scorpia’s head and easily digs through her memories. The night Scorpia described is there—her and Perfuma dancing through the night, getting a hotel to spend time with a couple they met at dinner, getting breakfast with the couple the next day and promising to keep in touch—it’s all perfectly aligned.

Too perfect.

Adora wakes up to movement on the side of the bed. She rubs the sleep away from her eyes and quickly deduces the time—she slept well past noon without Glimmer forcing her way inside so that means Adora looked *extra* miserable last night. Adora’s attention snaps to the foot of the bed where Melog is sitting upright with their ears perked to the sky. They’re staring at the door with diligence. She runs a hand through her hair, collecting herself, before reaching out for the magical creature with a question on her lips. Adora isn’t able to voice it when the bedroom door opens and—

Melog leaps off the bed and tackles Catra to the floor. "Melog…I can't breathe buddy," she exclaims, voice muffled under the creature.

Adora let's the mirror slip from her fingers as she carefully slides off the bed. Melog senses her coming and backs away to give her space. Catra looks up, curious, before she shoots her a sheepish grin.

"Hey, Adora," she doesn't get to finish when Adora slides to the ground and wraps her in a quick hug before she pulls back and kisses her. Catra makes a surprised noise but quickly slips back into the familiar. When she pulls away, out of breath, Catra follows her—giving her a quick peck—before backing off completely. "Hey...I thought you'd be mad at me…"

Adora drops her forehead to her shoulder and confesses, "I thought I was, but since you've been gone I've had time to think about things."

"Yeah?"

Adora nods. "When Finn died...I didn't ask how you felt about it, he was your only friend in the city, but I was too busy holding a grudge over you keeping the truth from me. But that truth was Lonnie being alive—"

"Lonnie's *alive?"* Bow's muffled voice says from behind the cracked door.

Adora looks up, not *too* surprised to see Bow and Glimmer collapse on the floor after being caught eavesdropping. Glimmer nudges Bow and whispers, "you couldn't hold it in until *after* they confessed and got their shit together?"

Bow glares at her. "Uhm, no! Lonnie's alive?" He turns to them for answers.

Adora nods. "It's a long story but...yes, she's alive. But someone *did* try to kill her and we've been trying to figure out who."

“How did this even happen?”

Catra shrugs, “I used a glamor spell on a Prime clone I had locked up. Wasn’t too hard.”

Glimmer mutters, “you had a Prime clone—doesn’t matter. Lonnie is alive and you’ve been lying to us about it?”

Adora frowns, “Lonnie asked her to keep it a secret and Catra is the Unspeakable on the case, remember? Her hands were tied.”

“How’d you get around it?” Bow asks.

Catra looks sheepish. “I kind of...just told Adora to follow me, so I didn’t actually break a verbal vow. The head of the Unspeakable division brought me to their office and just told me to solve the case and they’d let it slide.”

“I tried using the mirror to contact you,” Adora whispers, “but you didn’t pick up.”

Catra rubs the back of her neck with a sigh, “yeah sorry…there was no connection there. It was like a black hole. Everything is even fuzzy to me and I was there.”

“That’s where you’ve been,” Bow says, giving Adora a look as he recalls her lie from earlier.

Adora huffs, “I couldn’t just tell you my girlfriend disappeared into thin air and I didn’t know where she went.”

A weird smile stretches across Glimmer’s face. Adora doesn’t have time to figure *that* out so she keeps talking.

“And Catra just got back, I was waiting to see what we should do moving forward.” She turns to Catra who looks like her face has been set on fire. Oblivious, Adora tells her “Octavia was arrested for Lonnie’s murder.”

Catra snaps out of her daze quickly. She leans against the foot of the bed—contemplating her next move—before she asks them, "do you guys actually believe that?"

Adora frowns. "I don't know what to believe anymore."

"Guys," Bow says, "Octavia is guilty. All the evidence points to her."

Catra crosses her arms, she looks off to the side as she confesses "Scorpia and Perfuma came home early this morning, hours after Octavia was taken into custody…"

Glimmer frowns, "you've been gone since yesterday, how do you know—"

Catra pulls out the newspaper from her coat pocket. She holds it up and grins, "I did a little snooping before coming to check up on my idiot."

Adora smiles softly, "of course you did."

Catra smiles back in return before her face turns serious again. Catra says, "they've been gone for a while, and when I asked Scorpia where they were she just said out with some new friends…but Scorpia would've reached out to us hours ago about coming home *this* late. So...don't freak out—"

"Not liking where this is going," Bow mutters with a frown.

"I kind of stunned Scorpia and took a look at her memories."

Bow exclaims, " *what?"*

Adora hums. "Something I would've done."

Bow whispers to Glimmer, "you're right, they're *made* for each other."

Catra continues, "so Scorpia was telling the truth—the truth she *remembers* at least. But I'm an expert at mind manipulation and their memories have definitely been altered."

Bow asks, "why would someone do that?"

Catra mutters, "all we know is they came home a couple hours after the news of Octavia spread. I think the real killer kidnapped Scorpia and Perfuma—"

"And held them captive to make sure we wouldn't keep looking into the case," Adora realizes with a start.

Bow gapes, "but Adora stayed here waiting for you to come back, because none of us did anything the killer probably thinks we've accepted the outcome—Octavia being guilty. And I fell right into their trap," he shakes his head.

Glimmer rubs his shoulder. "It's a good thing we did, who knows what they would have done to Scorpia and Perfuma if we got involved."

Bow asks, "either way, what can we do? Everyone thinks Octavia is guilty, and if we try to do any more digging then the killer will hurt our friends—they already know Catra's been looking into it because they raided her flat; maybe they know Adora's involved too."

Adora says carefully, "I think it's time we got some help from the Ministry."

Bow frowns. "I thought we were fighting *against* them."

Adora promises, "not everyone is against us, trust me."

"So," Glimmer asks, "does this mean…"

"We're going back to London."

Chapter End Notes

Was going to have the little section with Catra as an interlude but this chapter was on the shorter side for my standards so I added it anyway; hope it didn't seem too out of place.

Thanks for reading, not sure if the next chapter will be up next week or later.

The Lonewolf

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

10

The rain lightens up by the time the golden quartet have their bags packed. Following the news of Octavia's arrest, Adora suggested they go back to London and get some help from the Ministry, but a pouting Scorpia—disappointed about the way their Holiday turned out—guilt tripped them with her puppy eyes. And so, the golden quartet decided to spend the rest of the day with their friends before heading to London. Adora tried to stress the urgency of the situation but Bow had some good points:

"We don't have time to spend the day with them," Adora whispers to him once Scorpia leaves the room. "We're trying to solve a—"

"Lonnie is safe." Bow says, "and the killer let Scorpia and Perfuma go because they think we're off their trail. Maybe laying low is a smart option right now."

Catra agrees despite the look of betrayal Adora sends her way, "acting normal is our best bet if we want to keep the attention off ourselves."

For their last day together Scorpia suggested an arcade room nearby, and so, they lost track of time—falling into the vibrant lights and the fire of competition. Even Adora—who had been fidgeting anxiously when they first walked into the arcade room—eventually lost herself in a Tetris themed game, coming extremely close to beating the top score. It was painful for her not to break it in the end, but she seemed satisfied when she won enough tickets to buy Catra a plush bear; something Glimmer teased Catra about the whole way back.

"Got everything?" Scorpia asks, pulling Catra out of her thoughts.

Catra nods, distracted, as she stares at the plush bear. It's too bulky to fit inside her suitcase without it being crushed. She can use a spell to extend the depth of her bag but that's no good. Either way, Adora will pout the whole way to London if Catra doesn't carry the bear with pride. Mind made up, Catra tucks the teddy under her arm. She looks back at Scorpia and finds her friend nervous, arms crossed, as she presses her weight between her right foot—switching to her left—back to her right—in an obvious nervous tick that has Catra wanting to claw her eyes out.

Catra puts Scorpia out of her misery saying, "don't worry so much, you and Fuma were *excellent* house guests. We just have to cut this vacation short so we can get Adora back to London for Octavia's trial."

Bow joins them on the porch with the other members of the quartet in tow. He wraps an arm around Scorpia and grins up at her, "Catra's right," he frowns "...huh, still sounds weird to say even after all these years."

"Does it?" Catra huffs, crossing her arms—calling him out on his bullshit.

"It's not your fault Scorpia." Glimmer says with a smirk, "business manages to get in the way when it comes to these two workaholics."

Catra lets the dig slide for now. She pats Scorpia on the shoulder saying, "I *promise* we'll visit another time…once all of this Octavia stuff has cooled down. Just…not another beach day, okay?" Catra has to try *very* hard not to hiss at just the *thought* of sand getting caked to her fur and the unpleasant smell of seawater.

Scorpia laughs softly, "yeah."

Catra allows Scorpia to pull her into one more lasting hug. Scorpia pulls back, giving her a stern once over as she demands "don't be a stranger this time."

Catra nods. "I won't."

“Have a safe trip back,” Scorpia tells them.

Adora smiles. “We will.”

“And be careful,” Perfuma warns, holding a hand to her chest like a mother worried over her child. “Mermista said in her letter that things are getting tense in London. With Octavia’s role under investigation the people are losing faith in the Ministry, questioning their intentions. And the four of you—you all have jobs connected to the Ministry…”

Adora frowns. “There are still some people we can trust—“

“I’m not worried about the *inside,”* Perfuma rushes out, “the *citizens* are the ones you should be wary of. You all hold such high favor as the golden quartet—saviors of the wizarding world—if even the smallest scandal came out about either of you, even if it’s unrelated to the politics happening, you could lose the support of the citizens. The foundation you’ve all built is shaky now.”

Adora realizes, “so eyes will be one us, more so than ever before.”

Catra frowns at the thought.

Watchful eyes being on her—it’s familiar, and very much unwanted on Catra’s end. Glimmer, already being somewhat wizarding royalty, had taken well to the fame they received after the war—her naive excitement—the *thrill* she had, is something Catra can’t relate to. Back then, they were just kids but, till this day, the fame is suffocating.

After the war the press was *always* on them. While Adora left Hogwarts to become an Auror, Catra stayed for her final year to carry out the rest of her studies; there were still a decadent of spells she wanted to learn from her mentors at the school, and—on a few rare occasions—the press managed to sneak their way inside, desperate for a piece on her time during the war. It was tough enough having all her peers stare at her—intrigued—while Catra only wanted to get through a lesson in peace.

Catra isn't looking forward to going back to that kind of lifestyle—it's what drove her into finding cases outside of London. She wanted to get away from the fame and go to a place where no one knew who she was.

"We've handled the press before," Glimmer says, not too worried about the implications.

Perfuma frowns, "still…"

"Don't worry," Catra says, sending a small smirk Perfuma's way, "we're tougher than we look."

Adora nods. "We have systems set in place for situations like this."

Adora doesn't further explain, a smart move on her part; a way to ensure—if things get messy—Perfuma and Scorpia won't be scrutinized for information they have on their whereabouts.

Perfuma still looks worried, rightfully so, but Catra doesn't allow the moment to fester. They've spent enough time in the city—chasing after fake leads, being manipulated by this bastard pulling the strings. Catra can't wait to cut them down—exposing them for the world to see.

"We should go," Catra says, holding out her hands in preparation for the ride.

They say their final goodbyes before they join hands; forming a circle as jagged as they are. Melog joins, rubbing their head into the side of Catra's leg.

Catra makes sure everyone is accounted for before she apparates them away.

They land in the living room space in one of the flats Catra owns in London. At first Adora offered her place as refuge but Catra thought it would be best if they hid out somewhere no one could

find them. And after what Perfuma said, Adora's starting to appreciate Catra's decision.

Adora takes a moment and looks around—it's been a while since she's been a visitor here. The last time she found herself in this flat was during one dreadful summer when the press were particularly driven to attempt an interview with her. Catra had just returned from a case in Italy when she reached out to Adora about getting together; Adora's flat was off limits—they didn't need news of their affair circulating the media—so Catra sent Adora the address to her private property. Catra owns it under a pseudonym, so no one will suspect the flat to be in connection with them.

It's the perfect safehouse.

"Nice digs," Glimmer admires with a whistle, throwing herself on the couch with a sigh.

Bow agrees, looking outside the window to appreciate the sights of London in all its glory. "It's good to be home."

"Agreed," Glimmer says, kicking her feet up on the table adjacent to the couch.

Adora flicks at Glimmer's leg until she lowers her feet off the table. Catra doesn't show it much, but she likes to keep her flat clean when she's able to.

"But seriously, this place is amazing. I didn't know there were flats with a view of London *this* great." Glimmer asks, "how many properties do you own?"

Catra shrugs. "A couple."

"Must be nice," Glimmer says, forgetting herself, "...having all that money left over from the Triwizard Tournament."

Catra waves her hand, using her magic to bring a bottle of red wine and an empty glass floating towards her. She serves herself

a hefty serving, takes a bountiful sip, before addressing Glimmer.

"I wouldn't describe anything I gained from that tournament as *nice."*

Adora worries her hands together—fighting the desire to pull Catra into an embrace. It was a horrible time back then, during their fifth year, when one of the professors—a double agent for Prime that no one knew about at the time—slipped Catra's name into the Goblet of Fire. It wasn't because they thought she was capable. They were plotting her destruction, hoping to plague the world of hybrids, mud bloods, and everything in between. Adora and Catra's friendship was rocky at Hogwarts, but their bond rekindled during the tournament.

When Catra's name was announced it didn't matter that they hadn't had a civil conversation in months—not since the orphanage, not since housing assignments split them apart—all that mattered was Catra's wellbeing. So Adora ran after her. It took some convincing, but, every night after, she and Catra met in the Room of Requirements and trained—practicing over and over until they ensured Catra was ready for *anything* they would throw at her. Adora couldn't explain why she felt the urge to do everything in her power to make sure Catra was prepared for the tournament.

Adora thinks she gets it now.

Glimmer winches as she recalls the events of their fifth year, "shit…I'm sorry."

"Don't worry about it," Catra mutters, helping herself to another glass.

Bow clears his throat and tries to diffuse the tension. "We appreciate you for letting us stay here while this cools off. It's weird having all of us together like this…too bad it always seems to happen under the worst circumstances."

Glimmer nods in agreement. “It’s like my mom always said, whenever something happens—“

“It *always* involves the four of us,” Bow finishes with a shake of his head.

Adora presses her back to the wall—anything to divert the attention from herself. She knows they’re only messing around, laughing at the unexpected adventures they found themselves getting at Hogwarts, and how it seems like—after all these years—nothing has changed.

Adora can’t help but feel like it’s all her fault. She *always* gets them involved even when she desperately tries not to.

“You guys can go back to your flat if you want,” Adora says suddenly, in a last feeble attempt at freeing them from her chaos. Sometimes Adora feels like she’s nothing but a wild tornado; pulling people along for the ride.

Glimmer frowns, “why would we do that? Catra, you have a guest room right?”

Catra nods, eyeing Adora suspiciously before turning to Glimmer. Catra says, “I have one guest room—“

“It’s hardly a guest room,” Adora blurts out, “it’s more of a glorified storage room slash work office.”

Glimmer shrugs, “we don’t mind.”

Bow says, “Octavia was *framed* and the real killer has their suspicions about us. We should all stay together. It’s safer this way.” He pauses, dropping his bag as he turns to Catra with a twisted expression. Catra raises an eyebrow, taking a preparatory sip of wine, as he walks towards her. Bow confesses, “I’m sorry for being so hard on you...I know I wasn’t the best friend to you when I found out what you were involved in—“

“It’s fine,” Catra waves him off.

“It’s not.” Bow says, “I *doubted* you...we’ve been through too much for me to do that.”

Catra shuffles awkwardly. “It’s my fault too. I could have tried to be a bit more transparent.”

“You had a promise to keep.” Bow says, “you did what you had to. Nothing to be sorry for.”

Glimmer smiles, “good thing you’re on our side, you were kind of kicking our arses back in America. I still can’t believe you managed to alter Alexander’s memory before we got there.”

Catra smiles—most likely losing herself in the memory of her escapades. “Yeah...that was fun.”

“ *Fun?”* Bow asks, voice growing in pitch.

Glimmer leans forward, as if this is a novel with a story she is vastly invested in and it’s finally reaching the climax. “How’d you get into the bathroom without us knowing?”

Catra waves her off, “I’ll tell you another time.”

“You *always* say that,” Glimmer pouts.

Bow stifles a yawn, “maybe it’s better to keep some things a secret. Besides, I’m too tired to hear the story. Where’s the guest room?”

Catra finishes her glass before gesturing for them to follow. “It’s this way.”

“I’m looking forward to getting some sleep,” Bow says. “Today’s been insane.”

Adora frowns, looking around anxiously as everyone starts gathering their bags. Adora asks, “you’re going to sleep? I thought we were going to the Ministry?”

“Adora, it’s 9 o’clock, we can’t just show up now. Everyone’s probably left already.” Glimmer says, giving her a strange look.

Adora crosses her arms to keep herself from doing something she’ll regret, “this isn’t something that can wait. We already wasted time hanging out at the arcade all day—“

“You were *so* into that Tetris game they had,” Glimmer argues.

“The point is,” Adora huffs, “Octavia could be put on trial any day now, we have to figure this out before it’s too late.”

Bow nods, giving her a soft look. “We know, but we can’t be useful if we’re all exhausted and we have to be cautious about the Ministry especially. I don’t know who you’re planning to speak to —”

“Not everyone is against us.”

“—but we have to be *sure.* If we tell the wrong person about Lonnie being alive…there’s no telling what might happen.”

Adora’s shoulders fall. Bow’s right, they can’t go out there showing their winning hand. This has to be handled delicately. Adora tries to push herself further into the wall—hoping to sink into the paint—but it just digs into her back, leaving behind a prick of pain down her spine.

Catra looks over at her and says, “we’ll go first thing in the morning.”

Adora isn’t satisfied with the answer, but she nods—anything to get their cautious eyes off her. And as Catra lazily guides Glimmer and Bow to their guest room, Adora schemes. It’s nothing extravagant—she isn’t a prodigy at strategy like Catra; she can’t form a plan where she’s already *three* steps ahead of her enemy—but it has the bones to turn into something great. Adora just has to make sure it all goes according to plan. Adora glances at the front door—weighing her options—before she notices Melog sitting in the middle of the hallway. *Watching* her.

“Adora,” she looks away from the magical creature—her warden in this prison—as Catra stalks back into the living area. Catra asks, “ready for bed?”

Adora scoffs, “like I can sleep at a time like this.”

Catra leans on the wall nodding. “Poor choice of words on my end so let me correct myself. Are you going to join me in my room and help me finish off this bottle of wine, or are you going to stay on the couch sulking all night?”

Adora pretends to think about it, “I guess I’ll keep you company.”

“Don’t sound so excited,” Catra huffs, turning around to go to the master bedroom with Melog at her tail. Adora smiles softly—despite what’s going on, she’s glad Catra’s along for the ride. There was a time at Hogwarts, during their third year, where Catra did something—something that shocked Adora to her core—leading to the inevitable crack of their once fragile relationship. The event made Adora question Catra’s intentions. Looking back on it, Adora realizes how wrong she was—she’d misinterpreted Catra’s resolve.

“My humble abode,” Catra says, crawling to the center of the bed. She crosses her legs and cradles the wine bottle in the space between, holding the empty glass as she prepares a drink for the two of them to share. “I know you said you hate the wallpaper but I haven't had the time to get it changed yet.”

Adora leans against the door until it closes with a dull *thump.* She kicks her suitcase to the side and gives Catra a disapproving look, “you promised.”

“I promised to *change* it, I never said *when.”*

“You and your loopholes.”

Catra shrugs. “They make life more interesting.”

Adora allows a brief moment to pass before she whispers into the silence, "...I'm sorry."

Catra looks up slowly. Her tail thumps on the bed—a nervous tick. Catra narrows her eyes and asks, "why should you be sorry?"

"For a lot of things," Adora says, letting out a hollow laugh. She continues, not loving the apprehension in Catra's gaze. Adora never wants to hurt her again. "I'm sorry for…not always respecting your work as an Obliviator."

Catra relaxes—just a little—and continues to pour the glass. She says, "when I got accepted into the Obliviator program you were thrilled."

Adora shakes her head, "I mean when we were at Hogwarts. Remember? You decided to be an Obliviator sometime around May, right when our third year was set to end."

"I remember," Catra mutters.

"I had the nerve to *lecture* you about making a terrible choice," Adora sinks further into herself—into her memory of their argument. "I didn't *understand,* so I had no right to say what I did…a few years after I became an Auror, I started to understand why you chose your profession. And during a *dreadful* case I worked, where one of the kids saw their parents be…right in front of them…" Catra's eyebrows pull together but she doesn't interrupt or try to appease her. She gives Adora the space she needs to voice her worries. "I finally *understood.* That day. My lack of experience made me speak so foolishly about things I didn't understand. But, I get it now. The work you do is important, and I'm sorry for ever making you think you were making the wrong decision."

"It was you."

Adora looks up, "what?"

Catra sets the glass and bottle of wine aside on the bedside table. She pulls her knees into her chest as she offers a confession of her own, "you're part of the reason I considered becoming an Obliviator."

Adora stumbles on her words, "I am?"

Catra nods, she looks away before facing Adora once more with determination—as if she's forcing herself not to run away at a time like this. "Your desire to protect everyone…back at school you would *always* throw yourself at every fight, protecting those who couldn't have a voice of their own. I admired that about you."

Adora splutters, "you made fun of me for rushing into things that didn't concern me!"

Catra does look away this time as she mutters, "I was…jealous—"

"Jealous?" Adora asks.

"Yes," Catra hisses, face growing redder by the second. "Look… you were my best friend at Weaver's orphanage, but when we got to school we got split up and our friend groups changed, and…it just felt like you were standing up for everyone but me."

Adora's stomach tosses as utter *shame* fills her.

Adora asks, "did you really feel that way?"

Catra nods nervously. "Look, it was a long time ago. We should just—"

"Then I'm sorry for that too." Adora says, clearing her throat as something gets stuck in it. She has to blink away the moisture from her eyes before she can find the courage to say "there was a lot going on at school, and it's not an excuse, but I always felt like I had to be *perfect.* My parents—who I've never met, let alone remember—were apparently these *legends* and everyone expected me to be like them. I felt like I had to be everyone's advocate and I guess…along the way, I forgot to be yours."

Catra looks away, “I didn’t need protecting.”

“You just needed me to be there.” Adora whispers, “but I wasn’t.”

Catra mumbles, “I wasn’t there for you either…and when I was, I just made things worse.”

Adora shakes her head. “You could never.”

Catra decides she does want the glass of wine after all. She reaches for it when—

“You know how I feel about you, right?”

Catra’s hand falls short, freezing mid air as a chill creeps in the room. This is uncharted territory, Adora knows it. This isn’t how their relationship is supposed to work. They’re not supposed to *talk* about these things—they’re not supposed to bring up the past—but their usual script has caused nothing but pain and misunderstanding. Maybe it’s time for them to try something different.

Catra forgets about the wine and turns back to her. Catra whispers, “of course I do.”

“I’ve never been with anyone.”

Catra blinks. “What?”

Adora flushes at the implication, “no, not like —*obviously* you and I have…you were there—”

“Adora,” Catra huffs, face not faring any better, “what are you saying?”

“I’ve never been with anyone *else,”* Adora rushes out, “not after the war…not *during* our meetups.”

There’s an awful silence that follows. Adora thinks she might throw up if Catra’s answer isn’t what she wants it to be, but Catra

says—

"...me either."

Adora lets out a relieved breath.

Catra frowns. "Did you think I did?"

"I didn't know what to think," Adora confesses. "We hardly see each other as it is and when we finally do—we're trying to solve a murder case."

Catra mutters, "I wanted to say something but every time I thought about reaching out, I got put on another case outside the country or you were held up with a case of your own. Never seemed like the right time."

"Is *now* a good time?"

Catra snorts, "no, but we better do it now because knowing us we'll have our hands full soon enough. But seriously," Catra says, "you know how I feel too, right?"

Adora whispers, "I do."

"I love you." Catra says.

Adora's stomach turns—it's been *too* long since she's heard this. Catra reads her mind, "I guess I should tell you more often…I just thought my actions spoke loud enough."

"I love you." Adora says—a weight lifting off her shoulders. She presses off the wall and meets Catra in the center of the bed. Catra barely has enough time to unfold her legs before Adora pulls her into her chest, tucking her chin into the groove of Catra's neck. The flood gates open. "I'm sorry about what happened with Finn—"

Catra freezes.

"—I know none of us could have predicted it, but we should have given you a heads up that we were coming. Then maybe—"

"Stop it." Catra says, digging her nails into Adora's side with enough force to get a wince out of her but not enough to bleed. "It was *my* fault."

"Catra—"

"I should have seen it coming, I'm a fucking *strategist.* It's my job to make sure shit like that doesn't happen." Catra says, "it was dumb of me to think I could prance around the city with you guys after the message I sent. It was my responsibility, Finn's gone because—"

"*You* didn't kill him," Adora says, pulling away and cupping the sides of Catra's face. "The puppet master—the person behind all of this—they're the ones who killed him. And you're trying to stop them…as long as you keep doing that, then his death won't be in vain."

Catra's face twists up—the mask cracking—as the tears fall. Adora cradles her back into her chest.

Catra spits out, "he looked so *scared."*

Adora shivers—recalling the light as it faded from Finn's eyes. "I know."

"I was such an asshole to him—"

"He knows you didn't mean it. He *knew."*

Catra laughs suddenly, it's such a sharp sound for a moment like this. "I met him when I was checking out the city—trying to be familiar with the area in case I ever got into a scuffle—"

Of course you were, Adora thinks with a smile.

"—he heard my accent and it was over from there. I thought he was just some kid who liked to flirt, but he…he was actually a great kid, you know? He saved a fresh slice for me, and fries for Melog, during the night shift. Do you know how long it takes for that old oven to heat up?" Catra shakes her head. "It was so lonely in the city…he made it bearable. He reminded me of you guys."

Adora smiles, "yeah?"

Catra nods. "He was goofy like you, a neat freak like Bow, and *crazy* like Glimmer."

Adora whispers, "and he was brave, like *you."*

"I'm not—"

"You kept Lonnie's secret even when I held a wand to your face… sorry about that by the way."

Catra chuckles, "it's okay…I would've done the same thing." Catra pulls away until their eyes are locked, "and I know how hard this is for you, having someone in your department betray your trust—their *Nations* trust. But the corruption in the Ministry has nothing to do with your resolve. I want you to hold onto it, it's one of the reasons I became an Unspeakable—I wanted to be someone people can count on. Like you."

Adora is trying *very* hard not to burst to tears right now.

"I'm proud of you."

Adora curses, "damn it."

Catra's hands hover in the air awkwardly, "are you okay? I didn't want you to *cry."*

Adora furiously wipes the tears away and once she's sure she won't break down again she says, "I'm proud of you, too."

“Please don’t make me start crying too.” Catra says, “I really want to kiss you and I can’t if I’m a blubbering mess.”

Adora makes quick work at drying her eyes with the back of her sleeve. Once she’s somewhat presentable, Adora gestures for Catra to do what she promised. Catra rolls her eyes before leaning forward. She kisses Adora—it starts off light but ends with Adora having to pull away to catch her breath. She lets Catra pull her into the bed. They cuddle up together and think on their discussion.

Adora asks, “you’re my girlfriend, right?”

“Obviously.”

Adora grins, “brilliant.”

Time slips away from them.

When Adora looks at the clock it’s nearing midnight. Adora removes herself from the bed, careful not to make it creak, before she walks over to the door. She looks at Catra one last time—looking peaceful, more so than ever, with her body curled in on itself. Her attention is taken when she locks eyes with Melog. The magical beast is in their tom cat form, slumped on the windowsill, giving Adora an unapproving look.

Adora doesn’t need their permission.

Melog realizes there’s nothing they can do. They turn their attention back to the view of London as Adora removes herself from the bedroom, closing the door gently behind her. Adora pulls on her coat, stashing a few things inside the pockets, before leaving out the front door. Once she’s outside—

Adora disappears with a *crack.*

Adora lands outside the Ministry of Magic and lets herself in through the front doors. While office hours have ended long ago, the night staff—tasked with cleaning and sorting files—and other workaholics are surely up and about. Luckily, Adora happens to know one of those workaholics.

Adora takes the lift to the eighth floor.

"Auror Grayskull," a few cadets in training greet her as she walks down the hall.

They probably got stuck with sorting through files for the night. Adora thinks, *I do not miss being a junior Auror.*

Adora nods their way, "cadets."

They pave a path—not daring to raise questions as Adora reaches her destination. Adora knocks three times before a muffled voice says, "come in."

Adora lets herself inside.

"Adora?"

"Evening, Director."

"Oh please. We're past titles."

Adora smiles genuinely and corrects herself, "Mara."

"I specifically recall giving you *three* weeks off on paid Holiday. Not one." Mara leans back in her chair and gestures to the one in front of her desk. "Have a seat, please. I hope work doesn't bring you to my office half past midnight."

"I'm afraid I'll have to disappoint you," Adora says somewhat sheepishly. She takes a seat as directed. Mara holds up a finger, fumbling through the files in her desk drawer, while Adora digs into her coat pockets and makes herself comfortable. She's all settled in when Mara turns back to her with a familiar newspaper

clipping in her hand. Adora frowns, "that's the paper of Octavia's arrest."

Mara nods in sorrow. "I know how strict Octavia is, but she's a good comrade…well, she *was.* It still shakes me to my core, knowing she was playing us all along."

Adora sighs. "I know."

"Is that why you're here?"

Adora shrugs. "I guess I just needed some closure. And I can't relax on Holiday knowing what she did."

"Lonnie's killer is caught," Mara frowns. "Isn't that all the closure you need?"

"I want to know *why* she did it."

Mara sighs, "maybe you'll find out at the trial."

"Maybe I will." Adora finally takes the time to look around the office. There are boxes piled up, most of the things stashed away for safekeeping. Adora asks with a frown, "are you switching offices? I thought you loved the view of the tower."

Mara confesses, "I'm retiring."

Adora freezes. "You're *what?"*

She can't picture Mara, of all people, giving up on work willingly.

Mara laughs, "why do you sound so surprised? Did you think I'd spend all my days at this desk?"

Adora looks away sheepishly—not wanting to admit that she did think that's exactly how Mara would go, gripping at her desk even in death. Adora mutters, "just surprised is all. You're not *that* old."

"I'm still your Director," Mara huffs.

Adora winces. “Sorry.”

Mara softens. “What happened with Lonnie has shown me life is too short. I’ve loved being a Director—and seeing all my cadets grow into able Auror’s such as yourself—but I can’t stay here forever.”

Adora can’t share Lonnie’s secret without being sure. She’s confident about this, but—it’s just not her secret to tell. And so, Adora allows Mara’s mind to wither and fester over Lonnie's death just as Adora had.

“Well, I wish you the best of luck, Director.”

Mara nods. “As do I. But I have no worries, I know your future is going to be bright.”

Adora readjusts her coat before she stands. “I won’t keep you any longer.”

Mara smiles softly one more time. “Have a good night, Adora.”

Adora slowly makes her way to the door. She reaches out for the knob before she pauses. Adora faces the door as she says, “I just think it’s weird, is all. You’re in a powerful position, the Direction of Magical Security, and you’ve only held the position for a couple years. Just seems like a strange time to retire.”

A tense silence filters the room.

Adora knows what to expect, but it’s still spine tingling, as she looks over her shoulder and finds a wand aimed at her head. What’s even more chilling is the *cold* expression on Mara’s face—it’s a far cry from the softness she usually carries. Normally, Adora feels safe in Mara’s presence. Now, there’s only *anger.*

“You couldn’t let it go,” Mara says. “Could you?”

“So it’s true,” Adora whispers, “you had Lonnie killed.”

“Don’t sound so shocked, you’ve obviously had your suspicions about me.” Mara keeps the wand aimed at Adora as she asks, “what tipped you off?”

Adora finds no use in lying now, “retirement…I know you—I *thought* I did at least.”

“You came to this conclusion all because I said I’m retiring?” Mara shakes her head. “No. You’re too dumb for that.”

Adora flinches—she knows she shouldn’t care what Mara has to say, especially not after what she’s learned, but Mara was her mentor.

“The *hybrid* tipped you off.” Mara spits with a cruelty Adora’s never heard off her tongue.

Adora shoots back, “I have a mind of my own. *I’m* the one who figured you out. I went to Lonnie’s house the night Octavia was arrested, I was under a glamor spell—”

“You were right there,” Mara realizes with a start.

Adora frowns. “And when Octavia said you were showing up I thought to myself, *why would the Director of Magical Security be coming all the way out here just to sort through a stack of papers?* You couldn’t search the house the first week of the murder because the case was still hot—too many people were investigating—so you gave it some time to cool off before you made your move. See, not as dumb as you think.”

“You came here alone. So my statement still stands.”

“It doesn’t matter. I know what you are and soon, so will everyone else.” Adora growls, “a filthy *death eater.* How could you? So many people trusted you—”

Mara frowns, “my loyalty is and forever will be, with Lord Prime. And if I have to work from the inside with useless Auror’s like you, then I’ll do what it takes.”

"Everyone will see you for what you are."

Mara shakes her head, "no, they won't. All they'll see is you—the *golden girl*— on the cover of every newspaper for breaking into my office and trying to kill me after I found out the truth about you *and* Octavia working in cahoots."

Adora slowly pulls her free hand from her pocket without making too much movement. Adora asks, "what are you—"

"Do I need to say it slower for you to understand? I'm framing you." Mara says, "I'd send you to the Bermuda Triangle with the rest of my *disappointments—"*

There are others who found out? Adora thinks.

"Honestly…I took you off the case so you would let it go, not so you could run around America with the hybrid and the rest of the golden crew." Mara mumbles, "the hybrid's a smart one, I'll give her that...for a mutt—"

Adora barely retrains herself. But she has to—this part is important.

"But you're too much of a problem to just hide away. If the golden girl goes missing then London will be hysterical, so I have to ensure they've lost your trust." Mara says eerily, "and it won't take much convincing. Before you left for Holiday you were already starting to unravel—this will be an easy web to spin."

Adora whips around with her palm raised just in time for Mara to shout—

"Confringo!"

"Protego!" Adora shouts with her hand raised—summoning a protective shield for Mara's blasting curse to bounce off. Adora has never been more grateful at learning how to perform wandless magic in Hogwarts after realizing Catra had been learning it over

the summer. Back then it was jealous ambition that had driven her, but now—it's saving her life.

Adora slips from the office while Mara's spell bounces off her shield. Adora runs down the hall, grabbing her wand in the chaos just in time for Mara to rush out after her.

"Stop her!" Mara shouts, alarming the three junior Auror's Adora had run into earlier. They look up in alarm, nervously shifting from foot to foot as the golden girl rushes towards them. But, orders are orders. They clumsily grab at their wands. Unfortunately for them, Adora's far faster and far more experienced then they'll *ever* be.

Adora raises her wand and shouts, "aguamenti!"

A turbulent stream of water rushes from her wand. Waves of water collide into the wall, swirling until it makes it to the center of the hallway. The junior Auror's take a step back, confused as the water slows in its path until it does nothing but merely lap at their calves. They look around and share a laugh when Adora shouts—

"Glacius!"

A chilling breeze rushes through the room, emitted from Adora's wand. The air is sent towards the junior Auror's, directly at their feet, causing the water to freeze upon impact—trapping them in a block of ice. Adora slides along the ice, aiding in her escape, as she easily disarms the Auror's with a quick "expelliarmus!"

It's worth seeing the shocked looks on their faces as Adora easily glides past them.

Adora hops off the ice when it reaches its end. She makes a sharp right, turning the corner as the lift comes into view.

"Bombarda!"

Adora ducks, but the explosion passes over her head and instead collides with the lift door. The ground shakes, knocking Adora to the floor, as the spell causes the lift door to crumble—collapsing down eight stories to the basement where it lands with a *boom.*

Adora looks up when the dust settles. The crate doors have been pried away thanks to the explosion, leaving behind a gaping hole full of intricate tunnels delving into different parts of the building. Adora can *try* to escape through this maze, but she fears it will only bring her more harm than good.

It doesn't matter; Mara makes the choice for her.

Mara presses the tip of her wand to the side of Adora's head. Adora raises her chin, eyes set on fire as she glares up at the imposter among them. Adora promises, "you won't win."

Mara shakes her head.

"I already have."

Adora looks past Mara and sees the junior Auror's, now free, holding their wands toward her. They're *afraid.* Adora swallows, *they're scared…of me.* Adora shakes her head. *Fine…let it be fear.* Adora isn't going out with her tail between her legs. She opens her mouth, a vicious spell on her tongue, but Mara is faster.

"Stupefy."

Darkness follows.

11

Furious knocking brings Catra from her room the next morning. Catra opens the door with a huff, it's already been a sucky day without having Adora at her side when got up, she doesn't need all the noise. Glimmer almost falls to the floor when the door opens.

Catra crosses her arms with a raised eyebrow, "I *told* you, you ate all the fried Oreos we packed on the way—"

"It's Adora," Bow says, face twisted up—an expression Catra does *not* want to see after hearing him say something like that.

Catra holds onto the door panel, bracing herself as she asks, "what happened?"

Glimmer holds up the portable radio and turns up the volume. Glimmer whispers, "I think you should hear this."

Catra digs her claws into the wood of her door panel, ears perking up as she listens attentively.

"...in the case of the Ministry vs Grimely, you stand accused of betraying not only your Country but also your comrades. In the crimes laid against you—in acting as an accomplice with Octavia Stronghold in the murder of Unspeakable, Lonnie Grimely—I ask you, Adora Grayskull—"

Catra curses under her breath, "shit."

"—how do you plead?"

Chapter End Notes

This chapter title "The Lonewolf" was in honor of Adora Grayskull. It's a great representation of how she goes off and does things on her own if it means protecting her friends from getting hurt. Unfortunately, Adora straying from the pack ultimately becomes her downfall.

Next update will be titled "Interlude II". It's a break from the main story but it's a flashback to their third year at Hogwarts so I think you guys will enjoy it. Should be up by the end of the weekday or weekend.

Interlude II

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Hogwarts, Third Year

Forbidden Forest. Adora just *had* to stir up trouble in the Forbidden Forest, of *all* places. And, as always, Catra somehow got roped into the shenanigans of the golden girl. Catra was simply minding her own business—sneaking around past curfew as she planned an especially heinous prank for an unsuspecting first year with Double Trouble (DT)—when Adora ran into them looking frantic. Adora was mumbling about *werewolves* and an uncle she never knew about, and before Catra knew it, she and DT were leaving to help the blonde on her quest. Unfortunately, DT slipped away from the group and, without the help of a buffer, she and Adora of course got into an argument.

Catra hasn't seen Adora since their spat.

Catra curses, kicking a bush when one of its thorns gets caught in her green robes. Catra growls under her breath muttering, "stupid Adora...always picking a fight with me and making *me* feel like the asshole…"

Awoo!

Catra's fur bristles as she hears the howl. *Werewolves, damn it.* The situation takes an even more dramatic turn—per usual—when Catra perks her ears as she hears Adora's familiar battle cry. An array of lights shoot out in the area just a couple trees to her right. *That idiot can't seriously be taking on a pack of werewolves…*

Everything in her mind is telling her to flee back to Hogwarts and get a professor, someone who's actually experienced to take on this threat, but Catra's body moves on autopilot. With her

enhanced night vision (the only good thing being a hybrid has *ever* given her), Catra extends her claws and leaps her way to the highest spot in a nearby tree. She leaps from branch to branch until she's above the light show.

"Stupefy!" Adora shouts, aiming the spell at a werewolf who's getting a little too close for comfort; it knocks the beast down, but it's no use—not when there are a dozen more inching in her direction, and while Stupefy subdues them it only lasts momentarily; the spell isn't strong enough to keep such a powerful creature at bay. Especially when the spell is being performed by a fourteen-year-old student.

"Damn it," Catra hisses when Adora starts to stagger back as she becomes overwhelmed by the numbers.

Catra takes a deep breath in as she prepares herself. The spells they're learning in class won't be enough to keep the beasts back. *Never thought I'd have to use this so soon…*

Catra thinks back to when she first started delving into this area of magic:

A haunting figure wakes Catra from her sleep.

"Come on," she growls under her breath, "pick up your feet and move!"

Catra's eleven when Weaver starts pulling her out of bed in the middle of the night—dragging her along with little patience—while the rest of the inhabitants sleep, unaware.

Ever since she, Adora, Lonnie, and some others received their letters for Hogwarts Weaver has been worse off than before. It's clear to Catra why Weaver doesn't want Adora to leave—she's always been the favorite—but she thought Weaver would be thrilled at getting Catra out of the house. She just doesn't understand the woman. Doesn't understand why she drags Catra out of bed at this ungodly hour, into the basement with the

curtains drawn, throwing Catra to the dirt covered floor, while she pulls out the eerie book of spells.

Weaver throws the book at Catra's scratched up knees—bruised from the fall. Weaver grunts, "read the next chapter on Horcruxes, and be done by the time I get back or you're not leaving this room tonight."

Catra backs away from the book until her back hits the wall. She draws her knees into her chest and whispers, "I don't want to…"

The first time she read the book she was just complying with Weaver, anything to get it over with but...overtime—as the nights dragged on—Catra noticed a change in her behavior.

The book manipulates her mind and whispers things in her ear. She doesn't like the person she's becoming; she snaps at Adora for the silliest things, claws at Lonnie when she's just trying to help, and Kyle...she doesn't even want to go there.

Weaver says in a chilling voice, "read it."

"I don't like how it makes me feel."

Weaver's face morphs into false softness—Catra flinches. She'd rather have the rage than the games.

"You're a hybrid, how far do you really think you'll get at Hogwarts —in the wizarding world—without having some kind of leg up? I'm trying to help you."

Catra knows she's lying. Maybe when she was younger, and desperate for a mother figure, she would believe Weaver. But she's older now. She sees right through the facade but she doesn't want to be stuck down here longer than she has to so she nods. It's enough for Weaver.

"I'll be back. Read." The door shuts behind Weaver.

Catra turns to the book with a glare, she whispers "I won't let you get in my head again."

Maybe there's a way she can control the voices.

Back then, Weaver made her read the book so Catra could be infected with darkness—but she proved Weaver wrong. Instead of succumbing to the call, Catra learned to manipulate it—dance with it— *communicate* with it until the darkness seeped into her skin as they became one.

Mind made up, Catra leaps from the highest tree and lands on all fours in front of Adora. Her entrance startles the werewolves for a moment; it's enough time for Catra to rise to her feet and draw her wand with practiced ease.

Adora's sounds startled—breathless. "Catra?"

"Hey, Adora," she says, grinning over her shoulder at her frenemy. "Save some fun for me."

The growling from their foe reminds Catra of the situation. She turns back to the issue at hand. Catra eases up the grip on her wand. This isn't a spell she's had much practice with, but hopefully the adrenaline and intensity of the situation will make up for her lack of practice.

"You shouldn't be here," Adora berates her, but Catra can hear the fear causing her voice to tremble. There's shuffling behind her as Adora stands by her side with her own wand raised.

Catra shoots back, "like you've ever told me what to do and I actually listened."

Adora grins, "you got me there."

Catra smiles before saying, "back up a bit."

Adora blinks at her, "what?" But Catra takes initiative. Catra steps away from Adora and further into the battle; she raises her wand

—staring death in the eye—and shouts:

"Fiendfyre!"

A turbulent stream of fire blasts from her wand. The beasts howl in shock, stumbling back as fire laps at their feet. It burns the grass, rushing out in all directions as Catra foolishly tries to keep it contained. Her robes blow in the wind—fluttering under the burst of energy. The fire keeps coming, spiraling from her wand causing her wrist to buckle—her control slipping. The force of the stream pushes her feet back into the dirt as she loses her grip; *hold it,* she thinks to herself, *prove her wrong.*

Catra growls, shoving her wand forward to redirect the flames with better control than before. She takes a slow step towards the massacre and rights her footing into a solid stance. She's not getting knocked down tonight.

Her adjustments seem to be working well enough—most of the werewolves, if they're not trapped in a ring of flames, are retreating. With the spell under control Catra feels inclined to look back over her shoulder and ask Adora:

"Are you alright?"

Adora looks at her with a stupid dazed expression, she stutters out a quick "yeah, yep! I'm splendid and you're—everyone's splendid."

Catra frowns. "What?"

"What?" Adora parrots.

Before Catra can question the uncharacteristically shy blonde a sudden shriek echoes behind them.

DT, Catra thinks, panic gripping her in its vice. She glares at the backs of the retreating werewolves; one problem is taken care of, but of course, two more spring up. DT is in trouble but Catra can't leave this fire raging. The destruction would be catastrophic.

"DT's in trouble," is all Adora says before she foolishly runs in the direction of the scream.

Catra's grip on her wand tightens, her emotions flare and with it so do the flames. She has to force herself to calm down lest she burn this forest to the ground. But she can't help it. Adora just *always* has to rush in and save everyone without caring about her own wellbeing.

"Calm down," Catra whispers to herself, thinking back to her Defense Against the Dark Arts (DADA) lessons. *Emotions are directly correlated to the proficiency of magic,* she recalls verbatim. And without a cool head she'll never be able to weld it properly. Being a hybrid already comes with enough problems; she doesn't need them thinking she lacks self control—can't have them send her back to Weaver's.

Time passes and time heals. Catra manages to clear her head and eventually the fire dies down. She double checks her work before she runs in the direction of the scream she heard earlier, nearly falling down the steep hill as she slides to a stop after reaching the bottom. Her breath leaves her throat at the scene: just across the open space of the forest is Adora, standing adjacent to DT who is having their soul sucked by a *dementor.* Catra ignores the buckling of her legs —*stupid fear*— but she still *tries.* She has to. DT is one of her closest friends.

"Expecto Patronum!" Adora shouts, aiming the spell at the threat.

Catra covers her eyes as a *bright* light engulfs the space of the woods they've trapped themselves in. A powerful wave of magic rushes through the air, leaving Catra speechless. *When did she get so strong?* Catra wonders in awe, helpless to do nothing but watch as Adora's Patronus graces them with its presence. The blue glowing stallion trots in the air and banishes the darkness.

Adora's legs buckle once the threat is terminated—now that DT is safe. Again, Catra doesn't know what gets into her, but suddenly she's racing to Adora's side just in time to catch her. Adora looks

shocked to see her, or maybe she's shocked at Catra for not letting her fall. Either way, Catra avoids her gaze and turns to DT. They're breathing steadily but they lay on the ground, limp. Catra's face twists up. *I never should have let them come with us…this is all my fault.*

"It's okay," Adora's voice brings her back. Catra turns to face her. Adora isn't smiling—not in a situation like this—but her eyes are steady and they reassure Catra. "They'll be okay."

Catra looks back to her fallen friend and lets the silence wash over them.

"Fiendfyre?"

Catra dutifully avoids the Headmistress—Angella's gaze—as she interrogates the duo. It's not the first time she and Adora have found themselves in this very room being scolded for saving the day. Catra huffs to herself, *honestly, they teach us about bravery but then whenever we help someone we just get yelled at. They need to make up their bloody minds.*

Angella turns to Catra's DADA Professor, Micah, with a heated stare. Micah shrinks under the look, gulping, as he takes a sheepish step back.

"Honestly Micah, what exactly have you been teaching her?" Angella asks.

Micah stutters, "well, uhm, it's not *exactly* part of my curriculum..."

"Clearly." Angella frowns, "so the question becomes, *where* did you learn such a spell?"

Catra looks up and goes for the truth, "I read about it."

Angella blinks. "You're telling me...you learned *fiendfyre,* a dark magic spell, by simply *reading* about it?"

"It was a good book." Catra shrugs.

"And a *forbidden* one—"

Shit, Catra thinks.

"—so the only way you could've gained access to it was by sneaking into the forbidden section of the library. Another tally to your list." Angella says, "it's becoming *quite* long, Miss D'riluth."

Catra bristles as the need to defend herself grows. "We saved DT! I don't get what the big deal is."

"Aside from the obvious, you used a *dark magic* spell...Hogwarts is designed to teach young wizards and witches how to protect themselves, how to govern themselves accordingly as they hopefully become the leaders of the next generation, but *you* —"

Catra stills, growing cold as Angella looks at her in *disappointment.*

"—you, toe a dangerous line. Dark magic will only lead to corruption." Angella goes on to say more when Micah places a hand on her shoulder. She looks at him, curious, but his soft gaze is set on Catra.

Micah confesses, "you don't want to go down that path. You may think you have it under control but it's quick to eat away at you, trust me... *I've* been there."

Catra looks away.

"I'll deal with Miss D'riluth before class tomorrow," Micah says, "5am sharp."

Catra barely contains her groan. Waking up early isn't her thing, but it's still better than facing Angella's punishment.

"I'm very angry with the two of you. You're each at the top of your houses, and I expect you to lead by example...but," Angella

says, drawing their attention, “I can not neglect the good you’ve done. So, for having the bravery to defend your friend, I award 10 points to Gryffindor,” she turns to Catra and adds with a smile, “and 10 points to Slytherin as well.”

Catra unconsciously turns to Adora who’s already looking at her. They share an excited grin before Angella interrupts with—

“But, I’m also taking 40 points away from each of your houses.”

“What?” Catra exclaims in a high pitch, “but why?”

Angella’s eye twitches. “Miss Grayskull disobeyed the rules, leaving campus grounds past her curfew to chase this little *mystery* —involving two of her classmates in the process, and landing one of them in the *infirmary*—"

Adora winces.

Angella turns to Catra, “and *you—”*

Catra shrinks under Angella’s glare.

“—could have set the entire woods on *fire.”*

Catra grins sheepishly, “it was for a good cause?”

“Someone could have gotten seriously hurt. You’re lucky it didn’t go out of control.”

Catra crosses her arms and mutters under her breath, “wasn’t luck.”

“Excuse me?”

Catra knows a losing battle when she sees one so she keeps her mouth shut.

Angella turns to Micah once more saying, “deal with your student. I don’t want another incident like this.”

Micah nods. “Of course. My apologies, Headmistress. Won’t happen again.” He glances at Catra with a look that says *“we’re talking about this later”.*

Angella crosses her arms, “and don’t *you* have a quidditch tournament this weekend? I should have you put on probation. I wonder how Gryffindor will fare without their best beater on the field.”

Adora’s face twists up, she opens her mouth with a retort but in the end she thinks better of it. Instead she ducks her head shamefully.

Angela thinks for a moment, sighing, “but if I remove you from the game there’s a chance Slytherin could win and that would be a reward for Miss D’riluth…”

“It’s been a long night,” Micah says with a sheepish smile, “how about we deal with repercussions tomorrow? Once everything has cooled down and we have an idea of where to go from here.”

Angella deflates as if realizing just how tired she herself is. She says, “fine...but plan on a weeks-long detention. Both of you.”

Catra barely contains a snort, *like I haven’t snuck out of detention before.*

“Alright the lot of you,” Angella says, “off to your dorms.”

“Wait,” Catra interrupts.

“What is it?”

“Is DT okay?” Catra asks, surprising everyone in the room. She stifles a growl—did they seriously think she wouldn’t care about her friends' well being?

Angella softens. “They’re fine.”

“Can I see them?”

Angella hesitates.

“Headmistress,” Adora admits, speaking up for the first time, “I’d like to check on them too...if that’s okay.”

Catra glares at the blonde. Adora’s always sticking her nose where it doesn’t belong; defending *anything* and everyone with a pulse, everyone except—

“Maybe they can just poke their heads in. I’ll go with them to make sure they don’t get into any more trouble.”

“Micah...” Angella contemplates it before she says, “fine.”

Catra gets up and eagerly follows Micah to the infirmary with Adora not too far behind. The walk to the infirmary isn’t far and soon they’re turning the corner and quickly rounding up on it. As they approach Catra slows her step; just outside the infirmary door is a tall stranger with a long braid thrown over her shoulder haphazardly. She’s dressed in strange dark robes with a familiar symbol on the back.

Micah sees her apprehension and offers softly, “don’t worry, that’s just Mara, she’s the new Chief Auror for her division. She’s working the werewolf case to ensure everyone’s safety.”

“What’s an Auror?” Adora asks.

Micah smiles, “they’re part of an organization tasked with the responsibility of protecting the wizarding world. They go across the world solving all kinds of cases.”

Adora’s eyes light up. “Wow.”

Catra rolls her eyes. “Of course *you’d* like a job like that.”

“What’s that supposed to mean?” Adora shoots back.

“It means you’re an idiot.”

Adora pouts, used to the slanderous nickname, while Catra sticks her tongue out at her.

"No visitors." The Auror, *Mara* , says as they join her outside the door.

Micah says, "these two were the ones who saved DT. I think it's at least fair for them to check on their friends' well-being."

Mara's eyes go wide. She turns to Adora and asks in wonder, "you're the one who used *fiendfyre?* The remnants of your magic were *still* in the air when I arrived at the scene, it felt like it was quite the powerful feat. Very impressive for a third year, I bet you would—"

"Oh no," Adora says quickly, taking an awkward step back as she nudges Catra to the front. Catra sends Adora a glare but the blonde continues and gestures at Catra with a smile. "Catra's the one who did it. I just used my Patronus to scare off the dementor."

Mara turns to Catra, surprised, and after a brief moment she *smiles.* But...something about Mara's expression doesn't seem genuine. Catra's tail frizzes up as Mara seems to grunt out a quick approval in her direction before turning back to Adora with much less disdain.

Catra doesn't fret over it much—she's never had a good relationship with authority figures, so it makes sense she isn't a fan of Mara's. And so, Catra makes her way into the infirmary while Adora does some networking. She slips through the door, closing it behind her, and comes to an immediate halt. DT sits hunched over in the cot, picking at the stray strands of the fabric. They stare at their lap for a long moment before turning in her direction.

A chill creeps up. The look in DT's eyes—it's so *cold.* The spark is long gone. Catra hardly recognizes them. *This is my fault…* The

thought snaps her out of it. The least she can do is try to keep a brave face.

"DT," she says with a feeble grin. They don't answer right away, it's enough time for Catra to cross the room until she stands at their side. Catra shouts in surprise when DT grabs her by her robes—pulling her close. Their nose bumps into her shoulder—DT knocks their forehead against her bony shoulder with enough force to send a sharp pain through her bones. But she sucks it up. She deserves this.

"...everything was so dark," DT says, trailing off.

She's never seen them like this.

They slam their forehead into her shoulder again—*thump...thump...* Catra loses track of the intervals. She averts her gaze, hoping to delay the tears but in her diversion something catches her attention. On the desk adjacent to the cot is a pamphlet—advertising a facility for traumatized individuals. Catra digs her claws into the comforter. *They're planning on sending DT away…*

Before her thoughts can spiral, the thumping suddenly comes to a stop. Catra glances down and finds those dull eyes bearing into her with some of the intensity DT still has left. Catra winces as DT clutches at her arms and drags her even closer—her forehead bumps into theirs with a dull *thud.*

DT whispers, "I need you to do something for me."

Catra grabs their shoulders and promises, "anything."

Catra owes them that much.

I've decided, Adora thinks to herself with a grin. *I'm going to work hard so I can become an Auror, so I can protect people—just like Mara.* This way she can be right one scene to stop bad things from happening. Adora's new goal fills her with energy she hasn't

felt in a while. Giddy from her high, she rushes into the infirmary to inform Catra of her decision. Out of all her friends—even Bow and Glimmer—it's strange, but Catra's the first person she wants to share this with.

She'll probably call me an idiot, Adora thinks with a snort. Their relationship has been rocky—up and down—but tonight, aside from their small spat, they made a pretty good team. Adora hopes they can get back to that.

Adora slips inside the infirmary while Micah chats with Mara about a topic Adora lost interest in. Her smile slips from her face. She almost wants to laugh; it's just like Catra to get her hopes up before shooting them right back down—sometimes lower than before.

"Catra," she whispers in the thickness of it all, carefully grabbing her wand. But she doesn't aim it at Catra—she could never forgive herself—she just holds it in case the need arises.

Adora hopes it never does.

Catra, with her wand pressed into the side of DT's head, turns to Adora sharply. A rush of emotions seem to wash over her—an opening—because no matter how cruel she may act at times, Catra is no monster.

"Put the wand down." Adora whispers.

Catra's resolve seems to falter. Her arm begins to bend—slowly retracting her wand.

Pat!

The noise redirects Adora's focus to DT. Their hands grip at Catra's wrist, pulling it closer until a drop of blood starts leaking from the pressure of the blunt end of the wood. DT is staring up at Catra with a look so fierce it leaves even Adora in shambles.

"Do it," they growl.

“Catra,” she tries to stop her, but DT’s grip holds Catra—grips at her with a force more powerful than Adora’s plea. Adora calls out in one last attempt, “don’t do this…”

Catra meets DT’s intense gaze with one of her own.

“Catra, no—“

“Obliviate.”

Adora can only watch as Catra uses her wand to extract a memory from DT’s mind—it will only do more damage if Adora tries to interfere now. So she watches—watches as Catra manipulates her magic in her favor...almost with *ease.*

When did Catra learn this spell?

When Catra used fiendfyre Adora admits, it was a bit of a shock—and strangely infatuating—and sure, it’s dark magic, but she used it to *save* Adora. So she wasn’t as worried as Angella seemed to be. But now...Adora doesn’t know what to think anymore.

The spell comes to an end, leaving DT gasping for breath as they fall back into the bed. Adora runs over and grabs DT by the shoulders.

“Are you okay?” Adora asks in panic while Catra stands at her side with her breath held. *If she messed this spell up...*

The noise makes DT wince, and soon their eyes open as they slowly come to. They blink at Adora once. Twice.

“Someone isn’t getting any beauty sleep,” they mumble, sharing a not so subtle look in Catra’s direction as they gesture to Adora’s frazzled state.

Adora’s grip loosens. “You’re okay?”

“I’m fabulous as always, but you…” DT waves her off and turns to Catra instead, “what’s going on? Last thing I remember is you and

I planning a prank for that little brat who made Scorpia cry."

Catra smiles at them. It irks Adora how—even at a time like this—Catra can just turn off her emotions and dissociate.

"We got roped into helping this idiot," Catra says, "you went off on your own for some reason and when we found you, you were on the ground. I think you slipped in the woods and hit your head. It rained earlier so it was pretty gross out. Adora and I carried you back."

DT shakes their head, "oh...that's embarrassing."

"Consider it... *forgotten."*

Adora grabs Catra and pulls her in. She keeps her voice calm as she says, "we should get back before Micah complains."

"She's so bossy." DT mutters before sending Catra a teasing grin, "you're definitely going to have your hands full with her."

Catra mumbles, "tell me about it."

"Let's go," she pulls Catra out the door.

Mara is gone by the time they make it out so it's just Micah leaning against the wall as he waits for them. He shares a few short words with them before bidding them goodnight, trusting them to go to their respective rooms with the Prefects on duty to keep an eye out. Adora holds onto Catra, keeping her stride, until they turn the corner.

Adora slams Catra into the wall and demands, "why'd you do that?"

Catra shoves Adora away with a threatening growl, "what good is knowing about a near death encounter going to do for them? You didn't see how fucked up they were, you were too busy sucking up and exchanging business cards. They *told* me to do it. If they want to forget then that's their decision—not *ours."*

“We could have—“

“Don’t you get it?” Catra exclaims, tears on the verge of escaping, “it already *happened!* The only thing I could do was help them forget.”

Adora grabs Catra by the collar of her uniform when she tries to walk away.

Catra glares at her and demands, “let go of me, Grayskull.”

“How could you do something like that? And what if the spell went wrong? You could have scrambled their mind.”

“They knew the risks—they *told* me to do it. It’s the least I could do for getting them involved in your shenanigans. *Every time* I get dragged into your shit show someone gets hurt—“

Adora shakes her head, “they ran off on their own…”

“—it *always* ends like this.” Catra glares at her, “and *you’re* always the common denominator.”

Adora tightens her grip on Catra’s collar to steady herself. She whispers, “you don’t mean that.”

“...let go of me. I’m sick of getting involved with you.”

Adora frowns, “let’s just talk about this—“

“I said, let go of me!”

Catra raises only her *hand* and suddenly a wave of magic—harmless in theory but effective in its execution—pushes Adora back and into the adjacent wall. Her back collides with a dull *thump.* Adora’s breathing is ragged, she stares at Catra with wide eyes because *since when does Catra know how to use wandless magic?*

The burning behind Catra's eyes seems to dull, the light flickering, as she slowly comprehends what she's done. She looks at the hand she used to subdue Adora, she takes a shaky breath as she staggers backwards nearly tripping over herself.

Adora opens her mouth with a whisper, "Catra…" she trails off, not knowing if she's about to console her childhood friend or continue trying to talk some sense into her.

"Just," Catra interrupts, raising her hand—Adora doesn't flinch. She's not afraid of Catra—she could never be. But, it's Catra who stops her hand halfway in its tracks. Catra clenches her hands into fists and holds them at her sides. Catra turns the corner saying, "just leave me alone."

Adora watches her go; running away like usual.

When Catra's footfalls grow too low for Adora to hear she slides down the wall until her bottom hits the marble floor. Adora leans her head against the wall and stares up at the ceiling—avoiding the judgmental eyes egging her on from one of the nearby paintings. A flutter of movement in her peripheral alerts her of the painting's disappearance; they're probably off to gossip with the other paintings about the latest development in the war between her and Catra.

It isn't news to anyone—isn't news that she and Catra continue to try and best each other—so Adora isn't too worried about what rumors the painting will spew.

Catra's the one I'm worried about, she thinks with a sigh, tucking her chin into the space between her huddled knees.

There's so much she doesn't know about her—so much that's changed. Catra isn't the same girl who used to follow Adora around the orphanage with her tail wrapped around Adora's wrist. Catra is fierce; she's independent, a force to be reckoned, and Adora fears one day—

Catra will be *dangerous.*

Chapter End Notes

I decided to make them 14 during the end of their third year because as I was reading it I said, "they're way too OP (overpowered) to be 13". Catra and Adora are obviously a cut above the rest of their classmates and the spells they've learned (and the level they perform them at) has always been insane. For Adora it's obvious to the professors why she's so strong: her parents were legends and powerful magic wielders so it's genetic. The same goes for Catra: she doesn't know it yet but she gets her skill from her mother who is the most powerful Unspeakable in the wizarding world. But because Catra's relationship to her real mother is a secret people are often shocked by her (a hybrid) magical ability; she gets the same prejudice and discrimination a muggle born would have gotten in the Harry Potter franchise.

This Interlude kind of marks the "split" between Adora and Catra at Hogwarts. Catra decides to become an Obliviator with good intentions, but Adora doesn't respect it because she doesn't understand Catra's resolve. Plus the magical skill Catra has at their age is something Adora is envious of so it makes her work harder—pushes her into work so she can be on Catra's level; so she isn't left behind.

Adora is relatively happy during Hogwarts, it isn't until she begins her work as an Auror does she start to grow dark; meanwhile, Catra has been toeing the line of darkness since the orphanage thanks to Weaver. Because of this darkness it makes Catra unrecognizable to Adora and the "cracks" in their relationship get worse when they're placed in separate houses.

On another note, some have been wondering so here are the house assignments during their Hogwarts years in case I don't mention them all in the story:

Gryffindor: Adora, Bow and Glimmer

Slytherin: Catra and DT

Hufflepuff: Scorpia (but Slytherin basically adopts her) and Kyle

Ravenclaw: Lonnie and Rogelio

I considered making Catra Ravenclaw but after this Interlude her ambition and drive is definitely fitting for the Slytherin title. She's willing to do whatever it takes to achieve her goal.

Also, we have a release date for The Owl House! I'm super excited for Season 2b, Amity is my favorite and the kid has come so far…

Next chapter should be up next week hopefully.

All Rise

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

11

Bang!

Adora jumps out of her skin, nearly falling off the bench as she's awoken by the ruckus. Her eyes shift to the source—a bolted iron door—swinging out towards her, nearly coming off the hinges, as a junior Auror trots in carrying a tray. Adora quickly recognizes the slop they try to pass off as food—something preserved for the Ministry's worst criminals.

Adora grips at the wooden bench and fixes her glare to the dirt stained ground. The dust cakes her boots with its soot; a cloud hangs over her head. She doesn't remember anything—she *hates* not knowing, hates feeling *helpless.* The last thing she recalls is leaving Catra's flat and heading to the Ministry. *Guess that means Mara is responsible,* it's the only explanation for why she's in this situation. Mara framed her, and for extra security she wiped Adora's memory of her confession so it can't be used as evidence during the trial.

"You can't just barge in here," a second junior Auror says, cautiously walking inside the holding room.

"I had to see for myself." He turns his nose up at her announcing, "Grayskull. I've got your lunch."

Adora pushes off the bench in a jerked motion—the Auror's flinch involuntarily. She raises an unimpressed eyebrow at the future of the Auror department.

Adora walks up to the barrier and presses her body against the bars; she slips her arms through the gaps, her lips turn up slightly

as the junior Auror's take a cautious step back. To ease the tension, she busies her hands by gripping the bars. Adora hums, *it's weird being on the other side...*

"Hey," the Auror with the tray says once he gains the courage, "...your lunch."

Adora blows a stray hair out from her face. Her eyes flit over to the tray; she knows exactly what they put in that slop and she doesn't intend on eating it.

"Not hungry."

The tray collides with the bars of the cell, just a couple inches from her face, but she doesn't flinch—won't give them the satisfaction. Instead, Adora meets his fierce gaze with a leveled one of her own. Her lack of interest pisses him off even more.

"Marty!" The whiny one by the door exclaims, looking around frantically as Marty grabs Adora by the collar of her coat. "Let her go—"

"How could you?" Marty exclaims, "people respected you—I thought you were a hero...but you're just a traitor." He uses his free hand to blindly grab his wand. Adora's jaw juts up as he presses the tip of his wand into her skin.

"Marty, stop it," he begs.

Marty asks, "why shouldn't I do it? The world will be better without filth like her. Don't you remember what death eaters did to your family? To Gia? I should end her right here, the kiss is too good for all the hell she's put us through."

Adora's jaw clenches, her grip tightening on the bars as his wand begins to spark to life. A spell forms on her tongue when she feels heat radiating from the wand—burning at her skin.

"Get your hands off my client!"

Adora blinks, startled, as Netossa—a face she hasn't seen in a *long* time—barges into the room with a shout. Marty lowers his wand in shock, faltering for just a moment before he asks "you're actually defending this traitor?"

"Traitor?" Netossa asks in outrage. She barks out a dry laugh. "Have you forgotten who she is? She's the *golden girl,* one of the saviors of the wizarding world—"

"And it's all a façade," Marty shoots back.

Netossa's eyes narrow into slits as she spits out, "innocent until proven guilty. And when she *is* declared innocent, I'll be right at your door with a court notice charging you with harassment."

Marty releases Adora with a start. Reality dawns on him. It appears he hadn't considered what would happen if Adora's not deemed responsible for her actions. Marty swirls his wand, swiftly cleaning the mess he made from throwing the lunch tray. He grunts out something Adora can't comprehend—maybe an apology—before he pulls the other Auror out the room.

Before leaving Marty says, "you have five minutes to—"

"I'll take all the time I want with my client." Netossa glares at him saying, "I don't care if the Minister of Magic himself is kept waiting."

Marty gulps down a reply. He gives Netossa a sharp nod before removing himself. The door slams shut and soon they're alone.

Netossa's walls come crumbling down. She races to the bars and asks, "are you okay?"

Adora rubs at the spot on her neck where the wand was pressed. She mutters, "I'm fine."

"Fine?" Netossa's voice squeaks—rivaling Catra's characteristic high-pitched squeal of surprise. "Adora, you're on trial for *murder* and *treason."*

"I'm innocent," she argues with a shrug.

"Do you have proof?"

Adora takes a step back, frowning. "You can't actually believe I would be capable of killing Lonnie. She's family—"

"I know! Of course I believe you...but it doesn't matter what I think, you're going to have to convince the Minister." Netossa reiterates, "so, what do you have?"

Adora falters, "I'm pretty sure I had proof but...everything is so fuzzy." She rubs her head and tries to recall a memory that's been stolen.

"Look, I've known you since Hogwarts…"

Adora smiles to herself, thinking back on how Netossa and Spinerella were somewhat of the responsible ones in their friend group. Whenever the golden quartet got into any trouble those two were always there to prevent things from getting worse. But, being two years older, when Netossa and Spinerella graduated they left the quartet to their own devices and—unsurprisingly—they got into a *plethora* of trouble in their absence.

Netossa brings Adora from her revere saying, "you would never do this; I'm willing to put my reputation on it...but we can't go out there without a counter attack. Do you have *anything* we can use?"

Adora thinks ruefully, *there's only one thing that'll get me out of this.*

"Adora." Netossa says, losing her patience.

"Catra," she says after a brief pause, "and Glimmer, and Bow...if anyone's going to get me out of this, it's *them."* She never wanted to get her friends involved in this. It's the reason she left to face Mara on her own, but she's unfortunately backed herself into a corner. Adora can easily prove her innocence by confessing the

truth about Lonnie's *death,* but it isn't her secret to reveal; she can't use it as her trump card. Even if they decide to lock her up in Azkaban for *life,* Adora will take this secret to the grave.

Netossa's face twists up. "I don't think they can help us..."

Adora's breath hitches. She presses her face into the metal until it leaves a bruising red mark in its wake. She demands, "what are you talking about? What's wrong?"

"Adora...I don't think you understand how serious this is. Everyone thinks you've *killed* an Unspeakable, an Unspeakable who everyone thought you considered a sister, on top of that they think you're a Prime loyalist. The Country's faith in the golden quartet has been dismantled." Netossa whispers, "I doubt they'll let Catra and the others inside the courtroom—it'll cause mass hysteria. And then there's the press barricading the doors…"

Adora mutters, "oh."

Netossa snaps. "How the hell are you so calm?"

Adora's pounding heart tells a different story. But still, she replies with a confident "have some faith in my friends."

"I admit, you're crazy—the lot of you." Netossa asks, "but where are they? I had Spinerella try to get in contact with them but she keeps getting nothing. It's like they're off the grid, not even Angella can get a hold of them."

Adora isn't ready to consider what this might mean. She changes the subject. "When's the trial?"

Netossa whispers, "in thirty minutes."

Adora's face goes white. "*What?* Can they do that? Don't they have a shit ton of legal work to get through before they can proceed?"

“Normally yes, but this isn’t an ordinary case. Mara has deemed it a matter of national security—“

Adora mutters, “of course she has...”

“—says you’re a danger to the wizarding world and if we let this moment slip you might escape before the prosecution. They’re pushing this along,” Netossa folds her arms and mutters, “you’re lucky I was working late at the office when I heard them bring you in. They were going to set you up with a lousy public defender before I stepped in. And now...they’re proceeding faster than expected. It’s what tipped me off that something wasn’t right —aside from you being tried for *murder.”*

Adora clenches her fists as she deduces, “they want me put away as soon as possible.”

Netossa nods. “You *must* know something. Why else would they be doing this? Look, you know you can tell me—“

The door creaks open. Netossa clamps her mouth shut but it drops open again as a young man with a bowl cut let’s himself in. Adora looks him over—he’s wearing a white dress shirt that’s properly tucked into his black slacks without a crease in place. He adjusts his tie anxiously when she and Netossa send him a pointed stare.

Netossa snaps out of her surprise and says, “I thought I made myself clear. I’ll have all the time I want with my client.”

He blinks. “Pardon?”

“You got wax in your ears? I said—“

“I heard you. Sorry, just let me…” he trails off, spinning his messenger bag to the front so he can dig through its contents. Eventually he plucks out an ominous folder with a cheer. He pulls out a paper, nodding to himself in confirmation, before he looks up and says “I think there’s been a misunderstanding—“

"Clearly." Netossa grumbles.

"—Miss Grayskull is *my* client."

"What?" She and Netossa exclaim simultaneously.

He jumps back in shock. He takes a nervous gulp, readjusting his skewed glasses as he says "it's all right here if you need confirmation."

"I don't need confirmation to know you're wrong." Netossa says, "I received approval to represent Miss Grayskull last night when I saw them bring her to the holding room. It's been cleared."

"It's been overruled," he corrects.

Netossa frowns. "On what grounds?"

"On *you* not being qualified to represent—"

"I'm not qualified?" Netossa demands; nostrils flaring. "I'll have you know I graduated top of my class—"

"I'm aware," he interrupts softly, "I'm not saying you lack any skill as a defender. I know how well respected you are, heck, I've studied a dozen cases you worked on while I was at University. But you specialize in public defenses, not *federal* ones...you don't have the qualifications for this case and the Minister will not allow your involvement unless you're a key witness."

"Is that true?" Adora asks, not having much knowledge about the nuts and bolts of the legal system. She's more of a kick ass first and talk later kind of person; on rare occasions where she did have legal work her junior Auror's took it off her hands despite her attempt to stop them. It was Mara's idea, she recalls with a start; she'd convinced Adora to handle more important matters and leave the paperwork to the cadets.

Netossa looks ashamed to admit, "it's true."

“What does this mean?” Adora has an idea but the words slip from her mouth without her permission.

“It means, I can’t be on your defense team.” Netossa fixes her glare to the man saying, “I didn’t think they’d be so *strict* with that rule.”

He smiles. “It’s a *special* case.”

“I’m starting to see that.”

Adora looks the man up and down. She raises an eyebrow. “So, *you’re* my defense?”

“My name is Lex. And yes, I’ll be doing whatever it takes to make sure you’re able to walk away from this unscathed.”

Netossa asks, “can you give us a second?”

Lex hesitates. “We should really—“

“It’ll be fast.” Netossa says.

Lex seems apprehensive but eventually gives in; feeling the tension in the room. Lex swiftly places the folder into his bag for safekeeping and says, “just a few minutes; I have to prep Miss Grayskull accordingly.”

Netossa sends him a curt nod. Lex slips from the room to give them space.

“I’m sorry...there’s nothing I can do since the *Minister* stepped in.” Netossa mutters, “who did you piss off?”

Adora presses further into the metal, swiftly ignoring her question by giving one of her own. “So, what are my options?”

Netossa rubs her neck saying, “you can either have Lex defend you or roll a dice and represent yourself...there’s not much else

you can do on such short notice." She frowns, "I'm sorry I can't do more."

"Not your fault." Adora waves her off.

Netossa glances at the door before she whispers another option, "...you can run."

Adora looks at her, skeptical. "I can't."

"You're strong enough to—"

"I know I *can,* but running won't fix anything. It'll just make things worse—help paint a clearer picture of the person they're trying to make me out to be. And if I leave now...it'll just lead to more corruption. This has to end here."

"I get what you're saying but…are you really going to let *him* be your defense? He seems a little mental to me."

Either I let him defend me or I stand before the Minister of Magic with nothing but fragmented pieces of the truth. Adora sighs, coming to a decision, "this is my best option."

Netossa looks away. "I wish there was more I could do—"

"It's fine," she says with a tight smile, "honestly, I'm just glad to see a familiar face…and, have you heard any news? Like Spinnerella, Mermista, and the others—what do they all think?" She holds her breath in anticipation for the dismantlement of Netossa's expression—waits for the bad news. But, it never comes.

Netossa grips the iron between her hands and looks down at her with determination. She declares, "*everyone* knows you'd never do this. We've got your back."

Adora feels lighter. "Thank you."

Netossa's face lights up, "I can ask the Minister if I can attend the trial as a spectator. I know only witnesses or members of the defense can be in the stands but maybe if I—"

"No." Adora says abruptly—stilling Netossa with a cold glare. Adora's grip tightens on the bars as she says, "stay away from the courthouse."

Netossa frowns, stepping as close as the barrier will allow. She eyes Adora—taking in her suddenly frazzled appearance, she's not sure what she said to tip the girl over the edge. For the most part, Adora's been relatively calm—even accepting—about the turn of events. But now…she seems *afraid.* Netossa whispers, "why should I stay away? What's going to happen at the—"

"Sorry to interrupt," Lex says, startling Netossa who hadn't heard the door budge. Netossa glances at him over her shoulder and, based on his expression, she doubts the sincerity of that apology. Lex holds the door open, glancing at the clock, as he says "we're a little pressed for time. If you don't mind?" It's a polite dismissal, but still—Netossa's emotions flare. Something isn't right about all of this.

"Go."

Netossa turns around, shaken to realize Adora is still watching her with that chilly expression.

Adora repeats, "go…Lex and I will take it from here."

The last thing Netossa wants to do is leave. But, with her hands tied, she mutters one last encouraging advice to Adora before making herself scarce. Adora feels her body relax—just a bit—when Netossa's out of the room; out of harm's way. In all honesty, Adora doesn't know what the outcome of this trial will be. But, her intuition is showering her with all kinds of red flags.

"—skull?"

Adora snaps out of her thoughts, looking up to see Lex watching her nervously. She shakes her head and asks, "pardon?"

Lex eyes her over the frame of his glasses wearily. "I said, do you have any evidence to assist you in the trial? Or maybe some witnesses? The other defense has quite the stack lined up."

"Oh," Adora says, "no, I don't."

Lex nearly turns white. "You have *nothing?"*

Adora sighs, leaning her head to rest on the solid metal—apparently it's the only thing she can rely on to keep her upright. Adora waves her hand flippantly and says, "aren't *you* supposed to figure that stuff out?"

Lex mutters in his hand, "I've never gone with so… *little* before."

"And how many cases have you won?" Adora asks, curious, but not looking forward to the answer.

Lex rubs the back of his neck—the first sign Adora shouldn't get her hopes up. He stutters out a nervous, "well, uhm…I graduated University about three years ago and since then I've worked on maybe seven high risk cases and the legal system is just a difficult to—"

"How many have you won?" Adora asks again, patience thinning.

"Well, one of my clients was killed in transit and the case was called off so technically…one?"

Adora bangs her head against the bars.

Lex hurries to say, "but this time is different!"

Not looking up, Adora mutters "...enlighten me."

"This is different because you're not a criminal with a troubled history that's difficult to unpack, you're the *golden girl."* Adora

looks up, giving Lex the courage to continue. “Look, sometimes evidence isn’t important…it’s all about telling a story.”

“A story?”

Lex nods. “It doesn’t matter what the truth is, we just have to present you as an upstanding citizen who’s caught in a web she didn’t create. You’re a bloody *hero,* so people are already skeptical. We just have to spin this narrative in our favor.”

Adora asks, “and how do we do that?”

Lex glances at the clock. “Just be yourself, tell the truth, and I’ll do the rest. Trust me, I’ll get you out of this.” Lex sends a smile her way; it’s meant to encourage her but—

Adora isn’t settled.

When the time comes, two Auror’s lead Adora and Lex from the holding room. The Auror’s guide them to the courthouse on the opposite side of the building; as they approach the entrance Adora’s stomach begins to toss because—just a short distance away—a large mob gathers by the doors.

“Why don’t we just apparate in?” Adora asks, uneasy about the raging crowd and the magic seeping shackles keeping her defenseless. “This isn’t normal protocol.” While she skipped out on most of the legal paperwork after making her arrests, Adora did however attend multiple trials and spoke on the case to ensure it was carried out justly. But, for those cases, they didn’t make a spectacle out of walking their suspects to the courthouse.

Lex glances at her over his shoulder and mutters, “as I’ve said before, this is a *special* case.”

Before they’re noticed by the crowd, Lex stops her. The Auror’s huff in aggravation but give them a bit of privacy by turning their backs. Lex explains, “this is a tactic for the other defense; this is kind of like their prologue. The golden girl’s fall from grace; the

people who once lined the streets—singing her praise—are gathered again, but this time it's not a celebratory event. They want to evoke negative emotions before the case begins."

"But it doesn't matter what they think."

Lex nods. "The Minister makes the final call. Think of the council as...advisors."

"Got it." Adora says, eyeing the crowd wearily. "Any advice?"

"Don't speak. Just keep moving." Lex asks, "ready?"

Not really, she thinks. Even so, Adora sends him a jerked nod. The Auror's continue their escort duties. Lex stays at her side the closer they get to the front; Adora pinpoints the exact moment the crowd notices their arrival. There's no loud outburst or a spark of recognition within the sea of faces—it's something much worse.

The hair on the back of Adora's neck stands as she feels magic lace through the air. She grinds her teeth, fingers flexing as she contemplates summoning even just an *ounce* of magic to defend herself. But, in the end, Lex makes the decision for her. The spell hurtling towards them bounces off a protective shield Lex conjures with rapid ease—even the two Auror's seem impressed.

Lex holds his wand erect to keep the spell alive as people from the crowd throw an array of nasty spells and hexes their way. He mutters, "don't use your magic...it's bad for your image."

Adora's surprised by Lex's intuition.

He smirks. "What? Like I expected those shackles to hold back a member of the golden quartet."

Adora loosens her stiff posture. For a moment, she feels safe—like she can actually put her trust in Lex. *He hasn't won a single case,* she reminds herself dimly; thinking back on this fact causes Adora's shoulders to hunch back up.

Lex turns to the Auror's with an expression Adora can't make out due to the glare from the sun shining on his glasses. Lex says, "you two are *Auror's* aren't you? Mind doing your actual job?"

The Auror's are too embarrassed by their slow reaction time to mouth back at the defender. They raise their wands and aid in creating a barrier however, Lex doesn't let his guard down and keeps his wand raised even as they make it to the doors—passing the rowdiest section of the crowd.

Adora contemplates using a little magic to conjure up a dutiful silencing spell but—maybe the silence is worse. And a sick part of her actually wants to hear—wants to take in their wrath as they spew out words like:

"Traitor!"

"She should get the kiss!"

"Face us you coward!"

Adora shifts her gaze away when a particularly hostile man slams his fist against the barrier. He shouts a slew of curses—she's heard worse—and spits at her. Her fists clench—she barely holds on as the storm rages. *After all the good I've done for this Country...this is how they repay me?*

"Adora!"

Her heart nearly escapes her chest. Right at the front is Kyle and Rogelio dressed in matching gray suits. Rogelio stands behind Kyle, his beefy hand on the shorter man's shoulder to keep him from getting too close. A brief memory flashes; them, at the orphanage, on a cool summer night talking about all the fun they're going to have at Hogwarts. Kyle was smaller back then, a sniveling mess—anxious about attending the wizarding school. Adora had calmed him down, said no matter what houses they got sorted in—they'd still be friends. Still be a family.

Kyle's gotten a lot taller since then. He's barely recognizable from that little boy who used to scrap his knee and get left behind for being too slow during their games. She briefly wonders how that version of him would handle this situation. *He'd probably cry;* but this version doesn't give her the satisfaction.

Kyle's face is stained red, his wand is held so tight his knuckles turn white. He shouts, "tell me you didn't do *this.* Tell me you didn't, Adora. Answer me!"

Rogelio mutters something in his native tongue—a language Adora hasn't spoken since her youth, so she only gets a few bits and pieces. She wants to stop this madness—wants to tell them the truth—but her resolve holds firm. Adora clamps her mouth shut and allows Lex to guide her up the final flight of stairs until they're swiftly walking through the doors. The Auror's on guard duty close the doors behind them.

Adora nearly collapses upon entry. She can take the rage of strangers—even the wrath of her own nation—but her family…

"Hey." Lex says, fixing his glasses with a quick dab. "Don't let it get to you."

Adora mutters, "the entire Country hates me, even Kyle and Ro...how am I supposed to take it?"

"Got me there," Lex says, sheepish. He gestures to the courtroom and quickly guides her inside. "We should get you seated while the room is empty. Trust me, you don't want to get stuck in a crowd again."

"They're coming *inside?"*

"Only the ones who are testifying or had family members lost to...the crimes committed by the loyalist's." Lex ushers her, "come on."

They reach the courtroom in a few quick strides. There's soft conversation filling the space but it dulls to a low hush as Adora

and Lex grace them. Adora watches the council—seated in a booth behind the empty seat assigned for the Minister—they stare back at her wearily. Adora huffs, subtly gesturing to her wrist bracelets keeping her restrained. *I guess they should be a little worried, I've broken myself out of worse situations.*

Lex gestures to a tall chair—centered right in the middle of the room facing the council. "Have a seat. I'll be right over there the entire time."

The Auror's keep a close eye on her as she cautiously takes a seat. There's movement at her back—multiple sets of footsteps—but she keeps herself facing forward, staring emptily at the Minister's golden name plate. Actually, she prefers to keep her eyes front—this way she doesn't have to see who's coming to watch her public dismantling.

Crack!

Adora glances up as the Minister of Magic appears in his seat. The voices quiet down upon his entry. Despite the urgency of this case, Adora can't help but feel like she's at Hogwarts all over again. But instead of being tried for murder, she's being scrutinized by Angella for getting into a fight with Catra in the Great Hall—ultimately causing a vicious food fight between Gryffindor and Slytherin. Back then she thought it was the end of the world. *It's funny how big something seems in the moment…*

Sadly, Adora is brought to reality as she feels the heat coming from the Minister's stare. She takes in the irony of her position; seated in a lone chair at the center of the room—a prime spot for judgment. And isn't this exactly what this is? An unfair trial—a betrayal of her Country onto her—a way for Mara to wash her hands clean of this entire endeavor. And no matter how this ends, Adora isn't leaving without a stain on her reputation.

Adora flinches at a sudden sharpness in her left side. She turns, glaring at the source. Lex mouths, *pay attention,* as if he's scolding a child for not paying attention in class. Adora rubs her

sore side and dutifully faces the Minister as she catches the gist of his speech.

"...in the case of the Ministry vs Grimley, you stand accused of betraying not only your Country but also your comrades. In the crimes laid against you—in acting as an accomplice with Octavia Stronghold in the murder of Unspeakable, Lonnie Grimely—I ask you, Adora Grayskull, how do you plead?"

Adora sits up in her seat. She crosses her hands over her knees and says, "innocent."

The Minister hums. "I must admit, it is unfortunate—us meeting under these circumstances. I've heard marvelous things about you and your comrades so it's disappointing to have you sitting here in front of me today."

Adora tells him, "I didn't do this."

"Do you have any proof of this… *innocence?"*

Adora bites the side of her cheek when a vulgar reply comes to mind. Luckily, Lex notices her unease and stands. The Minister glances his way—Adora takes the moment to relax her posture while the eyes are off her.

"Minister," Lex says breezily, "there is no solid evidence linking my client to this case. Everything is hearsay. Fabrications of the truth, at best."

The Minister raises an eyebrow saying, "the opposing defense claims otherwise. They have a witness saying the crimes tied to Miss Grayskull are *very* much tangible."

A witness? Adora frowns, nearly spinning around to scope out the room. In the end she refrains—it'll just make it seem like she's nervous about what the witness has to say.

Lex's momentum falters, he awkwardly sits back down as the Minister waves his hand—a chair appears from thin air, adjacent

from Adora but pointed towards the Minister and his council. A *crack* sounds in the room and a young man appears before the Minister—occupying the seat.

Adora huffs, *so he gets to apparate in but I have to take a walk of shame?*

The witness holds onto the chair handles with dear life as the chair is magically lifted from the ground—carrying him to the center. Adora leans back, eyeing the familiar witness as her own chair is levitated off to the side. Everyone's focus turns to the man. Adora narrows her eyes, taking in his familiar profile but only draws a blank.

The Minister explains, "this is Kevin Mace, he was there the night Miss Grayskull attacked the Ministry of Magic—"

Attacked? Adora pulls a face.

"—tells us, what did you see?"

Kevin looks away from the Minister's beady eyes, he looks at his feet instead. He mutters, "I was on duty at the Ministry of Magic last night, me and a couple other junior Auror's, we were supposed to be sorting out old documents. Auror—I mean…Miss Grayskull, she came up the lift and nodded at us before she went into Director Mara's office."

The Minister leans forward. "Did she say anything to you? In passing?"

Kevin shakes his head. "No. She just went into the office, and a couple minutes later we hear this *boom.* Not soon after we see her running out all frantic with the Director at her heels, we tried to stop her but she…she uhh…cast an ice spell and we got stuck for a while."

The Minister overlooks Kevin's embarrassment and instead turns a critical eye to Adora. He demands, "what were you doing at the

Ministry so late? Surely, an Auror with your high standing wouldn't have been subjected to needless paperwork."

Adora goes off what little she can recall. "I had to talk to Mara," she says, forgoing the Director title—Mara doesn't deserve to hold it.

"In relation to what?"

Adora falters, her memory lagging at the most inopportune time. "...about Lonnie's case—"

"Don't!"

Adora can't stop herself. Her eyes flint to the stands. Her heart drops as she spots Kyle, once again being restrained by Rogelio, as he shouts, red in the face, "don't you *dare* speak her name!"

The Minister says soft but stern, "Mr. Grimley, while you have a right to be in my courtroom, you must compose yourself during the proceedings. One more outburst and I'll have you removed."

Kyle mutters something nasty under his breath. Adora turns away before their eyes can lock again—she can't handle his stare again—fears she might fall apart and reveal everything if only it means baring him of such ugly emotions. He's so different from the man she knows.

"—Grayskull," she snaps her head up as the Minister tries to gain her attention. "You said you were going to the Director's office to discuss Grimley's case. Did you discover new evidence?"

Adora's brow furrows as her memory of the night ends—growing murky just as she recalls stepping inside Mara's office. She grips her chair again—the marks she leaves behind can rival the ones caused by Catra's claws when she's in one of her *dreadful* moods. Adora opens her mouth, not sure what half confession she's about to spew when suddenly—

“Pardon me, Minister.” The voice boils Adora’s blood. Part of why she wanted to keep facing forward was to avoid Kyle and Rogelio —and the rest of the members in attendance—but most of all, it’s because of *her.* Lex can sense Adora’s approaching storm; he sends her a pleading look but Adora pays the warning no mind. Her eyes fix on the source of her destruction—Mara, in all her glory; she has the *nerve* to show her face. Adora watches as her mentor—fallen from grace in Adora’s eyes—stands, head raised like a woman who has nothing to hide. Mara offers like some kind of *saint,* “I’m willing to reveal *my* memories of the event if it helps.”

The fabric beneath Adora’s nails gives under the pressure. She doesn’t want to think about the fabrications made to Mara's memory; surely they’ll paint Mara as the hero and Adora as the foe.

The Minister waves her off. “Director, your position requires privacy; it is essential to maintaining the protection of this realm. There is no need.”

Mara nods. “I can still recount what I know to be true. Maybe my knowledge can shed some light.”

“...very well,” the Minister says, “the floor is yours, Director.”

The witness disappears with another *crack* and with the chair free, Mara takes a seat; she spares no glance in Adora’s direction upon her descent. Mara crosses her legs and begins to spin her web, “it’s true, Miss Grayskull came to my office late at night to discuss the case, but her unraveling started from the beginning.”

Adora quickly pieces Mara’s story together. Lex meets her eyes across the room. He smiles to himself, impressed with Adora’s intuition and quick deduction. Adora relaxes her jaw, releasing the arms of the chair from her grasp. *Don’t let them think you’re unhinged. Don’t play into her narrative.* Yes, her Country turned its back on her—but now isn’t the time to let it fester.

"When Mrs. Grimely's body was first discovered Miss Grayskull didn't take the news well. She started acting rash during the cases she was assigned, and it only got worse when Grimely's case was taken on by the American's."

"How so, Director?"

Mara explains, "on her first case after Grimely's death, Miss Grayskull was in pursuit of an assailant—Victor was his name—she apparated into a *muggle* bar and hit him with a nasty stunning hex in front of everyone. It took multiple Obliviators to wash our hands from the event." Mara falters, "I apologize for not bringing this incident to your attention, Minister, but I wanted to give Miss Grayskull a break…I knew— *thought*— she had been through a lot. And Micah Moon—"

Adora freezes.

"—he's the person who normally handles incidents like this but I was wary of his…loyalty."

The Minister raises an eyebrow. "Micah Moon is a well respected Junior Minister—he oversees *your* division—and has held his position *far* longer than you have. Are you implicating him in this case?"

Mara shakes her head. "Of course not, I just thought his opinion on Miss Grayskull's situation might be skewed. He was a DADA Professor at Hogwarts before taking his position. I thought he might go easy on Miss Grayskull—maybe push it under the rug—so I decided to put her on paid Holiday; to clear her head. I also planned to have her mental state evaluated upon her return."

The Minister looks to his council and mutters, "wish I could have a paid Holiday." They smile and laugh at his joke politely like the herd they are. The Minister looks to Adora once the council quiets down. He asks, "would you say you were feeling guilty about the passing of your comrade? Do you think that's why you were acting unlike yourself?"

"I have nothing to be guilty for." Adora frowns, "I was *chasing* a suspect while Lonnie had her throat slit—"

Some of the council members hold a hand to their mouths in distaste at the unwanted mental visual.

"—how could I have been in two places at once?"

The Minister eyes her over the rim of his glasses, "you're a talented witch…I'm sure you could figure something out." He turns back to Mara, "is there anything else?"

Mara says, "Miss Grayskull took my advice and went on Holiday. Although, in her absence there were a few strange occurrences. While I wasn't in charge of Grimley's case, I did keep an eye on it in the papers and…there were strange incidents occurring in America during Miss Grayskull's absence." Mara begins to list, "a muggle was killed at a local pizza establishment—"

"Pizza?" Someone on the council mutters, looking to the others for help but they only shrug their shoulders in confusion.

"—Finn Hale, if my memory allows. He was found with a fatal wound in his chest by the NYPD—a muggle security team—one of America's inside wizards does undercover work with them and when he noticed the magic in the air he made sure to arrive on the scene first. He fixed it to look like a muggle injury—a gun shot I believe. But, he said the true death was from a... *killing curse."*

Sharp gasps erupt within the room. Adora holds her composure even as the council sends her horrified looks.

Mara continues, "Ted Allister—after breaking into Joanne Bennett's flat—has been missing for the last three days. He was a respected wizard in the community and a loving grandfather; he wouldn't just up and leave." Mara frowns. "I'm not saying Miss Grayskull killed the muggle, but it's safe to say she should be *at least* tried with kidnapping and acting outside her jurisdiction. Even if she isn't held responsible for Grimely's death, her Auror's license

should be revoked. And all of this conveniently occurred while she was on supposed Holiday."

The Minister turns to Adora with a frown. He asks, "Miss Grayskull, is it true that you were in America during these occurrences?"

Adora meets his gaze. "Yes."

The council mutters to themselves but the Minister goes on, "and are you responsible for these events?"

Adora tries to explain, "I only went to America to find out the truth—"

"It was out of your jurisdiction. You have no leeway in the matters of what happens in America." The Minister shakes his head in outrage. "This isn't Hogwarts—you can't go around poking your nose into things that don't concern you."

Adora struggles to keep her mouth closed.

"Did you kill the muggle? Is Allister held up in your flat as we speak? Was he just a victim who got too close to your truth?" The Minster shakes his head, "honestly I don't know what to believe. I would have your memories read but…unfortunately, you are still considered an Auror until this case is finished. We can't look through your memories without jeopardizing the secrets you've obtained over the years working other cases." He rubs his temple before he asks, "is there anyone else who can testify to you not being directly involved in the instances the Director has listed?"

Adora shakes her head, refusing to have Catra and the others implicated.

"I was afraid so." The Minister looks pained—as if his only hope has been dashed. That's what Adora's been feeling lately; her hopes being destroyed—stolen from the very people she swore to protect. They were against her—after *everything* she's done for

them. The Minister says, "if there's nothing else, then we shall bring Octavia Stronghold to the stand so we can—"

"Pardon me, Minister." Lex says, standing from his seat swiftly.

Mara slows in her step—looking over at Lex with a strange expression pulling on her face.

The Minister frowns. "Yes?"

Lex announces, "I'd like to call a witness to the stand."

Adora's eyebrows bunch together at the sudden confidence Lex has—something that's been absent the entirety of this trial. Intrigued, Adora leans forward.

Mara stops walking all together; she spins around and asks, "a witness? I wasn't made aware of this. You can't just bombard us with—"

"You bombarded me with evidence from *America's* jurisdiction," Lex shoots back, "something outside the grounds of this case—"

Mara's response is just as charged, "it was important for my defense."

"And so is mine." Lex says with a shrug.

The Minister rubs his eyes at their childlike squabbling and mutters, "Director, please return to your seat. It's true, bringing up information from America's jurisdiction goes beyond the scope of this case—I don't even want to question how you got a hold of the information…so, I think it's only fair for Miss Grayskull to have someone testify on her character." The Minister gestures to Lex, "I'll allow it."

Lex nearly preens. "Thank you, Minister." Lex adjusts his collar—like it's the first time he's ever had his way during a trial. Clearing his throat, Lex says, "I'd like to call to the stand—"

The hair on the back of Adora's neck alerts her long before Lex reveals:

"—Catra D'riluth."

Chapter End Notes

I cut a lot of moving parts from this chapter and decided to split it up into two parts because there was so much happening and it was way too long. I've been told my chapters are "a lot" so I'll give you guys time to breathe this time.

Hope this chapter wasn't too boring but I had to set the court scene; the action will be back soon enough so just hold tight. But until then, politics. Also, I realized this is the longest She-Ra story I've ever written. Nice little milestone for me.

Expect the next chapter sometime next week per usual.

Now You See Me

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

11

"—Catra D'riluth."

Utter outrage breaks out within the courtroom. Adora swears she can feel the ground shake beneath her feet as the council voices their concerns while the audience begins to panic as fear takes over. Adora glances at Mara but her expression gives nothing away—almost like she isn't surprised by this turn.

Mara lifts her head as she faces the Minister and his council. Her voice reigns over the noise, "Minister...after what we've discovered, I think it's safe to say we can't surely rely on *her* testimony. If we've learned anything today, it's that the golden quartet in its entirety can't be trusted."

The Minister laces his hands together; he rests his chin atop and says, "even though the evidence is stacked against Miss Grayskull...she deserves a fair trial, and the reliability of the remaining members of the golden quartet is not in question today." The Minister sends Adora a weary glance—seemingly apprehensive despite his stance—before he begrudgingly gestures to Lex, "you may proceed."

Lex announces, "Miss D'riluth, if you would be kind enough to grace us."

Adora anticipates the characteristic *crack* announcing Catra's entry, but it never comes. The council whispers amongst themselves as the crowd grows restless with anticipation. Adora glances around—trying to catch a glimpse. *I can feel her magic, she's here somewhere—*

The door opens with a soft *thud.* Adora smiles, glancing to the side as her girlfriend makes her dramatic appearance (Catra and DT were best friends at Hogwarts for a reason, with their mutual love for dramatic flares). A low whisper bounces off the walls as Catra—dressed in a pleasing black suit *(the Angel of death,* Adora muses)—glides down the aisle with Melog forever by her side. Adora leans forward, magic itching on her tongue—just in case—as Mara side steps Catra and offers her the floor.

Catra slips into the seat while Melog rests at her side. She crosses her legs, one over the other, and greets the Minister with a polite nod. Hearing Catra's voice sends a wave of reassurance through Adora, "thank you for having me, Minister."

"Miss D'riluth," the Minister says with a shake of his head, seemingly frustrated, but there's an amused expression pulling at his lips, "you've caused quite the stir. Are there any more members of your *team* who will be in attendance?"

At the mention, Adora discretely tilts her head in search for Bow or Glimmer; she comes up short. In her retreat, she catches Mara's disgruntled expression—the mask slipping as she grinds her jaw at the spectacle Catra is making.

"Not that I'm aware of," Catra responds breezily.

The Minister confesses, "like I've told Miss Grayskull, I truly wish we were meeting under better circumstances."

Catra nods sullenly. "Unfortunately, this isn't the case."

"Unfortunately," the Minister mutters in agreement. He clears his throat and gets back to more pressing issues, "I'm sure you know why you've been summoned, Miss Grayskull's defense team believes you can be an asset to her case. Would you be kind enough to explain how?"

Catra leans back in her seat as she starts at the beginning, "I've been stationed in America—New York City to be exact—for a couple weeks because of a new case I've been assigned. Adora

and the others came to my flat for Holiday not knowing I was actually in America on business. And, it was rude to throw them out, so I let them stay."

"Who is included in *others?"* The Minister asks wearily.

"Adora Grayskull, Bow Armstrong, and Glimmer Moon."

Adora sighs, *so much for leaving Bow and Glimmer out of this…* Although, it's not fair to put this blame entirely on Catra; Adora's sure it was Bow and Glimmer's idea to have their own names implicated in the trial. It's not too surprising really; it's always been like this, if one of them is in trouble then *all* of them are in trouble—sort of an all or nothing kind of thing.

The Minister doesn't look surprised either, "so *all* of you were there during the events mentioned?"

"We were." Catra nods.

The Minister's face twists up. He demands, "so all of you are responsible for the crimes committed?"

Catra frowns, "everything we did is classified information for—"

"—how convenient," someone on the council mutters in disdain.

Catra smiles—innocently baring her fangs to the councilor who spoke out. "Yes, almost as convenient as the Director having access to classified information outside her jurisdiction."

"Enough," the Minister frowns, in no mood for the squabbling, "you're an Obliviator, you can't just—"

"Actually," Catra corrects, "I've been an Unspeakable for the past couple of months. Wanted a change in pace, you know?"

The Minister asks, "can anyone vouch for this?"

Catra shrugs. “Of course, all the paperwork is taken care of and listed on file for reference.”

“Bloody hell,” the Minister groans, rubbing his temple in frustration, “this surely changes things.” He raises his hand, waving it slightly, causing the doors to lock with a deafening *swoosh.* The audience grows weary as the Minister announces, “due to the *complications* of this trial, no one will be allowed to enter or *leave* this room until this trial is finished. Anyone who objects will be subdued immediately and charged accordingly.” He turns to one of the council members, “have an Obliviator team on standby.”

Adora eyes the crowd wearily. Kyle and Rogelio seem less frazzled than before, but in light of the Minister’s decision they seem apprehensive.

The Minister turns to Catra once the contingency plans are set in place. He says, “you’re an official Unspeakable so, since there are certain things you’re unable to share, we can—“

“There’s no need,” Catra interrupts with her hand raised.

“Pardon?” The Minister frowns.

Catra explains, “as long as you have the proper barriers in place I don’t have to hold back information; my oath will prevent me from speaking out of bounds. Every measure seems to be accounted for—unless you disagree?”

The Minister shakes his head in silent agreement. “Let us continue then.” He leans forward asking, “what case were you assigned?”

“I was in America to continue the case that was taken over by their district—to find out who was responsible for Lonnie’s death.” Catra flippantly waves her hand, “the American’s practically begged me to step in, but Lonnie was an old friend so I couldn’t refuse even if I wanted to. Adora and the rest of the Scooby gang —“

"The *what?"* The Minister interrupts—baffled.

"It's a muggle thing," Catra mutters under her breath before she reiterates, "Adora Grayskull, in addition to Glimmer Moon, and Bow Armstrong, came to America for Holiday—that's it—but unfortunately they got wrapped up in my case. It was my decision to appoint them as my support staff; we worked together before, during the war, so I knew chemistry wouldn't be an issue. I had jurisdiction in America and as my support staff so did they. And the *incidences* mentioned were…unfortunate misunderstandings —"

"Misunderstandings?" A councilor rises from their seat with a foul shout, "a muggle was *killed* with an unforgivable curse—Ted Allister is *missing* and as far as I'm concerned *you're* the main suspect."

Catra raises an unimpressed eyebrow. She meets the councilor's fury with a leveled tone, "Finn Hale—" she pauses, eyes flickering to the side, and for a moment, Adora expects her resolve to slip; Catra's still tangled with bitter emotions from the loss of a dear friend, but Catra holds her own. Catra straightens her back and quickly regains momentum—almost unnoticed. "Finn Hale was an innocent bystander, a masked man killed him to get back at me for getting close to the truth. Before I could interrogate the man, he killed himself—he was prepared to sacrifice his life. And Ted Allister was living a secret life as a Prime Loyalist—"

The same councilor argues, "he was an upstanding citizen who—"

"He had *dementors* in his backyard," Catra scoffs.

Adora takes great pleasure in watching the rowdy councilor awkwardly sit back down—startled by the confession.

Catra continues, "Allister broke into Bennett's flat so we would track him down; he planned on getting rid of us, but thankfully Adora and I fended the dementors off. Allister ran away during the outbreak so we don't know where he is." The last part isn't exactly

true. Allister *did* run away, but Adora distinctly recalls tasking Catra with the job of tracking the man down and Catra is an *excellent* hunter.

Adora gulps, *does Catra seriously have Allister tied up somewhere?*

"After Allister escaped, where did you go from there?" The Minister asks suddenly.

"We exhausted all our leads so we decided to make our own," Catra looks sheepish as she confesses, "so, we used a glamor spell and impersonated some junior Auror's…Kendrick and James I think?"

"Kenny and Jeff." Adora corrects with a playful eye roll. Catra often messes names up on purpose as a power move or when she's feeling mischievous.

Catra nods—a silent *thanks.* "Yes, those two. We used their identities to infiltrate the crime scene at Lonnie's house; Adora and I went into the office to look through some paperwork and—"

"This is absurd," another councilor exclaims, voice echoing within the courtroom. The man rises from his seat with a scowl as he gestures to Catra like a child tattling on the playground, "you just confessed to subduing two junior Auror's and *impersonating* them at an active crime scene."

"Yeah, I know." Catra frowns, "I just said that."

The councilor's eye twitches. "*So,* you should be tried for—"

"Why did you go to the office?" The Minster asks—interrupting his council member in favor of hearing the rest of Catra's tale.

"Since Lonnie was an Unspeakable it was hard to narrow down the main reason someone would want to kill her. So, we decided to look into her last case and see if it could give us a clue. Most of

her files were still at her house—she was a worse workaholic than me—so we started there."

The Minister leans forward. "And did you find anything?"

Catra nods. "I found a document—an invoice—linking someone to Prime's Loyalist group. Someone in the *Auror* Division." A sea of gasps floods the room. The councilors squawk indignantly, voicing their opinions—

"The Auror Division?"

"This proves Miss Grayskull is responsible!"

"Some witness; she just implicated the person she was supposed to defend."

"Quiet down you lot!" The Minister shouts, putting a swift end to his councilor's gossip. "The Auror Division is quite large, need I remind you? This alone isn't enough to tie Miss Grayskull to *murder."* He turns to Catra and asks, "did you find out who the invoice was addressed to?"

Catra shakes her head. "Not at first."

"What do you mean?"

"The invoice didn't have an *exact* name attached to it, but Adora had her suspicions." Catra says, "we managed to slip out from Lonnie's house without causing a stir, and even though we found evidence of cracks in the Ministry it wasn't enough; we quickly realized New York was a bust—probably a dead-end from the start put in place to distract us—so we decided to get some help from someone we thought we could trust. It was Adora's idea—to get help from the Ministry.

"We arrived back in London—at one of my flats—sometime late last night; Bow convinced us to get some rest, go to the Ministry in the morning, but Adora was adamant on going right away."

The Minister knows where the rest of the story is going. “And Miss Grayskull went to the Ministry on her own that night.”

Catra nods. “She did.”

The Minister sighs. “If there is no witness to testify against Miss Grayskull’s crimes then I have no choice but to—“

“Did she alert anyone?”

Adora’s head snaps to Lex as he suddenly rises from his seat. His disruption causes the Minister’s eyebrows to raise. Lex draws everyone’s attention as he reiterates in a clear voice, “before Miss Grayskull left your flat. Did she tell anyone where she was going?”

“Yes.”

Adora feels a sudden spark of magic radiating in Mara’s direction. Adora grinds her teeth; she frantically teases the restraints keeping her magic dulled. Adora huffs, *really wish I had my wand right now...*

“She did?” Lex phrases it as a question, but Adora has a feeling he already knows the answer. Defenders are weird like that—asking questions to ensnare the audience. “But…” Lex frowns, face pinching up as if he’s truly confused.

Adora marvels at the show Lex is putting on. Adora thinks, *maybe he’s not as clueless as I thought.*

“—Miss Grayskull was alone at the Ministry during her visit, unless...are you implying the testimony given by the defense was a lie?”

Catra says, “it’s not a lie.”

Lex asks, “how are you so sure?”

“Adora told me.” Catra reveals, “before she left for the Ministry; she told me what she was planning to do.”

“Minister!” A councilor shouts—rising up. “This is outrageous! Miss D’riluth just implicated herself in Miss Grayskull’s crime; she should be charged as an accomplice! Nothing else she says can be trusted!”

Adora dulls out the rest of the proceeding; she can honestly go without the council butting their heads into things they know *very* little about. Thankfully, the Minister seems to have a solid head on his shoulders. While the rest of the councilors—in addition to the rowdy crowd—become overwhelmed with the direction the trial is going, the Minister goes with the punches and adapts accordingly.

Adora leans further into her seat. She stares at the magic draining shackles strapped to her wrist as she loses herself in a memory; Adora seeks shelter in a simpler time—a time where her reputation wasn’t stained—where her Country didn’t accuse her of treason—more specifically, Adora thinks back to last night.

The calm before the storm:

“You’re my girlfriend, right?”

“Obviously.”

Adora grins, “brilliant.”

Time slips away from them.

Adora stares at the ceiling as her mind races—unable to sleep. And when even the silence becomes too loud Adora whispers in the dark, “...it’s Mara.”

Catra’s ear flicks in her direction. She tilts her head to the side and mutters out a drowsy, “what?”

“Mara,” Adora confesses with her brows pinched in, “she’s the one I want to speak with.”

Catra shuffles around on the bed until her body is facing Adora. Catra stares at her—unblinking eyes glowing brighter than the

light of the moon that engulfs them in a light hue. Catra stifles a yawn and says, "yeah I figured, there aren't a lot of people we know who work directly for the Ministry. But it's fine, right? You trust her enough."

"Actually," Adora realizes, "I'm not so sure."

Catra sits up completely. Adora chooses to stay on her back; she's very much in favor of taking in the alluring image of Catra staring down at her with worry in her gaze—it's nice to know someone cares about her; it makes her stomach warm.

"Hey," Catra says softly, forcing Adora from her thoughts, "what do you mean?"

Adora shrugs—suddenly feeling sheepish. "...it's just kind of weird. While we were looking through Lonnie's files…Mara showed up…"

Catra frowns—eyebrows bunching up cutely. Catra asks, "isn't that normal for an Auror?"

"Not with her title." Adora explains, "Mara's the Director of Magical Security—she has bigger things to deal with—but, for some reason, she came all the way to Lonnie's house to look through a stack of papers. It doesn't add up."

Catra whispers, "are you okay?"

"Why wouldn't I—"

"She's your mentor," Catra interrupts—too drowsy to beat around the bush. "You took it pretty bad when you found out someone from your division was responsible…but this is Mara. She got you into the Auror program and taught you everything she knows."

Adora nods. "So it won't be hard to take her down."

Catra says, "we have to be sure."

"Well," Adora mutters, glancing off to the side, "I won't know until I ask."

Catra gently tugs Adora's chin up until their eyes are locked. Catra warns, "don't do anything stupid."

Adora laughs, playfully slapping her hand away. "Like I could sneak out without you noticing; you're the lightest sleeper I know and, plus, you have a magical creature as back up so...there's that."

"They don't approve by the way," Catra says after a moment of silence—Adora assumes she's communicating to Melog through their magical bond. Catra gestures to the magical creature who's lounging on the windowsill, "they think it's too dangerous for you to go on your own."

Adora suggests, "you can come with me."

Catra snorts. "And have Bow and Glimmer burn my flat down in rage? No thanks."

Adora sits up as a thought seeps inside her mind. Adora frowns, "and don't try talking me out of—"

"I have a plan."

Adora blinks. "Seriously? You're not even gonna try and fight me on this?"

"You'll do what you want to do. I can't stop you." Catra grins, "plus, I've been getting a little restless anyway."

Adora shakes her head, amused. "What did you have in mind?"

"You go to the Ministry and talk to Mara, don't let her know anything on our end, just scope out the situation and see if you notice anything off." Catra reaches back and grabs something from her drawer. When she has it, she holds it up for Adora to see.

Adora's eyes widen—she quickly deduces where Catra's going with this. She reaches out and carefully grabs the two-way mirror from Catra's grasp. It's funny how something so small has kept them connected during even their worst spats. There was a time Adora thought Catra had given up on their friendship—on them—and with it, the only thing connecting them. But she was pleasantly surprised when she took a leap of faith—using the two-way mirror to contact Catra when she was at her lowest—and she got a response.

Adora blinks away the tears, smiling. "The mirror."

Catra smiles back and promises, "I'll be with you the entire time."

The Minister snaps Adora out of her revere as he asks, "what did Miss Grayskull plan to do?"

Catra says, "she just wanted to talk to Mara." She continues, ignoring the scoffs of disbelief from the skeptical councilors, "Adora said she wanted to talk to Mara about Lonnie's case. We weren't sure who we could trust—"

"Minister, please, this is a waste of time." Another council member interrupts, "if Miss D'riluth wasn't at the Ministry the night of the event then she isn't much of a witness. Why should we—"

"I saw it." Catra announces.

The Minister frowns. "What did you see?"

"She's lying!" The same councilor shouts, "she just said Miss Grayskull went to the Ministry alone!"

Catra asks, "if I may?"

The Minister nods. "You have the floor."

Catra shares a look with Melog; the magical creature rises to their feet and moves to stand before the Minister and his council. Melog turns to the side—facing the adjacent wall. Adora leans forward—

watching in awe—as Melog's eyes begin to glow neon blue. The audience gasps as a projection-like ray of light shoots forth from Melog's eyes until an image is presented on the adjacent wall for all to see.

"Nox," Catra says, voiding the room of light so everyone can see the projection better. The image comes into focus and reveals the inside of Adora's coat pocket. While the image itself doesn't do much for Adora's case, the conversation in the background is a key factor.

Adora marvels at the audio—taking in the memory that was stolen from her.

"—it doesn't matter. I know what you are and soon, so will everyone else." Adora says, "a filthy death eater. How could you? So many people trusted you—"

Mara declares, "my loyalty is and forever will be, with Lord Prime. And if I have to work from the inside with useless Auror's like you, then I'll do what it takes."

"Everyone will see you for what you are."

"No, they won't. All they'll see is you—the golden girl—on the cover of every newspaper for breaking into my office and trying to kill me after I found out the truth about you and Octavia working in cahoots."

"What are you—"

"Do I need to say it slower for you to understand? I'm framing you." Mara says, "I'd send you to the Bermuda Triangle with the rest of my disappointments but…honestly; I took you off the case so you would let it go, not so you could run around America with the hybrid and the rest of the golden crew. The hybrid's a smart one, I'll give her that...for a mutt—"

Catra's magic signature spikes at the insult—sending a familiar chill down Adora's spine even though she knows it's not directed

at her. She shakes off the feeling and focuses on more pressing matters. Adora tilts her head and tries to catch a glimpse of Mara, but it's futile in the darkness. Instead, Adora works on summoning *any* ounce of magic she has. She doesn't want to be tied up when Mara realizes she lost.

"But you're too much of a problem to just hide away. If the golden girl goes missing then London will be hysterical, so I have to ensure they've lost your trust." Mara says, "and it won't take much convincing. Before you left for Holiday you were already starting to unravel—this will be an easy web to spin."

"Protego!"

"Confringo!"

The image distorts to static as Adora and Mara jump into battle. Melog's eyes grow dull—the image waning—but it doesn't matter. They've revealed everything they need.

"Lumos," Catra says, summoning light once more.

The room bursts under the pressure—a loud roar shakes the foundation of the room as the council and audience argue back and forth. The Minister shouts over them but this time it doesn't have the desired effect. The evidence Catra has presented causes too much of a stir; not even the threats slipping from the Minister's mouth can silence the masses.

"This is absurd!" Someone shouts, "we're supposed to believe this fabrication? What grounds does this have as—"

"If this isn't enough then Adora's memories have all the proof we need," Catra says; her voice calms the room momentarily as they listen—interested in what else she has to spew. "...but I have no doubt Mara obliviated Adora's memory of this conversation. But alas, I'm an expert at mind manipulation; it'll be easy for me to bring out the truth."

Adora tugs at her shackles—fingers tingling as her magic slowly builds between the palms of her hands.

Catra confesses, "I told Adora to take the two-way mirror in case she got into any trouble, it was in her pocket the whole time, and I knew—if Mara truly was responsible for Lonnie's murder—she would delve into Adora's mind for intel. Thankfully, I put a spell on Adora's mind—patented by yours truly—to protect case sensitive memories from getting into the wrong hands."

Adora's concentration slips—her magic jumping—as Mara suddenly stands from her seat. The room tenses. The Minister narrows his eyes and shouts, "Director, take your seat! Need I remind you, no one is allowed to leave."

Mara turns to him with a sneer—a *nasty* expression Adora's never seen on her face before. But then again, her memories from last night are gone, so maybe she has seen it before. Even the nauseous feeling—building at the bottom of her gut—seems familiar.

Mara frowns. "You're truly going to believe the lies of these children?"

"The evidence they've gathered is quite high, Director. And you attempting to barge out of my courtroom isn't helping your case."

Mara spits out, "*my* case? So I'm the one on trial now? What a joke. You've let these children shift your focus and dictate—"

"I said," the Minister grabs his wand—rising from his seat with enough force to shake the podium. His face grows solemn as he aims his wand at Mara, "sit down, Director."

"You can't hold me here." Mara says with a cruel smirk, "even if any of this is remotely relevant, unless you tie me directly to Grimely's murder I don't have to stay here."

Adora goes to move—not sure what she can do with the little magic she has gathered—but surprisingly Lex beats her to it.

Adora watches—startled—as Lex turns to Mara and reveals with eerie confidence, "I can."

Mara's gaze flicks away from the Minister. She eyes Lex up and down; mouth turning up as if he's nothing but a stain on her shoe. Mara asks, "and who the hell are you? Just some low rate defender who's in over his head."

"*I'm* the person who can identify your magical signature and confirm you used a killing curse on Lonnie Grimely."

Mara barks out a rough laugh . "You're absurd—just grasping at straws. Grimely is in the grave, are you truly suggesting we dig her back up just to run some tests on her? Only to prove you wrong?"

"She's not in the grave." Lex declares confidently. Adora watches in awe as Lex waves a hand over his face—disrupting the glamor spell and revealing—

"I'm right here."

The entire room startles at the revelation—at the *ghost.* A roaring noise erupts—filled with a mixture of outrage and confusion—shaking the foundation of the courtroom. But, out of everything, what stands out to Adora the most is Kyle and Rogelio's desperate shouts.

"Lonnie!" Kyle exclaims. Rogelio shouts something as well—probably a similar desperate plea—but Adora can't understand much of it. Adora nervously glances over her shoulder, watching as Kyle and Rogelio work through their shock. Adora turns her gaze back to Mara; she doesn't look like someone who's seen a ghost—no—she looks like someone who's lost and is utterly *pissed.*

The Minister mutters, "Merlin's beard…what is the meaning of this?"

Adora startles as Melog—having snuck over to her side during the ruckus—bumps their head into her leg urgently. The magical creature mutters something under its breath; they repeat the verbiage, nudging Adora with their forehead when she doesn't budge. *Are they trying to…* Adora discreetly holds out her hands to the creature. Melog hums in approval and makes quick work of removing the shackles.

"Sorry for the fuss, Minister, but we ran out of options. This was the only way." Lonnie says unapologetically. "If I can explain."

The Minister shakes his head—face still white from the reveal. He sputters out, "it's *your* case."

Lonnie smiles dimly—it lacks any emotion—it's mostly just something to do to keep her mouth busy. It slips as she dives into her story, "there's really not much to it. The night of my *murder,* I was running some errands when I noticed someone was following me. I enlisted help from Catra—for backup in case anything went down. I told her to meet me at my house; I headed there from the bar I stopped in, and they followed me home but thankfully Catra got there before them. Whoever they were—they were there with intent. Catra adjusted my daughter's memory before we hid her somewhere safe.

"Catra helped me fake my death so we could find out who was responsible. The person who cast the killing curse was under an Imperious curse themself so we knew the real killer wouldn't be easy to apprehend. We just needed *time.* Thankfully, people thought I was taken out from the equation so it wasn't hard to move around and gain intel; it was a bitch living warehouse to warehouse though."

Adora smirks at the quip despite the gnawing tension.

"Catra used a glamor spell on a Horde Prime clone," Lonnie dutifully ignores the disgusted comments and swiftly continues, "...before the *body* was buried we had our friend Entrapta Bolten —head of the inventors division—take a sample of the wound left

over by the killing curse; it's being protected in an unlisted lab. We had the magic signature, we just needed someone to link it to and we needed a confession before revealing this information...we had to be sure—"

"—stop her!" One of the councilor's shout, raising their wand as Mara rushes for the doors—unable to apparate with the powerful spell keeping everyone locked inside the courtroom.

With her hands free, Adora leaps into action. Her momentum is dampened as Catra appears at her side—she digs her claws into Adora's shoulder with enough force to get her point across. Catra mutters in disdain, "you don't even have a wand."

Adora grins at her from over her shoulder. "Since when has that stopped me."

Catra rolls her eyes; she digs into her coat pocket and pulls out a familiar wood piece. "Here."

Adora takes her wand—it sings to her, shocking her finger in a joyous greeting as they're reunited. Adora asks, "when did you—"

"I stole it from Mara's office. Why do you think I walked through the doors when Lonnie announced me as a witness? I was already nearby."

Adora has an *array* of questions itching on her tongue, but Mara takes priority. The disgraced Director throws up a protective shield —fending off the attacks coming from the Minister and his council —as she pushes towards the doors. Unfortunately, Kyle and Rogelio are there with their wands raised.

Kyle's hair—frazzled and mussed—flutters as he conjures a nasty spell. His gaze burns even Adora as he shouts, "bombarda!"

Mara holds out a free hand and shouts back, "protego!"

Adora watches in horror as Kyle's spell bounces off Mara's shield and is redirected back to them. Kyle's eyes widen—glowing under

the light of the spell—as he and Rogelio take a staggered step back.

Whoosh!

Lonnie—having run over during the ruckus—leaps out in front of Kyle and Rogelio. Her momentum causes them to fall to the floor as Mara's spell collides with the door, leaving a gaping hole in its wake. Mara waves her hand and conjures a barrier keeping Lonnie and her family from giving her any more trouble. But, before Mara can make her escape two figures step out of the smoke—

"Don't come any closer," Bow demands, eyes narrowed as he aims his wand at Mara. Adora grins; despite the chaos, she's glad to see her friends in the fray. It reminds her of old times.

Glimmer says, "it's over, Mara."

"Foolish children…it's just getting started." Mara says with a jagged smile—it nearly splits her face in half. But her expression doesn't leave Adora chilled—it's her eerie warning. Adora swirls her wand between her fingers. Mara raises her free hand—she snaps her fingers—and says, "here's a little something I learned from Allister."

The chairs within the courtroom distort—curving in on themselves—as dark magic radiates off the dying wood. Adora grinds her teeth as all the furniture in the room turns into its very own *dementor.*

Catra huffs, "more? Seriously, what's the adoption policy on these things?"

"She's getting away," Adora growls as Mara shoots a nasty bout of spells in Bow and Glimmer's direction that—on top of the dementor's posing on issue—throws them off their game. Once Mara's foot crosses the threshold of the hallway she disappears with a threatening *crack. Damn it, she's on the move.* Adora quickly decides Lonnie and the others can take care of the dementor's on their own; she side steps the soul-sucking

monsters with the help of Catra and Melog and soon they're at the doors.

Bow notices the look in Adora's eyes. He says, "we'll catch up with you two later."

Adora nods. "Take care of everybody."

"We always do," Bow grins.

"Wait!" Adora startles as Octavia joins them in the hallway. Adora doesn't recall seeing her during the trial but she was also focused on other pressing issues. "I'm going with you."

Catra frowns. "And why's that?"

"Because I'm Mara's right hand; I know her better than anyone." Octavia says, "you can try tracing her magic signature but by the time you do she'll be long gone. Let me help you."

Adora decides to give Octavia a chance. "Fine," she decides, not really having much of a choice.

Octavia holds out her hands. Adora and Catra cautiously grab a hold—Melog wraps their tail around Catra's leg in preparation. Right before they leave Catra asks, "where to?"

Octavia answers, "the first place Mara would stop at if she had to flee the Country."

Without another word, they vanish with a *crack.*

They land with a dull *thump* inside the teller hall of Gringotts Wizarding Bank. A pained groan causes Adora to whip around—wand raised in the direction of the noise—but she falls short as she takes in the scene. The goblins charged with protecting the bank and managing the day to day services are all scattered across the floor; there are spell marks staining the walls, telling a tragic story. Adora frowns, *Mara was definitely here.*

“She’s robbing the vaults? Is she mental?” Catra mutters after a moment, “...actually, I probably would’ve done the same thing.”

Octavia leads them deeper in the bowels of the bank but they don’t need her guidance anymore. All they have to do is follow the trail of fallen goblins and the streaks of blood staining the walls—depicting a gruesome canvas.

Adora nearly bumps into Catra’s back as the woman comes to a stop. There’s a protest on the tip of Adora’s tongue but it dies down as Melog’s fur turns jagged and red. She looks up, expecting to see Mara lurking around the corner, but the only person here is —

“Seriously?” Catra’s growl rivals Melog’s by a long shot; her magic leaks out, causing her hair to spike.

Adora looks over Catra’s shoulder and finds Octavia staring back with her wand aimed at them. “Octavia?” Adora whispers in utter defeat, “not you too…” they weren’t exactly *close* but Adora thought they had a mutual respect for one another. Unfortunately, she’s learning that even actions can be deceiving.

Catra shakes her head; she speaks out since Adora seems to have forgotten her voice. “I don’t get it.” Catra frowns, “you’re a *hybrid,* why would you support his cause?”

Octavia narrows her eyes at them. “Lord Prime can make me pure — *whole.* Mara promised if I worked hard enough I could—“

“You’re delusional.” Catra growls, “they’re using you and you’re too blind to see.”

Octavia blinks back a surge of emotion. She scoffs, “I wouldn’t expect filth like you to understand our mission.”

“Filth?” Catra huffs, twirling her wand as she prepares for battle. “I’ll make you eat those words right after I make you look in a fucking mirror.”

Adora glances at Catra and whispers under her breath, “are you sure?”

Catra smirks—not taking her eyes off Octavia—as she teases, “worried about me, love?”

“Yeah.” Adora snorts. “For *her.”*

Catra’s expression hardens as her decision is finalized. Catra confirms, “yes, I’m sure. I’ll take care of her and then I’ll catch up with you soon. I promise.”

Adora presses a lingering hand on Catra’s shoulder before she follows the trail Mara left behind. Octavia shoots a spell her way—a futile attempt to stop her—but Catra flicks a hand, summoning a protective shield that lets Octavia’s spell bounce off with ease; it lands somewhere deep within the cave causing rocks to tumble.

“I’m the one you should worry about,” she hears Catra threaten before an array of spells blocks out the rest of their dialogue. Adora grips her wand tightly as she travels deeper into the cave. A rustling up ahead causes her to slow—attempting to keep her footsteps light like Catra often chastised her about. She thinks it’s working when—

“You were never one for stealth.”

Adora stops, narrowing her eyes as Mara steps out from a vault that doesn’t belong to her—she can tell by the door that’s been forced off its hinges. Mara drops the sack of gold and pulls out her wand instead. Giving Adora all her attention.

“You were my teacher,” Adora quips, “so whose fault is that?”

Mara hums, as if she’d forgotten their history. Mara comes out of a memory with a fond yet bittersweet smile, “...you had so much potential.”

“Could say the same thing about you,” Adora huffs.

Mara frowns. “I guess we both let each other down then.”

“Guess so.”

Adora clears her mind—voiding herself of the fond memories she and Mara share; they’ll only hold her back in this fight and Adora’s going to have to give it her all if she’s going to be able to cut this bond. And so, Adora shakes out her shoulders as she prepares for the final battle—

Mentor versus student.

Chapter End Notes

I like the title of this chapter because “Now You See Me” can refer to Lonnie revealing herself to the world and also everyone realizing Mara’s true intentions.

I know you guys wanted to see Catra versus Mara but I think it’s better if Adora takes her down. Mara was her mentor and Adora has been chasing this case for such a long time; it makes sense that she’s the one who gets to end it. But don’t worry, Catra’s role isn’t done yet and she’ll have a ton more badass scenes in the future.

This chapter ties in great with Interlude II. The reason I included it before the trial was to show how strong Adora and Catra’s relationship has become; it went from a fickle thing—barely held together by a string—to Adora putting her full trust in Catra; having faith that her girlfriend would show up during the trial to save her from being sentenced to Azkaban.

Also, I read the comments and a few of you predicted the two-way mirror playing a key role in the trial and I was like “Damn, I wanted it to be a surprise” but sometimes predictable is good. I considered removing its involvement to try for something more surprising but I had it planned for a long time and it would've felt weird not including it. If you read back to Chapter 8 (technically Chapter 7, excluding the Interludes) The Lonewolf, the way I describe Adora getting

comfortable in her chair is her secretly pulling out the mirror while Mara's back is turned. Kudos to those who figured it out; you got me. Hopefully Lex's reveal was a good shock though.

Not sure when the next chapter will be out; I have to handle some adult stuff but I eventually plan on finishing this story. I have the ending outlined and everything, just need some time.

Thanks for reading, all.

A New Era

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

11

"It doesn't have to be like this."

Adora rights her footing, cocking her wrist ever so slightly, as she replies, "it's too late—"

Mara barks out a laugh. "It's too *late?* This coming from the *golden girl* herself? I wish those bloody reporters were here to see exactly how hypocritical your doctrine is."

"I think we're *far* past the point of letting you explain yourself." Adora grits out; she tightens her hold on her wand—a steady reminder to not let Mara get into her head. She always did a good job of doing that; a way of making Adora come to decisions—wholly manipulated by Mara—with the foolish notion Adora had come to them on her own accord. "You lied to us for *years;* this entire time you've just been Prime's lackey—a bloody *death eater* — we trusted you! And I…" Adora shakes her head, in disbelief, "...I became an Auror because of you—"

"And what a disappointment you turned out to be."

Adora flinches despite herself. She wishes she could brush off Mara's disdain—coming out unscared—but deep down Adora knows, regretfully so, Mara's opinion of her still holds some weight.

Adora shoots back, rather childlike, "you're the disappointment."

"It's such a shame," Mara sucks her teeth, "you had so much potential for greatness. All you had to do was play your cards right, then you could have a seat at the table beside me—mentor

and student—we could have been formidable knights of darkness —upholding Lord Prime's wishes!"

"You're mental," Adora spits viciously but her words fall upon deaf ears.

Mara's rant continues, "do you know how *blessed* you are to be connected to Lord Prime?"

Adora frowns. "I was nothing but a horcrux—"

"—a *vessel,"* Mara corrects. "What an honor to have bestowed upon you, but you squandered it—betrayed our Lord." Mara's face contorts, "and even after severing your tie with him, you somehow made it worse for yourself; becoming an Auror only to dismantle his army, letting a *hybrid* defile you—to lie with such *filth—"*

Adora whispers a nasty hex fueled simply by emotion, skin boiling, but Mara simply sidesteps the attack.

"—and it could have been forgiven." Mara says, "it's not too late for you to join the side of the righteous."

Adora's eyes narrow in. "I'd rather die in the coldest corner of Azkaban—have my very *soul* sucked from my body—than to join sides with anyone who supports that monster. And you want to talk about hypocrisy? Prime is a *half-blood,* hardly anything close to pure if we were to go by your logic."

"You ungrateful brat," Mara growls, having struck a nerve.

"Ungrateful?" Adora splutters, "you tried to frame me for *murder,* you nutcase. Don't act like you were trying to do anything in my best interest. For *years* you've manipulated me, but it ends now. You're done pulling the strings."

A dark shadow casts over Mara's face. "Then I'll just have to *cut* them—"

“Bombarda!” Adora shouts.

Mara’s quick on the draw, she utters a simple “protego” summoning an invisible shield to defend against Adora’s exploding spell.

Adora grits her teeth, lashing out with a vicious “confringo!”

“Protego,” Mara says with the flick of a wrist before shooting back with an unforgivable curse, “crucio!”

Adora leaps to the right—knowing a simple shield is no match for an unforgivable curse released by a witch of Mara’s standing. The curse narrowly misses Adora’s head, dissolving into a nearby boulder causing it to shrivel into smithereens. Adora falls to the ground, rolling with the motion, until she slides to a stop behind a jagged boulder—covering her from view; she presses her back against the stone, clutching her wand to her chest, allowing herself a bit of reprieve. Mara’s shrewd cackle echoes in the cavern.

“Did you *honestly* think it would be so simple?” Mara’s voice sounds closer than before.

Adora looks up—eyeing the stalactites as a plan forms.

“I taught. You. *Everything.”* Mara spits out, word for word, until her voice tampers off into a shrill screech. Mara sounds a bit more composed as she asks, “or have you forgotten? You can’t get the jump on me—”

Adora shoots out her arm, aiming her spell to the ceiling with a shout, “bombarda!” The spell collides with the ceiling—exploding on impact. Adora curses under her breath, holding onto the bolder as the cave begins to shake around them—caving in on itself.

Mara hisses, “you fool!”

Adora summons a protective barrier atop her head as the stalactites shoot down at a fast velocity. While the world falls

down around them, Adora rises to her feet—protected by her shield—she finds Mara in the chaos; her former mentor has taken a page out of Adora's book and is also protecting herself with a convenient shield. Mara meets her gaze—unflinching as the cave collapses.

"Rule number three," Mara repeats, "if you can't catch your opponent off guard, then use your surroundings to your advantage…funny, I taught you this as well."

Adora frowns. "You didn't teach me this—fumos!"

Smoke escapes Adora's wand—engulfing the cave in a foggy screen. Adora leaps back, shielding herself behind a nearby boulder; she switches her wand out and uses her free hand to keep her shield alive until the rockslide subsides. *I may not be able to beat her one on one, but if I can find an opening…* Adora sighs, *no, that'll take too long…I have to come up with something fast.* Mara isn't one to let her opponents lay idle.

At moments like this, Adora envies Catra's strategic genius. Sure, Adora's rush-in method gets the job done most of the time—and her sheer strength is enough to subdue her opponents—but Mara isn't an *ordinary* opponent. She knows all Adora's ticks and tricks. Unfortunately, Adora doesn't have a plan that will keep her two steps ahead of Mara; but, it will get the job done.

Adora grins as an idea sparks to life; if Angella were to see her expression, Adora's sure a headache would be sure to form.

Adora hasn't performed this spell since her third year at Hogwarts.

"—stupefy!"

"Ack!" Octavia chokes out; the last attack in Catra's array collides with Octavia's chest—sending her flying back until she smashes into the wall of the cave. A gruesome crater forms in the shape of Octavia's body—trapping her in the wall.

Catra limps over to the crater, winces when her leg moves the wrong way; it got scarred during the battle—clipped—when Catra foolishly allowed her ego to get the best of her. She should've taken Octavia seriously instead of thinking she could defeat her with a simple flick of her wand. Because of her mistake, her leg paid the price.

"I'm fine," she mutters, trying to calm Melog's jagged fur. "She's the one you should be worried about." Melog's fur bristles even more; despite it all, they're a sweetheart at their core. To appease her uneasy companion, Catra cautiously presses a finger to Octavia's neck to check for a pulse.

Catra turns to Melog with a huff, "see? She's alive, you big baby."

Melog mutters some unkind words Catra very much would not like to repeat at the moment. Instead, she confiscates Octavia's wand for safe keeping. Catra places a binding spell on Octavia in case she manages to gain consciousness.

With the coast clear, Catra kneels on the ground and presses a hand to her leg—magic seeps from her palm as she begins the healing process. Melog laps at their own wounds in the meantime. Once she's finished Catra stands up and tests her mobility.

"Good enough for now," she mutters before glancing in the direction she recalls Adora going in right before they split up. Catra decides, "we should check on Adora...I don't like the crazed look Mara had at the trial."

Melog nods in agreement; they make quick work on tracking Adora's magical signature so Catra can save her energy for other matters. Melog chirps with discovery of a trail they can follow. Catra's ready to go—desperate to help Adora (though Catra doubts her girlfriend needs assistance)—but something holds her back; locking her in time. Not even Melog's persistent nudging can break the thrall. And if Catra was in her right mind, she might panic about the dampening of her connection with Melog—how their bond seems to fade in the presence of the new thrall.

…the tides align.

Catra's ear flicks; she tilts her head to the side, frowning as an unfamiliar voice calls out to her.

"Do you hear that?" Catra asks, glancing at Melog briefly. The magical beast shakes their head and gives her a strange, disbelieving, look. Melog mutters something and for the first time —Catra doesn't *understand* them.

Catra staggers back—finding no comfort in Melog's presence for the first time.

…don't be afraid, your connection shall return. I just needed to borrow it—

Catra whips around, expecting to find the source of the voice but she comes up empty. Catra bares her fangs and demands, "what the hell is going on? Show yourself, or are you that much of a coward?"

I'm not the one who's hiding…

Catra flinches, "what does that even mean?"

You walk around this earth not knowing.

"Not knowing what?" Catra frowns, taking a step closer; she ignores Melog, waving them away as they nip at her pants leg desperately.

When the tides align, only then will the moon reveal itself… revealing the truth…

"The moon?" Catra whispers the warning—trying to make sense of it. "What truth? Who are you?"

Follow my voice. I'll tell you all I know to be true.

Against her better judgment, Catra complies.

“You’re right about one thing—”

Adora lowers her shield as the rocks finally stop falling; she presses her back to the stone covering her and tries to glare through the mist she’s created. Mara’s voice sounds far away but there are spells to manipulate that—a way to fool Adora into a false sense of security—but she won’t fall for it. *Stick to the plan...*

Mara taunts, “I didn’t teach you to hide like a *coward.”*

Adora readies her wand; she flicks her wrist to dampen the fog just enough for her to catch a glimpse of Mara’s shadow.

“But if I can be honest,” Mara whips around, “you could use some work on your stealth—“

“—glacius,” Adora whispers, aiming a jet of ice to the ground beneath Mara’s feet.

Mara staggers for a brief second—but, it’s enough. While Mara is distracted, Adora leaps out with a spell on her tongue; it unfortunately never slips past her teeth as Mara quickly rights herself on the ice and uses her wand to subdue Adora midair with a binding spell.

Mara shakes her head, fixing her wild hair as she demands, “did you really think I’d fall for a child’s spell you used on those idiot Junior Auror’s?”

Adora grins despite her situation. “Nope.”

Mara frowns, uneased by Adora’s demeanor. “What are you—“ she trails off with a startled shout as Adora grits her teeth—face contorting—as she pulls her arm back with sheer *willpower* before using all her energy to pull her fist forward until she’s decking Mara in the face with a solid jab.

Mara’s head shoots to the side under the force but she snaps back just as quickly with a livid scowl. “You little—” Adora disappears in

a cloud of smoke.

Mara realizes with a start, "a *clone?"*

"—confringo!"

The spell hits Mara in her right flank—sending her to the ground. Mara chokes out a spine tingling scream; she clutches her injured side, hissing when pressing on it only makes the pain double. But it must be done. Mara ignores the blood gathered on her palm and presses on the wound to keep the bleeding at bay. She lifts herself up with a single arm and glares as the *real* Adora makes her appearance out from the fog.

Adora picks up her wand and doesn't waste any time aiming it at Mara. Adora smirks—enjoying the disbelief on Mara's face. She taunts, "what was that about not falling for children's spells?"

Despite it all, Adora can't fault Mara for falling for a doubling charm. When Adora first used it during her third year, she fooled even Angella—easily getting out of detention to help Bow and Glimmer with an adventure they needed help with. Unfortunately, the charm took a lot of Adora's energy to perform and the clone burst into smoke causing quite the scare. Adora still recalls Angella's murderous look when she tracked the trio down.

Nice to know it's still effective even if only for a moment.

"I gave the clone my wand so you wouldn't be suspicious," Adora supplies, feeling the need to explain the methods to her madness. "Give it up. It won't be long until all of London discovers who you are. You've lost."

"Shut up!" Mara exclaims, shooting her free hand back to the ground. Adora frowns, readying her wand as she senses Mara's magic in the air—it's caked with a strange substance— *dirt.* Adora realizes too late. Mara's magic seeps through the ground until it circles Adora—shooting up in the form of vines—encasing Adora in a vicious binding spell. Adora gasps as she's lifted into the air; the

vines wrap around her wrist so tight she drops her wand under the pressure; her back arching under a devastating squeeze.

"It's *far* from over…" Mara hisses—her body curls in on itself as she heals her side, just enough for her to stand to her feet although with a stagger. Mara raises her hand and *clenches* her fist. Adora cries out—the vines take their cue from Mara's hand; they wrap tighter, and tighter, until Adora feels her skin cave under the pressure. Mara says with glee, "I'm going to kill you—tear your body apart—and then, I'll go after everyone you love. Those idiot friends of yours, the family you made at the orphanage, and the *hybrid…"* Mara cackles, "I'll put *extra* time aside for her. And once the golden quartet is dismantled—when the Country loses all hope—the Dark Lord will rise again."

Adora's body contorts under the vines—her body snaps together as Mara clenches her fist even tighter. Fire seeps through her body—Adora thinks she might just pass out.

A strange scent reaches her nose. *Smoke,* Adora thinks with a frown. She cracks open a weary eye; smoke is in fact seeping through the air, but it's not coming from the vines…it's coming off *her.* It's as if her body is at molten levels—the vines weep, crying out as they fall from Adora's body and fall back to the ground limp.

Adora feels a familiar heat seeping behind her eyes. She hasn't felt like this since—

"Impossible," Mara's startled cry brings Adora back. Mara shakes her head and whispers frantically, "I don't understand…"

Adora looks down—she's *floating.* Even more surprising, her body is cloaked in a blue hue. Adora clenches her fist, marveling at the pure *magic* racing through her veins. *I see,* Adora deduces before getting back to the issue at hand. Her eyes—now electric blue—narrow in on Mara.

Mara lashes out with an array of spells, "bombarda! Crucio! Stupefy!" Her eyes dull, defeat soaking in as Adora's body acts like a battery of some sort—absorbing every spell. Mara falls to knees, clutching the poorly healed wound at her side.

"You severed your connection to Lord Prime, so why…" Mara shakes her head, "this can't be…"

Adora says, "it's over, Mara. Turn yourself over and—"

"You don't get it." Mara growls, "even if I *wanted* to, I can't show my face to the coven after something like this. My Lord…he would—"

"He's *dead,"* Adora argues, "he has no hold on you."

"Your body is *leaking* with the magic left over from your days as his horcrux," Mara spits, "you're a *fool* to think he's dead. As long as his magic is on this earth…he will continue to exist—through *you* and all his other little tools."

Adora shakes her head. "I don't believe that."

Despite what Mara may say, Adora refuses to have *his* name—his *legacy*— live on. No…Adora will make this power her *own.*

"He lives on…this will never end."

Adora senses the spell before Mara has a chance to utter it. "Don't do this—"

"—Avada Kedavra!"

Adora raises her hand to absorb the spell like before but the magic encasing her acts as a shield. Adora can only watch as the spell bounces off her hand—

"Wait!" Adora exclaims, reaching out to grab a spell that's already in full motion.

Mara's eyes go wide—shock lacing her face—as the spell hits her in the chest. And as Mara is flung into the air—colliding to the floor with a cold *thump*— a dark part of Adora finds the moment poetic, devastatingly so, how they've come full circle.

Mara was taken out by the very same curse she got Finn with.

With Finn's death fresh in her mind, the blue aurora disappears. Adora allows herself only a second to melt down but she quickly becomes lucid. Adora traces the magic in the air—traces the magic signature that was once encasing her during the battle. Just as she assumed, the magic guides her to a pile of rocks. Adora gets to her knees and digs through the pile until she digs out a golden cup—it must have fallen from Mara's bag before their fight. But this cup holds more value and devastation than anyone could ever imagine.

Adora raises the cup until it's eye level with her, she greets her old foe, *"Prime."*

Silence leaks into the cavern but Adora waits. Years as an Auror has given her patience when it comes to this.

"...golden girl."

Adora frowns, using her free hand to dig into her coat pocket. Adora shakes her head, "you've got to learn some new tricks…did you really think I'd be stupid enough to let you create *another* horcrux? Like I haven't seen this a dozen times before. And I was just a kid back then. I'm not falling for it again. You're done."

"As long as you rely on my power to kill—"

"She did it to herself," Adora defends herself, though…she isn't sure if it's true.

"—there will always be a chance for me to revive."

Adora obtains what she was seeking and pulls it from her coat. Adora nods, "and I'll always be prepared." She places the horcrux

on the ground and raises the jagged piece of the basilisk fang.

"Foolish child. Even if you win today, I will always be connected to you. So, even in your death, I will jump at the opportunity to find another vessel."

Adora shrugs. "I guess we'll deal with that when we get there."

Clang! Adora doesn't wait for another lengthy spiel from Prime; she bashes the cup with the basilisk fang. Adora doubles over, hissing as a part of her dies along with him.

"Damn it," she mutters, digging her fingers into the dirt to steady herself. *Prime's right, as long as he's connected to me he can always find a way to resurface.* Adora shakes her head. She's not alone in this fight. They'll deal with it when they get there.

Adora staggers to her feet. She glances at Mara—a shell of her former self. But, then again, maybe Adora never really knew the original either. Her mentor lived a lifelong façade. Adora walks over to the limp body; she gazes down at the woman who had such a drastic fall from grace.

Adora's brow bunches up. "I hope it was worth it."

With nothing else to say, Adora marks the spot for the team of Auror's who will surely be on the scene; then, she follows Catra's comforting magical signature.

Octavia is caked into the wall of the cave when Adora makes it back toward the entrance. Adora feels only a *faint* trace of Catra's stupefy spell—probably the spell that finally did Octavia in—so she quickly cues in on the battle being over a while ago.

Adora frowns. "Where is she?"

Instead of asking silly questions, Adora continues to track Catra's magic signature; it guides her along the right path, as if she's an old friend. Catra's magic keeps her comforted—helps block away

the memory of Mara's dulling eyes, and the eerie voice of Prime she thought she'd forgotten only to have it cemented in her mind. *Maybe Entrapta can find a way to remove Prime's trace from me,* Adora knows if anyone can figure out a foolproof way to isolate a magical being it'll be Entrapta.

Adora's train of thought slows to a halt as Melog races towards her just as she turns a sharp corner. Adora smiles, happy to see a familiar face, "hey buddy." Her smile wanes at the sight of Melog's droopy fur—their coat glowing dark blue. Adora rubs their head, trying her best to console them in their mourning. She tries not to think about what Melog could be mourning.

"Where is she?" Adora's voice wobbles despite her best effort.

Melog bumps their head into her knee before they guide her further into the cave. Adora steadies herself for whatever she might encounter around the corner. Her knees nearly give in, buckling under the pressure, but not for the reason she suspected. Adora readies her wand and takes a cautious step.

"...Catra?"

The object of her affection stands at the edge of the cave with her hand outstretched toward the Gringott's dragon—the guardian of vaults. Catra's ear flicks in her direction. Adora chews on her lip, her gaze flicks from the dragon to Catra in rapid succession; not quite sure who she should be keeping an eye on.

"...Adora?" Catra mutters, blinking away the fog from her eyes.

Adora licks her lips and whispers, "back away from the dragon, *slowly."*

The dragon huffs out a ragged breath—a hot stream of air causes Adora's coat to flutter. Adora doesn't want to draw her wand; dragons are—at their core—gentle creatures. *They also breathe fire that'll rival even Catra's fiendfyre.* Yep, Adora definitely doesn't want to get into a fight with a dragon.

Catra snaps out of her daze; she eyes the dragon one more time before backing away slowly. Adora doesn't make a move until Catra is within reaching distance; she pulls Catra by the elbow and rushes back the way she came. Along the way Melog's fur simmers back to their normal hue. Adora guides them to the exit, very aware of the internal conversation Catra is likely having with Melog.

Good, she huffs, *I hope Melog is ripping her a new one for approaching a fucking dragon.*

Adora waits until they're out of the cave system and above ground before she lashes out, "what the hell?"

Catra blinks. "What?"

Adora's eye twitches. "A bloody *dragon?* And you say I'm mental."

Catra rubs her neck, glancing off with a faraway look Adora hasn't seen her express since the Triwizard Tournament. Catra mutters, "it's a long story…how's Mara?"

Adora swallows at the memory. "She's gone."

Catra's shoulders sag. "Adora—"

"I tried to stop her," she reiterates, "but…everything just happened so fast." She sinks into Catra's embrace—taking in the familiar scent of pine and mint. Adora clutches at Catra's jacket and confesses into the crook of her neck, "that's not all *...he* came back."

Catra stiffens in the hug but doesn't pull away. After a moment, Catra lowers her voice and asks, "you took care of it?"

Adora nods. "I had the fang in my pocket. Ever since…I've been carrying it with me for a while." Ever since their first run in with Prime—back at Hogwarts—even though Adora *killed* him, she always had a feeling another shoe would drop.

Sadly, she was right.

Catra says with a sigh, "the connection is still there."

Adora nods ruefully. "Yeah."

Catra pulls away, brushing tears from Adora's face. Catra nudges their foreheads together, "we'll talk about this, okay? Just...not here." Catra's eyes flick to the side—gesturing to the fallen goblins who are slowly starting to gain consciousness.

Adora takes a deep breath. "Okay…you're right."

"I tend to be," Catra breaks the tension with a grin.

Adora nudges her away with an eyeroll. "Come on, let's cue the Ministry in on our location so they can make sense of all this."

12

"—how sorry we are for putting you through all of this…"

Adora loses track of the Minister's apology—zoning out. It's not her fault she can't focus on his spiel. Five days have passed since the Mara and Octavia incident and the Ministry of Magic has been up to its elbows in press coverages.

Netossa even stormed the doors of the Ministry threatening to take them for all their worth for sullying the golden quartet's good name. *Several* public apologies have been issued since then; all of which they had to attend. And sure, it was nice getting praise from their Country—and having parties thrown in their honor (mostly because of the free food)—but it's getting excessive now.

They haven't been this popular since the war.

Adora glances toward the door nervously. Her grip tightens on the armchair as she contemplates how stressful this is for Catra especially. The fame was what inevitably drove Catra out of London—further from her friends—from *Adora.* And sure, she has

complete confidence in their relationship but…a small part of her worries one night Catra might run off again.

"—listening?"

Adora snaps back to the present. She offers the Minister a charming smile, although, he doesn't seem fooled by it. "Minister, please…my friends and I are very grateful for all the positive press we've received since the *incident,* but at this point all we can do is try and get back to our ordinary lives."

The Minister clears his throat, "about that…"

Adora freezes. "What's wrong?"

The Minister laughs, waving off her concern with a smile. "You and your friends are always expecting the worse…which is understandable after all we've put you through and I won't stop until I make sure you are all—"

"Minister," Adora says as politely as she can, "please spare me the accolades and tell me what's wrong."

He nods. "There isn't anything wrong…well, there is a *lot* wrong with the Ministry of Magic; I see that now. There is corruption, and although Mara is gone I can't help but wonder if there are more espionage agents like her within our organization. I need people I can trust working with the Ministry; we have to restow its name."

"What are you saying?" Adora asks.

"I'm asking if you would step in as the Director of Magical Security."

Adora's breath leaves her body, "what?"

The Minister smiles. "Don't seem so surprised."

Adora shakes her head. "But I'm—"

"—qualified for the position."

"—*twenty six!"* Adora exclaims, "I planned on being the Director of Magical Security when I turned thirty—thirty-two the *latest.* This seems like a huge leap."

The Minister reassures her, "we're not going to throw you into the water, Miss Grayskull. Previous Directors who upheld the position will be training you for months to come until you're ready to take up the mantle." He frowns, put off by her silence. "I don't understand, isn't this what you've always wanted? I heard you wrote about it in your application essay to the Auror academy."

Adora sinks into the chair. She looks away and mutters, "I just feel like…it's a handout."

The Minister's chair scrapes along the floor drawing her attention back to him. He eyes her through his spectacles, "Miss Grayskull, I'll have you know I do not make this decision lightly. I selected you for the position because you care about this Country and have been doing *everything* in your power to protect it since your days at Hogwarts. I'm picking you because I know you'll do what's right —every time."

"So?" The Minister holds out his hand, "what do you say?"

Adora hesitates. This is *everything* she's ever dreamed about, but…things are different now.

"I'm sorry," her voice echoes. Adora can hardly watch as the Minister lowers his hand with a depleted look. Adora confesses, "I've always had my entire life planned out, you know? I'd find a way out of Weaver's house, be the bravest witch in Gryffindor, graduate at the top of my class at the Auror academy…every detail was in line but, life isn't like that." Adora smiles softly as she decides, "I think—I *want*— to live in the moment more. Enjoy life for a bit before I accept a desk job.

"There are still cases out there that need loyal Auror's on the front line. Sure, the Director of Magical Security oversees them but they

can’t be in the field and—for now—I think it’s where I need to be.” Adora sighs, “I’m sorry if that’s not the answer you were hoping for.”

“No,” the Minister sinks into his seat with a smile, “it’s far better.”

Adora looks up.

“The position will be waiting for you when you’re ready.”

Adora smiles. “Thank you.”

“No, thank you.”

Adora shakes his hand and shares a few more quick words before she exits the office with a sigh. Adora leans against the wall to steady herself before she continues her journey through the halls of the Ministry. Her eyes flick about until she settles on a very welcome view of Catra lounging on a bench with her legs crossed—her head is propped up by her hand as she stares at the passerbyers with a bored expression. Even Melog—choosing to take their tom cat form—yawns at her feet.

And for a foolish moment, Adora’s shoulders relax because Catra’s *here.* And maybe this time, she’ll stay.

Catra’s eyes spark to life when they notice her arrival; she gets up from the bench and meets Adora halfway with a kiss.

Adora holds Catra’s hand, guiding them down the hall. She asks, “how was the meeting?”

Catra yawns out a muffled, “good…what about yours?”

Adora pokes Catra’s stomach. “You first.”

Catra rolls her eyes but eventually she yields. Catra whispers, “the Unspeakable Division is sort of a shit show right now; apparently people have been breaking their vows without facing any repercussions.”

Adora’s eyes go wide. “Seriously? How is that possible?”

“Hell if I know,” she shrugs, “so they need people they can trust to work the more important cases, and I’m first in line since I helped with Lonnie’s case.”

Adora interrupts, “how’s she doing? I haven’t heard from her since Kyle and Ro sent me an owl apologizing for thinking the worst.” The two men promised to meet up for lunch to talk in person but for now they wanted to get their family back to normal. Which is understandable.

“She wasn’t at the meeting, one of the upper heads said she’s taking time to be with her family.”

Adora nods in agreement before a thought occurs to her.

Adora says, “oh, and by the way...”

Catra glances over, curious. What greets her on the other end is an unpleasant—and unfortunately familiar—pinch to her right side.

“Hey!” Catra snaps, rubbing her sore arm—glaring at Adora out of the corner of her eye. Girlfriend or not, Catra finds herself struggling to keep the hex from slipping past her lips. She takes the high road instead and asks, “what the hell was that for?”

Adora frowns. “For not telling me Lex was actually Lonnie.”

Catra seems like she’s trying very hard not to roll her eyes. She sends Adora a muted expression, “you’re a shit actor, Adora.”

Adora’s frown morphs into a pout. “I’ve gotten better.”

“Sorry, love. Couldn’t risk it.”

Adora supposes she understands the urgency of the mission so she waves her hand, gesturing for Catra to continue.

Catra eyes her warily before she goes on, "so anyway…they want me to take over the Unspeakable case in—"

"There you two are." Glimmer interrupts, turning the corner with Bow at her side. "What's taking so long?" Glimmer shakes her head, "I actually don't care…can we leave? This place has always creeped me out."

"We can't go yet," Catra says with a huff. Before Glimmer can get into a rant Catra explains, "the Minister is holding another press conference explaining the outcome of the trial and he'll most likely ask us to attend."

Bow rubs his neck as he admits, "I don't know about you guys but —"

"—we're sick of public apologies," Catra says what they're all thinking.

Bow deflates. "Thank Merlin, I've been holding that in for days. But then again, I guess it's the *least* they could do after all the hell they put Adora through—parading you through the city like that. What were they thinking?"

"It's not just me," Adora says, "*all* of our reputations were stained because of this trial. Not everyone is going to believe the truth—"

"Fuck them." Glimmer says flippantly—gaining an indignant gasp from Bow and a chuckle from Catra; Adora only blinks owlishly.

Glimmer says, "seriously...if they don't want to believe us—after *everything* we've done for this Country—then maybe we should take some time for ourselves."

"There it is," Catra mutters. "You just want your—"

"—yes, I want a Holiday." Glimmer doesn't try to hide it. "But you two are probably too busy, right?" Glimmer sighs, taking in the sheepish expression Catra and Adora offer. "Thought so."

Bow asks softly, “is that what your meetings were about?”

Adora tightens her grip on Catra’s hand before she admits, “the Minister wants me to take over Mara’s old position as the—”

“Director of Magical Security?” Catra exclaims.

Glimmer gasps. “That’s *huge!”*

“Congratulations,” Bow smiles. “You’ll be great at it.”

Adora rubs her neck nervously as she flushes under the attention. “Thanks.”

Glimmer gestures to Catra saying, “spit it out. I know that anxious expression.”

“Well…not to steal anyone’s thunder or anything but, after the trial I’ve gotten tons of offers from all over the world.” Catra says sheepishly, “I'm kind of the hottest Unspeakable in the world right now.”

Bow smiles but it doesn’t meet his eyes. “That’s great, both of you really deserve it.”

Catra looks at his less thrilled counterpart. “Sparks, what’s up?”

Glimmer crosses her arms. “I’m really happy for you two, I am… but I guess…this is it, huh?”

Catra raises an eyebrow. “Pardon?”

“You’re getting all kinds of Unspeakable case offers and Adora is gonna be the Director of Magical Security...you’re going to be super busy now that your careers are taking off—more so than before.” Glimmer shrugs, “guess we won’t be seeing you two for a while.”

Catra and Adora glance at each other wearily. After a short beat they burst out laughing.

Bow looks startled. “What’s so funny?”

“Lonnie’s case was a nightmare on its *own.”* Adora says.

Catra nods. “The worst I’ve ever seen.”

“So?” Glimmer frowns, still out of the loop.

“So,” Adora says, squeezing Catra’s hand with a smile, “I told the Minister I appreciate the offer but...I’m going to finish my Holiday and enjoy some time away from work.”

Catra adds, “as for me, I’ll be taking a brief sabbatical. And from now on, I’m just gonna stick with Unspeakable cases inside of London instead of traveling all over the world. Don’t you think it’s time I settled down a bit, yeah?”

Glimmer gapes, “does this mean—“

Adora nods. “Best Friend Squad Holiday—”

“—revamp,” Glimmer adds not so subtly.

“Is back on!” Bow exclaims.

Glimmer asks in a rush, “but wait, not that I’m not super happy for the both of you for getting your shit together—“

“Rude.”

“—but Adora, all we’ve learned from Lonnie’s case is that the Ministry is corrupt. If you don’t take the position then who’s to say the same issue won’t happen again?”

Adora smiles. “I said I’m resuming my *Holiday,* not turning them down. They said they’ll wait as long as they need to.”

Glimmer squeals. “Oh! Where should we go this time?”

“Definitely *not* America,” Bow says with a shiver. “...at least, not for a while. Too many memories.”

Catra nods stiffly. “Agreed.”

“What about Europe?” Bow exclaims with glee, “there are *tons* of magical creatures we can hang out with! I mostly have connections in Romania, but we can spend time with the dragons!”

Adora gasped. “Can we ride them?”

“They’re not *pets,* love.” Catra says in a soft chastisement. Melog makes a noise in agreement. “...but I’m sure if you ask nicely they might be willing.”

Adora almost makes a comment about the Gringott’s dragon Catra had a run in with but keeps it to herself. Catra hasn’t spoken about the encounter much but Adora can tell it’s bothering her. Since the trial they’ve been staying at Catra’s unlisted flat and, more often than not, Catra has woken Adora in the middle of the night with nightmares. She’s doing her best to give Catra space to eventually discuss them with her but…one step at a time she supposes.

Glimmer’s voice brings Adora from her thoughts. “Can we go to Italy like we originally planned? Take a break from all the excitement before easing back into it with *dragons.”*

“Of course,” Catra agrees with ease, “my flat has lots of space.”

Bow cheers, throwing his hands in the air. His crop top shoots up even higher, catching Glimmer’s lingering gaze. “Romania, here we come! Well, Italy first but you get where I’m going with this.”

Catra notices the glint in Bow’s eyes; she takes a step back but somehow she gets trapped in a group hug that sends them toppling to the floor—a mess of mixed limbs. They collect themselves quickly—laughing at their misfortune. Catra pulls herself up, content with kneeling on the floor as she watches Adora playfully chastise Bow and Glimmer for their shenanigans. A smile slips across Catra’s face but the moment is short lived.

Melog joins Catra at her side; they nudge her arm —*reminds* her of the situation. Catra locks eyes with Melog, *I know.*

Catra *refuses* to let this opportunity slip through her fingers.

Chapter End Notes

> It's been a while since my last post, I took a few weeks off to recharge from work/studying; I probably won't update weekly like before but I will pop in to update this now and again. I have a solid outline for this story so I promise it will get done and it will be amazing. The next chapter I have planned is on the shorter side so it might be up sooner than expected.
>
> Thanks for reading, as always.

Requiem

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

0 - 4

Rosalie Hale takes her time descending the spiral staircase; what awaits her is a vast sea of grieving relatives who have flown in from all around the world—some she hasn't seen in years. It's dreadful, the circumstances under which they must meet. Aunt Carol—who is in attendance, dressed head to toe in black—is one of her favorites; she always has the best candy tucked away in her purse, willing to share at the drop of a hat—she even let Rosie sneak a sip of wine when her mother wasn't looking one summer night.

"It's a right of passage." Aunt Carol had whispered, smirking at the puckered up face Rosie made as the drink hit her taste buds. *"It's an acquired taste, dear."*

Whatever that meant.

Rosie reaches the final step with a grin as she spots the flamboyant hat peeking out from the dreary crowd. *Aunt Carol!* It has to be her, she's known for her loud headwear— *specifically.* Joy bubbles to the surface of Rosie's chest. The feeling tampers off however as Aunt Carol's tear streaked face tilts to the side—a subtle movement she makes in order to speak to another family member whose name Rosie doesn't recall. At this new angle Rosie can see everything clearly; Aunt Carol looks like she'll *break* at any given moment. Fickle is the trigger.

Something nasty bubbles inside Rosie's throat as she realizes: this isn't a jubilee.

Rosie looks over the crowd once more—hoping to see someone with a *different* expression—she comes up empty handed. Hope

dulling, Rosie slinks off the banister—trailing her fingers along the mahogany—as she heads for the kitchen where less people are gathered. She dutifully nods and politely accepts the offered hugs as she makes her journey. Under the static Rosie can faintly hear them saying things like:

"I'm so sorry for your loss—"

"Everything happens for a reason—"

"Come here, bring it in—"

"If you ever need anything—"

A low buzz fills in the rest of the gaps; if she were starring on a game show, playing for the jackpot prize, with her only task being to repeat their condolences, she'd lose. At this point, it all gets muddled together.

"Pastor Joan…" Rosie stops, just peeking out from the back door of the kitchen, as she hears her mother say "thank you for speaking at the funeral, and for letting us have it at the church."

Pastor Joan—Rosie assumes—replies softly, "of course, you're family. It's no trouble at all...it seems like it was just yesterday when Matthew left us."

Dad, Rosie thinks with a sinking feeling.

Her mothers voice trembles like the old floorboards beneath their feet, "his funeral was on a chilly day like this too…" she trails off—eerily staring up at the popcorn ceiling.

Rosie was only a toddler when her father died from a heart attack so she barely recalls the day they set his body to rest. All she remembers is latching onto her uncle's chest as her mother cried into Aunt Carol's neck. The strange thing is, her parents actually divorced years before her father's passing; her mother was inconsolable for someone who hadn't been in her father's life near

the end of it. But…Rosie supposes there's a lot more to their story she doesn't understand.

Maybe she'll ask her mum more about it some day.

A pot hits the counter top with a *pang,* pulling Rosie back to the present. Pastor Joan chides her mother softly, "you shouldn't be cooking for—"

"I have to do *something."*

"You've done all you can…"

"It's not enough." Her mother says frantically, "there needs to be food—"

"The caterer can handle—"

"There is none!"

Rosie winces, not accustomed to her mother's sharp tone.

A moment passes before her mother answers with far less bite, "funerals aren't cheap, Pastor...so let me cook…"

Rosie slips from the doorway before she can hear the Pastor's reply. She contemplates going back into the living room—to hang on the wall while the others mourn *(a dreary flower she would be)* —but she doesn't want to get swept up in a sea of hugs again so she slips out the back door into the yard.

The sunlight slaps across her face—a welcome change from the chilly air conditioned air. Rosie sucks in a breath of fresh air and nearly chokes on her exhale. Just a couple meters away is a tall woman with bushy brown hair pulled into a lazy but stylish ponytail; jagged bangs streak across her forehead, providing a shadow that restricts the rest of her face from Rosie's view.

The woman is facing the lake that separates them from their neighbors across the way. It's an isolated home—Rosie has to take

the bridge just to visit her friend Maze—but today, she thinks she can appreciate the privacy.

Rosie slowly inches towards the stranger with a sensible question on her tongue, something like: *who are you and why are you lurking in my backyard?* But when she opens her mouth she blurts out—

"You're really pretty."

The woman looks down at her; the new angle of her head changes the path of light so that the sun's rays are hitting the top of her head—blanketing her in a lovely halo. No longer obscured from view, Rosie finds intriguing mismatched eyes and *freckles.* But what surprises Rosie the most is how the woman doesn't seem alarmed—not even spooked in the *slightest* by her presence. The woman simply pauses, a small smile leaking across her face as she replies with a gentle "thank you."

Rosie clears her throat and tries not to buckle under the stare. The woman seems nice on the surface, but Rosie has a feeling something darker lies beneath the façade.

"Uhm," Rosie stutters, "do I know you?"

"No," the woman says after a pause, "but I was a... *friend* of Finn's." She lingers on the word friend—almost like she's unsure, but her expression ends on a confident note.

Rosie *giggles,* startling herself and the stranger who raises a confused eyebrow. Rosie gathers her breath and says with as much sympathy as she can muster, "my condolences, he must've driven you absolutely mad."

A gentle smile graces the woman's lips, "it wasn't a bother, truly." She says it with so much care and *affection* that Rosie has to ask —

"Oh," Rosie's lips quirk up, "were you his *girlfriend* then?"

“Bloody—” the woman’s eye twitches as she mutters with disdain, “he was *seventeen.”*

Rosie raises an eyebrow, taking in the woman’s disgruntled form—a stark contrast to the persona she was presenting before. Rosie concludes, “get that question a lot, do you?”

“Understatement.”

Rosie smiles, basking in the joy of the moment before she rears up to continue. Rosie asks, once the air has settled, “so?”

The woman relaxes her shoulders—frown slipping from her face—as she smiles, eyes pinching up as if recalling a pleasant memory. She explains politely, “we did *not* have that kind of relationship, but…not because of the lack of effort on his part...I was actually new to the city and he helped me adjust. He was a great kid—a great *friend.* I can admit that now.”

Rosie confesses, “he was a great brother too.”

The woman raises an eyebrow in subtle surprise. Her voice wavers, “you’re Rosie?”

“You know me?” Rosie frowns.

“Finn mentioned you a couple times at the store,” she does a pretty good impression of Finn when she says, *“my little sis Rosie is tough as nails, sometimes I think I’d go crazy if it wasn’t for her.”*

Rosie laughs at how *accurate* it sounds. This woman *must* have known Finn, either that or she’s a damn good improviser.

“He was always saying stuff like that,” Rosie says, already thinking of something else to discuss—eager to keep the woman talking; she’s the only person here who hasn’t tried to get Rosie to cry on her shoulder or smother her with a hug. Yes, her brother is gone and she’s devastated but, for now, she’s too shocked to mourn.

It hasn’t really set in yet.

“I’m his favorite, and only, sister.” Rose begins to list off her slim fingers, “Finn always lets me play with his PlayStation even if I mess up his levels—and he never yells at me if I do—and he always brings me a slice of pizza when he gets home late from work…” she stops mid sentence, “I mean...he *did.”*

The woman changes the subject—a delicacy Rosie is thankful for. “I almost didn’t show my face.”

Rosie asks, “why not?”

“Goodbyes are a bi—“ she corrects herself swiftly, “goodbyes suck.”

Rosie nods, kicking at a nearby rock. “Yeah.”

“Plus,” she smiles, “if I didn’t come I’m sure he’d haunt me about it...probably say something about me being an honorary family member.”

“Of course.” Rosie grins, “once he gives you your first free slice you're pretty much a Hale.”

Rosie prides herself in leaving such a fierce woman speechless.

“And since you’re family,” Rosie demands gently—trying to channel her brother’s *don’t take no for an answer* attitude— “I’m sure I’ll see you again, right.”

The woman’s expression bristles but never breaks. She swallows a lump and gives Rosie a solid nod.

“Of course.”

Rosie smiles, satisfied, but it falls slightly as she hears the muffled family piano being fiddled with by professional fingers. The songs are starting and Rosie doesn’t want to panic her mother with her absence—she already has enough going on—so Rosie prepares

herself to face the masses. She takes a step but turns around when the woman doesn't follow.

"Go ahead," the woman says, "I'll see you around."

Rosie realizes she never asked, "what's your name?"

"...it's Catra."

Rosie tucks the name away for safekeeping. They share one more glance—of mutual understanding—before Rosie slips back inside. Everyone's gathered by the piano while Uncle Mike plays so she isn't bombarded with affection this time around and makes it to the kitchen without incident. She spots her mother in the same spot talking to the Pastor. Rosie goes to announce herself when a woman in a business suit walks in swiftly with a vanilla envelope stretched out for her mother.

Rosie doesn't know the woman but based on the dread leaking across her mother's face, the lady doesn't come bearing good news.

"Here's your invoice ma'am."

"How much will it be?" Her mother asks—jumping to the point, not having the courage to scan the papers herself.

"Nothing. Everything has been paid for."

Her mother startles, "what? But I haven't—"

"Anonymous donor ma'am. Everything is taken care of."

Her mother breaks down into tears. Rosie's feet move on their own, rushing her back out into the yard because somehow she just has this *hunch.* And Finn always told her to *trust them.*

Rosie slips back outside, desperately trying to catch a glimpse—or some kind of sign—of the stranger with the freckles—of *Catra.*

When Rosie reaches the yard, Catra's already gone.

13

"It's for the best."

Catra casts a lingering glance back at the lake house; dread fills her stomach while she watches, secluded from view under the canopy, as Rosie gives up her search and heads back inside with drooping shoulders. *She looks just like him sometimes,* Catra thinks ruefully as she recalls Rosie demanding Catra's presence in the future.

Unfortunately, Catra isn't sure if it's a promise she can keep.

"Is it though?" Adora asks, joining her side with a gentle shoulder nudge.

"Of course it is." Catra hisses, "you *saw* what happened to Finn...I can't let the same thing happen with his sister; our life is too dangerous. It's better if I keep my distance."

Adora hums in agreement but answers with, "if you *really* believed that then you wouldn't have told her your name or, at the very least, you would've erased her memory."

Catra crosses her arms, claws biting into the sleeves of her jacket. She *hates* how well Adora can read her in moments like this.

"Besides," Adora counters, "Finn was terrified in the end; sometimes *not* knowing is a worse fate...I'm not saying you should tell Rosie about Hogwarts and the Floo Network—"

Catra scoffs. "Cuz that would go along splendidly."

"—but," Adora chides gently, not minding Catra's tone when she knows the strain she's under, "maybe a *portion* of the truth will do her some good and, *maybe,* it'll be a nice way to honor Finn's memory. By giving his sister what you should have given him."

“Some semblance of the truth, huh.” Catra mutters, slipping into a deep thought as she tries to ignore the burn of Adora’s stare.

Catra can’t help but think her situation with Rosie isn’t the only thing Adora is referring to. She can hide her emotions from Adora all she wants, but in the night she’s weak—scarred by a recurring dream. And every time she reaches her arm out in the realm of dreams, she is unwillingly pulled into the depths of ego; she wakes up—Adora at her side, eyes frantic, as she gently holds Catra until the tremors subside—nails digging in, leaving behind traces of blood along Adora’s skin (already marked from the war) that will soon be smoothed over with a healing spell. There’s always a question on Adora’s tongue but she never gets the chance to ask before Catra is turning over on her side.

Ever since her encounter with the Gringotts dragon, the dream has haunted her. And even though she never tells Adora about it Catra has a feeling she already knows. But, maybe some things need to be said aloud. And so, Catra turns to Adora and takes her hand—reaching out has always been a good first step for them and she hopes the same holds true.

“About my—” Catra begins.

“—mwr,” Melog interrupts as they jump from the trees—cloaked in their Tom cat form to appease the muggles. They land with a gentle *thump* in front of the duo.

Adora frowns. “What’s wrong buddy?”

Catra follows the path in which Melog gestures; her shoulders relaxing as Bow and Glimmer make their way over. Adora notices them as well, a pout on her face—surely irritated with the well timed interruption.

“Hey,” Glimmer greets, sliding beside Catra with a gentle expression reserved for moments like this. “Sorry to interrupt.”

Catra shakes her head. “No it’s fine, I’m the one who told you to get me if we stayed too long.”

“Are you sure?”

“Yeah,” Catra nods, grabbing Glimmer’s shoulder as Bow prepares to apparate them to the Floo Network in London.

Glimmer asks gently, “how was it?”

Catra admits, “it was nice...I feel like I’ve finally had some closure.”

“That’s good,” Bow says. “I’m sure he would have loved to have you here.”

Catra rubs her eyes and swiftly tries to change the tone, “alright...enough sad stuff. Are we ready?”

Glimmer grins, but it comes across as dull—lessened by the circumstances. Still, Glimmer tries to sound positive as she says—

“Italy, here we come.”

Chapter End Notes

I thought about making this into an Interlude since it was shorter than my other chapters but it’s part of the main story and Finn’s death had a huge impact on Catra so I decided to keep it as a chapter. Plus, Interludes seem like standalones that don’t need to be included in the main story and this was a nice way to sum up Finn’s involvement while giving Catra a platform to grieve.

For this chapter I liked how the introduction was in Rosie’s perspective because we always see characters get hurt/killed in the crosshairs of battle between the main characters but we never see the aftermath of the affected side characters so this was an interesting perspective.

Also, if you’re wondering, the 0-4 stamp stands for the portion of the story where Finn was included up until the end; it’s kind of like the years lived on a tombstone.

Next chapter might be up next week so look out for it on a Friday or Sunday night. I posted this prematurely because it's been a while since I've updated. I'm also working on "Catra D'riluth: The Vessel" so hopefully that chapter will be up by this weekend; good news for you Naruto fans.

As always, thanks for reading. And don't worry, the action will start up again in the next chapter (I'm trying to go for 100k words on this story so the chapter count is ambiguous for now).

Lastly: how would you guys feel about a Prequel story taking place during the golden quartet's fifth year in Hogwarts? It would take place right around the time where Catra is in the Triwizard Tournament.

Let me know.

A Dragon Said to Me...

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

14

Dragon Sanctuary, Romania

Bow Armstrong knew he wanted to be a breeder for magical creatures the moment he saw his first dragon egg. It was during his fourth year at Hogwarts. The semester started out dreary, even the golden crew (void of a certain freckle-faced deviant, at the time) were about themselves—restless from the lack of excitement.

For once, the golden crew were normal—boring—Hogwarts students.

Angella, being well-attuned to the needs of her students, sought to introduce a special guest in hopes of boosting morale, and when Huntara Blakehurst entered their field of view, Bow knew he would be in for a treat. The woman was littered in scars, a foggy storm brewing beneath her eyes as if she'd escaped a terrible storm but—somehow—the storm refused to release its hold on *her.*

He remembers Huntara being a bulky woman with muscles so protruding it made most of the girls (and some boys) swoon. Even Adora sported a flushed face, though she was far more composed than the squealing fangirls. Bow also recalls Catra's scowling face in the crowd; she had been sitting atop the brick wall with her crew of misfits, rolling her eyes at the swooning girls and hissing for some unbeknownst reason whenever she glanced in Adora's direction.

Back then, Bow thought it was hate fueling Catra's behavior. Now, he knows better.

Bow turned his gaze away from the enigma that was Catra D'riluth and faced a far more interesting sight. Huntara had turned her back and dug into a container she carried with her—expressing such care despite what her appearance suggested. Her eyes fended off the storm as she turned and presented a magnificent egg with intricate blue and red splatters. A *marvelous* canvas that made Bow want to do *everything* in his power to protect it—preserve it.

The rest of the school year he moved with a new velocity; fueled by his dream. And now, as he basks in the stars blanketing the sky, he finds a laugh bubbling in his chest as he marvels at coming full circle to where it all began.

Bow rises to his knees from his sleeping bag when sleep refuses to find him and—not knowing what keeps him awake (yet there can be a variety of things these days)—he pulls on his boots; they're caked with the mud lining the terrain they traveled the morning before. He presses a kiss to Glimmer's forehead while she rests. Part of him selfishly wants to awaken his fiancé to share in his insomnia but he's already put her through enough.

Glimmer isn't an outdoors person but, for him, she made the exception. And so, Bow chooses to let her rest.

He steps into the night and is surprised to find Adora by the fire. Though he knows he could never sneak up on her, he tries to keep his steps light so as not to rouse her too much.

"Please tell me you're not eating all our snacks."

Adora's shoulder jumps as she snorts. "And have Glimmer put my head on a spike? I think not." She looks up at him as he stands beside her. These days her eyes are brighter with Catra permanently at her side; yet, they are children of war so there are some things that remain. *Sinking* things.

Bow clears his throat. "What're you doing up?"

Adora seems to hesitate. “Catra was having a bad dream...it woke me.”

Bow nods, sullen. “I don’t want to even *wonder* what can haunt someone as strong as her.”

Adora bites into one of the turkey sandwiches they packed for the trip. “...I use my magic to fight off the roughest dreams that leave her sweating at night—“

“But not all?”

Adora shakes her head. “It’s a recurring dream...call me mental but, maybe she *needs* to have it so she can get to the source. But, if it becomes too much for her to bear I’ll remove her pain.”

“Has she told you what they’re about?”

Adora shakes her head. “I’m trying to give her some space. She’s been better about opening up since visiting Rosie but some things are still fresh and I don’t wanna push her.”

Bow finally takes a seat at her side on the wooden log when his calf starts to cramp. He leans on his knees and tilts his head to her with a brittle smile. He finds himself scraping for hope these days.

“It takes time,” he says, “but look how far she’s come. From ignoring you at school to hexing you in the halls—“

Adora instinctively rubs at her side.

“—to actually taking your *advice* during the Triwizard Tournaments, to fighting at your *side* during the war, and now—not only *promising* to be with you until the end—but letting her actions speak for her.” Bow tries to lighten the air when he catches Adora’s eyes glossing over. He sports a playful grin, “I better be the best man at your wedding is all I’m saying.”

Adora's face lights up with a vicious blush. She splutters out a response, "you play too much." Adora halfheartedly nudges him away as she turns her face from him.

Bow raises an eyebrow. "You're seriously getting flustered. Is what I said really such a stretch? I honestly can't see you with anyone else." And, he doesn't think Catra would allow it—not without a few broken bones.

"There's no one else." Adora says, eyes flickering to and fro anxiously. "But it's too soon. We've only been together for a few months."

Bow hums. "If you count the times you two snuck around during the war—"

Adora stutters, "we didn't—"

"Glimmer and I shared a tent next to yours; it was already weird when you decided to room with the girl who you were always at odds with but, my suspicions were cemented when one of you forgot to place a silencing spell over the tent." Bow shivers at the memory. "It explained so many things."

Adora hides her face in her hands groaning, "please stop talking…"

Bow does no such thing. "The point is, you two have technically been together for *eight* years."

"What about *your* wedding?" Adora swiftly changes the subject, shooting him a look from the cracks of her fingers. "How long are you going to push it back?"

Bow laughs, undeterred. "Glim and I decided to push it to this fall with everything that's been going on. And with Mara and Octavia finally taken care of, we can rest easy knowing you won't be getting yourself into trouble or, Merlin forbid, you bring your work to our wedding. Like dementors or something."

“I don’t carry them in my back pocket,” she huffs.

“Nevertheless, you and Catra better be there. *Without* bringing your work with you.”

Adora holds her hands up on surrender. The sandwich is long gone. *When did she manage to shove the remains down her throat?* Bow thinks, amused.

“Did you forget I passed on being the Director of Magical Security —“

Bow shrugs, saying “—for now.”

“—and Catra is taking a break from work. We’ll make sure to take extra time off for your big day, don’t worry.” Adora is quiet for a moment before she asks, “are you nervous?”

Bow startles, not expecting the question or truly knowing the answer. “I’m not sure…”

Adora teases, “better not be having second thoughts,” but he peeks the veiled threat on her tongue.

Bow looks up to the stars. “She’s my best half—forever a part of me—sometimes I *swear* I can feel how she does on her worst days.”

“Magic.”

Bow frowns. “Pardon?”

Adora looks to her tent where Catra rests. A smile slips across her face as she whispers, “magic connects us...even when Catra and I weren’t on the best terms I always *felt* her. But I think once you become aware of the bond and its impact that’s when you truly open the gates.”

Bow nods—grateful that Adora has the words he can’t seem to form. “It’s like Melog’s connection to Catra.” Bow hesitates and

asks, "I've been wondering actually…"

"I can. Sometimes."

"Sometimes?" Bow presses, not being able to resist when it comes to magical creatures.

Adora's brow furrows as she thinks and a part of him—the one that's been around Catra for far too long—wants to say something like *don't hurt yourself.*

"...when Catra disappeared to talk to the Unspeakable Division about breaking her vow; Melog was mourning her loss and I guess I was in the same boat so we formed a bond. I couldn't understand what they were saying but I could feel their emotions...if that made sense."

"It did." He says gently.

Adora shakes herself out of her daze—she turns away from Catra's resting spot but the longing is still there. Adora tries to blink it away as she changes the tone of her voice to something gleeful, "so, you think we'll get to see a dragon tomorrow?"

Bow feels something spark inside his chest, childlike glee rises to the surface but before it can burst a tent flap opens with a *woosh.* Bow startles, pivoting to see Huntara force her bulky form through the tiny exit of her tent. Her face is as cheerful as he recalls on their first meeting all those years ago.

"You'll see creatures far worse tonight if you don't quit yapping," Huntara huffs, joining them at the fire but refusing to sit down. She glares at them but they've seen far worse in Angella's gaze as she berated them in her office so they don't flinch. Huntara almost *pouts* at the lack of fear but pushes forward, "this is sacred ground, don't think there aren't creatures lurking who want to protect this place."

Bow is familiar with the dangers of the gargoyles. He frowns, "as long as we're here with good intentions they won't bother us."

Huntara looks out into the trees. "Look, it's been years since the Dragon Sanctuary welcomed guests inside its gates."

Bow nods, familiar with the history. "They closed the site off to protect the dragons from poachers."

"Correct, but I don't know how you—" Huntara stops herself with an eye roll, "never mind, I'm sure the golden brats can do whatever they please; especially after the shit they put you through with that trial. The Ministry will *forever* be in your debit."

Bow doesn't use his golden quartet privileges often but getting a *personal* escort to take them through the sanctuary was something he could not resist. Glimmer thought it odd how the offer came from an anonymous source but it was also a once in a lifetime opportunity.

Bow lowers his head. "Our intentions are pure, I promise you that."

Huntara says, "my approval means nothing. If you're lying then the gargoyles will choose your fate. Then again, I'll be blackballed if you lot get killed." She flexes her arms with a grin, "so, I guess it's my job to keep you out of trouble."

Bow looks away, pride dwindling for a moment as he glances at his leaner physique before a rush of assurance washes over him. He smiles to himself. *Even when she's sleeping she's looking out for me.* Bow glances at his tent before his gaze flickers to Adora. Long gone is the teenager who used to get flustered at such a show of muscular prowess, what lies now is an unamused stare.

Adora deadpans, "do you even know any spells that can help us if the gargoyles attack?"

Huntara falters. "I've never needed to fend them off, as I said, the gates have been closed for years. My normal job is peeking in on the dragons during the day and guarding the gates from outsiders."

"—and the gargoyles only come out at night." Bow adds.

Huntara glares at him. "That's *also* correct."

"Catra and I would be better equipped at fending them off," Adora mutters to herself, oblivious to the twitch of Huntara's brow. "We have the most fighting experience and Catra's great with coming up with new spell combinations in the heat of the moment."

Bow smiles at the awe leaking from Adora's voice as she regales them in Catra's expertise. Huntara looks like she doesn't care either way as long as they don't murk up her name. She claps her hands together and a puff of dirt comes up.

Bow shudders.

"Alright," Huntara grunts. "Get back to bed, we have a long day ahead of us tomorrow."

"She's right." Bow says, not sure if he truly agrees or if he just wants to stop Adora from antagonizing their tour guide any further. Regardless, Bow pulls Adora to her feet; they each mutter a polite "goodnight" to the other party. Huntara mumbles out something in return before shoving herself back inside her regular-person-sized tent.

Bow stifles a laugh when Huntara curses as the tent flaps get in her way.

"Why doesn't she just use magic to expand her tent?" Bow asks once his desire for laughter fades.

Adora shrugs. "She seems like a traditional person, I wouldn't be surprised if she refrains from using it most days. Plus, she did say this area is sacred so maybe she's just trying to be polite."

"She couldn't have *purchased* a larger tent then?"

"Let's not argue over nonsense." Adora turns to him one more time; she gives him a mock salute as she cheers, "to seeing a

dragon", before she slips inside her tent.

Bow grins to himself. "To seeing a dragon."

Bow gets inside the sleeping bag without waking Glimmer and, despite how hard he tries, he can't sleep with the excitement gnawing at him. Eventually, he casts a drowsy spell on himself so tomorrow can come faster.

"Wake up."

Bow jolts from sleep at the rough elbow to his side; he blinks away the crust of sleep from his eyes before staring up at a *wonderful* view. Glimmer meets his gaze from above. Even though she appears tired, her messy hair scatters about pleasantly. His stomach flutters at the sight.

Bow grins, trying to go for pseudo-confidence. "Good morning, beautiful."

Glimmer shoves him in a failed attempt at hiding a blush. "It's too early for you to be cheesy," a frown slowly grows across her features, "and it's too early to go hiking."

Bow reaches out and holds her hands; he kisses her knuckles in gratitude. "Thanks for agreeing to come here...I know you're not an outdoors person."

"Yeah well, you're lucky I love you." Glimmer gives him a chaste kiss before rising from their makeshift bed. "Let's pack up so we can get going; the faster we head out the faster we can see a dragon."

Bow jumps at the reminder. He uses his wand to retrieve the tent, placing a shrinking charm on it as he packs it into his hiking bag to carry the rest of the way. Bow considers putting out the fire when Glimmer gets his attention.

"What's wrong?" Bow asks.

“Catra’s still sleeping.”

Bow follows Glimmer’s gaze to Catra and Adora’s tent; he recalls his conversation with Adora the night before—about the nightmares and night sweats. His stomach churns uncomfortably.

Bow clears his throat, “Adora didn’t wake her?”

Glimmer nods over at the river a couple paces down where Adora and Huntara are surveying nearby bushes and trees near the stream. Glimmer mutters, “guess not—wait...what is she doing?” Her face scrunches up when Huntara tastes a handful of dirt she’d scooped up. Adora’s expression appears to be on the same wavelength as Glimmer's.

Bow smiles, knowing the tactic well. “It’s a way for her to hunt nearby dragons; she’s trying to find a trail that will lead us right to them.”

Glimmer looks afraid to ask, “you know this from experience?”

Bow shudders at the thought of tasting dirt. “From reading.”

Glimmer looks relieved but soon a sigh racks over her body. “However gross it may be, it looks like it’s working. We’ll be leaving soon.”

Bow nods. “We should wake up Catra and—“

“Not it!”

“That’s not fair!” Bow argues, not knowing exactly why being the person to wake Catra is a bad thing but having enough sense to know that Glimmer cheated at the game.

“Rules are rules.” Glimmer pats his shoulder with a grin.

Bow shakes his head and accepts defeat. “It’s fine,” he grins sheepishly, “besides, how bad can it be?”

Glimmer raises an eyebrow but doesn't say a word; she pats his shoulder one more time before walking over to join a disgruntled Adora who watches Huntara with unrestrained disdain as their tour guide tastes a new handful of dirt. Bow turns before the scene can unfold; he slips inside Catra's tent and finds her tossing in her sleep with a worried Melog pressing into her side.

Melog makes a miserable mewl in his presence.

"I know buddy," he says softly.

Bow gathers his wand so he can first clear the nightmare from Catra's mind before waking her up. He kneels beside her and presses his wand to her head when she starts muttering a plethora of mumblings that mean nothing to him. At Melog's rapid mewling, Bow whispers a vanishing spell to wash away the terrors plaguing his friend. Catra's expression softens—eyebrows relaxing—sweat drying up as her fever wanes.

Bow shakes her with a gentle hand. "Catra, wake up..." she blinks slowly, coming to the surface as her mismatched eyes make an appearance—devoid of their usual vigor so early in the morning. Bow marvels at how at peace she looks; he almost turns his face, not wanting to disrupt such a vulnerable scene not meant for him.

"Bow?" Catra whispers, slowly becoming aware.

He perks up. "Hey, good—"

Melog's whimpering as they back themselves into a corner should have been his first clue to prepare himself. When Bow does eventually pick up on the sharpening of Catra's eyes and the curl of her lip as she sneers it's too late. A wave of magic shoots through the air. He doesn't move fast enough.

"—morning!" Bow screams, pain spreading like wildfire through his stomach. Another hex—just as debilitating—sends him flying from the tent and landing in the dirt. Bow groans, clutching at his stomach as the world spins.

Glimmer must notice the commotion because she shouts, "Catra's awake!"

The rest of Glimmer's speil is heard upon deaf ears; Bow can only focus on the *woosh* as Catra's tent flaps open followed by a growl, "Arrows."

Bow shrinks into the dirt as Catra stands over him while cracking her knuckles.

"What were you doing in my tent staring over me like a creep?"

Bow goes to stutter out a reply to defend himself from the accusations of lechery when Adora jogs over to diffuse the situation. "Alright, enough playing around you two—"

Playing? Bow thinks with the twitch of an eye.

"—Huntara found a trail we can follow." Adora waves a hand and her tent magically places itself inside her book bag. She scoops up the bag and grabs Catra's hand to guide her over to Huntara. Bow marvels at how such a simple touch can cause Catra's shoulders to go lax.

Before the couple moves on, Adora crosses her arms and says expectantly, "Catra, isn't there something you'd like to…"

Catra narrows her eyes at her girlfriend before turning to Bow with what he assumes is supposed to be an apologetic gaze. Catra at least sounds sincere as she says, "I'm sorry for hexing you."

Bow rises to his feet, dusting the dirt off his pants. "I'm sorry for waking you," he mutters a bit sarcastically.

Catra looks sheepish. "I'm not a morning person."

"Figured that." Bow jokes.

Huntara shouts from up ahead, "we're moving out!"

A grin breaks out across Adora's face; she pulls Catra along with her while Bow shoulders his bag and trudges behind them. At his side, Melog trots over and nudges their head into his leg. Bow pets the creatures' head—feeling eyes on him. Bow glances up, meeting Catra's fleeting gaze. She looks him over, likely to check for any injuries, before facing forward. He doesn't miss the flushing of her cheeks.

Bow feels his pep return—feeling lighter—as he jogs over to keep close to the group.

Huntara moves at a relentless pace, guiding them along the correct path as she cuts away branches in their path. He's not sure how much time passes. There's a growing ache in his quads from hiking uphill for so long but he still manages to eagerly pull out his journal from time to time to write in detail about the terrain and the beautiful sights of the sanctuary. He's lost in thought as he analyzes gooseberries—known for their neon green hue—indicative to this land, when Glimmer groans at his side.

"Are we there yet?"

Huntara snaps, "are you sure *you* fought in a war? We've only been hiking for a couple hours."

Glimmer wipes the sweat from her brow and mutters, "physical excellence wasn't really a prerequisite for being a war hero. *Some* of us like to let our magical prowess speak for us."

"Oh yeah?" Huntara shoots her a nasty look. "And what if you're stripped of your wand one day?"

"Wandless magic!" Adora jumps in—earning a scowl from Huntara while Glimmer laughs into her hand.

"And what if you're stripped of your very magical core? When you have *nothing,* you'll be thankful for training your body under the most stressful conditions."

Bow hears Catra mutter under her breath, “she’s not wrong…” as she likely recalls the physical training she put herself through for the Triwizard Tournament. Unfortunately, Huntara and Glimmer continue to bicker back and forth with no hope for a mediator.

Bow turns away from the spectacle and spots a bush with a jagged section missing as if someone had taken a large bite out of it. He gathers their attention and gestures to the bush saying, “it shouldn’t be too long, I’m pretty sure we’re nearing the Common Welsh Green. A lot of the deer they hunt eat these gooseberries; some myths say it’s the reason why their scales are green.”

Huntara looks over at him, impressed. “Correct, *again...* they should be just over—“ her voice gets overpowered by a shrill shriek. Not soon after, a billowing gust of wind forces them back a couple paces. Huntara tries to shout orders but her voice is lost in the wind.

Bow covers his eyes to keep the debris away, only looking up once the wind has faded into a delicate breeze. He peeks through the crack of his arm and his jaw drops. Beady yellow eyes appraise them, head cocking to the side like a confused puppy. The beast has an armor of green scales lining its body just as he suspected and it towers over them, reaching heights greater than the trees surrounding them.

Bow is too in awe to be afraid. “Wow.”

Huntara holds her hand out, lacking any hostility she’s been carrying with her. “Hey girl... I’m just passing through with some friends.”

The dragon sniffs her hand and recognition sparks behind yellow orbs. Huntara smiles—a strange sight—and pets the beast as it lowers its head to her.

“This is Emerald, the mother of most of our Common Welsh Greens. You probably won’t see her babes around unless you stumble across her nest which we will be avoiding to keep our

heads intact.” Huntara steps back and gestures to them, “you can touch her but just be careful.”

Bow is the first to step forward with his hand outstretched. “You’re marvelous…”

Emerald blinks at him and nudges her nose into his hand.

“She likes you.” Huntara snorts.

Bow is inclined to express how much he favors the warmth beneath his palm but isn’t in the mood for upsetting his fiancée by pressing his affections elsewhere. He memorizes the texture of her scales, the oceans of history behind those eyes, before he carefully backs away to retrieve his journal to write in detail about his findings.

Glimmer and Adora have a similar experience; each marveling at being in the presence of such a great beast. And for someone who didn’t want to hike all the way up here, Glimmer seems the most reluctant to back away when her time is up.

Huntara grunts, “you’re up, kit.”

When he doesn’t hear Catra snarl at the offensive nickname, Bow looks up from his journal. Catra seems fixated on Emerald who, in turn, seems just as interested. But, Catra doesn’t make a move to get closer.

Adora grabs her girlfriend's shoulder and asks in a low voice, “you okay?”

Catra flickers back to life. “Yeah, I’m good...but, I think I’ll pass.”

Emerald narrows her eyes, letting out a puff of air from her nose that sends Catra’s hair whipping around. Catra makes a face at the beast who turns her back to the hybrid in clear disdain.

Huntara teases, “didn’t take you for a coward.”

“Hey, she doesn’t have to do anything she doesn’t want to.” Adora interrupts, voice harder than steel.

Bow winces at her tone.

Adora hasn’t spoken much about what happened when she went up against Mara, even Catra—who stares off into the unknown these days—brushes them off whenever she’s questioned about her fight with Octavia by muttering things like:

“I kicked her arse, what else is there to say?”

“Call off your attack dog,” Huntara grunts.

Catra narrows her eyes—a familiar spark that’s been absent these last few days makes an appearance. Catra turns her nose up at Huntara. “I don’t think I will.”

Bow steps between them when he feels the hair on his arm become erect; he felt the same thing happen this morning when he woke Catra up. “This isn’t the place,” he warns, gulping as Emerald’s eyes become slit-like.

Huntara snatches her arm away. “Fine. Let’s get this over with so I don’t have to see you lot ever again.”

Bow stays in the middle to keep another fight from breaking out. It’s not an easy task. Most of the time he has to keep Glimmer’s smart comments in check while stopping Adora from glaring a hole into Huntara’s head. Surprisingly, Catra’s the one behaving—which is saying *a lot.* In between his journaling, he often catches Catra trailing behind the group as she gets lost in thought. *It’s nothing new,* he thinks.

During their stay in Italy—when Catra wasn’t spending time with Adora—she often kept to herself, even going on long walks during the day. He wants to ask if he can help, but he wasn’t there during Catra’s fight with Octavia. Hell, he hasn’t been in a life threatening duel in *years.* There’s no advice he can give her that could help her situation.

Adora's the one who was in the vault with her and has the experience of battle. It gives Bow some hope that, eventually, Catra will snap out of her funk.

"The sun is setting!" Glimmer exclaims.

Huntara glares at her. "Don't sound so excited."

Glimmer ignores the bulky woman in favor of plopping down in the grass. Glimmer can't contain her grin as she asks, "this means we have to set up camp, right? To avoid running into the gargoyles."

"Aye," Huntara says, cracking her neck with a sharp turn of her head. "Kit, come with me to move any nearby gargoyle statues from the area."

Catra walks over with an apprehensive frown and a question on her tongue, "why do I have to go?"

Huntara's eye twitches. "Because, *somehow,* you're the least annoying person here." Bow takes that comment by serious offense but he's too tired to argue.

Huntara leads Catra into the trees while the rest of them set up their tents and get the fire started. By the time they're finished the sun is nearly gone from the sky. Huntara and Catra return not too soon after with their hands caked in mud.

"Those damn things were practically cemented in the ground," Catra complains, sitting next to Adora on the log she's using as a seat. Catra leans into Adora's figure and closes her eyes—seemingly on the verge of sleep. Bow nearly squeals when Catra's nose twitches but, alas, there is no cute sneeze to be followed.

Huntara engulfs a turkey sandwich. At least she has the decency to finish chewing before she speaks, "the gargoyles have a magical ability that prevents people from using magic to remove them from the land—kind of a messed up way to get you to work

for it. We managed to move the statues far enough away so there shouldn't be any trouble tonight."

Glimmer puts on her best face and asks, "can we stay out for a few more minutes? I'm not tired yet—"

"—you've complained all day about wanting a break." Huntara snaps.

"—and the four of us don't get a lot of moments like this." Glimmer finishes.

Bow nods. "It's true, usually around this time we'd have someone attacking us."

"Or throwing us in Azkaban," Adora adds, earning a laugh from the quartet.

Huntara stares at them. "You're all mental."

"It's the world that's mental, not us." Catra mutters with her eyes closed, head tucked safely in the space near Adora's neck.

Huntara shakes her head. "Fine…but no longer than half an hour. And don't forget to put an extra protection spell over your tents in case a gargoyle wanders back into our area." They promise to do so and Huntara nods before heading inside her tent that is definitely a size too small.

They sit by the fire in a comfortable silence, enjoying being in each other's presence while the crackling fire engulfs their senses. Bow spends his time making a couple finishing touches in his journal entries when an idea sparks. He looks over at Catra and carefully asks, "hey, Catra, could you sketch a Chinese Fireball for me?"

Catra's nose scrunches up—seemingly in disdain—as she answers with her eyes closed, "you're including pictures now?"

Bow nods sheepishly. “Yeah…I know there is a *ton* of literature about dragons out there but it’s kind of nice having my own journal.”

Catra makes a show of not being interested but, regardless, she extends her hand. Her eyes slip open as she asks, “do you have a pencil or something?”

Glimmer frowns. “He gets a picture? Just like that.”

Catra shrugs. “Why not?”

Catra appears aloof but her tail is flicking to and fro in the same manner Melog’s does when the magical creature is playing with its favorite toy.

Glimmer argues, “I’ve been waiting *months* for the portrait you promised me.”

Catra leans forward with her mouth curled up, canines making a brief appearance. “It’s not my fault my eyes burn when I stare at your picture for long periods of time.”

Glimmer shoots back, “yeah? Well you—”

Ark!

“Gargoyle!” Glimmer exclaims—leaping into Bow’s arms like the dog from a muggle show Catra told him about once.

Bow thinks back on it. *Was his name Rooby Roo?*

Bow shakes his head, fending off the inopportune question, as he looks out in the direction of the noise. Bow realizes, “I think that was a baby dragon.”

“Shouldn’t they be in their nests?” Adora asks.

“Maybe it’s eating a snack before bed?” Glimmer suggests once she calms down.

"No." Catra surprises them as she rises to her feet; she glares at the towering trees, getting lost in the darkness as if it's staring back into her. "It sounded like a cry for help."

Adora glances at him asking, "what do you think?"

Bow nods. "It doesn't make sense why a baby would stray so far from its nest, and we already know there aren't any close by...something's wrong. It can't be the gargoyles, they're here to *protect* the creatures of this land."

Glimmer looks weary as she mutters, "please tell me we're not—"

"—let's go then," Adora says, already running toward the noise with a scowling Catra right behind her.

"Don't just—" Catra's voice trails off as she and Melog follow Adora into madness.

Glimmer groans. "Why can't we have a normal Holiday without something going wrong?"

"That's way too boring." Bow grins.

Glimmer contemplates his comment with a nod, "...that's true."

Bow does his best to follow after the duo but tree branches and fallen twigs delay them. After a few moments of running aimlessly, Bow opens a line of communication with Catra—he *tries* to—but whenever he tries to make the connection something prevents him from doing so. Instead, he reaches out to Adora. *Where are you?*

Adora responds quickly, *I'm at an opening, go past the tree with the indent in the middle.*

Bow looks around, using his wand as a flashlight, when he spots it. *Okay, we're on our way.*

Good, there's a pause. *Catra's with you, right?*

Bow frowns. *No…I thought she was with you.*

"What's wrong?" Glimmer asks—pressing on his hand when he grips hers too tightly. He mutters a quick apology before kissing the back of her hand.

Bow answers, "Catra isn't with her." He rushes past the tree with the dent in it and jumps over a nasty bush. Thankfully, they find Adora pacing on the other side. She looks up eagerly before deflating when she doesn't spot Catra with them.

"Where is she?" Adora huffs, rubbing her eyes with the back of her hand. "...this is all my fault, I shouldn't have rushed in like that…"

Bow tries to convince her it isn't her fault but Adora isn't hearing it. Instead, he tries a different tactic. "Can you trace her?"

Adora shakes her head. "She didn't use any magic so her magical signature is cold right now and Melog went with her—"

Ark!

Adora jumps, "oh yeah," she leads them over to a ruffled bush and kneels down to spread the leaves revealing a baby Romanian Longhorn curled into itself. Adora smiles briefly at the sight—her fears subsiding for the time being. Adora says, "they were all alone when I found them though…I don't know what spooked it."

A rustling nearby stops them in their tracks. Adora rises to her feet and draws her wand despite Huntara's echoing warning; she places herself in front—ready to take whatever damage if it means keeping them safe.

Bow kneels down to keep an eye on their new friend as the rustling grows louder. A dark figure emerges from the trees just as Bow feels a wave of pure magic leak from the tip of Adora's wand. But, whatever spell she has ready on her lips fades away as the intruder reveals themself.

Bow nearly doubles over as Adora exclaims—

"Frosta?"

"Hey guys," Frosta says, trailing off nervously. "What are the odds, huh?"

Glimmer mutters under her breath, "you're *kidding* me."

It's been a while since he's last seen Frosta; her mother is close friends with Angella so Glimmer was asked to babysit on various occasions. Back then, Frosta was just a kid who kept following them around—latching onto every detail as they recounted stories from their past adventures.

Bow is broken away from his revere when he spots Catra emerging from the trees out of the corner of his eye while everyone else is distracted. Catra dusts off what she can of the soot and ash caked into her clothes while Melog shakes it out of their fur which causes it to get back on Catra. She glares at Melog before her attention is pulled away once she notices Frosta's presence. Catra's eyes go wide.

"Snowflake?" Catra exclaims, "what are you *doing* here?"

Frosta scratches the back of her neck and begs—

"...please don't tell my mum."

Chapter End Notes

> I was supposed to update one other story last weekend but I found this amazing fanfic "Ice Would Suffice" about Daenerys and Sansa (to all my Game of Thrones fans) and I highly recommend taking a look if you weren't satisfied with the real GoT ending for Dany's arc; it kept me occupied for the past few days but I'm not mulling over the sleep I lost trying to stay up all night reading.

Anyway, the benefit of having this in Bow's perspective is that I get to keep Catra's thoughts a secret as well as Adora's because even though Adora doesn't know everything her girlfriend is doing, she's around her the most and knows more than she's letting on. This also helps me utilize Bow and Glimmer more; for most of the story they've been on the sidelines as support but now we see their side a little. In some ways, Bow's perspective is the audience perspective. Motivation to write his perspective came from the previous chapter with Rosie.
It was also fun to show the bond he and Adora share.

Thanks for reading!

Mysterious Correspondent

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

14

Dragon Sanctuary, Romania

The night air nips at her heels, sending an unpleasant chill up her spine, but what leaves her most disgruntled is the ghost standing before her. Adora rubs at her eyes in rapid succession in hopes that the vision will vanquish. But ultimately, she keeps coming to the same conclusion. *Frosta Nightglass* is actually *here.* The news is startling and very much unsettling when Adora recalls what a fanatic Frosta is when it comes to them and their golden quartet exploits. And while Adora would very much like to demand answers, she decides to keep herself in check—acting as a healthy buffer while Glimmer interrogates their guest.

"What are you doing *here?"* Glimmer asks, repeating Catra's earlier line of questioning.

Frosta rubs the back of her neck and admits, "okay, don't freak out but...I may have followed you guys here."

"Merlin's beard, you're *mental!"* Glimmer exclaims with another shout seemingly on her tongue before she closes her eyes to steady herself. Then, something sparks within her eyes and soon her face turns white. Glimmer realizes with a start, "...you followed us to *Romania,* once your mum finds out she's gonna tell *my* mum and then—I'm dead."

"We're not children anymore, Sparks." Catra says with a taunt.

Adora has half a mind to tell her girlfriend to ease up but it short circuits when Catra walks over and brushes up against her side.

Glimmer can handle this one on her own, Adora decides—watching the fight proceed.

Frosta argues back petulantly, "yeah, I'm an adult."

"Debatable," Glimmer says with a sneer. And while some of what Glimmer says has some merit it doesn't change the fact that: Frosta's right. Gone is the nosy brat who used to follow them at their heels with the hopes of them regaling her with a story of their past. All Adora sees standing before her now is a young adult—nearly reaching Adora in height—dressed in a simple windbreaker and trousers. Although, there appear to be some *mannerisms* that are hard to shake off even with age.

Frosta puffs out her cheeks until she's red in the face and argues, "I'm *eighteen!"*

"Oh, so you know everything." Glimmer shoots back, effortlessly leading Frosta into their familiar dance—quips and insults keeping the music alive.

Catra bumps shoulders with Adora and mutters, "it's been a while since we've seen these two argue. It used to be hilarious but now, I'm not sure how I feel about it anymore…"

Adora nods in agreement, frowning as the duo bicker back and forth before realization strikes. Her brain finally catches up and Adora turns to Catra with a start. Adora asks frantically, "are you okay?"

Adora pivots on her heel, grabbing at Catra to make sure all her limbs are intact. Melog grunts out a mewl as if to say, *I'm here too…* And, in retaliation, Catra's tail swats Melog in the face, earning a disgruntled hiss from the magical creature.

Shenanigans aside, it fills Adora with joy knowing how well she's gotten at deciphering Melog's mannerisms based on their interactions with Catra.

“Cut it out,” Catra mutters as she flushes under the attention—hissing under her breath—but doing very little to stop it from happening. Catra’s voice sounds muffled with Adora’s hands pressing at her cheeks as she says, “I’m fine, ‘Dora…”

Adora releases her face and takes her hand instead. Adora bumps her forehead gently into Catra’s and whispers, “I’m sorry I ran off like that, I thought—“

“Hey…” Catra shushes her with a chaste kiss; she promises, “I’m tougher than I look.”

“We know.” Bow says, expression muted. He gives Catra a once over, pointedly gesturing at the soot caked to her pants. “You okay?”

Catra huffs at the reminder, “I ran into a feeding den by accident after I got lost chasing after this one,” Adora stifles a laugh, playfully slapping away the finger that’s poking at her side, “but thankfully the dragons weren’t there—they must’ve been sleeping for the night—but the stuff left over from burning their food is a pain in the arse. The damn stuff just sticks to everything.”

Melog mutters an insistent *mewl,* and shakes their fur out once more causing the debris to land atop Catra’s person.

“Okay,” Catra hisses, turning around to level a vicious glare at her familiar, “now I *know* that one was on purpose!”

Adora would very much like to sit back and eat a snack while Catra chases after Melog like a character in one of those muggle cartoons but Frosta is still *very much* here. Adora’s need for answers seems to outweigh her personal vendetta. She holds back a scowling Catra and turns to their guest. Adora asks urgently, “Frosta, what’s going on? How are you even here right now?”

Frosta waves off the second question with ease, “it was honestly nothing, they pride themselves on protecting the creatures of this

land but in reality, their security is *shit.* I didn't even have to go with my backup plan—"

"What is happening?" Glimmer mutters into the palm of her hand.

"—and besides, I learn from the best. Oh! Do you know what this reminds me of?" Frosta's eyes light up while the golden quartet groans in unison as the girl rambles, "it's like the time you all snuck into the wand shop at Hogsmeade—what was it called — *Ollivanders!* Man, that was a great story...and isn't that the first time you all became friends? Yeah, I think it was! *Ollivanders* always reminds me of an *olive branch* because Bow was almost in tears talking about how Catra risked everything to get his wand back after it was stolen from—"

"*Why* are you here?" Adora corrects as gently as she can, cutting off Frosta's ranting before Glimmer pops a blood vessel.

The light in Frosta's eyes seems to grow dull—it's a startling reminder of something Adora's seen in the mirror on numerous occasions. *What has she seen?* Adora asks herself, desperately wanting to know so she can do her best to remove the withering look from Frosta's eyes. No one this young should have to experience the burden the four of them have.

Frosta clears her throat and admits, "like I said, I *did* follow you all here but it's not what you think."

"Explain it to us," Bow says softly.

Frosta nods, nervously playing with her fingers. "So, my mum or dad don't know I'm here…they, uh, sort of think I'm on summer Holiday with some friends before I start the London Auror Academy in the fall."

Adora frowns. "You graduated Hogwarts a couple months ago… Netossa said she went to your graduation party but she didn't mention anything about you announcing that you were going into the academy."

"It's because I'm not." Frosta tries to explain, "I'm sort of doing this freelance thing where I take on odd cases that most Ministry workers would turn their backs on. And recently I've been looking into this case about missing persons and—"

"You're seriously mental." Glimmer frowns, "Frosta…you can't just go around acting like an Auror. You could get hurt—"

"Exactly!" Frosta perks up, "I'm usually fine to do these cases on my own but this new one I'm working on seems…off. And someone I know told me to always trust my gut instincts; it's honestly a coincidence that the latest missing person I'm investigating was last spotted in Romania." Frosta adds, "and I heard you four might be here so I sort of tracked your magical signatures with a locator spell and…the rest is self explanatory."

Catra blinks. "You want us to help you solve a case?"

"No." Frosta corrects hastily.

Catra asks carefully, "then what is it you need our help with?"

Frosta gulps under Catra's buckling stare, suddenly looking like a nervous student presenting before the class as she says, "Glimmer was right about this being dangerous—and I *have* to trust my gut on this—I just think having some backup from seasoned duelers will help."

"What makes you think it'll become that dangerous?" Catra asks.

"Oh come on," Glimmer interrupts, glaring at the hybrid, "you can't be serious."

Catra shrugs, unbothered. "Do you want to face her mum if something bad happens to her? Especially knowing we could have prevented it?"

"Of course not, but we can prevent it *now* and stop her from getting further involved in this madness." Glimmer argues.

“What’s the case about?” Adora asks suddenly, not being able to stop her own curiosity. Glimmer sends her a pointed glare at the betrayal but Adora can’t find it in herself to be too put off by it. Their time in Italy was nice, relaxing even, but Adora can’t lie and say she doesn’t miss the excitement of mystery solving and dueling.

At Adora’s peaked interest Frosta dutifully pulls out a clump of newspaper clippings from her messenger bag saying, “at first I was looking into Bardrick Martin’s case: he went missing when he was around my age—not too soon after he graduated from Durmstrang Institute in Europe. His parents said he got accepted into the London Auror Academy; the last time they saw him he was heading to London through the Floo Network. After a couple months he sent a few letters about how exciting the program was but one day he sent a letter saying he wanted to take a break and travel the world. His parents said Bardrick had solid plans for his future—he would *never* sacrifice it for anything.”

“How long ago were those letters sent?” Adora asks.

“Bardrick went missing seven years ago; apparently the Ministry’s *well-trained* staff didn’t feel the need to investigate...but the letters were probably sent around the same time he went missing.” Frosta explains, “I knew there wouldn’t be a trace of magic on the letters since it’s been so long since they were sent and I didn’t want to give up on him completely so I kept his case in the back of my mind until I could get more information.

“The next case I looked into was Celine Allaire, she was also around my age—and a recent graduate from Beauxbatons Academy of Magic in France, first in her class—her family said she headed to London for an internship at the Ministry. Celine sent a few letters about how exciting London was but one day they stopped coming. Her parents haven’t heard from her in five years.” Frosta furiously pulls out the next article clipping, “Ana Valle—graduate from Castelobruxo—another similar story; she had hopes of being an Obliviator and spoke about moving to London

to work at the Ministry when she stopped sending letters to her family. Ana's been missing for nine years.

"There are more missing persons reports just like these..." Frosta pulls out one particular article clipping—it's littered with creases and folds as if she's fussed over it more than the others. Frosta takes a deep breath before she says, "Alin Barbu: he lived in Busteni, a small town not too far from here. He was homeschooled most of his life but worked his way to the top and got recruited by the Ministry to do financial work; he kept in touch with his family by letter when he got the job but...one day his mum got a letter where Alin went off on a tangent about losing faith in the Ministry and wanting to give it all up. His parents reached out to his supervisor when the letters stopped but all they could tell them was that Alin packed up his office and left. His family hasn't seen him for a couple months."

Catra looks critical as she asks, "how does his case connect to theirs? Everyone else was well accomplished at accredited Universities. Alin sounds like he was only homeschooled with no higher level education."

Frosta argues, "I just…have a feeling that his case is tied to theirs. Plus, aside from his educational background, his story is the same as the rest."

"The Ministry," Bow announces suddenly, holding up his hands in defense when Glimmer sends him a look, "I'm not saying we should get involved, I'm just stating a pattern. Every missing person wrote about having a plush new job at the Ministry and then—poof—they were never heard from again."

Glimmer crosses her arms and huffs, "gee, the Ministry being corrupt? Who would have thought?"

Adora is inclined to agree when something starts nagging at her. Catra notices her discomfort and asks, "what's wrong?"

Adora shakes her head. “Nothing, it's just…the first person who went missing—”

“Bradrick,” Frosta supplies.

Adora nods, “Bradrick...he mentioned getting into the *Auror Academy…”* she turns to Frosta and urges, “what were the Ministry positions the others were looking into?”

Frosta lists verbatim, “Celine had an internship with the Ministry so it could have meant *any* division but Ana said she wanted to be an *Obliviator,* and Alin was working in the *financial* department.”

Adora rubs at her head, muttering to herself, “come on, think...what do all those things have in common?” Aside from them all being Ministry appointed positions, nothing seems to be linking them together.

Okay, Adora takes a deep breath to slow her racing heart, *if I can’t link them all then I should think about the most recent case and go from there.* That leaves her with Alin Barbu. He got a job at the Ministry working in the financial department and only went missing a couple months ago, so whatever happened to him must’ve involved some kind of scandal. *But,* Adora frowns, *the only scandal that was going on was—*

Adora realizes with a start, *my trial…*

The Ministry paraded her through London to dismantle her image once she found out the truth about Mara—it was the *only* thing anyone was talking about. Adora mentally retraces her steps; they were grasping at straws when they were in America, but it all came together once they infiltrated Lonnie’s crime scene and found—

“The *invoice,”* Adora says under her breath.

“What about it?” Catra asks, causing everyone’s head to turn in their direction.

Adora furrows her brow, not sure if she's grasping for straws or if something is actually coming together. "Alin went missing after getting a job in the financial department; he probably took care of lower level stuff as a new recruit so he mainly focused on things like balance sheets, financial statements—"

"—and invoices," Catra frowns. "You think *Mara* had something to do with him going missing?"

Glimmer says wearily, "or maybe we're just looking for someone to blame and she's the easy target, but…Mara's *gone* guys."

"But these people might still be out there," Frosta argues, "*someone* has to fight for them."

Glimmer rubs at her temple. "Let's assume you're all right, and Mara does have something to do with this, where would we even look? She's *dead.* And I'm not going to be the one to use dark magic to wake her from the grave just to have her laugh in our faces at how far of a stretch this is."

Adora racks her brain; she runs through every interaction she's had with Mara prior to her death. Anything that can clue them in on where she's keeping these kids who stumbled across something they shouldn't have.

There's nothing of significance in her memories with Mara before her demise. Adora decides to fast forward. She focuses in on the night she first approached her former mentor. Pain and betrayal try to keep her at bay—in hopes of protecting her from the truth—but Adora pushes forward and *leaps* headfirst into the memory:

"Everyone will see you for what you are."

Mara shakes her head, "no, they won't. All they'll see is you—the golden girl—on the cover of every newspaper for breaking into my office and trying to kill me after I found out the truth about you and Octavia working in cahoots."

Adora slowly pulls her free hand from her pocket without making too much movement. Adora asks, "what are you—"

"Do I need to say it slower for you to understand? I'm framing you." Mara says, "I'd send you to the Bermuda Triangle with the rest of my disappointments—"

There are others who found out? Adora remembers thinking to herself—

"Love," Catra's hand on her shoulder brings her out of the memory. Catra takes in her expression and, based on the pinching of Catra's eyebrows, it doesn't look good. Catra tries to smooth the wrinkles from her face so as to not alarm Adora as she carefully asks, "what do you remember?"

Adora confesses, "the Bermuda Triangle."

"The *what?"* Bow frowns.

Adora hides her shaking hands behind her back—not sure what she might do if she's within reaching distance of her wand. She spits out viciously, "when I snuck out of the flat the night we first got back to London—I went to speak with Mara—she mentioned sending me to the Bermuda Triangle with the rest of her *disappointments.* I remember thinking that it could mean some other people might've found out about her affiliation with Prime but there was so much going on and I—it just *slipped—"*

"This isn't on you," Catra frowns, reaching down to steady her shaking hands.

Adora bites back a rebuttal—not wanting to break down in front of Bow and Glimmer, but especially not in front of Frosta; she looks up to them and Adora knows how painful it is to see your mentors act out of character. Instead, Catra takes over—giving Adora a much needed reprieve. Adora squeezes Catra's hand in a silent *thank you.*

"Bardrick was in the Auror Academy, he could have seen Mara after hours at the Ministry while he was filing papers; maybe he caught her doing something questionable so she took him out of the picture." Catra speculates with startling ease, "and then there's Ana, she was in the Obliviator division which—I can attest to personally—might've led her to see some memories pertaining to Mara that she shouldn't have. Alin could have stumbled across the invoice Mara was trying to keep under wraps and…Celine is the only outlier, but I won't be surprised if we end up finding her at the Bermuda with the rest of Mara's trinkets."

Frosta looks between Catra and Adora with glowing eyes. Frosta nearly squeals, "you guys just solved the case in *minutes."*

Adora frowns. "Nothing's solved until we rescue them."

Glimmer gapes, "you can't honestly be serious right now. You're considering going to the bloody *Bermuda Triangle* without knowing what might be waiting for you out there."

Catra raises an eyebrow. "We've honestly survived worse."

Bow nods, "she's not wrong."

"I tend not to be." Catra quips, grinning.

Glimmer pouts at her fiancé. "Not you too."

"Come on Glim, just look at her," Bow says, gesturing to Frosta. The eighteen year old is in the process of trying to organize her newspaper clippings which keep getting skewed by the wind, ultimately flying from her hands before she remembers she has a wand. Bow turns back to Glimmer once he feels like his point has been made. "She might actually *die* without us. And if Angella finds out you let her best friends daughter go to the *Bermuda Triangle* by herself—"

"I know." Glimmer sighs, glancing in Frosta's direction as the girl finally manages to get the newspaper clippings in order. Glimmer whispers, "I'll go, but only to make sure she doesn't get into any

trouble. The moment things get crazy—I'm taking her out of there."

Catra frowns. "She's not a kid anymore, Sparks, she can hold her own. And look at what she's uncovered by herself, *when* those families have their children returned to them imagine how relieved they'll be. They won't have to *wonder* anymore…" Catra's expression flickers into a mixture of longing.

Adora frowns—not knowing what to make of it.

Bow's voice breaks the air, sounding cheerful all of a sudden despite the dreary topic, "Glim, do you remember those sirens we ran into at work?"

Glimmer's eyes go wide. "Oh yeah!"

Catra looks at them with a weary expression, ear twitching anxiously. "Sirens?"

Bow nods, eager. "We told this story to Adora when she came over for dinner once—it was actually when she got put on Holiday after Lonnie's *death*— but, basically, these sirens were unintentionally causing boats to crash on their beach whenever sailors were nearby. It wasn't their fault, their home just happened to be nearby a popular fishing spot; I was working in the area when I ran into Glimmer—"

"I was with a group of investigators to check it out," Glimmer adds.

"—we solved everyone's problem by having the sirens move to the Bermuda Triangle so they couldn't hurt any more sailors." Bow says, "a lot of magical creatures who are endangered are actually sent to the Bermuda Triangle since it's cloaked with natural magic that hides beings that don't want to be found."

Adora speaks up once her breathing is under control, "so you're saying…even if we get there, we might never find them if they don't want to be found?"

Bow hesitates, "there's a possibility, yes."

Frosta interjects. "But we won't let that happen. We're bringing them home."

"And then, once they're safe, I'm taking *you* home." Glimmer huffs, glaring at Frosta who cowers under the vicious stare. "Honestly, looking into something this big on your own and *stalking* us all the way here once you realized you were in over your head—"

"Hey," Frosta argues, "I did not *stalk* you guys…I used some things I *borrowed* from your room to fuel the locator spell."

"I don't understand," Bow frowns, "why didn't you just *ask* us? You could have sent an owl."

Frosta crosses her arms. Now, it's *her* turn to glare at them as she says, "I *did,* but none of you answer any of my letters."

Bow and Glimmer look away—seemingly guilty—while Adora mutters something about being busy with the case. It's not a complete lie on Adora's end; she's been up to her knees in attending issued public apologies by the Minister of Magic, and while some people are on her side there are others who doubt the authenticity of the trial. The amount of howlers sent to her loft in London became unbearable. After a few days of nasty letters in the mail Catra offered one of her private properties to Adora. She didn't want to overstep but Catra said, with a slanted grin, *there are worse people I could live with.*

"You were ignoring me." Frosta accuses.

Catra snorts out, "obviously."

Glimmer hisses, *"Catra."*

"What? It's true!"

Bow rubs his neck awkwardly. “To be fair, Adora was just on trial for *murder* like not even two months ago.”

Frosta nods sullenly, “if it makes you feel better, I defended you guys no matter what anyone was saying.”

Bow eyes Frosta strangely and asks, “don’t you want to hear about it? Usually you can’t get enough of our stories.”

Frosta waves him off. “Another time, we have other things to focus on.”

Glimmer blinks. “Maybe you *have* grown up, Fross.”

Frosta nods, preening with pride. “I have, and I’ll show you.” She pulls out her wand and tries to twirl it the same way Adora’s seen Catra do just before a vigorous battle. But when Frosta nearly drops her wand in the mud from attempting the swirling trick, she settles for aiming it in the air. Frosta promises, “I’m gonna show you all how much I’ve grown when I duel against—”

“There won’t be any dueling.” Glimmer cuts her off.

Frosta nearly falls over in shock. She holds out her hands—flailing them about—as she corrects her posture before turning to Glimmer with a gasp. “What?” Frosta frowns, “why not?”

Glimmer’s eye twitches. “What part of *I’m getting you home safe* don’t you understand?”

Bow adds, “plus the siren friends we made might already know where Alin and the others are being kept. It should actually be an easy mission for us. Huh, that’s a first,” he mutters.

“The *first* mission I get to go on with the golden quartet and there’s not even gonna be any fighting involved,” Frosta deflates, “...that’s so lame.”

Glimmer grins. “Welcome to the team. As a *temporary* member.”

Bow stands up as he carefully cradles the baby dragon that led them to Frosta's discovery. He rocks it gently and for a moment Adora thinks *he'll be a great dad one day.* And judging by the smitten look on Glimmer's face, she agrees.

"What about this guy?" Bow asks.

"I might've spooked it when I was running around looking for you guys," Frosta admits sheepishly. "But I'd leave it where I found it if I were you, I think the mum just went off for a quick nighttime snack. So we should probably go before she or the gargoyles find us holding the baby."

Bow carefully places the baby back inside the mini bundle of leaves that suddenly looks *very* nest-like. He stands and dusts the dirt from his hands when a sudden rustling from the same bundle of bushes they came through earlier gets their attention. Adora holds out her arm and stops Frosta from reacting when she sees the girl aim her wand in the direction of the noise. Frosta frowns, confused as to why she's being held back but Adora waits patiently—already familiar with the heavy footfalls.

Huntara looks panicked as she bursts through the bundle of leaves with sweat dripping from her brow as she whispers to herself "...I'll never be able to show my face in London if they find out I *lost* the golden brats—"

"Huntara," Catra says, gaining their tour guide's attention. Catra grins, "it's *so* nice to know you care about us."

Huntara frowns, "you're alive…"

"Are we not supposed to be?" Bow asks wearily, hand twitching towards his wand—a survival instinct Adora thought he'd lost after the war.

Adora nods at him in silent approval, glad to know the instinct is still present.

“I wasn’t expecting anything good after I came out of my tent and found you all missing without a trace.” Huntara finally notices the outlier, “what are *you* doing here?”

Glimmer rubs her forehead muttering, “not this again. Huntara, this is Frosta. A friend of ours who somehow followed us in.”

“Some security.” Catra taunts under her breath, earning a glare from Huntara while Frosta snickers into her hand. And while Adora normally plays the mediator between her girlfriend and the people she pisses off, this time she chooses to leave it alone.

Ever since they stepped foot inside this sanctuary Catra’s been acting strange. Adora doesn’t know what has her so spooked but she’s glad to see Catra getting back to some form of normalcy even if it’s only for a moment.

Huntara frowns. “Great, now I’ve got four golden brats *and* a younger brat.”

Bow tries to soften the blow, “if it makes you feel better, we’re heading out tomorrow.”

Huntara looks up, curious. “Why?”

“Their assistance is needed elsewhere,” Frosta says with her arms crossed.

Huntara *fumes,* “oh, so the Dragon Sanctuary is too good for you?”

“Yes.” Frosta nods.

“No!” Bow interrupts, taking the floor while Glimmer puts a hand over Frosta’s mouth to keep her quiet. Bow explains, “an issue was just brought to our attention and it’s something that can’t wait. But if it’s okay with you, we’d like to stay the night and get some rest before making any plans. We *very much* appreciate the opportunity we’ve been granted.” Huntara eyes Bow to check the validity of his apology.

After a moment Huntara gives them a stiff nod—accepting the olive branch—but not without sending Frosta a nasty look. “Alright,” Huntara says, “let's get back to camp and then tomorrow I’ll lead you back to the front gate.”

“We have to hike back *down* the hill?” Glimmer looks like she might cry.

Huntara shakes her head. “No, we’ll take the jeep since it seems like you’re pressed for time.”

Glimmer’s eye twitches. “There’s a *jeep?”*

Adora trails behind the others as their tour guide leads them back to the campfire; she dutifully tunes out Glimmer and Huntara’s squabbling so she can get lost in her thoughts. She doesn’t get far.

Frosta joins Adora at her side; Adora raises an eyebrow and asks, “what’s up?”

Frosta clears her throat; in a low voice she says, “nothing it’s just —I know it didn’t really have anything to do with me but...I’m sorry I couldn’t do more during your trial.”

Adora frowns. “You’re right, it didn’t have anything to do with you. So there’s nothing you could have done. Besides…” Adora looks over at Catra with a smile, chest growing warm as she watches her bicker with Melog, “I was in good hands.”

“You two are gross,” Frosta makes a face, “I like it better when all you did was argue.”

Adora smiles at the distant memory of Frosta’s first visit to Hogwarts; Adora was in her sixth year minding her business when she caught Catra getting into some trouble. Long story short, she and Catra got into a small duel while Glimmer was showing Frosta around. Ever since then, Frosta’s been enamored with them and their exploits.

“I’m serious,” Adora feels the need to stress, “there’s nothing you could’ve done.”

Frosta makes a disgruntled face but otherwise doesn’t bring up any more grievances.

They make it back to camp without incident; Huntara barks out a few more warnings and, this time, she makes sure everyone is accounted for before bed.

Frosta wishes them a good night before she goes to set up a tent for herself. Adora makes sure Frosta’s settled before slipping inside her own tent. She spots Catra digging through her bag in the corner while Melog lounges around nearby. When Adora settles beneath the covers Melog suddenly decides to make themself scarce.

Catra’s ear twitches as Melog slips from the tent; she waves her hand, summoning a silencing spell with ease. The quiet washes over them—a brief moment of reprieve before the start of a conversation Adora isn’t sure she’s ready to have.

Catra sits beside her cross-legged, leaning her face into the palm of her hand and starts off easy with a simple, “you okay?”

Adora flips on her back and stares at the stars through their tents' transparent ceiling. She confesses, “not really.”

Catra starts, “it’s not your fault—“

“They’ve been missing for *years,* Catra. And nobody noticed.” Adora growls; magic leaks from her core until it coats the room in *charged* potential energy. She clenches her fists in an attempt to redirect her frustrations elsewhere but their portable lantern light flickers with her rage. Adora closes her eyes, “I shouldn’t have killed her. I should’ve kept her alive so I could extract as much information from her as possible—she was too valuable to Prime’s mission for me to let her off the hook.”

“Kidnapping?” Catra snorts. “Come on, that’s not your style.”

Adora turns to Catra—eyes set ablaze—and asks, "what would you have done?"

Catra doesn't look startled, instead, she seems lost in thought as she tries to answer the question honestly. After some time, she shrugs. Catra offers, "I probably would've killed her."

"Then we're in the same boat." Adora sighs.

"We're not," Catra frowns, "you didn't mean to kill Mara. Even with everything she did, you still had some hope of bringing back even a *flicker* of the woman you thought you knew. That's just who you are—you don't give up on people."

"Yeah," Adora whispers, "well maybe I should."

"Hey, hey." Catra grabs her by the chin until their eyes are locked. Catra levels her with a cold stare, "you don't want to go down that road. Trust me. We've each seen *terrible* things and have probably done a lot worse, but the only thing that saves us from becoming like the monsters we chase is our desire to be different. So don't let go of that feeling you always have in the pit of your stomach whenever you're placed in that position. It might seem like a weakness but it's actually your greatest strength."

Adora searches Catra's eyes; she has to ask, "you said you'd kill her." Adora frowns, "why wouldn't you keep Mara alive for questioning if you had the chance? It seems like that's usually your go-to move."

Adora hasn't even pressed Catra about the whereabouts of Allister. Even after the trial the Minister deemed Allister's missing person's case closed until further information was brought to their attention.

Catra smiles to herself—a strange expression for such a topic, but Adora isn't afraid. *We both have scars,* Adora unconsciously touches her chest where the *failsafe* mark is etched into her skin. It still burns on some occasions. Almost as if Prime is growing

stronger—no. Not Prime himself but his number of believers. His *followers.*

"It depends," Catra answers, "for different *opponents* I change things up. And normally I believe they can be of use to me in the long run but someone like Mara…" Catra's brow furrows, "she was a Prime Loyalist from the very *beginning,* maybe even as far as our Hogwarts days. And that's a scary thought; to have someone like that freely entering the school—manipulating the minds of the students…she might've even done some recruiting when Angella's back was turned."

Adora tightens her fist, recalling the fateful day when Mara approached her after the werewolf incident with DT—the *hope* Mara inspired in her to become an Auror. *How close was I to being recruited?* Adora shivers at the thought.

Catra goes on, "someone that ruthless and devoted to Prime wouldn't be of use to me, they'd be a liability. There's no sure way I can put a time frame on Mara's time spent serving Prime and with her loyalties I doubt she would even give me correct information; you saw for yourself how I protected some of your memories before you approached her at the Ministry. Who's to say Mara didn't have a similar setup? If anything she'd be luring me into a trap—a false sense of security fluffed with fabrications of the truth."

Catra adds, "and there's no hope for reform. Not with her."

"Some people can't be saved." Adora summarizes.

Catra nods. "But Alin and the others can be. The past *sucks,* but right now we have to keep moving forward and focus on what we can change. And maybe," Catra trails off, breaking into that far off stare again, "...we'll get some answers once and for all."

"Answers?" Adora sits up; she doesn't think Catra's referring to Alin and the others.

Catra blinks out of her daze and clears her throat; she offers a soft, "I got my closure at Finn's memorial…maybe by rescuing Alin and the others you can finally set Mara's story to rest and finally get some closure. It doesn't trump the other shitty things she's done—or put to rest the fears of there being more of her secrets out there—but it could help."

Adora has another question on her tongue but the slump of Catra's shoulders makes her choose otherwise. *Another time.* Adora scoots over and opens the sleeping bag; Catra curls up beside her and presses her head into the space between Adora's neck. After a moment Melog reappears and takes the spot at the foot of the sleeping bag. Adora tightens her hold on Catra—hoping her actions speak loud enough for the both of them. But, she worries not—

Time will reveal.

Dragon Sanctuary, Romania

(minutes before Frosta's arrival)

"Damn it," Catra scowls, letting loose an array of profanities as Adora slips further into the darkness with only a *faint* magical signature for Catra to trace. *Stupid Huntara and her dumb no magic rule.* The further away Adora gets—the *louder* the voice becomes.

Mewl! Melog tries to get her attention, urgently bunting at her leg as Catra willingly changes directions. *Adora can handle herself.* She slips past Melog—ignoring their insistent begging. The further she gets to the *voice,* the weaker her bond with Melog becomes and soon—right as she's at the edge of the unknown—all she can understand from Melog are incoherent mewls and whimpers. And even with their connection temporarily broken Melog stays at her side; forever the loyal familiar. Catra makes a note to thank them later.

Grrr, Melog growls—fur turning jagged and red as beady eyes glow in the dark.

Catra doesn't need the dragon to step out from the shadows. She recognizes those eyes from earlier. "Emerald," she says.

There's rustling in the dark but Emerald doesn't reveal herself. Instead, a scoff follows. *"You didn't seem interested in me earlier."*

"I was spooked," Catra licks her lips and says, "it's not everyday you have a bloody *dragon* trying to break through your mental guards. And it isn't the first time, the Gringott's Dragon—"

"—his name is Falkor." Emerald corrects with a snarl.

Catra shrugs. *"Falkor."*

Melog's insistent growl sends the hair on the back of Catra's neck standing. And while their connection may be broken for the moment, Catra's still good at reading her familiar. And so, almost instinctively, she throws up a protection spell just in time for a *hot* puff of air to escape Emerald's nose. The heat meets the cool air —altering its chemical composition into ash and soot that settles atop Catra's barrier for the time being.

Emerald taunts, *"you've got a lot of pride for someone who's coming to me for answers."*

Catra shakes her head, biting back a growl of her own. But it doesn't matter; Melog wears her emotions on their sleeve for her. "I'm not the one who's been reaching out to—"

"Your magic knows your true desires and so it acts accordingly," Emerald reveals, *"so whatever ghost you thought was haunting you is only just a product of your own delusions. You did this all yourself. Your magic called out to me—and your magic weakened your bond with your familiar so we could have this conversation—all because you have questions. All because Falkor told you how you can find the truth about your lineage."*

Catra falters, unwilling to completely believe her magic has betrayed her in such a way. She's spent *years* perfecting her craft and to have such a weakness... *I'll work on it later.* Catra tilts her head up and stares into glowing eyes; she confesses, "Falkor told me to go to the Bermuda Triangle if I wanted my questions answered."

Emerald grunts out a conformation. *"Then I don't see why you're wasting your time with me when you already know where you have to go…or maybe you're afraid to find out the truth."*

"Falkor was actually serious?"

"Dragons don't jest."

Catra shakes her head—refusing to believe the answers to all her questions are just a few bounds away. "The Bermuda Triangle is a waste land," Catra whispers, "a place for people who don't want to be found."

"So it is fear that makes you hesitant." Emerald taunts, " *and were you not heading in that direction anyway? Is that not the reason for your string pulling?"*

Catra doesn't have a satisfying answer that'll appease any of them.

Emerald's eyes seem to go up higher as she stands, preparing to leave. But before she goes, she leaves Catra with a piece of advice. *"...go to the center of the Bermuda Triangle where the bonds that tie us to this world are at its weakest. There, you'll find your answers."*

Emerald's heavy footsteps grow light until Catra is left alone in the dark. Her heart begins to race—legs buckling—but her body slowly relaxes as her connection to Melog is restored. Her familiar nudges her knee and comforts her. Suddenly, it doesn't seem as dark anymore. A spark calls out to her—Adora's magical signature, forever a beacon ready to guide Catra back home.

The Bermuda Triangle is where she has to go. She's known for a while. *But,* Catra frowns, *it's the place where people go when they wish to be hidden...*

Catra just hopes that, when the time comes, Adora will be her beacon and lead her back home.

Chapter End Notes

> Catra unfortunately always does ambitious scheming on the side because it's just the way her mind works; even when she's on Holiday she wants to tie up loose ends. And if anyone's wondering, the mission Bow and Glimmer spoke about with the sirens was actually mentioned in Chapter One. I thought it was cool how things from the beginning are starting to tie into the issues going on now; it kind of hints at the end of the story because things are starting to come full circle. It's bittersweet but I've also got some great chapters ahead that I'm excited for you all to read and we'll also have the Prequel shortly (immediately) after the end of this story so it won't all be bad.
>
> I mentioned before that Bow's perspective was nice because Adora and Catra are the main focus so it's harder to hide things when I have them telling the story from their view. But what's great about this chapter is Adora has her suspicions about Catra but then Frosta brings them this juicy mystery on a silver platter and Adora can't refuse. Now Adora's distracted with tying up her own loose ends with Mara so she's not in the mental mindset to fully analyze Catra to the point where she gets to the bottom of what's haunting her girlfriend. Just like Catra needs to work on letting people in, Adora has to work on not letting work be her main focus to the point where it distracts her from everything else around her.
>
> Anyway, I was up a couple nights ago coming up with ideas for the Prequel and somehow I outlined the entire story (which will still be subject to change as it progresses). Right

now I’m 98% sure the name will be “Exploits of Power: The Champion”.

Bermuda Trinkets

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

15

North Atlantic Ocean

25.0000° N, 71.0000° W

Woosh! Catra clutches the mattress so viciously the fabric buckles beneath her claws and gives with a jagged tear. Another wave causes the ship to awkwardly shuffle; the motion sends the bed Catra is strapped to sliding across the room until it slams into a nearby desk. Melog, who has chosen to be a loyal companion and brave this storm with her, is in a similar position at the foot of the mattress; their fur is a sickly green—a *very* telling indication of how Catra feels at the moment. The unwelcome reminder sends her stomach tossing.

When the ship hits another wave Catra finally submits and presses her right palm into her stomach. Her palm is laced with healing magic to help her adjust to the motions of the sea but she uses it sparingly as to save her magic for later.

As the spell does its job, Catra shoots up from the bed with a gasp. A moment of clarity strikes and Catra is reminded of Adora warning her about it being worse below the deck of the ship. Catra looks at the circle shaped window where the murky sky greets her, *it doesn't look too bad from this angle.* Catra considers rejoining the group when the thorn in her side sings from the top deck—

"La, la, la, la…"

Catra growls, contemplating just burrowing her head beneath the nearby pillow, before she leaps from the bed with determination.

The ship moves against her, sending her into the wall but Catra works with it and latches on—using it to guide her to the steps. Melog dutifully follows her to the top deck where the singing grows louder.

"For the love of Merlin," Catra shouts as she graces the five other occupants, "can someone *shut* him up?"

"I've tried." Glimmer whispers under her breath in disdain. She pales in comparison to her fiancé who is staring at the mustached man with sparkling eyes.

"Ah! My dear friend, you've finally graced us with your presence." Seahawk reaches for his lute and works on tuning it accordingly. He promises, "I won't leave you out of our next carol..."

Adora races over and holds Catra back from doing something she might regret. "Seahawk, don't you think you should keep an eye out?" Adora asks, trying to stop a homicide.

"Yeah!" Bow squeaks out when Glimmer nudges him. Bow clears his throat and says, "you're gonna be our only indicator that the sirens are nearby so we need you to have your guard up."

"Can someone explain the plan to me again?" Frosta asks with a small notepad ready—the same one she's been using to take notes religiously from the moment they set foot on Seahawk's ship. Catra had managed to snatch the notepad once when Frosta's guard was down; inside were a bunch of observations on the golden quartet's *strategy* and how she can implement it for future endeavors.

Glimmer sighs at their younger counterpart, "don't you have it written down already?"

"It's fine, I don't mind going over it again." Bow says before he turns to Frosta to explain the plan once more. "Like I said before, I've already been exposed to the sirens; when I first came across them I took a potion that dulls the effects of their thrall and once it's in your system it sticks. But Seahawk hasn't taken the potion,

so he'll fall for the thrall which will let us know when we're getting close. Once we find the sirens we'll ask if they've seen Alin and the others."

Frosta nods eagerly, "using Seahawk as a siren detector... *brilliant."* Frosta quickly jots something down on the notepad while Catra frowns in silent disapproval; she has intentions of calling Frosta out when the ship *lurches* and sends Catra flailing from Adora's arms until her back hits the railing.

"I *hate* the ocean," Catra groans, clutching the railing for dear life.

"You really weren't kidding about being seasick." Frosta says, looking over at Catra with a frown. "Why not use your magic if it's that uncomfortable."

Catra sighs, "I've been through worse, and I need to save my magic for when we get there."

"You think we'll run into some trouble?" Adora asks—already at Catra's side with a hand rubbing soothing circles on her lower back.

Catra shrugs. "Not sure. But with our luck, we will."

Seahawk rubs his chin and mutters, "it's a good thing my darling Mermista stayed back for this one."

"I still think that was a bad call on our part," Glimmer mutters in which Catra nods in silent agreement because Mermista might be the only buffer for Seahawk and his shenanigans *(boat arson).*

Bow asks, "how is she by the way?"

Seahawk preens. "She's *wonderful.* Her latest novel is a best seller, that's why she couldn't join us on such late notice; she's having a book signing today and after she's swamped with project meetings."

“Oh yeah, I bet she’s got a lot on her plate...” Bow scratches the back of his neck nervously saying, “and thanks again for agreeing to do this. We tried to get our own boat but none of us would’ve had a clue what we were doing and you’re the only person we know who has experience at sea. I hope we aren’t taking up too much of your time.”

Seahawk shakes his head, grinning. “Nonsense, what’s a favor between mates?” Catra withholds a snark, recalling how Mermista made them all promise to purchase a copy of her book before allowing access to Seahawk’s services.

But, ulterior motives aside, Seahawk is an old friend who’s granted them access to his ship on various occasions. The first instance happened sometime during the quartet's sixth year at Hogwarts; after sneaking out past curfew—with hopes of finding more information about *Horcruxes* and how it related to Prime—they missed the local ferry but thankfully Seahawk was heading in the same direction. At the time Seahawk was only a sailor in training and, unbeknownst to the quartet, had taken his mentor's ship out without permission—all because he wanted a group of friends to call his own and thought doing them a favor was a step in the right direction. In the end, they managed to get the intel they needed on Prime but not without Seahawk setting a few ships on fire as a distraction when things took a turn.

Catra shivers, recalling Seahawk’s novice steering.

Almost on cue, another wave rocks the ship; Catra digs her claws deeper into the wood of the railing to keep herself from being propelled again. She groans, slamming her head down so she doesn’t get lost in the hypnotic sea. *This is what I get for rushing out of Romania,* Catra chastises herself. Though, she has to admit, it was hysterical to see Huntara blow a fuse during their abrupt departure—mumbling nonsense about them not respecting the Dragon Sanctuary.

“I hope this story is better than her last novel,” Glimmer says with a shiver, “I had to sleep with my wand under my pillow for *weeks*

—"

"Do normal people not already do that?" Adora asks Catra in a low voice to which Catra shrugs, perplexed herself.

"—it was so spooky." Glimmer finishes.

Bow nods thoughtfully. "It was, but the ending was nice...despite the circumstances."

"It was a little bittersweet," Glimmer admits.

"Seahawk." Bow asks, curious, "what did you think about it?"

Seahawk answers groggily, "it's *wonderful",* but his glazed over eyes are lost to the sea.

Bow stands beside Seahawk and tries to follow his line of sight. He asks, "what's wonderful?"

"The music!" Seahawk exclaims in awe, "can't you hear it? It rivals anything I've ever heard."

Catra, still desperately hanging to the railing, gives Bow a subtle nod. In response, Bow urges Seahawk to guide them in the direction of the music—gaining instant compliance. Catra and the others lean against the railing—everyone at different angles—looking out for the sirens. In the mist of their search a strange fog surrounds them—almost locking them in place. *That wasn't here earlier,* Catra notes just as she almost gets pushed off the ship when Seahawk rushes to her side, frantic. Bow casts a binding spell on Seahawk to keep him from going overboard as he chases the thrall.

Clank! The ship comes to an abrupt stop in the center of the mist. Catra looks down, trying to see if they've hit a stone pillar, but it's hard to see through the thick fog. *Wait,* Catra gives up her hopeless plight when her magic reacts to a powerfully *twisted* core. *Ancient magic.* It encases the area.

Adora joins Catra at her side. “You feel it too?”

Catra nods. “Yeah. *Ancient* magic—the same one that probably cursed them all those years ago.” Despite what it may seem like, Catra does listen when Bow goes off on his tangents about magical creatures and such. She specifically recalls Bow explaining how sirens are just witches who were cursed with a spell that prevents them from getting close to anyone. A cruel fate.

Catra decides on a whim, “I can track them from here.”

“You’re not going alone,” Adora frowns, already grabbing Catra’s arm to stop her from doing anything stupid. But before Adora can chastise her girlfriend any further, the ship *rattles* and shakes—sending the occupants sliding to the back of the deck in a large heap of bodies. Catra is the only one who remains at the front—her claws still embedded in the wood—while Adora and the others flail helplessly, trying to right their footing, as the ship begins to sink.

Catra curses. *The sirens probably put a hole in the ship when we stopped.* “Bow!” Catra exclaims, “mind calling off your friends?”

“Working on it.” Bow responds, already casting a spell on his feet to help him walk up the inclined ship.

“Frosta!” Catra orders, “go to the bottom and plug up the hole!”

Frosta gives her a curt nod before she staggers to her feet and makes her way below the deck with her wand drawn. By the time Frosta disappears down the steps, Bow has reached Catra. He leans over the railing with his wand ready and shouts so loud it echoes across the sea—

“Lumos!”

Catra shields her eyes as a bright light breaks through the fog screen—stretching out further than any simple light charm could ever be capable of. Catra grins at the showcase of magic. *He’s definitely one of us.* Her reprieve is cut short as she spots

something in the distance; a small island with a *beautiful* woman lying in the sand. The woman's features morph into something painstakingly familiar—calling out to Catra, edging her into a storm. She wears *Adora's* face.

Catra shakes her head, forcing herself to stay present; she focuses on embracing Adora's magical signature behind her. It keeps her grounded on reality. And soon, the siren is revealed as a ghastly creature with scars littering her face—hair matted and skewed. *That was too close.* While men are more susceptible to the thrall of a siren, women are at threat too. Bow offered Catra the potion to help dampen the thrall but Catra declined; she's confident in her ability to resist and doesn't favor potions mixing with her own magical signature unless she has to.

Bow leans over the railing and waves his hand frantically. "Beatrice!" He grins, face slightly flushed—a small indication of the siren impacting him even with the use of the potion.

Beatrice's scowl slips into one of surprise. *"Bow?"*

Bow grins, waving eagerly in response.

Glimmer finally makes her way over and shouts in a greeting, "hey girl! Long time no see!"

"Glimmer too?" Beatrice laughs, "I'm not surprised. You two are a package deal."

Seahawk shoots up at the sirens' laughter but the magical bindings send him falling back to the ground. Adora scoops him up and feeds him the potion to dull the sirens' thrall once she deems it appropriate.

When the ship shudders once more Catra asks in a hasty voice, "this reunion is nice and all but do you mind telling her friends to *stop* trying to drown us?"

"Beatrice!" Bow shouts, "can you call off your friends?"

Beatrice's face contorts into shame. She nods eagerly before leaping into the water; her blue scales rippling beneath the light and sea until she is lost entirely. A few moments later she emerges with the sirens who were most likely responsible for damaging the ship; they glare at the occupants on the ship—tempted—but after a few curt words from Beatrice they disappear into the water.

"What are you doing here?" Beatrice asks. "I know it's not just to visit me."

Glimmer looks guilty, "you're right, this isn't a social call; we're actually on a mission to find some missing people who were sent here. We were hoping if we gave you a picture you might have an idea of where they are."

Beatrice sulks deeper into the water. "You know the Bermuda Triangle is a place people go when they *don't* want to be found. I have to respect the wishes of the occupants."

"And if they were sent here against their will?" Adora demands. "Does your logic still hold?"

Beatrice frowns, not sure what to say.

"Please." Bow urges. "Their families are worried and we don't think we can find them without your help."

"I've never seen any *people* be sent here, but...if it's true what you're saying—about them being forced to be here—then they're probably at the center of the triangle. I've heard that spot is the most dangerous—it likes to lock people away, draining them of their magic until nothing more remains of who they once were. Their ties become *broken."* Beatrice shudders, "I've seen a lot of creatures go there and never return. I don't know what happens once you cross the barrier so I can only point which direction for you to go. I can't show you the way, I'm sorry…"

Glimmer nods. "It's okay, we understand."

“I don’t think you do.” Beatrice frowns. “Are these people worth risking *everything* that keeps you tethered to this world?”

In the end, no one has a clear answer, but their actions speak for them as the group pushes forward in the direction that Beatrice points. Bow keeps his light spell alive to guide them through the fog which seems to thicken as they get closer to the center of the triangle. And it’s at this moment that Catra’s reminded of Emerald’s promise—for her questions to be answered. Catra keeps her gaze locked ahead even as the group talks amongst themselves—going over details of the case to assist them in their search. But Catra doesn’t need to do that; she’s studied this case front to back, obsessively.

“I see something!” Bow alerts the crew, stretching his *Lumos* further to get a better view.

Catra and Frosta gather on Bow’s end of the ship and stare out into the sea. Their new location lands them in a strange terrain; island fractures clutter the murky sea. Catra begins to ask Bow what he spotted when a flash of movement in her peripheral catches her attention. Catra quickly spots what has him transfixed —a humanlike figure. The person staggers on an island piece—losing themself in the fog.

“We’re losing them,” Frosta urges.

“Then I’ll go after them.” Catra decides.

“You’re not going alone.” Bow frowns. “Frosta and I will go with you. Seahawk,” he turns to the sailor and asks, “can you stay with the ship? If anything goes wrong I'll send a flare for help.”

Adora interrupts, “I’m going too.”

“Same.” Glimmer agrees.

“...Adora should come with us,” Bow says after giving it some thought, “she has more experience in the field.”

Glimmer shoots back, “why can’t I—“

Bow interrupts, “because this isn’t a safe place to stop, if something goes wrong—if something tries to get on the ship—Seahawk will need help keeping this thing afloat; he’s not used to combat like the rest of us. *You* should stay with him—”

“I’m not letting you go by yourself.” Glimmer argues, red in the face.

Bow hugs Glimmer tight, pressing a kiss to her forehead. He promises, “I’ll be okay—I’m part of the *golden quartet,* remember? I’m stronger than I seem. And I won’t be alone.” He gestures to Catra and Adora explicitly.

Adora joins the hug between Bow and Glimmer; she says, “we’ll bring him back.”

“*You* better come back too.” Glimmer says before her eyes flick over in Catra’s direction. Glimmer’s expression morphs into something akin to mischief causing Catra’s fur to bristle. “Group hugs are mandatory, arsehole.” Catra makes a show of rolling her eyes but gives in and joins the fray.

Catra pulls away from the hug once enough time has been allotted and looks to her familiar who’s pouting at her feet. Catra smiles softly and kneels down until they’re eye level with one another. “Take care of Glimmer and the caroling lunatic, okay?”

Mwr, Melog whimpers. Catra herself shares a shiver in sympathy as she feels her bond between her familiar weaken once more. *Sorry buddy,* Catra decides, *I’ve got to do this one on my own.* A thrall more powerful than any siren tugs on Catra—urging her in its direction.

“Hey.” Adora whispers with a frown. “You ready?”

Catra rubs Melog’s head one more time before she rises. “Yeah, let’s bring them home.”

“We just have to find a safe way to get down there.” Frosta mutters, rubbing her chin as she contemplates their options. “Maybe Seahawk can bring the ship closer to one of the island patches and then we’ll use a hovering spell to get us down safely?” Frosta grins at her quick problem solving—looking to the golden quartet to gauge their opinions.

Bow nods. “Good idea, Seahawk let’s—”

“That’ll take too long,” Catra decides; her eyes skim the terrain and she quickly pieces together a plan of execution. The only hindrance is her stomach—it’s still in knots over the motions of the sea but there’s an easy fix. Catra swiftly gathers magic into her palm before slapping it to her stomach; she jerks forward with a choked gasp—the remnants of seasickness leaving her. Once her equilibrium returns, Catra leaps onto the railing and calls over her shoulder, “follow me.”

Glimmer exclaims, “how are you—”

Catra jumps off the ship without looking back, ignoring their startled cries. As she falls, Catra reaches into her jacket and retrieves her wand.

“Glacius!” Catra shouts, wand outstretched as she aims the frost torrent out in front—freezing a portion of the sea. Catra lands on the ice with a *crunch* and wastes no time aiming her wand to carve an icy path towards a nearby island.

Crunch! Catra looks over her shoulder and isn’t surprised to see Adora’s the first to catch up with her. Adora has her wand out, using it as a flashlight; she sends Catra a slanted grin.

“Showing off?” Adora teases, “we’re already living together—”

“I’m *not* showing off,” Catra splutters.

“—you don’t have to try so hard to impress me anymore.” Adora finishes with a grin.

Thankfully, Adora's teasing is laid to rest when Frosta joins them with an awed expression. "That was a great use of an ice spell," Frosta mutters to herself—plucking out her notebook to write down some new notes.

Catra waits for Bow to join them on the ice before she leads them to the closet island. "Don't fall behind, I'm not gonna waste more energy keeping this alive too long so the earlier ice will melt." Adora keeps close to her and thankfully doesn't bring up Catra's earlier display; while it may have seemed like Catra was showing off—in reality—she was being *hasty.*

Catra shakes the thoughts away and tries to be present; she keeps the ice spell alive until she reaches the island. Bow is the last to join them and once he's safely on the sand, the ice melts into the sea.

"I saw the figure go this way," Bow gestures to a thick patch of fog, "but my eyes could've been playing tricks on me. Do we have an easier way of knowing?"

Frosta suggests, "we can use one of Alin's letters to fuel a locator spell…but it's been a couple months since he wrote it and his magical trace might be gone."

"It's better than walking around aimlessly." Adora supplies.

Frosta pulls out the letter and uses her wand to cast a locator spell on the parchment; the paper glows bright yellow, coming to life as it floats above Frosta's hand. Frosta grins, enthused by the revelation, but it's short lived as the yellow glow is suddenly tainted by a gray substance. The paper shrivels in the air—falling into a ball in Frosta's palm.

"...what happened?" Frosta frowns.

Catra gestures to the island they inhabit. "The triangle hides people who don't want to be found...maybe Alin and the others have given up hope."

“Or they think the alternative is worse,” Adora mutters, “Mara must’ve threatened them about what might happen if they escape. When we find them we have to be careful—any wrong wording might scare them back into hiding.”

Bow suggests, “our best bet is following after the person we saw earlier.” He steps over a strange block of wood and in turn it convulses. Catra’s eyes go wide.

“Stupefy!” Catra exclaims, stunning the *dugbog* before it can attack. Catra looks around the island and is startled to see *dozens* more wooden logs littering the sand. Catra warns, “this place is surrounded by dugbog's—be on guard.”

Frosta frowns. “What are dugbog’s?”

“Stupefy!” Adora shouts, knocking out a dugbog that was creeping up on Frosta’s left. “Stay close to me,” Adora says, pulling Frosta to her side as she eyes the terrain. Adora explains, “dugbog’s are a type of magical creature that looks like a piece of wood when they’re just sitting around but when they’re ready to attack they shift into a crocodile.”

On cue, the pseudo-wood logs begin to morph into 6ft long crocodiles; they snap their jaws as their noses pick up on the odd magical signatures. Catra’s back hits Bow’s; they stand pressed against each other with their wands drawn as the creatures circle around—separating them from Adora and Frosta.

Bow gasps, “I see them!” Sure enough, the human-like figure is staggering through the fog up ahead. At the same time, Catra feels a familiar thrall calling her in the same direction.

Catra looks over at Adora and shares a curt nod—silently cuing her into her plan. Adora frowns—seemingly not a fan—but she nods back and shoots a nasty hex at the crocodiles circling her and Bow. It gets the crocodiles’ attention and soon most of them are turning their attention to Adora and Frosta.

“Let’s go,” Catra urges Bow; she carves a path through the roadblock with a couple hexes. She and Bow come out clean on the other side and chase the figure.

Catra’s always been the fastest on the team so she’s ahead of Bow; she loses herself in the thrall and—unknowingly—the fog as well. She doesn’t notice how far she’s gone until she realizes Bow is no longer visible behind her. She’s alone at the center of the triangle with no Melog or Adora to keep her tethered.

“I’m over here,” the thrall whispers in her ear.

Catra picks up her pace—pushing ever forward even as her feet sink deeper into the sand. *It’s just up ahead…* Catra is dead set on leaping headfirst into the unknown when a shrill *scream* echoes from the right. She whips around with her wand drawn and finds Alin cornered by two dugbog’s—they snap their jaws at him, sending a shudder through his body as he helplessly backpedals. And it’s *clear* what she should do right now; her *purpose* should be to rescue Alin and then save the others but—

Catra makes a sharp left—leaving Alin to fend for himself—while she selfishly chases after the thrall. Unfortunately, the voice of reason comes in the shape of Bow; his voice is *molten* as he shouts from behind her, *“Catra!”*

Catra stops in her tracks—her magic threatens to lash out but somehow she manages to keep it in check. With a steady breath, Catra spins around to meet Bow’s cold stare. No words are shared. Catra races over to Alin and together she and Bow fend off the two dugbog’s. And even when the threat is extinguished, Alin flinches back—falling on his arse, scrambling back in the sand wearing a *haunted* expression.

Bow’s cold stare melts into something gentle. He kneels down and carefully offers a hand to Alin saying, “we’re here to help you…I swear.”

Alin darts his eyes between Catra and Bow; his brows pinch together and suddenly magic—a portion he's probably stored away for a moment like this—shoots from his core.

"Stupefy," Catra says quickly—knocking Alin out before he can lash out.

Bow catches the stunned man; he checks on his vitals before carefully laying him down in the sand. The hair on the back of Catra's neck stands on end as she feels Bow's magic flare up in aggression. With a sigh, Catra pockets her wand and prepares herself for the argument that's sure to come. It doesn't take long; Bow stands abruptly and turns to her with a frown.

"What was that?" Bow's voice slices the air.

Catra's finger twitches—instinctively, she gathers magic in case she's not able to get her wand in time.

"I had to knock him out," Catra says with a shrug, "he was about to attack us. He's been trapped here for months so—"

"Don't." Bow demands, cutting off her rant. "You *know* that's not what I meant. You've been acting weird since the end of Adora's trial; you went on these random long walks when we were in Italy —"

"Oh," Catra deadpans, "is that a crime now?"

Bow swiftly ignores her sarcasm and continues as if uninterrupted. "—you were spaced out at the Dragon Sanctuary, and now you almost let Alin *die* at the claws of those dugbog's…so just tell me, why are we here, Catra?"

A cold breeze creeps up on them. Catra stares at Bow—not sure if she'll tell the truth this time or come up with something that's close enough to leave him complacent. Before she can decide, Adora and Frosta choose this moment to catch up to them.

Frosta leans over as she catches her breath. “Man, I’m out of shape…” her gaze flicks over to Alin’s limp form. “Alin! Is he okay?”

“Just stunned.” Catra says, not taking her eyes off Bow. “He got a little rowdy when we found him so I had to knock him out. We can question him about the others when he wakes up.”

Frosta kneels down beside Alin with a sigh. “Finally some good news.”

Adora stands next to Catra, quickly noticing the tension in the air. Adora carefully asks, “what’s going on?”

“Ask Catra.” Bow snaps, “this is her favorite part after all—watching her plans come together.”

Adora’s magic spikes protectively. “Bow…”

He glances at Adora—there’s a small flash of hurt behind his eyes but otherwise he doesn’t look surprised to see her sticking up for Catra. He shrugs it off and turns back to Catra and asks, “when we were at the Dragon Sanctuary you disappeared right before Frosta showed up. Where did you go?”

Catra frowns. “I told you what happened.”

“And I don't believe you.” Bow shoots back.

“Stop!” Frosta exclaims, jumping between the golden crew with her arms outstretched.

Bow looks at Catra and then to Frosta’s protective stance. He shakes his head in disbelief as everything starts coming together. “I can’t believe this…you’re working a case, aren’t you?” Bow accuses, turning his gaze back to Catra as he makes the accusation.

“She’s not.” Frosta argues before Catra can speak, “I didn’t lie to you guys. This is *my* case.”

Bow isn't convinced; he asks Catra, "and how are you connected to it? Nothing happens just because when it comes to you."

Catra weighs her options and ultimately decides it's not a secret worth keeping if it leaves Bow disgruntled with an anxious Frosta in the middle of it. *Most of my loose ends are tied up anyway, and there are no more repercussions for breaking a vow...another thing I'll have to look into once this is over.*

Catra sighs as she comes to a decision and confesses, "Frosta's a new recruit for the Unspeakable Division."

Adora gapes. *"What?"*

"Explain." Bow demands, knowing there's more to the story.

Catra huffs, "I told you before, my division is a shit show right now—people are breaking their vows left and right without any repercussions. There are only a handful of loyal Unspeakable's and the Ministry trusts me; I was the lead on Lonnie's case and I helped expose Mara so the heads of my division offered me a position as a supervisor of sorts. My main job is overseeing new recruits and Frosta happened to be on the list." Catra admits sullenly, "during my long walks in Italy I was really looking over this case. When I was finished with the file I made an informed decision to assign the Bermuda Triangle case to Frosta; I told her to reach out to me if she ran into any trouble along the way."

"That's right." Frosta nods eagerly. "That's why I followed you guys to Romania. So stop blaming her, she was only—"

"You assigned her *this* case?" Bow asks, "what if Frosta hadn't come to us for help? What if she had gone off on her own?"

"She's not a *child,* Bow." Catra says with a scowl, "and I had everything handled before we even left Italy."

Bow furrows his brow. "What do you mean?"

Catra frowns. “I just told you I looked over this case when we were in Italy; I connected the dots about Mara being involved pretty quickly—mainly because I remembered Adora’s conversation with Mara when we used our two-way mirrors. I knew Frosta would find out this case involved some kind of Ministry conspiracy and she’d assess the situation correctly—understanding the dangers of the case—and reach out for my help. But, most of all, I knew she’d hit a dead end without having knowledge about Mara’s invoice. I had everything handled.”

Bow spits out, “so you orchestrated all of this?”

Catra rolls her eyes at his dramatic flare. “You wanted to go to the Dragon Sanctuary and I knew Alin’s case would lead Frosta to Romania.” Catra shrugs, “it was a win for everyone.”

"*You* were responsible for the anonymous offer we got allowing us into the sanctuary.” Bow shakes his head in disbelief. “You’ll really stop at *nothing.”*

Catra says, “everyone got what they wanted. I don’t see why—”

“No.” Bow interrupts, “we still don’t know what *you* get out of all this so tell me—what’s so important that you’d risk Alin’s *life* for it.”

Catra doesn’t answer.

Bow laughs but it sounds hollow. “You can’t even tell us the truth. You’ve already lied about taking on an Unspeakable case when you *explicitly* said you were taking a sabbatical.” Bow turns on Adora and asks, “and why aren’t *you* upset? She’s been working on Mara's case and you’re just fine with it, unless…” Bow scoffs, “did *you* know about this?”

Adora holds her ground as she admits, “Catra told me she was working a case—“

“Of course you knew,” Bow shakes his head.

"—but I didn't know *which* case she was working on, and I didn't know Frosta would be involved in it."

Bow nods, "so you *both* lied. And for what?" When Catra offers nothing more, Bow exclaims, "you still can't even say it!"

"Bow," Adora tries to speak but he shoots her down.

"No," Bow frowns, "I'm not surprised about the lying but…after *Lonnie's* case I thought you two would've learned not to keep things from us." He looks at Catra specifically when he says, "whatever you're chasing has obviously taken its toll on you and it just hurts because—Glimmer and I are your *friends;* all we've ever wanted to do was help you in situations like this. But you can't even trust us with the truth; after *everything* we've been through. Even after all these years…"

"Bow," Adora whispers.

"I can't right now." Bow says shakily, "just…give me a second." He turns on his heel and walks a couple paces away—just enough to get some space from the group but not too far away to run into any trouble on his own. Adora sighs to herself, sparing Catra one lingering look before she kneels beside Alin to assess his injuries.

"I'll use a tranquility spell to calm him down so he's not so skittish when we wake him." Adora says, "then he can lead us to the others." She makes quick work on the spell; while Adora's occupied Frosta walks over to Catra with a withered expression.

Catra's shoulders fall as a sigh slips from her lips. She gives Frosta a look and mutters, *"don't."*

Frosta's face cracks—tears threaten to fall as she voices her concern. "This is all my fault…none of this would've happened if I hadn't just tried to solve this case on my own. I never should've asked for your help."

"I already told you, you made the right call. And without knowing about Mara's invoice or hearing her slip about the Bermuda

Triangle then the case was nearly impossible to solve."

Frosta argues, "*you* would have figured it out."

"Probably," Catra says softly, "but you're not me. The sooner you figure that out, the better off you'll be." When Frosta's expression remains glum, Catra lowers her walls a bit more. Catra whispers, "I know you look up to us, okay? But I'm not the blueprint to your success; so stop taking notes on everything we do and start making your own connections because when you're in the field the only thing you can trust are—"

"My instincts." Frosta answers with her head to the ground.

Catra smiles. "Yeah."

"I get that I should do my own thing but," Frosta sighs, "I feel like you've put a lot of faith in me to see this mission through but…I let you down."

Catra scratches the back of her neck. "I won't lie, I was disappointed when I heard you got placed in Gryffindor—"

"You keep reminding me…" Frosta sulks.

"—but, despite what your friends or family might think, you did a good thing today." Catra continues as Frosta carefully lifts her head, "you chased all those leads on your own and you were able to correctly access the situation by realizing you might've been in over your head. Asking for help doesn't make you weak; there are some cases you can't do on your own. Plus, you got to go on a mission with the golden quartet—" Catra tussles Frosta's hair with a grin, "something you've wanted to do for ages."

Frosta slaps Catra's hand from her head and mutters, "yes, yes, you're a mastermind who planned all of this with everyone's wishes in mind. I know already."

Catra adds softly, "but most importantly, you saved Alin—and soon you'll save the others. You should be proud of that."

Frosta tries to argue but is swiftly cut down.

"And this mission was not a handout," Catra says, "every new recruit is supervised when they get their first case. So stop giving yourself a hard time and celebrate your accomplishments."

Frosta lifts her head, seemingly better off than before. It puts Catra's mind at ease for a moment before her thoughts begin to flood back in. But before she can drown in them, Frosta gets her attention with another question.

"Does it get easier?"

Catra raises an eyebrow. "Which part?"

Frosta looks over at Bow and whispers, "lying to your friends and family—having them look at you the way he did."

"No."

Frosta's face pinches up but she says nothing.

"It never gets easier...but," Catra looks over at Adora and says with a smile, "one day you might find someone who has enough faith to trust in you…someone who can accept that—no matter how much you want to—you can't tell them everything."

Frosta doesn't need to follow Catra's gaze to know who she's referring to. And normally when Catra gushes about Adora, Frosta sticks out her tongue and curses all that has to do with romance but this time an expression of *relief* takes over her features. Frosta takes a deep breath and comes back refreshed. Catra takes pride in seeing the spark return to Frosta's eyes.

"Alright," Frosta says as she cracks her knuckles, "let's finish this case and return Alin and the others to their families."

Catra adds, "you've got *me* too, Snowflake. If you're ever having a bad day on the job, you can always come to me; it helps when

you have a support system—people who understand your perspective."

"You don't even answer my letters." Frosta deadpans.

Catra's eye twitches. "I *read* them, okay? I just skim the fluff and see how urgent it is." Catra frowns, "but I'm serious. Reach out to me whenever it feels like you might drown."

Frosta smiles. "I will."

Catra nods. "Good."

"You know," Frosta says carefully, "you should take your own advice."

Catra frowns, confused.

"About asking for help." Frosta cues her in—making a point of looking at Bow. "It doesn't make you weak."

Catra stares at her pupil—watching as the student, for a moment, becomes the master. Catra's eyes flick to the side; she feels something heavy rest on her chest as she gazes at Bow's solemn form. There's a lot of truth behind Frosta's taunting. Even though so many years have passed since Hogwarts, Catra realizes—

There are still things she needs to work on.

Chapter End Notes

> For this chapter I wanted to focus on Catra's tendency to keep secrets from the people closest to her and how, instead of talking about it, she comes up with these elaborate schemes that seem like they're benefiting everyone when in reality she's being manipulative and selfish. It mostly stems from her job as an Unspeakable; she's been working cases alone for a while so she's not really a team player and also (as an Obliviator) she's seen the trauma that comes from knowing too much so she tries to keep her friends away from

the truth. But we saw with Lonnie's case that wasn't a good idea (ex: Finn's death). In this chapter Catra seems "stuck" in this phase of her development but she's actually making some strides; this is shown by Catra giving Adora a heads up that she was working a case—even though she didn't go into all the details she kept Adora informed. It shows a healthier side to their relationship because they're including each other and doing their best not to keep secrets. But, Catra still struggles to be open with people outside from Adora (even within the golden crew).

On a less serious note: the brief conversation between Bow and Glimmer at the start of the chapter where they spoke about bittersweet endings was me trying to break the fourth wall by giving a nod to this story's approaching end.

Next week we'll take a break from the main story with the final Interlude ("Interlude III"); it's a flashback that's been requested by a few people. It takes place during the golden quartet's seventh year at Hogwarts—more specifically, the long awaited war arc. This will be the only glimpse I'll give for this arc mainly because I'm not too interested in expanding on it; I like focusing on the aftermath of the war and the previous build up for it.

As always, thanks for reading.

Interlude III

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Barnton, London

Infiltrating enemy territory was Catra's grand idea—one she very much regrets. And while ego clouded her vision, in her post reflection Catra recognizes that she should have scrapped the mission plan—never letting it see the light of day. Though she accepts complete blame, there were other factors involved in her decision making: the quartet had hit a dead end, exhausting all their clues as to where Prime's final Horcrux might be, and they were getting restless. In the midst of it all, Bow took up listening to the news on his portable radio, and after hearing about all the innocents being punished for the *disappearance* of the golden crew…he *snapped.* And Catra couldn't blame him; Hogwarts was receiving the most backlash from death eaters—sent by Prime—to weed out the world's remaining hope. To weed out the prophetic *golden quartet.* And so, with her friends anxiously looking to her for answers and with the blood of her fellow classmates on her hands, Catra put together a plan.

The mission should've been simple, in theory, but things never go as planned.

The idea came to her when she and Glimmer were getting supplies from a local muggle village (they knew Prime would rather burn than step foot inside its parameters). Surprisingly, there was an underground wizarding market in the basement of one of the muggle bars. Curious, Catra and Glimmer—under the protection of Polyjuice—went to check it out.

While they were in the market they overheard a young boy frantically whispering to his friends about a flyer he received inviting him to a death eater recruitment meeting; the boy was a

nervous wreck so Catra, seeing an opportunity, snatched the flyer and offered to go in his place—wearing his face. He was too grateful of being relieved of the burden to ask any follow up questions.

When Catra explained the mission she deemed it as low risk but Adora was adamant on joining Catra in her endeavors. For extra protection, Bow and Glimmer promised to wait outside and storm the house when presented with a signal. The plan was simple: go to the meeting and obtain new intel. Catra just never predicted Lord Prime *himself* would walk into the house to greet his new potential followers.

Shit, is all Catra can think as pure *ice* races through her veins. *Bow,* Catra lowers her mental guards to reach him, *you and Glimmer need to get out of here. Now.*

What? Why? What's going on? Bow argues, never one to leave a friend behind.

There's a retort on her tongue but it dies—turning to dust—as Prime cuts his stroll short and turns his gaze to *Adora* like a dog recognizing a familiar scent. It takes Catra less than a second to realize the implications.

Fuck! Catra's fur stands on end as her mind starts spiraling. The glamor spell cloaking Catra's figure will do just fine with hiding her identity but the one encasing Adora will be futile. Catra doesn't know much about Adora's connection to Prime—just that their magic is one in the same—but she knows Prime will easily see through Adora's glamor and recognize her magical signature.

Catra feels Adora's magic spike—a second too late—as she finally catches up on what's happening. But luckily, Catra's magic is already breaking through—dismantling her glamor and revealing herself to the room as she sacrifices privacy for a bit more *power.* There's a disgruntled gasp to her left—the person is put off with being in the presence of a hybrid—but Catra pays no mind. *Listen to me Bow!* It's the final advice Catra offers before she puts up

her mental guards and cloaks herself with magic, preparing for the jump.

"You." Prime sneers, drawing his wand at lightning speed as Adora reaches to do the same. Prime aims his wand at Adora and shouts, "crucio! Bombarda!"

"Protego!" Adora shouts, waving her hand in a wild display of wandless magic when she can't reach her wand in time. Unfortunately, her experience with wandless magic is low—she only started practicing it last year—so her shield is fractured; it's enough to block the crucio but it's not enough for the bombarda. And soon, Adora's reaping in the fruits of her failure—gasping as the spell strikes her in the chest, sending her toppling backwards.

Prime capitalizes on her slip; a gruesome smile stretches across his face, yellow teeth glinting in the dim light of the room, as he *cherishes* the moments before Adora's demise. While Adora's still falling backwards in the air, Prime raises his wand to deliver the finishing blow.

Crack! Catra appears in the air, leaping towards Adora's limp form, with the use of apparition. There are deep cuts along Catra's arms and legs—a s*plinching* , punishment for using apparition in such a rush—but she doesn't notice. *Protect her,* is all Catra can think.

"Avada Kedavra!" Prime shouts.

Catra wraps Adora in her arms and together they disappear with a *crack.*

Forbidden Forest, Hogwarts

Splash!

"Come on, come on, come on," Catra whispers in a desperate mantra like it'll stop Adora from bleeding out. "Please be okay…" she begs Merlin as she lugs Adora's body from the lake they landed in upon arrival.

"Fuck." Catra curses as she nearly falls in the mud, feet slipping, as she backpedals out the water onto land with Adora hanging from her arms.

The night air bites at Catra's soaked form but she's not in the right headspace to use a spell to dry her clothes—she landed in *Hogwarts* of all places. And while she'd like to say it's due to a tactical move (Prime would never expect them to be stupid enough to head back to Hogwarts) it was made on a whim; in all honesty, Hogwarts is the only place that has felt safe to Catra. Maybe that's why she landed them here but there's no time to debate her bad decisions; she'll have to work with what she has.

Catra finds a spot beneath a tree to lay Adora on her back; she uses her wand to dry Adora's wet clothes—ignoring her own—and makes quick work of ripping Adora's shirt apart to see the damage. It's worse than she thought. Catra blinks away tears, fingers grazing maimed skin.

"Buy me a drink first," Adora whispers in a choked breath—blood leaking from her lips for trying to speak at all.

Catra wishes they had time to banter back and forth. Instead, she sends Adora a strained smile and lifts a hand to encase them in a protective bubble—invisible and without sound to the outside world. Catra presses her hands to Adora's chest and works on healing what she can. *Bow,* she opens her mental guards and says in a rush, *I'm with Adora in the Forbidden Forest. It's bad… she got hit…*

Bow answers right away, sounding busy. *Is she okay?*

For now, Catra looks at the wound. *I'm stopping most of the bleeding but I don't know how to do internal healing like Glimmer. I can't do much—*

It's enough for now. Bow answers.

When can you get here? Catra asks.

Bow answers after a pause. *Glimmer and I heard spells being fired so we fought our way inside. We're a little held up right now but we'll be there as soon as we can. Just hold on.*

Are you guys okay? Catra asks, knowing she and Adora are always the best bet when it comes to dueling.

We will be. Bow declares. *Take care of her. We'll get there when we can.*

Their connection breaks, silence forming in its wake, but that's okay; Catra didn't know what else to say. How can she say she's sorry for letting them down? How can she say she's sorry for thinking she could ever be anything else but a hybrid in over her head? She was never supposed to be part of the golden crew—everyone knew it. She wished she listened, but winning the Triwizard Tournament made her ego swell; it made her think she could actually become *more.*

Catra's gaze flickers to Adora's chest; beneath the blood is the all too familiar *scar.* The very scar that's kept Adora company in her sleepless nights. *The failsafe* is what Adora likes to call it. The mark was branded on Adora when she was two years old—the night Prime killed her parents right in front of her crib. No one knows the purpose it serves, but Adora thinks it ties her to Prime because the scar *burns* whenever he's plotting or growing stronger. *It's a failsafe,* she recalls Adora saying one cold night, *it's his way of punishing me for surviving…a way to let me know he'll always be here, one way or another.*

"...m' sorry."

Catra startles back to the present; she looks down to meet Adora's withering gaze. Even when she's on her deathbed she tries to keep Catra reassured. Catra shakes the thought away. *It's my time to offer her some reassurance.*

Catra can't smile without breaking into tears so she offers in a soft voice, "what do *you* have to be sorry for?"

Adora winches at a particular sting of magic before she gathers herself once more. Adora blinks away the fog from her eyes and explains, "for getting you involved in this…for leaving you all alone at school after I *promised* to always be with you…and," she gets a dark look in her eyes as she says, "and I'm sorry for not doing anything about Weaver when she took you down to the basement —"

"You didn't know," Catra tries to reassure her.

"I *should* have." Adora's retort leaves no room for dismissal.

Catra snaps back, "you're not the only one who promised to be there for you. We *both* did. Don't just ignore the fact that I treated you like shit for years just because we got placed in different houses. So *stop* apologizing when you have no reason to." She wishes Adora would just shut up for once and let Catra save her.

Adora frowns. "It wasn't your fault—"

Catra scoffs. "I knew what I was doing."

"—but you were being manipulated by *dark* magic." Adora argues, "I didn't notice Weaver taking you away at night but I do remember you getting anxious and snappish after we got our acceptance letters…and us being split into different houses kind of —set off the avalanche."

"It's not an excuse," Catra whispers.

Adora nods, sluggish. "I know…but it's one of the *reasons."* Adora's eyes flicker as she struggles to keep them open. Catra uses one hand to shake Adora from her approaching slumber. Adora whispers, "I'm sleepy…"

"No, no," Catra says frantically, "stay awake…come on, just keep your eyes open until Bow and Glimmer show up okay?"

Adora's lips quirk up as she confesses with a snort, "I saw them *kissing…"*

Catra laughs—not at all surprised with the tension those two have, and how protective they are with one another.

Catra's joy is short-lived when Adora starts to tank once more. Catra shakes Adora and tries to rack her brain with something that might keep Adora awake long enough for help to arrive.

"Stay awake, Adora…" Catra begs.

Adora's head tilts back. "Just...let me close my eyes for a—"

"Our sixth year."

Catra's face is stained red by the time the words leave her mouth; she has half a mind to retract them but, to her fortunate misfortune, Adora's eyes grow a little wider—mouth gaping. Catra pushes through the embarrassment, forcing her eyes to stay locked on Adora's as she asks "do you remember the party you planned for me after I won the Triwizard Tournament? You knew I was overwhelmed with all the fans and the journalists so you asked if I wanted to step outside on the balcony for some air; we went out there and…you started to tell me something but you were interrupted...you never did tell me what you wanted to say."

Adora's face is pale—not what Catra imagined her expression would be when they had this conversation. But, then again, things *never* go as expected when it comes to them.

Catra confesses, "I know what you wanted to say."

"...you do?" Adora asks, startled.

Catra nods to herself. "You were about to say it but then Scorpia called us away because there was an attack—"

"On Azkaban," Adora says as her memory fills in the gaps.

"Yeah, a masked assailant broke into Azkaban to free Hordak—Prime's right hand. It was close to the end of our sixth year—we had so much ahead of us—but when we got that news…I knew everything would change. And it did." Catra admits, "and I was hurt about it for a long time, selfishly so, because I knew you cut our time short because there was a war coming for us—so I get it. I don't like it, but I understand. I get why you felt you had to lock it away but you have to know, you're allowed to *want* things for yourself Adora."

Adora breaks eye contact for the first time, "I'm supposed to *save* everyone—"

"You didn't ask for it—"

"It doesn't matter." Adora frowns.

"You're wrong, how you feel is important and if *you're* not going to be the one to…" Catra lets the sentence slip away; a weird feeling bubbles in her stomach as she contemplates her next words. It's not ideal, but if it gives them enough time for Adora to stay present—Catra will latch onto it. "...if you're not gonna be the one to say it, I will."

Adora's breath hitches. "What…"

"I love you—you *idiot."* Catra says it so resolutely it leaves no room for rebuttal. She's partly aware of the tears falling down her face but Catra keeps the momentum rolling. A weight lifts from her chest as she presses on, "I've been in love with you the moment you stood up for me at the orphanage when those older kids were making fun of my tail; and yeah, I had a *shitty* way of showing it but…it's true." Catra thinks about the past and realizes, "I didn't want to believe I could want you in my life the way that I did—the way I do—not after everything that happened. A few years ago I would rather *die* than admit that but now I'm sure I want you in my life for however long you're willing so, it'd be *great* if you didn't die on me."

Suddenly, something bursts from Adora's chest.

Catra hisses, hands shooting back to cover her eyes as a blinding light escapes the scar on Adora's chest. Catra clenches her eyes shut when the light breaks through the cracks of her fingers; her knees nearly buckle as Adora's magic *flares,* reaching out with open arms until it touches Catra's own magical core. A gasp leaves her chest as Adora's magic connects with hers—swirling together into something bigger than themselves—before it shoots back to Adora.

With a grunt, Adora seizes up as their magic ripples through her body like a current. The light dims as the magic races through Adora's wound; Catra gathers herself and looks at the product of their combined magic. *No way,* Catra gasps as she takes in the *healed* wound Prime left behind. *It's completely gone,* Catra can't help but run her fingers across Adora's unblemished skin—save for the *failsafe* scar—she seems to glow under the moon.

"Hey," Adora's voice startles Catra, "I told you…get me dinner first."

The joke hangs in the air; normally Catra would laugh at the attempt of normalcy but something churns in her stomach. She feels nervous—anxious even—but she has long since come to peace with taking whatever Adora is willing to give. *So why do I feel…* Catra's thought is cut short as she starts to understand, *these are Adora's emotions.* It's confirmed by the way Adora's brow bunches together and the biting of her lip.

Not knowing what to make of this new ability, Catra relaxes her own body and, in turn, her magic follows—reaching out to embrace Adora. The pit in Catra's stomach eases—Adora calms down.

Adora sits up with Catra's help and finds the confidence to say, "I love you too."

Catra doesn't have time to explore the long awaited confession or the implications of their new magical bond, in fact, her mind goes blank when Adora leans over and *kisses* her. And suddenly there's no war or death eaters out to get them—there's only *this.* Catra returns the kiss, allowing herself to get swept up in what little freedom they have left.

"Catra!"

Ice shoots down their backs and they break away with a gasp. Behind their protective shield, they spot Bow and Glimmer running around aimlessly in the night with their wands drawn as flashlights.

Adora jumps to her feet and exclaims, "we're over here!"

"There's a sound proof shield up." Catra explains, clearing her throat as she stands up and prepares to remove the spell. But, before she can, Adora presses her palm to the shield and it *vanishes* beneath her touch. Catra frowns, "did you just take apart my spell?" Catra's no expert but she prides herself in being proficient enough to not have her spells dismantled so easily.

"Yeah," Adora looks flustered as she stares at her hand in awe, "it kind of…spoke to me and told me what to do."

Catra isn't sure how to feel about *that* but there's no time to process anything as she nearly falls to the floor when Bow and Glimmer collide into them.

"There you two are!" Glimmer pulls out some supplies from her bag and says in a hurry, "now let's check on Adora and make sure —" she cuts herself off with a scream. "Adora! You're okay? Catra said you got hit."

Bow looks at Adora's appearance—barely glancing at her ripped shirt before he turns his back to her. Bow clears his throat, "your shirt is still…"

“Oh,” Adora flushes; she makes quick work of repairing the torn garment before giving Bow the okay to turn around.

“What *happened?”* Bow asks, turning to Catra for answers. “Did you heal her?”

“Yeah.” It’s technically not a lie; her and Adora’s magic worked together and somehow did some top tear spell work but that’s an issue for another day. Catra tries to downplay it, “I guess it wasn’t as bad as I thought…things just seem all over the place, you know? Once Prime showed up I kind of acted on autopilot and got us out of there. Sorry for leaving you guys behind.”

“You did the right thing.” Glimmer says, “there’s no telling what might happen if Prime gets a hold of Adora.”

Something seems off about the way their eyes flick towards the school. Catra narrows her asks and asks carefully, “what aren’t you telling us?”

Bow goes to answer but he’s cut off when the ground beneath them suddenly shakes—nearly sending them tumbling to the ground. Adora reaches out to keep Catra afloat while Bow does the same with Glimmer.

Catra snaps. “What the hell was that?”

Adora hisses, snatching her hand from Catra to clutch at her own chest. Catra’s breath leaves her body as Adora’s emotions wreak havoc on her body—she can *feel* the turmoil Adora’s going through. Catra puts her hands on Adora’s shoulders and asks softly, “what’s wrong?”

“It’s him.” Adora reveals in a whisper, “he *knows* I’m alive...and he’s not happy.”

Glimmer says, “but he doesn’t know where we are and all we need is the last Horcrux to take him out.”

“He’s not giving us any options,” Adora says after she spaces out for a second; eyes glazing over as Prime sends her a message. Catra tightens her grip on Adora’s shoulders to give her some comfort—to keep her grounded—until she comes back to them with a gasp.

Bow looks afraid to ask, “what is it?”

Dread fills Catra’s stomach long before Adora reveals—

“Prime’s attacking Hogwarts.”

Great Hall, Hogwarts

(Six Months Later)

“Alright, great work everyone! Let’s take thirty for lunch and then we’ll finish removing the rest of the rubble.” Spinnerella adds, “and please be careful to stay within the confines of this space during your break. There are areas of the school that are still under repair.”

Glimmer stretches her arms with a sigh; she’s been up all day helping out with rebuilding the school after Primes attack which left the castle in nothing but rubble. But, with the help of the students, they’ve managed to repair most of it and have even gotten the approval from Angella to reopen the doors as they prepare for the upcoming semester. *My final year,* Glimmer corrects herself with a grin.

“What’re you smiling about?” Netossa asks, butting into Glimmer’s space with a knowing look. Netossa guesses, “it doesn’t have anything to do with you *boyfriend* does it?”

Glimmer tries to keep her blush down but it has a mind of its own. Her relationship with Bow took off after Prime was defeated but it’s still new and she’d like to protect it at all costs. Glimmer ignores the stares and waves Netossa off by offering a half truth,

"I was actually thinking about how great it is to see you and Spinny here after all these years."

Netossa rolls her eyes. "It's only been *two* years since we graduated…but I get what you mean, I missed it too."

"Wish it could've been under better circumstances."

"That's true, but…nothing ever goes according to plan." Netossa recalls why she stopped Glimmer in the first place. "Oh yeah, I need you to do me a favor. We're getting ready to swap teams to give the guys in the Entrance Hall a break and everyone on the swap out team is accounted for except Catra…"

Suddenly, there's frantic whispering nearby:

"Did she say Catra?"

"Where is she? I never see her around."

"She's probably taking a break. She deserves it. I heard she punched a death eater in the face."

"Yeah? Well, I heard she punched Prime in the face!"

Glimmer frowns at the nearby gossip that proceeds at the mention of her friend; she turns to glare at the eavesdroppers who buckle under her stare and get back to work.

Netossa notices the slip and winches. She lowers her voice and asks, "is it still that bad?"

"Unfortunately." Glimmer mutters.

Ever since the golden quartet took down Prime and saved the world they've received a lot of attention from the press and students at Hogwarts. But, for some unknown reason, Catra seems to be on the receiving end of the worst of it. *I've been meaning to ask her about that.*

Netossa nods apologetically. “Well, I get why she’s not resting in the normal resting areas…but I need you to find her, the shift swap is in fifteen minutes. Do you know where she might be?”

Glimmer has a good idea and tells Netossa she’s on the case before she slips out unnoticed by the eavesdroppers.

The trip to the Astronomy Tower is short—but dreadful—and soon Glimmer finds herself climbing the final step. *Why does she always have to be in the highest place of whatever building she’s in?* Glimmer leans over, hands on her knees as she struggles to catch her breath. Once she’s ready Glimmer pushes herself up; she quickly spots Catra lounging in the window with one leg draped over the windowsill and the other swinging above the ground.

Catra’s hair is pulled into a low messy bun. Her bangs are longer these days—resting just above her nose. She’s dressed in her Slytherin robes perusal as she gazes out the window, not greeting Glimmer but surely being aware of her presence. Ever since the war Catra’s been well attuned to her surroundings—always keep her ears perked for any unwanted intruders.

Sometimes Glimmer misses the girl who would hiss—clearly thrown off guard—when someone snuck up behind her.

“You’re like a princess in a tower.” Glimmer says, trying to get a rise from her.

It works like a charm.

Catra whips around to glare at her as she spits, “I’m *not* a princess.” And it's great, seeing the defiant flame in Catra’s eye—something she wore with pride during their earlier Hogwarts years before the tournament tried to stomp on it—but it’s short lived. The flame dulls, dying to a gentle ember as Catra turns back to the view. Catra mutters, “tell Netossa I don’t need to be *called* upon. I know when the shift changes.”

Glimmer leans against the wall of the window Catra's sulking in. Knowing Catra will likely tell Netossa off herself, Glimmer asks "why're hiding up here all the time? I know the rest of the school and the press are nuts, but Bow and I miss having you around to complain about stuff."

"Gee thanks," Catra scoffs.

Glimmer tilts her head. "But seriously, what's up with that?"

Catra sighs. "You know how the fame is—you experienced it the first day at Hogwarts when people realized you were *that* Glimmer Moon, the Headmistresses kid—and I got an unwelcome taste of it when I won the Triwizard Tournament…"

"And now we're war hero's," Glimmer finishes with a weak smile.

"It's worse than that." Catra rubs her head, continuing to air out her grievances when Glimmer motions for her to do so. Catra says after a moment, "do you remember last week? When you got on me for not reaching out to Adora when she was looking down?"

Glimmer's magic flares at the reminder; she went to Catra with a bone to pick because why else would Adora be walking around Hogwarts looking like a kicked puppy?

Things have been weird between Adora and Catra since the war ended. *Well, there's nothing weird about Bow and I hearing them fuck in their tent.* Glimmer still shudders at the memory; she and Bow could've easily avoided being traumatized if one of them had remembered to use a damn silencing spell.

So yeah, their situation isn't weird. But, rooms filled with stifling sexual tension? Most definitely.

Glimmer clears her throat. "I recall."

Catra doesn't seem to notice or chooses not to point out Glimmer's behavior. Catra fiddles with her wand and confesses

beneath her breath, “Adora got accepted into the Auror Academy for London’s Division and she’s taking the offer—”

“That’s great!” Glimmer exclaims.

“—but she won’t be finishing her seventh year.”

Glimmer’s brain short circuits. *“What?”*

Catra can’t meet her eyes. “Yeah…surprise.”

“But…how?” Glimmer splutters, conflicted on how to feel. “I thought you had to be a graduate to enroll?”

“The golden girl can do anything.” Catra snarks. “They made an exception.”

Glimmer’s shoulders fall; she wants to think about what this will mean for them going forward, and why Adora didn’t tell anyone besides Catra when the program start date is fast approaching, but one question seems the most important.

“What does this mean for you?” Glimmer asks carefully.

Catra looks away with a frown. “The school took a huge blow—literally—and a lot of parents are worried about sending their kids back here, the same goes for *new* prospective students as well, they don’t believe Hogwarts is safe anymore. Prime is gone but there are still death eaters out there who haven’t been caught so their concerns are valid and with Adora *leaving…”* Catra’s eye twitches at the word. “...the school needs a new face to represent all that the parents are worried the school lost: power, strength, and protection.

“And who’s a better choice than the Triwizard Tournament Champion turned war hero—”

“They want *you* to represent the school?” Glimmer realizes.

“Ding, ding, ding.” Catra deadpans.

Glimmer knows what it's like to worry about living up to expectations so she gives Catra a withered look knowing she'll understand. The shadow across Catra's eyes remains but she does offer Glimmer a grateful smile.

"So," Catra says, "forgive me if I'm *absent* during our seventh year. If you can't find me it's because I'm trying to get a break from the journalists and Frosta clones trying to sneak into my dorm."

Glimmer hesitates, "you could always leave."

Catra shakes her head. "I've gotten offers to some Obliviator programs—with a similar deal Adora got—but there's still more I need to learn," she stares at her wand in deep thought. "...I have more magic I have to master plus, I want to relax a bit before joining the real world."

Glimmer says, "you're the only person Adora's told—the news would be everywhere if she hadn't—don't you think that means something? You should reach out to her before she goes."

"Don't you get it?" Catra asks, voice low and unchanging despite the fire in her eyes. "Adora's *leaving,* there's nothing for her here…and I won't be the one to stand in the way of what she wants."

Glimmer can't believe such stupid words are coming for their strategic genius.

Glimmer argues, "she'll still need a support system—"

"I won't distract her. I've done enough of that for a lifetime." Catra stands from the windowsill and meets Glimmer's gaze as she finishes with one last lie to herself, "Adora and I are just in two different places right now. It would never work."

Before Catra can slip away, Glimmer grabs her on impulse and wraps her up in a hug. Catra grows still but doesn't try to fight it. Glimmer whispers, "don't be a stranger, okay? Bow and I will still

be at Hogwarts to finish our seventh year so you're not alone. If you ever need anyone to talk to, just come to my dorm."

Catra pulls away with a playful scoff. "I wouldn't be caught dead in Gryffindor territory."

There's a pleasant smile on Catra's face but it's only there to mask the longing and pain—something Glimmer's seen Adora mirror in the days approaching her timely departure. And, even though it was a lie Catra spoke to herself, Glimmer can't help but wonder if their timing truly is off. If it is, she just hopes one day they'll stop running from each other; the tactic is dressed up—disguised—but it doesn't change what it is at its core:

Adora's running from the school—tucking her heart away from possible pain—meanwhile Catra's choosing to find refuge in it—hiding from the fame and heartache—all because they're afraid of rejection.

"Hey," Glimmer adds before Catra departs, "I'm serious, you don't have to hide away on your own…you should rely on your friends more. Rely on *us."*

Catra seems to take Glimmer's words to heart as she mutters in passing—

"I'll work on it."

Chapter End Notes

> The scene where Adora and Catra's magic connects into one represents them opening themselves up to each other in the fullest way possible; this leads to their magical cores bonding to the point where they can feel what the other is feeling. This gate was able to open because they were vulnerable with each other and confessed their love. This connection isn't mentioned in the main story because, when Adora brought up joining the Auror Program, Catra unknowingly cut the bond to protect herself when she felt Adora was leaving all over again; this led to a lot of misunderstanding, to the

point where Adora thinks Catra would be better off without her. The bond is still disconnected in the main story because the two just got into their relationship and reconnected; Catra and Adora also have a lot of secrets for their occupations so they can't afford to be completely open with one another.

Bow and Glimmer do however have their bond open; it's hinted at in Chapter 14 ("A Dragon Said to Me…"); in the scene Bow is feeling inadequate but then Glimmer's magic unconsciously reassures him.

Another thing I'd like to note is how disconnected Catra feels from the golden crew—almost like she doesn't belong there. During Hogwarts, as a hybrid, she received a lot of scorn (from Weaver as well) so there's a lot of insecurities there; despite what she's done, and the friendships she's made, she doesn't feel like she's good enough. This outsider mentality ties into why Catra keeps the golden crew out of the loop at times.

Lastly, if it seems like the crew was a bit nerfed in this Interlude it's because they're teenagers (17 to 18 years old) who haven't had wartime experience. This is why Catra chooses to stay at Hogwarts because she knows there's still a lot she has to learn. Their unproficiency is hinted at in the scene where Adora isn't skilled enough at wandless magic—to the point where she's unable to completely form a shield. It's also shown when Catra isn't able to do anything other than stop Adora from bleeding out. They become the overpowered forces we know and love when they gain experience in the field via work in their respective occupations. Still, they're definitely a cut above the rest of their classmates.

Anyway, thanks for reading.

Into the Lion's Den

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

15

Munch! Adora feels her stomach growl in a jealous fit as Alin devourers the turkey sandwich until there's nothing left but the wrapping it came in. She pulls out another when Alin tries to lick off the mayo on his fingers. He jumps at the unexpected move, but Adora offers him a reassuring smile and soon he's snatching the offering—making quick work of it like the previous. Adora looks over his lanky form—surely from malnourishment—before she settles on eyeing his battered clothes; there are tons of magical creatures hiding out here so it's not crazy to assume Alin got into a couple scraps here and there. But, she is curious as to why he didn't use magic to fix his clothes.

"Hey," Frosta says, voice soft as she walks over—leaving ample space between her and Alin. Frosta gestures for Adora to come closer.

"Be right back." Adora tells Alin to which he offers a stiff nod. Adora walks over to her younger companion and asks, "what's up?"

"Thanks to Alin we have a way to find the hideout for the remaining missing persons; he said the group moves around a lot so we'll need a locator spell to find them...well, the *remaining* members who survived at least." Frosta pauses, taking a cautionary step back, when Adora's magic seeps to the surface.

Mara, Adora huffs, *even from the grave you're still doing damage.*

Frosta clears her throat and continues, "...I know, it's hard enough we have to explain to the parents what happened—that their children were betrayed by the very system they wanted to be a

part of—and now we have to tell some of them that their children didn't survive. Catra said Unspeakable missions are hush, hush, but I can't see a scenario where the families don't revolt and lash out at the Ministry when they hear about this."

A familiar chill creeps down Adora's spine just as Catra makes herself known—

"Exactly." Catra says, causing Frosta to startle. Catra gives her pupil a disapproving look before she explains the situation. "The Ministry can't handle another scandal…not after what happened with Adora, and it doesn't help that Mara's implicated in *both* scandals."

Adora crosses her arms when she notices the way Catra's gaze flickers between the two of them—settling more on Frosta. And suddenly, something burns in Adora's stomach; it's been building since their time in Italy and has only spread—festering—during the moments of Catra's confession. Adora tries to keep calm as she asks, "what're you planning to do about it?"

Catra frowns at the accusation. "It's not *my* idea but the heads of my division marked this as a threat to wizarding world so—"

"They want to sweep it under the rug?" Adora demands, outraged.

"No…" Frosta shakes her head, turning to her mentor for guidance. "They wouldn't do that...right?"

"They think it's for the *best."* Catra mutters, using air quotes.

Adora clenches her fist and demands, "and *you?* What do you think?"

"They're not completely wrong, this will shift the public's frustrations to the Ministry and its corruption but…pushing it aside won't amount to anything; it'll just turn into another scandal if the secret comes out." Catra admits, "I spoke with them about a plan

to move forward after I finished reviewing the case during our trip to Italy—"

"And?" Adora challenges, "what did you decide?"

Despite Catra's constant mention of her department *heads,* Adora knows Catra holds more power in her division than she's letting on. But, to what extent, Adora isn't sure.

"...Mara is dead but her impact is stronger than ever; all we've learned from the trial is there are more Prime Loyalists lurking around so I doubt they'll react well when they discover Mara's precious trinkets are freed and slandering the reputation of an revered death eater—one of Prime's possible right hands." Catra rubs her chin and adds, "and if we release them to their families without protection—while having their testimony covered in every media outlet—Alin and the others won't survive long. So, they'll need to go under witness protection."

Frosta tilts her head, "seriously?"

Catra nods. "I've already alerted a trusted group of Auror's; as we speak they're gathering the families and placing them under protective housing as they await the arrival of their missing children. The families will be given the choice of whether they want their stories shared or not and, in the situation where they *do* want to share the horrors they've been through, they can choose to remain anonymous for their protection. But, no matter what they decide—"

"They'll never live normal lives again." Adora finishes with a frown.

"Unfortunately not…there's some reassurance with Mara's death but—her legacy proceeds her." Catra looks away as she mutters, "if there was a better solution I would offer it. To be honest, I considered wiping their memories of this event—their families too—so they could live on in blissful ignorance but…it felt wrong taking away their choice."

Adora contemplates the outlined plan before she comes to her own decision. Adora nods, saying, "I think it's the best solution given the circumstances."

Catra's lip quirks up in Adora's direction as she thanks her for the input. Then, Catra turns to her pupil with a question. "What about you, Snowflake? Any thoughts?"

Frosta startles at the attention. "Me?"

Catra shrugs. "It's *your* mission, and it's protocol for Unspeakables to outline the course of action post-mission. I'm still your supervisor so the final decision is mine but I'm open to suggestions."

The shock drains from Frosta's face as she suddenly looks away in deep thought. When a short time has passed, Frosta speaks up. "...I agree with the plan you've outlined; it grants the victims the *choice* to make their voices heard while keeping them safe from the eyes of the public and possible enemies. I just," Frosta sighs, "...wish we could've gotten here sooner."

Adora knows the feeling all too well.

"Mara's been doing this since we were attending Hogwarts, Fross," Adora offers with a sad smile, "there was nothing we could've done at the time. But we should count our blessings. Think about all those families that'll be reunited."

Movement from her peripheral catches Adora's attention. Adora turns her head and spots Bow a fair distance away motioning for them to follow; there's an article of clothing—a battered hat maybe—glowing yellow as it floats above his palm. Adora nods in his direction saying, "looks like Bow got the locator spell working. We should head out."

Catra nods. "Frosta, get Alin to lead us there; we want his face to be the first thing they see so we don't have a group of frightened people lashing out with their magic."

“On it.” Frosta gives Catra a lame salute before making her way over to Alin.

Catra crosses her arms, barely waiting until Frosta’s out of hearing distance before she turns to Adora with a raised eyebrow. “Go ahead then.” Catra urges, gesturing to Adora with a nod.

Adora weighs her options and settles on a swift, “we can talk about it later.”

“That never seems to work well for us.” Catra says with an awkward grin. “...I know you’re upset about me keeping you out of the loop—”

“I’m not, actually.” Adora confesses, surprising even herself as she realizes the truth in her words. Adora smiles at Catra’s startled expression and says, “you were honest with me about taking on a mission when you could’ve lied about it entirely, and yeah, you didn’t tell me *everything* but...I know secrets are part of your job.”

“Stop, don’t do that.” Catra argues with a frown, “don’t act like it doesn’t bother you that I made the decision not to tell you about Mara’s involvement in this case.”

Adora bites her lip and contemplates her emotions from that perspective but, eventually, she comes up empty. There’s no bitter sting of deception. *I’m relieved,* Adora realizes, *Catra could’ve come here on her own but...she kept me with her.* A brief memory comes back to her—the night Adora told Catra about possibly cutting her seventh year short to join the Auror Academy; Catra didn’t take the news well, going as far as *severing* their magical bond until nothing but a hollow spot remained. Back then, Adora wasn’t *seriously* considering taking the offer, she only wanted to get a reaction from Catra—but it backfired.

Instead of talking things through, they played mind games with each other and buried themselves in work as a distraction from the pain. And Adora doesn’t plan on making the same mistake again.

“I’m serious, Catra. I’m not upset.” Adora takes Catra’s hand and gives it a squeeze. She whispers, “I’m just glad you’re *here.”*

Catra lashes out, “why aren’t you upset?”

Adora stares at her girlfriend and suddenly it clicks. Adora frowns. “Do you *want* me to be upset?”

Catra shakes her head. “What? No, why would I…” she cuts her own sentence short, letting it fall victim to the wind as she grows speechless. Catra avoids Adora’s stare by looking at their joined hands.

Adora lowers her voice and says, “look, it seems like you *want* me to blame you for things beyond your control but I have none to give you. Your job demands sacrifice, it’s something I understand —I’m an *Auror,* Catra. There are things I can’t tell *you* but, it’s part of our work.” Adora hesitates before saying, “if you’re actively seeking a reason for me to be put off by this then maybe you should consider whether this job is fulfilling your needs.”

Catra looks up, meeting Adora’s steady gaze, as she asks “is that what you want?”

There have been nights where Adora’s kept herself awake running through every conversation with Catra leading to their untimely split after the war; she tried to map out where she went wrong. It wasn’t until recently—she’s ashamed to admit—that she considered looking at it from Catra’s perspective. What she came to see was the fear Catra had of Adora leaving her behind and, in some regards, that fear came true; Adora chased her dream while Catra loved her from a distance. And Adora’s done a lot of good, saved a lot of lives as an Auror, but the longing has always been there. Now, in a strange twist of fate, Adora finds their roles reversed.

This time, Adora’s the one who’s satisfied with taking whatever she can get.

Adora's gaze flicks to the side as Frosta draws closer with Alin at her side. Adora blinks away tears and clears her throat so her words don't come across as hoarse. "Like I said," Adora offers a final squeeze before she frees Catra's hand, "I'm just glad you're here."

Adora doesn't give Catra time to respond and soon she's leaving her girlfriend behind in favor of following after Frosta as Alin's locator spell leads the way. During the trip Bow keeps an admirable distance between himself and the group; Catra stays in the back, keeping an eye on their flank in case of a surprise attack. With the assurance of Catra looking out for them, Adora worms her way to the front until she's in step with Bow. He glances at her but quickly directs his gaze forward with a huff.

Adora sighs. "Look, I know you're mad…and you have every right to be, but you *know* what her job is like. Unspeakables can't reveal details about their cases."

"Didn't seem like she had a hard time telling us earlier." Bow says, "in fact, she said Unspeakables have been breaking their vows left and right."

Adora frowns. "So, what, she should be like those Unspeakables who are betraying their nation by letting their secrets slip? She's doing the right thing and you know it—"

"The right thing is *not* manipulating us like we're some kind of pawns in her game." Bow demands, magic spiraling dangerously enough to cause Adora's to rise to the surface. He sends Adora a sharp look, "it's like I don't even know her…"

Adora snorts. "That's because you don't."

Bow snaps his head to her with a frown. "What?"

"It takes a strong person to work as an Obliviator, sorting through awful memories where you're left feeling helpless because it's just that—a memory. No matter how much we try, we can't change those. Then imagine becoming an Unspeakable with hopes of

stopping those memories from happening but, sometimes...you still get there too late." Adora says, "the point is, Catra's been slipping from our group since we beat Prime and I didn't help by leaving—"

Bow shakes his head saying, "you did what was best for you."

"—I should've done a better job checking in with her...Catra's chased away a lot of people's demons but along the way, they fought back." Adora swallows a thick emotion as her own demons threaten to rise up. "She's been on her own for so long, you know? I think it's just become second nature to do things like this."

"But we're here now." Bow argues.

"She knows." Adora smiles. "And that's great but it doesn't fix *years* of damage...and I'm not saying you should just forgive her but, I'm suggesting, you take it easy on her. Like you said, she's come a long way. There's a time where she wouldn't even tell us about what she had planned."

Bow seems to consider what Adora's said and after a long silence he asks, "how are *you* okay with settling for scraps of her?"

The question hangs in the air. A few months ago Adora would be embarrassed by her answer but it's hard to feel ashamed when Catra's suffered through the same.

"She's been doing it for *years,"* Adora shrugs, "it's time I returned the favor."

Bow's eyes go wide as he contemplates her answer. In the end, he offers no more words and they silently march onward.

The locator spell leads them through the thickness of the fog until they're coming out on the other side with a better perspective. And as the fog clears, a looming cave greets them with strange traces of magic radiating from it. *This is where they're hiding.* Adora motions for Frosta to step forward with Alin so he can lead

them the rest of the way. Bow kills the locator spell so his hands are free in case a fight breaks out.

"Lumos." Adora whispers, using her wand to lighten their path.

Frosta looks around in awe, taking in the concave walls carved with various stories. She runs a finger over a particular image and asks, "what're these?"

"Cave drawings." Catra supplies.

Adora looks over to see Catra walking into an area not surrounded by the light spell as she chooses to rely on her heightened eyesight. Catra glances at the drawings before she turns to Alin for confirmation. "Am I wrong?"

Alin shakes his head, lips pursed, showing slight distrust towards Catra; but she doesn't seem put off by it. "You're not wrong," Alin keeps moving forward as he tells them, "this place has a way of messing with your mind—making you think you have no option but to *stay* here—so, while we could, we wrote down our stories. Just something to remind us where we came from. It helps keep our sanity."

Adora looks at Alin's battered clothes again. She asks, "does it mess with your magic too?"

Alin frowns. "...when we were *sent* here, our wands were taken from us so we had two choices: learn wandless magic or die. But, like I said, this place has a way of holding you here; we've tried using apparition but it just brings us back to the cave. And sometimes, when we try planning other ways to escape, the voices come out..."

"Voices?" Frosta asks.

A shadow covers Alin's eyes. "They find us at night when we're sleeping…they say things like, *no one's waiting for you back home.* Or they'll bring up our worst memories until we decide our families are better off without us."

“That’s not true.” Frosta argues, “they’ve done *everything* to find you. Their lives have been miserable without you; I’ve personally spoken to your parents so I can promise you—you’re wanted.”

Alin blinks away the shadow from his eyes and offers Frosta a strained smile. He admits, “I don’t know if I believe that, but… things seem clearer with you around.”

Frosta blushes as she gives Alin a confident smile.

Adora finds herself smiling as well—proud of how far their friend has come; from riding the golden crew's coattails to blazing her own path as an Unspeakable, of all things. But, her revere is cut short as they reach a wide clearing lit with various candles embedded in the cave wall. And suddenly *hooded* figures emerge from the shadows—Adora can almost see their magical signatures as their defenses go up. But before a fight can break out Alin steps forward with his hands stretched out.

“Stop!” Alin exclaims, “they’re here to rescue us.”

The hooded figures look at one another before they part a path for a slim figure to walk through. *Maybe it’s their leader?* Adora guesses. And thankfully they don’t have to wait long; the figure removes their hood.

“Celine!” Frosta gasps, recognizing the woman from the case file.

Celine Allaire turns her nose up at Frosta and grunts a nasty reply, “what gives you the right to speak my name in such a familiar tone?”

Alin steps in front of Frosta and shoots a disapproving look at the older woman who appears to be in her mid-twenties. “Celine, they’re here to help.”

Celine’s eyes narrow. “I remember another time we thought someone was sent to *help* us when they were just another spy sent from the Ministry to help our fears fester—another way of ensuring our compliance.” Her gaze locks on Adora and in

response Catra's magic flares dangerously. "I know a Ministry dog when I see one. You're an *Auror,* aren't you? Just like *her."*

"I am." Adora confesses, not ashamed of who she is.

Celine snaps, "Alin, how dare you—"

"You can trust her!" Frosta argues, "you went missing five years ago so you were around during the wizarding war; don't they look familiar to you?" Frosta gestures at the golden crew anxiously.

For a moment there's nothing but fire behind Celine's stare but, as she takes the trio in together, her gaze slowly morphs into one of shock. A gasp escapes her mouth—her magic dies down—as she takes a staggering step backwards.

"You're," she whispers in awe, "the *golden girl.* The *savior* of the wizarding world."

Adora makes a face at the name. "I'm no one's savior, and I didn't do it alone either." She makes a point of turning to Bow and Catra.

Celine startles. "The golden quartet…"

"Our fourth member is watching our ship," Catra supplies, "which is waiting to take you home. *All* of you."

Celine still seems hesitant. "Is it really this easy?"

"I know what you're thinking." Catra says, "if we can take you away like this then what's been stopping you before, but Alin's explained the psychological trauma you've all experienced. And I can't promise things will get back to normal with your families but I *can* promise to get you out of here safe. And this kid," she nods to Frosta, "was the one who took the time to speak to each of your families and even risked her life to find you. And I bet she's willing to offer more support even when this is over. So, if you don't believe in us then maybe you'll believe in the girl who's never given up hope."

Celine drops her guard, shoulders falling as she tells the other hooded figures to submit. In response, the others remove their hoods. Adora recognizes most of them from the report Frosta reviewed with them earlier but this version of them looks worn—aged with time—and scarred with trauma. And while they came into this alone, they end-up leaving together.

Alin spares the cave one final look before leaving it behind him with nothing but the cave drawings to tell their story.

When they make it to the ship Catra uses an ice spell to create a bridge of sorts so Alin and the others have an easier time getting on board. Frosta and Seahawk stay with the survivors while Glimmer—having sensed Bow's inner turmoil—makes her way down to join them on the frozen bank of ice Catra's set aside for them.

Crunch. Glimmer steps closer until she's in speaking distance. She looks between the trio with a worried frown before her gaze settles on Catra. Adora's positive Glimmer knows the truth of this mission—it's impossible for her not to know with the bond she and Bow share—so Adora's surprised at how calm Glimmer addresses Catra.

"You've been working a case this whole time, and Frosta's involved in it." Glimmer starts off stating the facts. "Can't say I'm surprised, you two love throwing yourselves into work for some reason..."

Adora's pretty sure Glimmer knows the exact reason but she's grateful when her friend doesn't voice it.

"But apparently, there's still something you're not telling us." Glimmer's gaze flicks to Adora sympathetically. "Something you're not telling *any* of us...so I'll respect your privacy. Until then, we should head back and give Frosta a hand."

Adora gives a stiff nod in response and follows Glimmer and Bow to the ice bridge leading up to the ship. It's not until she's halfway

there does she realize Catra isn't following them. Adora spins around; her abrupt movement causes Glimmer and Bow to look her way.

Adora asks, "you coming?"

There's a brief pause in which Catra looks behind them, and when Adora follows her gaze she finds Catra silently communicating to Melog who's whimpering from the ship. Adora's breath hitches. She whips her head around and tries to gauge what's running through Catra's mind but it's a complex process—one she hasn't mastered divulging.

"Catra…" Adora whispers, shaking her head.

Catra clears her throat. "Part of my post-mission plan involves sending Alin and the others to a private infirmary to have them looked over for physical wounds while also having a therapist to assess their mental states. Frosta's gonna be busy taking their statements for her mission report so we've got some time before we head back to London. And I was hoping…" she trails off nervously.

"What is it?" Bow asks, surprising Adora with the softness of his voice.

Catra folds her arms, looking small. She avoids Bow's gaze and mutters, "there's something I need to look into."

Adora examines Catra's body language. There's something off about her request. If Catra wanted their help looking into a case she wouldn't be this anxious so it must be personal to her.

Adora realizes, "it doesn't have anything to do with your case, does it?"

Catra looks to Adora, seemingly grateful that she doesn't have to voice her concerns. Catra simply nods in confirmation.

Glimmer senses the tension in the air and says, "you don't have to —"

"I want to." Catra frowns, "I feel like I keep saying I'll work on trusting you guys more but then...I do the opposite. And it's harder with my job—nearly impossible—but *this,* I can tell you." Catra takes a deep breath as the secret weighs on her. "I've been distant lately because of these weird dreams I've been having—"

"Catra." Bow interrupts, looking sick to his stomach. "It's okay. I don't want to force you to—"

"You're not forcing me to do anything." Catra huffs, "when I was struggling with dark magic I felt like I was in this swirling blackhole that I couldn't escape—all because I didn't talk about what was going on; I just let it fester. And I know talking about it isn't a full proof solution but it *helps.* Keeping this bottled up isn't doing me any good so just, shut up and let me say this or I never will and then we'll just end up right back here—stuck in this cycle."

Bow hesitates. "Okay."

Catra nods. "Like I said, I've been having these weird dreams since the trial. I can't remember a lot from them but it always ends with a voice telling me to go to the Bermuda Triangle, but that's not what made me want to come here. Adora, do you remember when you found me with the Gringott's Dragon—Falkor?"

"Yeah," Adora nods, "you were all spaced out."

Catra licks her lips and confesses, "that's because I was *talking* to him."

"What?" Bow exclaims.

Adora finds herself not too far behind. "You were...how?"

"I didn't understand it the first time it happened—"

"First time?" Bow mutters to himself in shock.

"—but now I'm sure of it; Falkor cut my connection to Melog, temporarily, so we could talk." Catra holds her hands up when she senses they might jump at her with various questions. "I don't know *why* Falkor reached out to me, all he said was head to the Bermuda Triangle. The same thing happened with Emerald when we were at the Dragon Sanctuary—that's where I was when you guys were fussing over the baby dragon. Emerald basically told me the same thing—that I'd find the answers I've been seeking about my *lineage."*

Adora feels her blood turn cold.

"You think," Adora's voice sounds hollow in even her own ears, "...you think this has something to do with your *family?"*

Catra anxiously scratches her head. She mutters in a rush, "I don't know. Dragons are pretty cryptic."

"I still can't believe you spoke to *two* dragons." Bow gapes.

Catra scoffs. "Yes, they were very generous to drop this bomb on me."

"Why didn't you tell me?" Adora asks, trying to keep the panic from her voice—trying not to think the worst.

What if her real family is here?

Shut up, Adora argues with her dark thoughts.

If she has them then she won't need—

I said shut up! Adora's shout rings in her ear until nothing but a dull buzz remains.

"I honestly thought I was going crazy," Catra confesses, "...and I didn't want you guys worrying over something that might not be true so—I wanted to check for myself first."

“That’s where you were headed when you left Alin with those dugbog’s.” Bow says.

“You weren’t too far behind me, and I knew you were strong enough to save him if backed into a corner.” Catra says, “but I did hear a voice telling me where to go—kind of like a thrall.” Catra looks off to the side in somewhat of a daze, “they want me to go to the center of the triangle…”

Glimmer startles. “Beatrice said it’s too dangerous. You already risked enough when you went there to rescue Alin and the others—it’ll probably get worse if you spend more time there.”

“It might.” Catra shrugs, “but I have to try. I’ll regret it if I don’t.”

Bow whispers, “you’re seriously going back there.”

Catra offers a tight lip smile. “You don't get what it was like growing up with that *woman.* I’ve spent years hoping for answers about my family so I could find out why they would leave me with…” Catra shakes the thought away, “I’ve waited long enough. There’s no way in hell I’m letting it slip through my fingers.”

A weight drops in Adora’s stomach. *I get it.* If there was some way for Adora to speak to her parents—or any known living relative—she would take it. So while she doesn’t want Catra to go, Adora isn’t foolish enough not to realize the hypocrisy that will arise if she tries to stop her.

“I’m going with you.” Adora says, holding Catra’s hand in hopes of expressing all that she can without giving away too much. Catra squeezes her hand back in silent appreciation.

“I’m going too.” Bow says resolutely. He presses a hand to Catra’s shoulder and says, “I get why you can’t tell us about your Unspeakable missions—the work you do is important—but you don’t have to plan elaborate schemes with us. And stop treating us like pawns in—”

"Pawns?" Catra scoffs. "You and Glimmer are my *rooks.* I'd lose my moral compass—or what's left of it—if I didn't have you in my life."

Adora's face heats up when Catra turns to her with a lingering gaze.

"And you…you're my *queen."* Catra pauses and takes a second to think to herself—seemingly oblivious to Adora's internal meltdown. Catra decides with a hum, "now Seahawk…he's a pawn."

Glimmer grins, "don't let Mermista hear you say that." She lets the quip hang in the air before she steps deeper into the huddle. Glimmer says, "I'm with you too."

Catra raises an eyebrow, skeptical. "So, you're not pissed at me for ruining our Holiday…again?"

"Oh, I was *livid* when Bow told me what happened but…" Glimmer's voice softens, "we knew what we were getting involved with. Not much has changed since school."

"No." Bow interrupts, catching their attention. Glimmer gives him a look of warning but Bow powers on. "I feel like too much has changed...Catra, sometimes I feel like we're *strangers.* I mean...would we have even seen each other this year if Glimmer hadn't forced you into that Holiday in New York? Or if you hadn't run into me in New Zealand?"

Catra flinches as she admits, "probably not until your wedding, no."

"Exactly." Bow's voice trembles; he looks away from the group and stares off at the sea. "...being used in your game—even as a rook—sucks but that's not even why I'm mad."

When Bow seems tongue tied, Glimmer's magic springs forth and embraces him in search of the truth. Once she has it Glimmer reveals, "it's *fear."*

“What?” Catra frowns. “Of *me?”*

“Of growing apart.” Bow confesses.

A sharp pain stabs Adora in the heart as Bow’s voice echoes. And maybe it’s because Bow’s magic is so fresh in the air, but she can relate all too well. Her gaze flicks to Catra whose brow is scrunched.

“...seriously? That’s what you’re worried about.” Catra offers a soft smile, “you think you’re getting rid of me that easily? I’m in it for the long run, Arrows.”

“I mean it.” Bow argues, “you two are always busy; it takes a national *scandal* just to get the four of us in the same place. And I love both of you but—don’t you ever get tired of all this?” He glances at Glimmer saying, “I know we do.”

He’s right, it has to end eventually but—while Adora’s still able—she’ll continue working in the field. Too many things are left unsettled with Mara and Adora fears Bermuda is just the beginning. Even so, maybe the future will be brighter if more people like Frosta are slowly climbing the Ministry ranks. With even the hope of more workers like her, Adora won’t mind taking it easy with her desk job position as the Director of Magical Security. As for Catra, there’s no telling where her mind is.

As Catra shifts her gaze to the side—avoiding their curious stares—Adora realizes her girlfriend either has no clear answer, or she’s withholding it. Adora doesn’t know which is worse. And while Catra never answers the question they’ve all been wondering, she does offer Bow some comfort.

“I won’t lie and say we’ll never grow apart,” Catra says, “but I can promise you, if we do, we’ll find our way back.”

It doesn’t fix all the issues they have between them, but it’s enough to move forward.

Catra tells Frosta to hold down the fort, not trusting Seahawk not to set something on fire unsupervised. Adora stays close to Catra during their journey back to the ominous island they found Alin on. If Catra notices Adora's tight grip on her hand she doesn't call her out on it; all Catra does is squeeze her hand in return at equal pressure.

The thick fog returns with a wicked intensity, even their light spells struggle to blaze a path. And this time around, there's no threat of dugbog's or any other magical creatures lurking on the island; it's off putting for Adora. *This is too perfect,* as if every measure is being taken to ensure Catra reaches her destination without any unnecessary hassle.

"Adora," Catra's voice breaks her from her thoughts. Adora blinks away her daze and takes a step forward only to be hindered by an invisible magical force—similar to a protego spell. But somehow, Catra's able to walk through it without any strain. Catra looks at their joined hands, brow bunching up, before she meets Adora's gaze. "What's wrong?"

Adora licks her lips; she tries to push through the spell but the magic is beyond anything she's ever felt before. And yet, it's so *familiar.*

"There's some kind of protection spell, I can't pass." Adora says, frantic.

Bow grunts, giving it a try only to meet the same fate. "I can't either."

"I didn't even notice it." Glimmer mutters, frowning at such a display of power. "We should've at least felt it approaching."

Adora turns to Catra whose gaze is fleeting—flickering over her shoulder to where the fog is at its thickest. The *center* of the triangle. Adora presses her forehead to the barrier keeping them apart and closes her eyes as she prepares for the worst. She

won’t be the one who keeps Catra from learning the truth about her family, no matter how *terrified* it makes her.

In the off chance that something does happen to Catra where Adora’s not able to physically be there for her, Adora can use her two-way mirror to get in touch. But there’s something nagging at her—Beatrice’s voice on repeat to remind her of the horrors granted to someone who stays in the center of the triangle for too long: *it likes to lock people away, draining them of their magic until nothing more remains of who they once were.* The warning has remained fresh in Adora’s mind since they left the ship, and she was fine with Catra getting answers as long as she wasn’t *alone.* But now, Adora doesn’t know what to think.

Still, even though her heart is against itself, Adora takes a deep breath and opens her eyes. She finds Catra staring back at her. Adora does her best to offer a supportive smile before she gives her blessing.

“Go ahead.” Adora's voice sounds thick in her own ears.

Catra frowns. “You sure?”

Adora is anything but. Trace memories of the time Catra seemingly disappeared from the face of the earth comes to mind. It feels like ages ago since Catra was called to speak with the Unspeakable Division heads but, not being able to trace Catra’s magical signature—or contact her with the two-way mirror—is fresh in her mind. Adora fears the mirror won’t be enough to keep them connected. But, most of all, she fears Catra might make the decision not to return all of her own free will.

Even so, Adora lies with a swift, “I’m sure.”

And then, Adora lets go.

The oddest thing happens when Catra walks into the center of the triangle. The looming fog dissipates and—in the blink of an eye—a hallway, that seems to go on forever, takes its place. Catra looks

to her left, noticing a familiar bench, and then she turns right and eyes the white coated walls. Her heart speeds up, her body moving on autopilot as she swiftly approaches the gigantic wooden doors. Instinct tells her to push them open and on the other side she finds a room also painted white with a tall woman standing at the center. A light seems to be encasing her; to Catra the woman glows with power and radiance but, for some reason, she appears nervous. It's such a *human* reaction for such a powerful being and so it appears odd on her. But Catra isn't given the time to debate it.

Suddenly, stolen memories come flooding back.

"You." Catra whispers.

The woman offers an awkward grin. "Me."

Catra's wide eyed stare, coupled with her silence, causes the woman grief.

The woman clears her throat and gestures to their surroundings. "I hope you don't mind me sprucing up the place but, I thought it might help you adjust better if I made it look like the first room we met in."

Catra's thirst for magical knowledge takes over for a moment and she can't help but ask, "what is this place? Adora said—"

The woman *smiles* at the name but Catra saves that reaction for later and continues unprovoked.

"—some kind of protection spell was keeping her back. Did you do this?" Catra frowns, struggling between impressed and pissed off.

"Yes, but it's only for your friend's safety. The center of the triangle is dangerous for humans alone—staying here for long periods of time leads to terrible consequences." She explains, "I encased this space with my magic, that's why you were able to walk right through it without noticing because—"

“Our magical signatures are nearly identical...” Catra realizes with a frown.

The woman nods, seemingly proud of Catra’s intuition. “Exactly...it’s like the first time you and Adora formed a magical bond, she was able to dismantle your shield with ease; this is kind of like that.”

Catra startles. “How do you—”

“I told you last time,” she smiles, “I’ve been watching you.”

Catra wants to rage—wants her magic to burst to the surface—but the aurora encasing the woman makes her feel at *ease.* A warmth that Catra’s never experienced before wraps around her and holds her tight. And suddenly, tears come flooding down because—

“You’re my *mum.”*

There’s no doubt in Catra’s mind.

“C'yra D'riluth,” she supplies with a grin. “You would’ve been named after me but—”

Pure magic laces through the air as Catra accumulates enough into her fist just before she lunges at C’yra with a punch. But what greets her on the other side is a sounding *smack!* Catra’s chest heaves—her hair is scattered about—as she hangs her head down, the top of which grazes C’yra’s chest.

C’yra has one free hand out, effortlessly capturing Catra’s fist in a *gentle* grasp; she keeps Catra immobilized.

“...what do you want from me?” Catra demands, not lifting her head.

C’yra has the nerve to sound hurt as she whispers, “I wanted to see you.”

"You've been gone my *entire* life." Catra growls, trying to pull her fist away but C'yra keeps a strong hold—refusing to let go. Catra continues to rage, unaware of the tears streaming down her face as she shouts: "You left me alone with that *woman* at that god awful home, do you *know* what she did to me? She forced me to learn *dark magic* because she said I wouldn't be strong enough on my own at Hogwarts; I was *ten* when it started. Do you know how fucked up that was? Can you even comprehend the strain that had on me? I was in a blackhole, for years, and you could've pulled me out; I went into Hogwarts lashing out at anyone who tried to help because the voices in my head outweighed them all. It was a constant struggle—Scorpia and the others did their best to keep me afloat and for a while, it seemed like it was enough.

"But *then,* during my sixth year, someone put my name in the Goblet of Fire with hopes of seeing me *fail.* It was already bad enough being a *hybrid* but then—I was front and center for the world to see and they *hated* me for something I couldn't control. Micah and Adora helped me during my dark magic withdrawal—and my friends were with me when the public ridiculed me—and despite what they wanted, I *won* the tournament; and I thought I'd have a second to breathe but *then* Prime decided to resurface and turn our worlds upside down. I didn't fight for the country that scorned me during the tournament—I fought for Adora—for my *friends* so we could have something better."

Catra chokes out a hollow laugh. "And when Adora left to join the Auror Academy they had the *nerve* to demand *more* from me—parading my face around the school as some kind of symbol. And even now—after everything—they still want more." Catra snaps, "and now you have the nerve to show up here like we can just move on from that. Mother's are supposed to nurture their kids—not throw them to the wolves. So *why?* Why leave me with so much weight to carry?"

Catra's heaving by the end of her fit. She feels like a teenager all over again—the same girl who would *rage* at everything, but this time around there's no Weaver around to hand out punishments. Instead, there's C'yra with her steady hand; she places it atop

Catra's head for comfort. And part of Catra wants C'yra to be cruel, just so Catra knows she wasn't missing much growing up without her.

In the end, Catra isn't granted the luxury.

"I never wanted to leave you alone." C'yra says, "life just had other plans for you and I, and I know there's nothing we can do to change the past but I want you to know I planned on giving it all up. When I found out I was pregnant I planned on leaving the Unspeakable field so I could focus on you. But, it's not easy stepping away...I think you can relate."

Catra shrugs, not offering anything else; she lets the woman—her mum—lead the conversation.

"I was great at my job so the Ministry held onto me for as long as they could; during my official final mission I was ambushed by a dozen death eaters, I won't go into specifics about the case but...let's just say I was on the brink of revealing something people wanted to keep hidden."

Catra looks up. "It took a *dozen* death eaters to kill you?"

C'yra smirks. "Where did you think you got your talent from?"

C'yra's smug expression startles Catra into reality, *she's seriously my mum.* Catra takes the time to finally take in the long brown locks, to her sharp blue eyes, her towering height, and finally her hybrid features.

"It's like I'm looking in a mirror." C'yra says, mostly to herself, but it breaks Catra from her shock.

"You still left me alone." Catra growls, "why not have a relative look after me? In your will you explicitly placed me in the care of the foster system." Catra still recalls the night Weaver used the evidence to shame her further.

"Your father was a *pureblood* who married a *hybrid;* each of our families disowned us. In my will I had you placed in an orphanage because I didn't trust my family to take care of you."

Catra argues, "anything was better than Weaver."

"Trust me." A dark look looms over C'yra's face. "It could've been much worse...but I'm sorry they placed you in that particular home."

Catra's glare flickers, the fire in her gut slowly dies because *it wasn't all bad;* there was Adora, Lonnie, Rogelio, and even Kyle. They became her family.

Catra's shoulders fall. "...what happened to dad?"

"He died," C'yra frowns at the unpleasant memory, "right before you were born; a heart attack of all things. But his death really put perspective on things. I always thought if I was the strongest Unspeakable ever then nothing could stop me but, even with all the magic in the world, you can't escape death. If you try to, that's when darkness takes over and you become like Prime—a shell of your former self, jumping from Horcrux to Horcrux. That's no way to live."

Catra swallows a lump in her throat. "What was dad like?"

C'yra smiles fondly and rolls her eyes. "Too nice...but he had this *fire* about him; I saw it most when we were in class. He was always getting the top scores—making me take second and being apologetic about it, but I knew he was competitive at heart; he just hid it well." C'yra says, "you're a lot like him."

Catra lets all *that* sink in before asking, "if you died on that mission then how can we meet like this? And why are you in charge of overseeing broken vows?"

"Like I said, I was great at my job and Merlin didn't want my talent to go to waste." C'yra says, "so, he gave me a choice: continue living, in a sense, overseeing the punishment of those

who break their vows all while granting me a realm I can shape however I want—with the chance to watch over you—or die.”

“*Merlin* gave you your own realm?” Catra gapes.

C’yra nods. “You remember the waiting room you had to sit in before coming inside a room nearly identical to this one. And don’t make that face, Merlin in just like the rest of us—”

“Just a powerful deity.” Catra deadpans.

“Exactly,” her mother smiles.

“Wait...” Catra asks when a thought comes to her, “last time I was in the waiting room there was another version of me from an alternate universe; does that mean there are alternative versions of you too?”

C’yra offers confirmation but doesn’t delve deep into the topic. “It does.”

Catra frowns. “Then why the hell is there only *one* waiting room? I can’t imagine you have budget cuts in a realm you can shape.”

C’yra laughs; it’s a light angelic melody.

“The waiting room is Merlin's doing, but each door is different and leads to the person who summoned you.” She explains, “because of my job limitations you’re only allowed to see me if you break your Unspeakable vow. I wiped your memory of our last meeting so you wouldn’t deliberately break another vow to see me. And last time I cut our meeting short because you seemed busy.”

Catra sullenly recalls the trial and the events leading after.

“I waited until things cooled down before reaching out to you. The center of the triangle weakens your ties to this world so that’s why we can speak in this place. But because our ties are weakened, it’s not safe for either of us to be here for long periods of time...but, I selfishly wanted to see you.”

Likewise.

After a second Catra whispers, "why now?"

"You've been busy with so many things, I couldn't find the right time. I also wanted to make sure you were strong enough." C'yra pushes on when Catra starts to argue, "not just physically but mentally. This space has a way of *warping* things and I didn't feel safe contacting you until I was sure you were ready."

Catra suddenly realizes, "you're the reason people have been breaking their vows without facing repercussions—the world is off balance because you're here with me."

"Yes." C'yra ducks her head, guilty. "But things will go back to normal once I return."

Return. The word flips a switch inside Catra. No matter how pissed she is about this situation she can't find it in her to fuel the fire; from what it sounds like, her mum did everything in her power to keep Catra away from her crazy relatives and went further to make sure they could eventually meet. And time is fleeting. Catra can feel her magical core being drained the longer she remains in this space.

It would be a waste of time for Catra to focus on the negatives. And, for whatever reason, she's been granted this opportunity. *I won't let it slip.*

C'yra grunts in surprise as Catra uses her free hand to wrap around her waist and, instinctively, C'yra does the same. They stand in the void, safely wrapped in each other as the world slowly falls apart around them.

Catra doesn't know how much time passes before she hesitantly breaks the hug.

"You're *here."* Catra laughs nervously.

C'yra smiles, just as nervous. "I am."

Catra tries to ease the tension, "I can't believe you went through all this trouble to get me here. I mean *dragons,* seriously? How long have you been planning this, and was becoming an Unspeakable even my *own* idea?"

C'yra scrambles to reassure her, "it was completely your idea, I had no control in making decisions for you; I think it became clear during the phase you had where you dyed your hair—"

"Can we not?" Catra groans into her palms.

C'yra smirks knowingly before she carries on, "but I may have… whispered a few suggestions in Falkor's ear to get the ball rolling. Just for extra guarantee. The rest worked itself out."

Now I know where I get my scheming from, Catra thinks with a snort. Unfortunately, her joy dampens as reality sets in. Beads of sweat roll down the side of her face. *I have nothing to prove to her, so why am I so nervous?*

Catra looks away; she breaks the silence and starts muttering to herself, "I've wanted to meet you for so long but now that you're here I can't think of anything to ask…"

C'yra gives her a knowing smile and begins to list off her fingers, "I was complete *rubbish* at healing when I first learned it, same as you, it took me ages just to get through the basics; your father and I met in school when I accidentally hexed him, instead of getting angry he asked me to show him how to do the spell and since then we were inseparable—it's cliche but, it's our story; and yes, you're father was a complete idiot at times so it seems like a generational curse…"

Catra laughs. "You heard all that, huh?"

"Of course, Cat." C'yra smiles fondly. "I remember all the questions you've asked yourself about me when you were growing up."

"Cat?"

“It’s what I used to call you. Do you hate it?”

Catra’s stomach feels warm but she offers a shrug. “No. I don’t hate it.”

“Better than Wildcat?” C’yra teases.

Catra groans into her palm. “You can blame that one on Scorpia, and you can’t forget DT’s loving yet insufferable: *kitten.* Wait, are you seriously laughing? You wouldn’t be if you had those two practically shouting those nicknames down the hallway; DT always did it to piss me off and Scorpia...well, she was just being herself so I can’t say much about it.”

When C’yra’s laughing dies down she says, “even if they drive you crazy, you love them. Right?”

Catra doesn’t hesitate. “I do.”

“Can you thank them for me? Tell them I appreciate them for looking out for you when I couldn’t.” C’yra says.

“Yeah.” Catra looks away, getting lost in a memory. “I honestly don’t think I would’ve made it through school without them; I would’ve been kicked out for fighting if Scorpia didn’t hold me back. But then, one day I saw someone bullying her for being a hybrid so DT and I stepped in to help; I think that’s when I realized I wasn’t alone. It gave me something to fight for—gave me something to prove. Every time they said I couldn’t...it just added more fuel.”

“They hate what they can’t control.” C’yra explains, “as Magicats we possess magic in its purest form and so, the people who harass you do it out of *fear.* They don’t know your true potential so they try to make sure you never reach it.” C’yra grabs Catra by the chin, she tilts her head up, saying: “I’m glad you proved them wrong.”

Catra feels a weight dig into her chest but she tries to play it off saying, “proving people wrong is my specialty.”

“Of course,” C’yra says softly, “I’d expect nothing less from my daughter.”

The youthful part of Catra that still exists—actively seeking parental approval—is finally put to rest. Catra quickly blinks away her tears.

“But,” C’yra decides, “I think out of all the friends you’ve made—Bow and Glimmer are my favorite; watching you form a bond with them was one of the greatest things I’ve got to witness, although…you know what else will top it?”

Catra’s too busy putting her emotions in check, she fails to catch on to the mischievous glint in her mother’s eye. Catra looks up asking, “and what’s that?”

“Your wedding.”

“What?”

C’yra’s gaze flicks to the left as she teases, “will there be another?”

Catra stutters, “of course not,” and if there’s any doubt about C’yra being her mother it’s completely tarnished at this moment. Only her mother could turn the tables on Catra so quickly.

C’yra looks back at her asking, “then why are you pushing her away?”

Catra flinches. “I’m not.”

“Is it worth it?” C’yra asks suddenly. But maybe it’s not sudden; she’s been watching Catra her entire life so she knows the root of her problems. C’yra digs them up and reveals them to the room, demanding a thorough examination.

Catra clenches her fist, trying to avoid the approaching conversation with a deflective shout. “Was it worth it for *you?”*

Despite the obvious taunt, C'yra doesn't rise to the bait. Instead, she answers to the best of her ability. "Our situations are different, I was a single mother with no family after your father died and, in some ways, taking Merlin's deal was the only sensible option. I didn't take up this position for *power,* I did it for my family." C'yra flicks her eyes to the left again as she says, "you need to figure out your own path."

Catra follows her mother's gaze and finds a jagged white wall—it's folding in upon itself, letting in bouts of fog. *Her spell is wearing off,* Catra realizes with a start. She whips her head around and finds the light that was once engulfing her mother dying down into a gentle flicker; even her eyes are growing dark.

"No." Catra frantically shakes her head, latching onto her mother's forearms—refusing to let go. "You can't do this again…"

C'yra pulls her into a hug. Catra feels a familiar trace of magic in the air, followed by something digging into her jacket. "A gift," her mother says. Catra has a question but C'yra is already fading away—her body floats in the air, Catra's grip alone isn't enough to keep her there.

"No, no, no…" Catra mutters until her voice is raw; she tries digging her claws into her mother's forearms but they pass right through.

"I know I'm not one to reprimand you on this but, give Bow and Glimmer a chance at the truth sometimes—they might prove you wrong in the best ways—and give Melog a hug the next time you see them, cutting off your connection hasn't been easy on them —"

"Stop it." Catra shouts, "you're not—"

"—respond to Frosta's letters whenever she writes you, she looks up to you more than you realize." C'yra continues even as she's lifted further and further away. "And give Adora my best, tell her there are no words I can give to express how *thankful* I am that

she's in your life; on your bad days I wanted to be there for you but couldn't. But, whenever I felt like hugging you she was there with open arms."

Catra whimpers, *"mum…"*

"I love you, Cat." It's the last thing C'yra says before she gives up fighting—her body disappears into small glowing particles. The wind carries her away and soon Catra's alone in the center of the triangle with a blanket of fog encasing her. But she's not alone. Suddenly a string of voices whisper devious taunts in her ear when she's at her weakest:

She left you, again.

Catra shakes her head, digging her hands into her frazzled hair. "No…" there's somewhere important she has to be, but her resolve is so fuzzy all of a sudden.

There's nothing for you out there...your family is here. Stay and fight for it.

Catra falls to her knees with her head pressed to the ground, stricken with grief. *Not again,* Catra thinks on repeat, fueled by the voices around her, *I'm not losing her again.* Catra's magic springs forth in its purest form until it surrounds her entire body in a glowing cloak. Catra staggers to her feet, the fog around her jerks back as if it's afraid of the magical waves coming off her. She lifts her head to the sky with hollowed eyes. Every warning she's received about the triangle is the furthest thing from her mind.

All the answers to your problem are right here.

You can change it all...

I can, Catra agrees. So why would she leave now?

Catra whispers, "wingardium leviosa."

Catra's body jerks forward; her body floats off the ground and chases off in the direction her mother went. Time eludes her. Catra doesn't know how far she gets before everything turns black.

0

"...wake up."

A white ceiling greets Catra when her eyes open; she stifles a yawn and carefully pushes up on her elbows—finding herself in a comfortable bed. Catra looks around, frowning. *What's going on…*

"Finally, you're up." C'yra stands over her with her brow furrowed. She presses the back of her hand to Catra's forehead and mutters, "you don't feel sick."

Momentarily thrown off, Catra asks "why would I?"

Her mother feigns a look of innocence when she says with a shrug, "it's just not like you to sleep in on the first day back." When that doesn't get the desired reaction she tries another angle, "come on Cat—"

Cat?

"—you're a *sixth year* now."

"Sixth year…" it all comes rushing back. A grin breaks out across Cat's face and she leaps out of bed with an excited shout, "oh yeah!"

C'yra eyes her daughter once more. "You sure you're okay? You seem a little sluggish."

"No, I'm fine it's just," Cat rubs her forehead and mutters with a pout, "I had this really weird dream last night…"

"Oh yeah? What was it about?"

Cat furrows her brow and confesses with a startle:

“I can’t remember.”

Chapter End Notes

We’ve reached 100k words!

I was thinking of cutting this chapter short at the section where Adora let go of Catra’s hand but that would’ve been a brutal cliffhanger. And I know this chapter was terribly long but I think there were lots of good plot points and ending with Cat was in some ways an even worse cliffhanger but at least you get the convo with Catra and C’yra for compensation.

I have notes for this chapter in terms of character development (things I want to point out) but I’ll save it for later because it ties into the next chapter and I don’t want to spoil anything. Plus, I have a feeling you’ll all need a break after this intense chapter.

Thanks for reading.

World of Mirrors

Chapter Notes

> POSSIBLE TRIGGER WARNING: there will be mentions of mental health issues (just briefly discussed) at the beginning of this chapter; just a heads up if it makes anyone uncomfortable.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

0

Fright Village, London

The D'riluth house is buzzing with magic as the bittersweet end of summer vacation hits—marking the final move-in day for Hogwarts students—and while Cat's room is always teetering on the chaotic side, it's even more pronounced as floating articles of clothing, and books, arrange themselves in a nearby suitcase. All the while, Cat stands at her full-length mirror and takes in her appearance: white dress shirt tucked lazily into slim fitted black slacks with a skewed green tie to represent her house. *Why do we have to wear our uniforms even when classes haven't started?* Cat pouts, pulling her long hair into a quick ponytail as she recalls Angella saying: *it's important for our students to look presentable on all occasions.* Cat rolls her eyes at the memory and then gives herself a final look over.

Deeming herself presentable, Cat races out her room and heads downstairs with her suitcase and other selected belongings chasing after her. She makes a sharp right, veering into the kitchen, while her belongings gather by the fireplace.

Cat announces, "alright, everything's ready."

C'yra finishes her coffee before she strides across the room to access her daughter; she cups Cat's face within her hands,

brushing away a stray strand of hair that slipped loose from her ponytail and asks, "you sure you're alright?"

"Mum." Cat whines as she carefully pries the hands off her squished face. "I told you a dozen times, I'm fine. Stop worrying."

"It's my job to worry." Cat rolls her eyes when her mother's back is turned but quickly masks her expression when C'yra whips around with a small black notebook in her hand. C'yra waves around the book in question with an eyebrow raised. "And you forgot *this,* so don't tell me not to be worried."

Cat gasps as the gears in her head finally decide to start moving, "my journal?" Confused, Cat reaches out for it only to have her mother hold it out of reach.

C'yra frowns. "You *never* forget this."

It's true, Cat *never* leaves the house without it. The journal in question was gifted to Cat when she started having depressive episodes nearing the anniversary of her father's death, Cat herself suffers from bipolar disorder—something her mother wouldn't have realized without the stressor of the daunting anniversary triggering Cat's first depressive episode when she was fourteen years old. Therapeutic journalism was offered by her counselor to help Cat address her emotions—finding a healthy way to approach them without ignoring them all together. It's a very *muggle* technique—most wizards and witches don't believe in mental health issues, seeing them as a form of weakness—but C'yra understood the importance of mental balance and stability; she made sure to get Cat a therapist so she could discuss issues she might not feel comfortable talking about with her mother. And while it was rough at first—being just a *child* talking to a stranger about a man she never got to know—Cat eventually found relief in her sessions; it became a safe space.

"So," C'yra says, "I'll ask again. Are you *sure* you're alright?"

Cat makes sure to meet her mother's eyes as she promises, "I'm sure...today's just hectic you know?"

"Are you nervous? About your sixth year."

"Kinda?" Cat licks her lips, forming a fist so she doesn't break out into a pace. "I'll be graduating *next year,* and that means I'll have to start studying for my N.E.W.T's exam…"

"And what have I told you about that exam?"

Cat snorts. "You said it's just a stupid standardized test that puts too much emphasis on *numbers,* and it unknowingly places us into these boxes to the point where we actually believe there's a limit to what we can or can't do. Oh, and it doesn't mean anything in the long run."

"Exactly, don't let it hang over your head. I want you to cherish the time you have left with your friends because you'll be graduating soon and one day you'll be surprised at how much you miss it." C'yra hands Cat the journal and her daughter safely pockets it into the messenger bag strapped across her shoulder. But before Cat can slip away C'yra asks her, "don't you want breakfast before you go? It'll be your last home cooked meal."

Cat tries to stifle her nausea at the thought of her mother cooking anything. *She has a lot of talents,* Cat thinks, *but cooking isn't one of them.*

"Uhm…" Cat scans the kitchen in haste and focuses on a nearby fruit basket. Cat desperately snatches an apple and takes a hefty bite. She offers her mother a smile and says with a mouth full, "problem solved!"

Luckily, her mother leaves the issues alone and focuses on preparing for their departure. And so, C'yra pulls out her wand, not wanting to waste raw magic on such a mundane task, and with a quick twirl, Floo powder is sprinkled across the fireplace—opening the door to the Floo Network. Cat's luggage shoots

through the green fire as directed by C'yra while Cat follows her mother to the fireplace.

"Shall we?" Her mother asks with a hand offered.

Cat takes her mother's hand and together they walk through the green fire, emerging on the other side unburnt. They appear in a crowded women's bathroom that's lined with dozens of fireplaces, each of which is shooting out green fire as other students, accompanied by their parental figures, make an appearance. C'yra keeps a tight hold on Cat's hand, not wanting her to get lost in the crowd, and swiftly guides them from the bathroom and out into King's Cross Station with their luggage trailing not far behind.

The familiar cobblestone road greets them as they begin their journey to platform 9 and ¾ and all the while, Cat eagerly looks around the station in search of familiar faces; she's so distracted she nearly collides into her mother's back as C'yra stops walking. Cat frowns, wondering what's wrong, when she realizes they've reached the halfway point marking where parents are unable to proceed. She'd been in such a daze she doesn't even remember walking through the brick wall leading to platform 9 and ¾ but she's not surprised. *I've done it so many times it's like second nature now.*

"Okay, listen up." C'yra says with the clap of her hands.

Here we go. Cat stifles a yawn as her mother proceeds to launch into her annual *talk.*

C'yra grabs Cat by the shoulder, giving her the *look,* as she begins ranting, "I better not receive any letters from Angella about you causing trouble, well…" C'yra lowers her expectations as she realizes how unlikely they are, "okay, just try and stay out of trouble for at least a few weeks; and clean up after yourself, your room better not be a mess—"

Cat argues, "but I live alone!"

As a Prefect Cat's expected to do a lot of things she doesn't want to, so having her own dorm is one of the only upsides. At first, Cat was sure Angella gave her the position just to torture her with all the meetings, nighttime monitoring, and student touring, but one day, when Cat got into trouble (as she tends to) she snapped and tried to call Angella out on it. Cat recalls the conversation and the surprise she had when Angella responded saying:

"Miss D'riluth, I appointed you as Prefect because you're the brightest student in your house, and a skilled witch, and I believe, with time and 'a lot' of patience—"

"You put emphasis on 'a lot', but okay." Cat mutters.

"—you can be a great leader if you give it a chance."

Their conversation didn't stop Cat from getting into trouble, but it did change the way she went about her responsibilities as a Prefect.

"I don't care if you live alone," C'yra says, "your room isn't a mess at home so the same applies for when you're at school. And keep up with your studies—"

"Easy." Cat shrugs.

"—and listen to your professors and be respectful."

Cat grunts, "as long as they're respectful to me there won't be any problems."

"You say that every year." C'yra says, a small smile pulling on her lips before her eyes flick to a nearby clock; she sighs, realizing her time is slowly depleting. She pulls Cat in for a goodbye hug, pressing a chaste kiss to Cat's forehead and whispers, "I know I'll be going back to work now that you're back in school but don't hesitate to reach out, I'm only an owl away; and you know Sparrow *always* finds a way to me."

Cat nods into her mother's shoulder, smiling. "I know, mum."

C’yra squeezes her one last time and pulls away saying, “I love you.” But, as she tries to part, Cat digs her claws into the fabric of her jacket until they’re reaching C’yra’s skin—drawing blood. And then something sharp shoots through the air—something C’yra hasn’t felt before—but just as quickly as it came, it disappears. Cat seems to shake herself out of it and finally lets go.

Cat blinks away whatever possessed her to latch onto her mother’s arm like it might be the last time she’ll ever see her again. Cat gulps down the emotions building in her throat and offers a shaky grin saying, “I love you too.”

C’yra doesn’t have a chance to respond as Cat spins on her heel and races onto the train; she does however stop by the door to wave at her mother who offers the same gesture in return (although, it seems stifled).

When enough time elapses, Cat turns around to face the roaring crowd as students shuffle eagerly into their sections as they greet old friends. *Here we go,* Cat tightens her grip on her messenger bag and carefully strides down the narrow walkway of the train. She peeks her head into a few seating sections in search of her friends but comes up empty; she does however spot Lonnie cuddled close with Kyle and Rogelio in their own isolated section. Cat considers going over to catch up with them but decides against it. *I’ll see them around,* Cat decides, *I’ve got all year anyway.*

Cat’s broken from her thoughts as some underclassman who isn’t looking where he’s going bumps into her; he falls backwards, plummeting to the ground while Cat holds her footing. It’ll take a lot to knock her down—a skill she acquired during the rigorous hours spent helping Adora practice her quidditch plays.

With a sigh, Cat dusts off the spot where the underclassmen collided into her and then she turns to him. There’s a moment where she considers offering a hand to the kid—even though *he* wasn’t looking where he was going—when suddenly his face morphs into a repulsed scowl.

He shouts, "watch where you're going *hybrid!"*

A chill creeps over the train car as Cat's magic sparks to life, but she doesn't plan on making a big show of her power; she just wants to give the kid a taste of what she's capable of so she conjures up a spell, the words are on the tip of her tongue—maybe a stinging hex, or something to make him puke up slugs, she isn't sure yet—but she isn't given the chance to let it loose.

Another underclassman rushes over and stands between them with his arms outstretched. Cat's hand twitches the same way his face does as he offers a nervous smile.

"He didn't mean that!" The kid, who's *far* smarter than his friend, shouts.

Cat eyes the duo—her magic on standby—but ultimately she decides against it. *Mum said I can't stir up trouble until a few weeks,* she recalls their earlier conversation with a sigh. And so, Cat allows her magic to simmer down.

Cat steps over them and says in passing, "whatever."

"Are you an idiot?" She hears the smart friend whisper-shout, "that was *Catra D'riluth."*

Cat takes satisfaction in the way his friend responds in a nervous splutter, *"that* D'riluth?"

"My, my, my," a familiar voice taunts as Cat steps into an empty train cart, "starting trouble so soon?"

Cat spins around with a grin as she says, "I've got to make an entrance."

"Wise words." One of her best friends, Double Trouble (DT for short), pulls her into a quick hug before they're ushering Cat to an empty seat. Cat places her messenger bag on the floor and leans against the window while DT asks eagerly, "so? What's the tea?"

"Tea?" Cat laughs, "you've definitely been in America too long."

DT sighs wistfully. "I honestly miss it."

Over summer vacation DT went to America, New York to be exact, to spend time with their cousins; they sent tons of letters to Cat about American cuisine and the show stopping Broadway shows. At one point Cat was worried DT might drop out of Hogwarts to embrace their passions as an aspiring actor but, alas, duty calls.

"But honestly," DT says, snapping out of their wistful daze, "what's been going on? In the last letter you sent you told me Miss blonde and gorgeous was coming over to your house practically every day during the summer—you even said she's been acting flirty with you and then: *poof.* I get no more letters from you."

Cat ducks her head, face flushed as she vividly recalls Adora's frequent trips to her house this summer. Adora actually lives in the same neighborhood as Cat, just a few blocks down, so it isn't a *huge* deal. But, what is a huge deal is how they spent nearly everyday together just talking and hanging out which eventually lead to Adora *kissing* Cat while they were walking home one night in July which also lead to a teary eyed *confession.* So, apparently, Adora's had a crush on her since their first year when she saw Cat hex a third year asshole who was bullying Scorpia. And, long story short—

"We're kind of *dating* now?" Cat confesses, biting her lip to stifle a grin.

DT blinks once, then twice, before a high pitched squeal erupts from their mouth causing a few heads to turn their way. Cat nearly falls from her seat as DT throws their arms around her. "It's a miracle!"

Cat pushes them away, frowning. "What does that mean?"

"It probably means that everyone's sick of seeing you two trip over your words when you're around each other. But don't worry, it was pretty cute, Wildcat." Their heads turn and they find Scorpia

leaning against the wall outside their door. Scorpia turns around with a sheepish smile when she feels their eyes on her. "Merlín, I'm sorry, you two seemed deep in conversation and I didn't want to interrupt."

Cat thinks listening in on a private conversation is ruder but there's no need for privacy when it comes to her best friend.

"Scorp!" Cat exclaims, eagerly waving the larger teen inside. Scorpia complies with ease, hugging each of them before taking a seat on the adjacent bench.

Scorpia smiles, nearly jumping out her seat as she asks, "so...did I hear what I think I heard?"

Cat nods, unable to stop smiling. "Yes, your eavesdropping was a success. Adora and I are girlfriends now."

Scorpia cheers. "Congratulations—"

DT rolls their eyes muttering, "—finally."

DT avoids the playful punch Cat sends her way before asking, "so how'd your mum take it? I bet she already knew, she's got, like, a sixth sense or something—she *always* knows whenever I'm sneaking out to your house."

"That's because you're shit at stealth and…" Cat mutters with a slight wince, "I haven't told my mum yet."

"What?" Scorpia's face falls. "Are you worried she might not take it well?"

Cat shakes her head quickly. "No it's not that, I know she'll be cool, I just wanted to keep it a secret for the summer because I knew school would get hectic...I guess I just wanted to avoid drama for as long as possible if that makes sense. Plus, Adora's crazy worried my mum won't like her—which is insane. My mum *loves* her, sometimes I think she wishes Adora was her daughter too."

Scorpia smiles. “You wanted to have something special that was just between the two of you, awe. I think it’s sweet.”

“Yeah…” Cat adds with a sharp grin, “and I also wanted to have as many *sleepovers* as I could with Adora before my mum finds out we’re dating and makes us sleep in separate rooms.”

DT slaps the back of Cat’s head saying, “and your true lecherous nature comes out.”

Cat rubs the growing sore spot on her head before she spins around with a hiss; she leaps over and wrestles with DT in retaliation. During their roughhousing, Cat fails to notice the arrival of two more guests.

“See? Every time we come over here something weird is happening.” Cat recognizes Glimmer’s voice and quickly untangles herself from DT. Glimmer notices the abrupt move and suddenly her lips quirks up. Cat huffs to herself as her magic sparks in irritation. “Don’t worry,” Glimmer teases, “your *girlfriend* decided to move in early so you don’t have to worry about being embarrassed by...whatever that just was.”

“Congratulations!” Bow exclaims, no longer able to hold it in, as he squeezes in behind Glimmer.

“Yeah congrats,” Glimmer adds with a genuine smile.

Cat smiles back. “Thanks.”

“Anyway,” Glimmer says, “we just wanted to—”

The metal case covering the vent located beneath the window Cat’s sitting next to pops off with a *bang!* The metal piece falls to the floor in a series of twirls before it rattles to the ground and, immediately after, a mop of purple hair pokes out. Everyone’s eyes go wide as bulky goggles greet them behind a cloud of dust.

There’s only a brief moment of peace before Glimmer screams, causing eyes to turn towards their cart once more.

"...just as I suspected, the air duct was clogged in the north cart so the AC wasn't working properly...but, I adjusted the temperature on the thermostat so the icing on my tiny cupcakes won't melt on the ride to school this time."

The final member of Cat's band of misfits—Entrapta Bolton—crawls out from the vandalized vent and sits cross legged in the center of their train section. She writes down a few notes in her tiny notebook before she pulls off her goggles to survey the room. Entrapta blinks at their startled stares.

"Hello! Oh, and congratulations Cat, I knew it was only a matter of time, although...my calculations were a bit off." Entrapta starts muttering about probability and hormones so that's when Cat decides to tune her out but she does offer a quick *thanks* before doing so.

"You see?" Glimmer mutters to Bow frantically, *"this* is why I don't come over here alone. Shit like this is always happening."

Bow eases Glimmer's tension with a comforting hand to her shoulders; he guides her from the room as he says over his shoulder, "we just wanted to say *hi,* but it looks a little crowded in here so we'll see you in the Great Hall for lunch?" Cat and the others agree to lunch and soon Bow's closing the door behind him to give them privacy for whatever it is they do.

When the coast is clear Cat plucks out a deck of cards and asks eagerly, "wanna play Exploding Snap?"

DT and Entrapta willingly gather to select their cards while Scorpia cautiously gathers her deck in fear of her cards exploding in her face like the last time they played. Cat has to frequently check to make sure no one of authority sees them playing because the game has been banned at Hogwarts ever since some idiot set a train cart on fire. *Stupid Seahawk,* Cat huffs, *has to ruin everything.*

They're so distracted with their game they don't notice when the train starts moving, and soon, after a handful of games in which Entrapta mostly takes the win (muttering about gambler's fallacy all the while), they arrive at Hogwarts. Most of the underclassmen quickly shuffle off the train while Cat and her crew take their time and finish their last game during which DT's deck explodes—earning a maniacal cackling laugh from Cat—while Entrapta, unsurprisingly, takes another win. Cat gathers the cards into her messenger bag, following behind her crew, and tucks them away just as she reaches the exit. Right on time.

"Miss D'riluth," Angella (Hogwarts Headmistress) greets her with a tired yet honest smile. "Welcome back…as to you Miss Bolton…" Angella continues to go down the list, greeting other familiar students, while Cat takes the opportunity to slip away. But, just as she's turning the corner, Angella adds "and I expect you to be at the Prefect meeting tomorrow, Miss D'riluth, bright and early this time. *Not* thirty minutes late."

"Yes ma'am." Cat says mockingly, which is as respectful as it gets coming from her so Angella lets it slide. And with one bomb disengaged, Cat walks into the Hogwarts with her friends at her side. A smile slips across her face as she realizes, *I actually missed this place. Weird.* She shakes away the nostalgia and pulls out her wand in case she's in the mood for some mayhem.

"Hey," Cat turns to DT and asks, "have you checked your schedule yet? I have Potions first block with some Professor I haven't heard of, and then I've got DADA with Professor Moon."

DT groans. "I have DADA first block and *then* potions…"

"I have charms for my first block, then herbology." Scorpia pouts.

Entrapta looks away from a gadget she's tinkering with to mutter, "my schedule is different too."

"It's like they're trying to separate us." Cat sighs, knowing it probably isn't too far from the truth.

On cue, a montage of shenanigans run through Cat's head—vivid images of the various schemes the four of them have gotten into over the years—but it slowly dies down when she passes a classroom with the door cocked open. Cat stops, brow frowning as she spots an ordinary mirror propped against a book on the Professor's desk in the front of the class. And suddenly, there's something scratching at her brain that's trying to get her attention. She feels like she's *forgetting* something. *Something really important.*

Confused, Cat reaches out—

"Kitten!"

Cat jerks her hand back and turns around and finds DT standing behind her with an eyebrow raised. They look at her startled expression before looking over her shoulder into the classroom—there's nothing exciting inside, just some books and desks, so DT asks, "what is it?"

Cat shakes her head saying, "nothing, I thought I saw something…and *stop* calling me that."

"But it's a purr-fect nickname." DT teases.

"I hate you."

DT loops their arm into hers and drags her away to their awaiting friends. "Correction. You *loathe* me, but we're both arseholes and no one else will put up with us. Now, come on, we're gonna fly brooms before getting lunch."

Cat's worries are vanquished as the opportunity for something competitive presents itself.

They make their way to the quidditch pitch and use their wands to call for their brooms which come flying from the sky and into their awaiting hands. They grab a leftover quaffle from the quidditch shed and split up into teams of two: Cat and Scorpia vs DT and Entrapta, and while Cat joined the game in hopes of the fiery feel

of competition, she feels nothing but joy as they goofily soar around—not taking the game seriously.

Sometime during the game Cat manages to intercept a pass between DT and Entrapta; she catches the quaffle and flies toward the trashcan they've designated as the goal.

"D'riluth steals the quaffle!" Scorpia says, hands cupped around her mouth as she pretends to be an announcer. "She soars towards the goal with seconds to spare! She aims—"

A flash of lightning is their only warning before a *downpour* of rain hits them with a vicious intensity.

"—and she's flying away…" Scorpia ends with a slight laugh that grows lower in pitch as Cat screeches and jerks her broom to the side, narrowly avoiding the trashcan, as she dives for cover under the side of the school.

Cat drops her broom and uses a drying spell to remove the wet spots on her uniform just as her friends join her under the covering.

"Let's head inside," Scorpia says, not in favor of flying during this kind of weather. Cat agrees and follows them into the school. When they reach the mid-way point to Hufflepuff territory Scorpia says, "I'm gonna change clothes for lunch but I'll meet you guys there."

"Sounds good." Cat says.

Entrapta makes a similar suggestion since Ravenclaw is on the other side of the school so Cat ends up walking into the Slytherin dormitory with DT at her side. The man inside the painting that guards the Slytherin dormitory raises an eyebrow at them as he awaits the code to allow them entry so Cat whispers it to him—earning instant access. The frame of the painting slides to the right, revealing a hallway leading to a common sitting room littered in green banners.

“I’ll swing by your room when I’m done changing,” DT says before slithering to their room down the hall.

Cat makes a noise of approval before she heads over to her Prefect room on the east wing with hopes of having a second to write in her journal before getting lunch. But, for some reason, she has a little trouble removing the protective wards she encased her room with. She manages to disarm them of course but there’s obvious resistance—magic that should be perfectly in tune with her own core fights against her but, as it notices her *power,* it eventually yields.

Cat slips inside her room and closes the door behind her with a frown. *Why was my magic fighting against me?*

“Don’t think so hard, you might hurt yourself.”

Cat reaches for her wand, startled at the presence of someone in her *warded* room, but her magic simmers down the instant she spots *Adora Grayskull,* her *girlfriend,* going through her drawers. While she’s in the process of plucking out one of Cat’s oversized Slytherin hoodies, she even makes a show of pressing it to her body to make sure it fits. Cat leans against the door, heart threatening to shoot out her chest while her hands start to sweat. Still, she somehow manages to form a coherent sentence.

“*You’re* the idiot in this relationship,” the mention of their new status still sends chills down Cat’s spine, “and what’re you even doing here?”

Adora shrugs. “You stole my hoodie so I’m only returning the favor.”

“By breaking into my room?”

“Okay,” Adora admits with a shit eating grin, “maybe I wanted to see you too.”

“Oh yeah? Well, I’m glad you're not in this relationship just to steal from me.” Cat takes in Adora’s cute snort before an idea

crosses her mind. She clears her throat and asks carefully, "hey, did the magic around my door feel weird to you when you came in?"

Adora unbuttons her blouse saying, "not really, why?"

"No reason." Cat trails off, taking in Adora's revealing sports bra. The appearance of smooth, flawless, skin halts Cat's train of thought but not in the way she expects it to. And suddenly, a strange memory presses against her mind. Cat holds onto the doorknob for some stability as the memory web is spun into a motion picture.

They're in the woods—the Forbidden Forest—at night, their clothes are soaked from falling in the lake, and Cat can feel her heart race as she panics. Then, she looks down and sees why. Adora's laying on the grass with a hole in her chest and Cat's trying to stop the bleeding. And if she looks at Adora's face for longer than a second she'll realize this version of Adora is older—scarred with trauma and hardship—but what holds her gaze is the jagged flesh atop Adora's exposed bosom. The word for it eludes her but then the memory supplies it:

"It's a failsafe," is what this version of Adora calls the mark branded on her skin. "It's his way of punishing me for surviving…a way to let me know he'll always be here, one way or another."

Cat comes out of the vision with a jagged breath; she frantically searches Adora's chest for the mark but comes up empty—there's nothing but unblemished skin. Cat shakes her head. *It was just a memory of my dream,* Cat tries to reassure herself. But, for some reason, she feels *sorrow* when she realizes the truth. *Why would I want her to have a hideous mark like that?* Cat looks away, mind reeling, as Adora finishes getting dressed.

"Hey, you okay?" Adora asks once she's finished.

Cat nods stiffly. "Fine…I actually came in here to write in my journal before lunch but I can do it after."

“You sure?” Adora frowns.

“Yeah.” Cat grins and tries to shift the conversation to something lighter, “plus, I’m starving from kicking DT and Entrapta’s arse in quidditch anyway.”

Adora’s frown deepens. “You played quidditch this morning?”

“Yeah, right after the train dropped us off.” Cat says while she turns to make sure all her luggage from the train is accounted for; her mother’s spell should’ve made sure everything stayed together during the trip but it’s always good to double check. When she’s finished, Cat notices the thick silence and turns back to Adora whose frown is only growing deeper with time. Cat asks softly, “what’s wrong?”

Adora crosses her arms, hugging herself, as she asks, “why didn’t you meet me in the Astronomy Tower? We *always* meet each other there on the first day back, when you didn’t show up I thought you missed the train and had to take the later one.”

Cat chastises herself for forgetting such an important task and then tries to reassure Adora as best she can. “Shit, I’m *so* sorry, I’ve been so spaced out today.”

Adora hesitates before asking, “do you want to talk about it?”

“It’s not really something I can talk about…” Cat frowns. “I had this weird dream last night and things have just been weird...I’m really sorry I left you up there alone, there’s no excuse for it.”

“Hey,” Adora reaches out and grabs her hand, “it’s fine, the view is always worth seeing...I’m more concerned with what’s got you so stressed out. Was the dream that bad?”

Cat is still put off by the *failsafe* portion she recalls from her dream and, for the first time in months, she *lies* to Adora saying, “I can’t really remember anything, that’s what sucks about it. But I’m fine, I promise.”

With one of their classic vows to seal the deal, Adora's frown dissipates in place of a gentle smile and then she closes her eyes and leans in for a kiss. Her lips are less than an inch away when a sharp pain works its way through Cat's chest. It feels like she's under some kind of attack and, in retaliation, Cat feels her claws slip out. Then, she *strikes.*

"Ouch!" Adora gasps, jerking her arm back to survey the claw marks seeping through the sleeve of her hoodie. Her terrified eyes flick to Cat whose breathing slows as she realizes what she's done.

"I'm so…" she trails off without a word because there are no words to make up for what she's done.

Knock! Knock! Cat gives Adora a fleeting look before she rushes over to answer the door—anything to get away from the mayhem she's caused. *I thought I was doing better...why am I lashing out, now, of all times.* Of course her life decides to unravel just when she has what she's always wanted.

"What?" Cat opens the door with a snarl.

DT seems surprised but when their eyes flick to the side, noticing Adora and her cradled arm, the surprise shifts in place of a grin. DT crosses their arms asking, "am I interrupting?" DT's voice has a teasing tilt to it as they mistake the mark on Adora's arm for another form of roughhousing.

"Yes," Adora answers swiftly, keeping her eyes locked on Cat as she says, "so can you give us a minute? We'll meet you in the Great Hall."

DT gives them a once over before nodding and making themselves scarce. Cat presses her forehead into the side of the door and tries to steady her breathing. She whispers, "I don't know why I did that…" to make it worse, there's a sick sense of *satisfaction* in gifting Adora with a mark—anything to get her closer to *that* version of Adora she saw in her dream.

No I don't want that, Cat shakes her head, *it's just a stupid dream, I won't even remember any of it in a few days.*

Adora cautiously presses a hand to Cat's shoulder. "Hey, come on, I'm pretty tough. Remember when I blocked that quaffle with my face last season? I stopped their winning goal and then we won the championships."

Cat laughs at the memory. "Shut up, I'm the one who hurt you—it should be *my* job to make *you* feel better."

"When you're happy, I'm happy." Adora assures her with a grin before she turns serious and says, "it's okay, I know you didn't mean to." She slips her arm through Cat's and guides them into the hallway. "Maybe some lunch will make you feel better, that always works for me."

Cat snorts. "Yeah, because all you do is eat."

Adora hits her with a quip of her own and then they're back to their casual bantering. Back to normal. Cat can almost fool herself of it, but her true emotions are in the way her body shrinks under Adora's touch and in the way her magic jerks—constantly on edge. *Why is it such a struggle to be around her?* They were fine during the summer, perfectly in sync, but now it's like Adora's out of step with her.

Cat tries not to dwell on it too much as they sit at their regular table in the Great Hall; Adora grabs a large helping of food and makes quick work of it while Cat takes just enough to hold herself over. She's worried she'll throw up whatever she puts down.

"That bad, huh?" Glimmer asks from across her when she notices Cat's not eating much. "I'm not surprised, the food *looks* great but it's honestly pretty shit sometimes—depends on the person who makes it."

Bow nods, sullen. "Yeah, unfortunately budgets had to be cut somewhere."

Adora says with a mouth full, "I like it."

Cat can't help but laugh. "Of course *you* do. You rush into eating just like you rush into everything else, no wonder you're in Gryffindor."

Adora looks bewildered and slightly offended. "*What?* Cat, I'm in *Slytherin*— with you—what're you talking about?"

"Did you hit your head this morning?" Glimmer asks, half teasing and half serious.

"No but," Cat rubs her head and groans, "I've been off all day."

"Are you okay?" Bow asks with a worried frown.

Cat nods. "Yeah, I just had this weird dream…but I can't remember what it was about."

DT breaks the tense air with a taunt. "Well, it must've been a *nightmare;* in what world would you date someone in *Gryffindor?"*

That's true. Cat welcomes the brief comfort and finds herself laughing along with her friends as her worry subsides momentarily, she even feels relaxed enough to join in on the conversation. They start by going around the table and taking turns to talk about what they did over the summer. DT takes up the majority of the floor as they go over an in depth explanation of their time in New York while Cat and Adora keep their answers short and crisp—blushing under the knowing stares.

Glimmer is just about finished grilling Cat for not answering her letters fast enough over the summer when DT gasps, "oh! I almost forgot, did you guys hear that they're canceling the Triwizard Tournament this year?"

A chill creeps down Cat's spine for some reason.

"Really?" Scorpia asks.

“That sucks,” Glimmer admits with a sigh, “those were always fun to watch.”

“Apparently one of the previous contestants got fatally injured so their parents gathered a ton of people to protest the tournament. It’s canceled until further notice.” DT says.

Cat’s grip on her fork fades at the confirmation of the tournament ruling. At her side, Adora finishes her last bite of food before she announces suddenly, “let’s go do something.”

“Like what?” Bow asks.

“I don’t know.” Adora shrugs. “Something fun to lead us into the new semester. Like…” her eyes dart around aimlessly before an idea comes to her. Cat shrinks back, cautious of the manic grin spreading across Adora’s face. Adora looks around to make sure no Professors are listening before she leans in close to whisper, “let’s go to the Shrieking Shack.”

Scorpia squeals, *“what?”*

“Seriously?” Cat huffs.

Adora nods eagerly. “I heard it’s haunted.”

“Go on.” Entrapta urges, leaning across the table with curious eyes.

Adora takes the cue and goes into a huge rant about the mysteries of the shack while Cat dutifully tunes her out because it’s all bullshit and Adora knows it. She and Cat snuck into the shack two years ago on a dare and the only thing they found was a stupid mirror in the back room. Sure, it was spooky going in, but there’s nothing there worth looking into.

Adora notices Cat’s disinterest and asks with a grin, “what? Are you *scared?”*

"I'm not scared." Cat frowns, not understanding why Adora's acting like they haven't been through this before. "There's nothing there."

"Then you won't mind going to check it out. If you're not scared, of course."

She's doing this on purpose. Even with that knowledge, Cat still rises to the challenge. "I'm *not* scared. I'll go into that shack as many times as I want."

"Great!" Adora grins. "Then it's settled. We'll sneak out later tonight."

Cat's head spins at how easily Adora manipulates her into doing something all the while making it seem like it was Cat's idea in the first place. With the bitter knowledge seeping into her stomach, the rest of their lunch goes by smoothly and once it's over they all head back to their respective rooms to prepare for class tomorrow as well as the night ahead of them. Cat offers to have Adora wait out the clock in her room but her girlfriend mutters something about having to check the quidditch pitch as captain of the team. It works out well enough because Cat's hoping to take a quick nap before their night of debauchery.

Her *quick nap* turns into a few hours. It would've been more had it not been for the tapping at her window that startles her awake. Cat stretches her arms with a yawn as she slides out of bed and walks over to her bay window without feeling the need to draw her wand. The security at Hogwarts is top notch—not once have they had a breach of security—and people know better than to start trouble with C'yra D'riluth's daughter.

Speak of the devil… Cat grins as she pries the curtains to the side and finds her mother's owl, Sparrow, perched on the windowsill; he does an excited jump when she opens the window to let him inside. Cat rubs at his scattered black feathers and hands over some treats for all his hard work before she pulls the tiny rolled

up paper from his satchel; she unwinds the paper and reads the short but sweet message.

Cat,

Like I said, Sparrow always knows where to find me. Don't hesitate to reach out.

Love, mum

Cat blinks back tears that come up unprovoked. *Why am I tearing up over something so small?* Her mother sending letters like this isn't anything new so why does it feel so scarce all of a sudden? Like she's never—

Knock! Knock!

Cat wipes her face and shouts over her shoulder, "just a second!" She scratches Sparrow's neck in a final farewell before she sends him on his way to do whatever it is he does. *He'll probably cause trouble in the Owlery,* Cat thinks with a snort.

Knock! Knock!

"Seriously?" Cat huffs as she strides to the door and pulls it open with a growl, "I heard you the first time…huh?"

There's no one at the door. Cat frowns, looking to the left, then to the right, as she tries to find the source of the noise. Then, she notices a magical signature in the air.

Cat leans against the frame of the door with her arms crossed saying, "you still have that thing?"

Adora laughs as she lifts the invisibility cloak until her head is peeking out. "Took you long enough to notice I was here." Adora taunts.

Cat sticks her tongue out in retaliation.

“Real mature, now come on,” Adora lifts the cloak with a hand outstretched saying, “everyone’s waiting.”

She takes Adora’s hand and snuggles in close under the cloak that hides them from the rest of the world. Adora leads the way, bypassing all the busy hallways and using a route that’s longer but isolated. And Cat should have butterflies right now—she should be a complete wreck—because *Adora Grayskull* is pressed against her side, but...why does being close to her make Cat’s skin itch?

Even her magic, which is supposed to be perfectly in tune with Adora, *rages* against its barriers—threatening to lash out. And no matter how hard she tries to keep it buried, small traces of it seeps to the surface and encases Cat in a cloak of her own. If Adora notices, she doesn’t bring it up, instead, she keeps walking —almost embracing the silence.

Cat isn’t sure how much time passes when they reach the secret entrance leading into the tunnel system that connects Hogwarts to Hogsmeade. Adora whispers the code to the painting and the frame shifts to the side to allow them entry; on the other side Cat is greeted by the other members of the crew. Scorpia stands out the most—she’s clutching her wand for dear life—huddled next to DT who’s trying to nudge the larger teen of them in a futile attempt. Glimmer’s in a similar position; she’s latching onto Bow, clearly avoiding Entrapta who’s wearing an even bulkier set of goggles with her wand out as if she’s preparing for a fight.

When the frame closes behind them darkness engulfs the tunnel but they’re all ready with their wands as they summon a quick *lumos* spell. Adora removes the cloak from atop them and safely tucks it away into her bag while Cat joins the fray.

“The lovebirds have finally decided to grace us with their presence.” DT still has time to tease them even as they struggle to keep Scorpia off their arm.

Adora jogs over with an excited grin and announces, “she overslept—”

"Adora." Cat hisses and, out of pure instinct, turns around to wrestle her into shutting up in which she manages to half succeed —not getting far as Adora grabs her by the wrists. In retaliation, Cat lets a tickling hex slip past her lips and takes deep satisfaction in the squeak that escapes Adora's mouth.

Adora grips her side, overcome by a fit of giggles. In between her uncontrollable laughter Adora says, "you…arsehole..." and, not one to be outdone, she easily falls into the jerky movements caused by the spell—embracing the madness instead of fighting it —and grabs her wand. Adora aims it at Cat, some kind of spell working its way through the air, but Glimmer snatches the crooked wand and puts an end to their game.

Glimmer turns to Cat with her hands at her hips and demands, "make it stop."

"Okay *mum."* Cat teases before she waves a hand to cease the spell.

"Do I have to separate you two?" Glimmer threatens as she hands Adora back her wand.

Once Adora's laughter tampers off she straightens up, wiping the tears from her eyes as she says, "no, no…we'll be on our best behavior."

"Then let's get moving," DT announces from the front, "this was *your* idea, blondie. You got the map?"

Adora nods and pulls a worn piece of parchment from her messenger bag; she presents it to the group after she makes a show of blowing off the dust sticking to it. Cat rolls her eyes, *and she says I'm the dramatic one.* Cat looks over Adora's shoulder as her girlfriend unwinds the parchment to reveal what would appear to be a blank piece of paper at first glance but, as Adora uses her wand to conjure a revealing spell, a map of the tunnels beneath Hogwarts are revealed.

"Where'd you get this?" Bow asks, cautious.

Adora shrugs. "Netossa gave it to me when she graduated, she said she can't stop us from getting into trouble but she can help us not get caught." Adora explains, "if we keep heading straight we'll reach the underground tunnels; they were sent in place by the first ever Headmaster of Hogwarts as an evacuation route in the case of emergencies. Those tunnels lead to tons of places—"

"Like Hogsmeade." Cat says.

"I wanted to say it." Adora pouts.

Cat snatches the map with a grin, "you were taking too long. Now come on, if DT doesn't get their beauty sleep they turn into a grouch."

DT gasps dramatically and hisses, "I told you that in *confidence!"*

Cat sticks her tongue out at DT and, in her distraction, Entrapta steals the map and takes over navigations. Cat likes to play a more chaotic role when they go on missions like this so she doesn't make a fuss and chooses to hang behind the rest of the group as they talk amongst themselves. They reach the tunnel system pretty quickly and from there they walk another mile or so until they're finally reaching the cellar door that leads into Hogsmeade.

Bang! The cellar door shoots open as Glimmer shoves her way through with a sigh, "finally."

Bow climbs out next and goes over to check on Glimmer while Cat takes in the fresh air and stretches her arms and legs that grew stiff in the narrow tunnels. A cold breeze makes Cat mutter a warming spell over her body, but nothing can be done for the shudder that racks through her as she spots the Shrieking Shack in all its glory. The peak of the house teases them just over the treeline; the entire property is encased in an old wooden fence, the kind used at farms to house livestock; the grass rages, not having been cut in years, and as Cat slowly approaches the yard, she finds the grass grazing her hips.

I've been here before, Cat tries to remind herself, *but…why am I so spooked?*

A magical signature that she's learned to embrace approaches her. Cat glances to her right and finds Adora gazing up at the house with a look in her eyes that Cat can't comprehend. It frustrates her—how terrible she is at reading Adora in this moment when it should be effortless.

"Okay," Bow announces, "we should all stay—"

Entrapta races through the blades of grass and eagerly heads for the house.

"—together," Bow finishes with a sigh before he marches up to the porch with Glimmer's hand safely tucked in his. The steps creak under his heavy footing—the sound exacerbated as Entrapta bounces to and fro as she searches from an opening, all of which are boarded up. Bow says, "Entrapta. Please, don't go off on your own."

"...intriguing," Entrapta adjusts her goggles and takes a closer look at the boarded up door, she mutters to herself, "this looks like ordinary wood but upon further inspection it's a defense mechanism set in place to keep people from infiltrating the house…hmm, maybe I should have heeded the warning written on the map and taken the tunnel to the Whomping Willow instead…"

"Whomping Willow?" Adora frowns.

"*Defense* mechanism?" DT demands.

Cat's mind catches up a second too slow; the wooden board surrounding the entrance to the house *ripples* under Entrapta's touch. A strange magic leaks across the air, sending the hair on Cat's neck standing up. There's no time for Cat to reach for her wand so she leaps forward, pulling Entrapta back, and shooting her hand out with a spell on her lips.

"Protego!" Cat exclaims, just in time as the wood transforms into a six foot crocodile that snaps its jaws in the spot Entrapta would've been in.

Adora gasps. "A dugbog?"

The magical creature lunges at Cat's shield—trying to find a way through—but her defense is impeccable; the time spent training with her mother over the summer seems to be paying off, even more so when her eyes flick to the side—taking in her surroundings—and she notices the boards covering the windows start to ripple as well.

Cat snaps, "Adora!"

"I'm on it." Adora says, swiftly pulling out her wand, as she shoots a spell at the creature blocking their entrance. "Bombarda!" The spell strikes the creature in the side, sending it falling to the side, just enough time for them to race to the door.

"Alohomora," Adora says with her wand aimed at the door; the spell unlocks the bolts protecting the door and Adora rushes to hold it open for her friends to race through right before she slams the door in the creature's face when it gets back up and lunges at them.

"Colloportus!" Cat shouts, locking the door just before they hear the dugbog throw its full weight on the door; but once a locking spell has been used, no amount of physical force can break the barrier of the spell. The knowledge sets them all at ease but it is only a brief luxury as DT turns on Entrapta with wide, panicked, eyes.

"Traps, what the actual *fuck?"* DT grabs her by the shoulders and demands, "what was *that?"*

Entrapta lifts her goggles when they fall awkwardly at her nose. She explains as best she can, "dugbog appear like wooden figures when they're stationary but—"

“I know what they are!” DT urges, “but *why* are they here?”

Exactly, Cat thinks, *they weren’t here the last time Adora and I came here.*

“Oh…I have no idea.” Entrapta slips from DT’s loosened grip and pulls out the map for a frame of reference, “dugbog are naturally found in marsh environments, and there’s no swamp around here—and the winters are harsh—so they must’ve been placed here by someone else.”

“It had to be recent.” Cat supplies.

Glimmer rubs her neck saying, “my mum might’ve had something to do with it, she’s been under a lot of pressure from other parents about the *safety* of Hogwarts so she might’ve used this as a way to ensure students stop trying to sneak out here. You already know they had to cancel the Triwizard Tournament…I guess this is another safety measure.”

“Word of mouth will definitely do it.” Cat says.

“Nearly *dying* will do it.” DT taunts but Cat lets it slide knowing they’ve been through a lot tonight and she has a feeling it’ll only get worse. “Give me this,” DT says, snatching the map from Entrapta to which no one argues, “no more *detours* that lead us into the nest of danger. If you saw the note Netossa left on the map then why did you take us this way?”

Entrapta says, “for science”, like it’s obvious and this time Cat’s instincts kick in right on time; she and Scorpia hold DT back while Entrapta, oblivious to the world around her, uses her wand as a flashlight and begins exploring the living room but, there’s not much to explore. For a *haunted house* the first floor is relatively normal—appearing like a room that’s about to be renovated. The furniture is encased in a protective plastic wrap but it doesn’t stop the spider web infestation or dust collection from building up. Even the walls, coated in some old fashion wallpaper, seem like they’re weeping from neglect. The only seemingly nice thing in

the room is the grandfather clock that's pressed against the wall in the center of the room; it's the first thing that always catches Cat's eye when she enters the house.

Twang! Scorpia jumps at the noise and wraps her arms around DT who does their best to kindly push her off them. DT hisses, "it's just the clock, Scorp."

There's an apologetic rant on Scorpia's tongue but Cat tunes it out as she walks over to the familiar clock; not much has changed about it since the last time she saw it. The fact that it still works, after all these years of the house being dormant, must mean some magical source is keeping it active.

"Spooky, right?" Adora tries to sneak up on Cat but her footsteps always give her away.

Cat rolls her eyes. "Give it a rest, this place isn't scary. I don't know why you wanted to come here again."

"It's just, you know, you seemed kind of scared when the dugbog attacked is all."

Cat's eye twitches but she takes a breath and says as calmly as possible, "I wasn't scared. I *saved* us with my awesome magic and if I remember correctly *I'm* the one who had to snap *you* out of it so you could actually do something useful so, no, I'm not scared. But maybe you're a little spooked."

"If that's how you remember it," Adora shrugs, feigning ignorance but the truth is in the way her magic swirls in the air playfully, catching the rest of the groups attention, as she teases, "but honestly, Cat, if you want to hold my hand I won't hold it against you."

Glimmer sighs. "You two, cut it out."

Cat pays the others no attention as she shoots back, "*you're* the one who wants to hold *my* hand."

“I can literally see you shaking right now.” Adora says.

“Out of rage.” Cat huffs.

“Guys.” Bow warns them but Adora keeps poking the lion unprovoked.

“Nothing will change how I feel about you, it’s okay if you’re a bit of a scaredy ca—” the rest of the words don’t make it past Adora’s lips because Cat lunges forward, dead set on wrestling Adora to the ground. But instead of avoiding the attack like she expects her to, Adora latches onto Cat’s waist and fully embraces the blow that sends them colliding into the grandfather clock at just the right angle to activate a secret trap door.

Their friends scream in shock as the floor gives way beneath the duo, sending them beneath the living room into a secluded room, right before the trap door slides back into place and locks them in. Cat lands with a groan, back colliding into a bunch of old boxes filled with clothes belonging to the people who once lived here. To make matters worse, Adora’s heavy body lands on top of her—knocking the wind from Cat.

“Guys!” Bow’s voice is muffled behind the floorboards. “Are you okay?”

Cat says with a groan, “not really.”

“We’re okay!” Adora says before Bow can turn frantic from Cat’s offhanded reply. “Lumos,” Adora whispers, using her wand to light the room; she crawls off Cat and helps her to her feet.

There’s rustling above them and suddenly Glimmer says, “we can’t open the trap door! We’re pushing on the clock but it’s not working!”

“It’s fine,” Cat shouts, “there’s probably a limit to how many times it’ll open so we’ll have to take the tunnel until it leads us to the backyard. There should be a cellar door—that’s where we’ll be exiting from—we’ll meet you guys over there.”

There's a brief pause before Glimmer asks, "how many times have you two fallen through a trap door before?"

"Too many." Cat answers.

Adora laughs and says, "we'll catch up soon!"

"Okay," Bow says, "be safe."

Cat waits until their footsteps sound muffled even under her heightened hearing before she allows her magic to slowly rise to the surface; she looks to her left and sees Adora—void of the goofy teenager persona she's been showcasing the entire night. *Calm down, this is Adora,* she has to remind herself. But, even so, her magic seems to have other ideas.

"You made us bump into the clock on purpose so we'd get stuck down here." Cat flexes her fingers cautiously saying, "so just tell me already, why did you want us to come here? Why do you want *me* here?"

Adora levels her with a hard look before she turns her back and silently guides Cat further into the basement she's trapped them in. And, without a lot of options, Cat follows her. The journey is quiet until Adora reaches whatever it is she's been searching for; she stops in front of an oblong object that's covered by a white tarp.

Adora turns around to face her and asks, "do you remember the last time we were here?"

"Yeah." Cat frowns. "What about it?"

"Refresh my memory?" Adora's question comes out as a demand and it leaves Cat unsettled.

"Okay then…" Cat mutters, "it was two years ago, so we were fourth years, and someone dared us to come here and bring back something to prove that we actually went into the shack and, we're both competitive as hell, so obviously we did. And just like

tonight—there was nothing here. The only interesting thing that happened was us getting freaked out by some noise and bumping into that clock, then we fell down here, and we found—"

"This." Adora pulls the white tarp off the figure to reveal an oblong full-length mirror resting on a stand.

Cat looks at her reflection in the cloudy mirror, she shrugs. "Yeah, we found this old thing and then Micah came rushing in to get us because we were gone too long and everyone got worried that something might have happened. And now we're back. Why?"

Cat tries to keep her eyes on Adora but there's some kind of magic—something devastatingly familiar—that *calls* to her. Cat's eyes flick between the mirror and Adora, unsure of where to put her focus but, in the end, she chooses the mirror—in search of the magic that whispers to her so beautifully. But, when Cat looks at the mirror again, all she sees is herself—alone and confused.

"You're not *her."*

Adora's voice startles Cat out of it and she turns her head sharply. For the first time since they left Hogwarts, true emotion is leaking across Adora's face in the form of *longing.*

Cat's throat swells as she whispers, "I don't—"

Adora interrupts saying, "I know what her magic feels like."

The words cause Cat's head to throb, the sharpness sends her body crumbling as she nearly topples over but is saved from the fall as her back collides into the wall behind her. Adora's panicked voice is nothing but a low murmur—a whisper in the approaching storm—as Cat is hit with a vivid memory:

"I'm going to need you to stop fucking lying to me." Adora snaps. "I know what your magic feels like, Catra…"

"Hey," Adora sounds frantic as she shakes Cat out of it. She makes sure to hold Cat by the wrist so she doesn't lash out like she did

this morning; she holds her arms there until her breathing gets under control. Adora asks, "are you okay?"

Cat rips her arms away and takes a step back. She shakes her head and whispers frantically, "no, no…it's just a dream…it's not real—"

"It is." Adora's voice is stern yet careful as she says, "you were right about what happened the first time we came here, we did fall into the trap door and Micah did save us…but before he showed up you and I found this mirror." Adora gestures to the glass before she explains, "there was a rumor going around school about there being a mirror that could travel between universes and of course we wanted to be the first ones to check it out; so when we got here you, I mean, *Cat* reached out to pull the tarp off and then she touched the glass—right at the center. Nothing happened at first, she even joked about it being a hoax when Micah escorted us back to our dorms, but then…the same night, I couldn't sleep so I went to her room to check on her.

"She was standing in front of her mirror just…staring at *nothing,* like she was under some kind of thrall only she could feel. I snapped her out of it and when she came to she had no memory of it, and she seemed fine after the incident but...I just couldn't let it go so, one night, I went to the restricted section of the library with my cloak and I found something on portals to alternate dimensions.

"The book I found said these portals can come in different shapes but the most common form is a *mirror.* The legend said, *once a being has physically touched the object tasked with separating worlds their soul is connected to the portal until the gates are closed."*

"No, that's crazy…" Cat trails off, wordless, because part of her has always been on edge since waking up this morning. The possibility of her not belonging to this world doesn't seem so out of reach, but still—it feels so real. Cat's butt hits the floor as she tucks her

knees into her chest. Her mind is a raging storm because, "if all of these *memories* I have aren't even *mine* then…who am I?"

"I don't know." Adora's face twists up as she confesses, "I honestly wouldn't have noticed for a while—you're a lot like her—but your magical signature…it's a lot more powerful than hers. Dangerous even."

Cat tucks her chin into her knees. *That's why I had trouble with the wards in my room—her room—because it wasn't set in place by my own magic.*

"Look," Adora says, "I don't know where you're from, but I bet that *dream* that's been tripping you up is the life you left behind when you came here."

Cat tilts her head back and stares at the ceiling. She mutters, "so none of this is real."

"It is to me."

Cat looks over at Adora—or some version of her—and sees her shell beginning to crack as tears threaten to slip free. Cat tells her, "don't worry, I'm not interested in stealing a life that's not mine… this is just, *a lot."*

"I know," Adora admits after a moment, "you're a lot like her, you know? But there's just…something in your *eyes* and in your *magic* that makes you stand apart from her—something that makes me want to hug you but at the same time it makes me want to stay away."

Cat thinks back to the *failsafe* mark on the other Adora's chest and she comes to her own conclusion, "it's called *fear."*

Adora splutters, "I'm not—"

"You are." Cat stands to her feet swiftly, raising an eyebrow as Adora instinctively reaches for her wand. In retaliation, Cat's magic playfully leaks through. Cat looks at her hand with a frown,

“but that’s okay.” Cat looks up and confesses, “I’m afraid to. I don’t know what’s on the other side of this mirror, or what was so terrible that I decided to leave it all behind but…”

When her words fail her, the same magical thrall seeps through from the mirror and reaches out to her—it *comforts* her. Cat’s magic dancing with the thrall and she finds herself stepping closer until she’s just a couple inches from the mirror. And as she looks at her reflection, Cat sees the haunted shadow in her eyes that makes Adora weary; and, the longer she looks, the more reality takes over and distorts this world she’s escaped to—suddenly, to her own eyes, she looks far older than sixteen.

“I can’t keep running.” Cat says as she grips the sides of the mirror for stability. And suddenly there’s a foolish part of her that wants to tell Adora to give her best to her mum and her friends but she has to remind herself, *this isn’t your life.* Even so, it doesn’t make things any easier. Going in blind is nerve wracking—she wishes she could be *Catra,* the woman in her fractured dream, because if she was that version of herself then she wouldn’t be afraid of jumping into the unknown.

When her fear begins to get the best of her, the same thrall from the mirror reaches for her with tripled intensity. It calms the shaking of Cat’s body long enough for her to look over her shoulder and give Adora her final words. But, apparently no version of her has ever been good with goodbyes.

Adora beats her to it and says sincerely, “I hope you find who you’re looking for.”

Catra nods. “Same to you.”

And so, she walks through the mirror as Cat—a fabrication of a life that doesn’t belong to her—but, on the other side, it’s *Catra* who’s plummeting from the sky.

Chapter End Notes

So…the prequel is gonna be a lot like this chapter but, like, 90% more angst—in the best (and worst) way possible. Also, I don't know how this chapter got so long; I had to add an extra chapter because this was supposed to be combined with some other plot points but it would've been too much. Because of that, the next chapter might be a little short but nothing too crazy.

Some things I think are important about this chapter is Cat having a therapist and how it gave her a way to deal with her emotions in a positive way opposed to Catra who bottled everything up as a kid which led to her fracturing lots of relationships. This drawback (not properly addressing these issues) will be explored in the prequel and this chapter is just a scenario of what could have been. She was able to get to this world because being in the center of Bermuda weakened her ties to her own world enabling her to slip into another.

While this wasn't really a "wish" Catra had of a "perfect world", it did have a lot of things she wished she had during her sixth year (which was the most stressful school year for her). It had mentions of the Triwizard Tournament being canceled which plays a huge role; her mother is in her life; she and Adora are in the same house while being in a healthy relationship; and she's not an outsider with Glimmer and Bow (she and Glimmer even write to each other willingly during the summer).

There are other notes I have but I'll save them for later. Also, I thought it was ironic how the master Obliviator finds herself with memory issues of her own.

As always, thanks for reading.

Home

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

0

When Cat walks through the mirror it's *Catra* who finds herself floating in a space engulfed in white particles. Catra has little time to admire the mystery behind it all as her memories come flooding back to her with a brutal intensity; she holds her head as it throbs in her ill timed revelation. A rough ball of emotions threatens to crawl out her throat but suddenly she feels a familiar trace of magic reaching out, *begging* Catra to come back. *Adora.* Catra recognizes her magical signature well and finds herself floating towards a circular door that's engulfed with a bright light when suddenly a figure appears before her.

"You." Cat hisses as she leaps forward with her claws drawn, a spell on her tongue, but the rapid momentum propels her at an awkward angle and she goes floating off in the wrong direction. Catra quickly corrects the child's trajectory by placing a binding spell on Cat's leg, anchoring her to Catra.

"Calm down," Catra huffs.

Cat glares at her from her upside down position; she crosses her arms, trying to appear in control even though it's *Catra* who pulls her closer until they're making eye contact. Cat frowns saying, "you want *me* to calm down? You're an evil doppelgänger who tried to steal my life!"

Catra rubs her forehead as a headache approaches. "I didn't steal your life, brat, I got stuck. And if you haven't noticed, I'm returning it to you so you're welcome." Catra adds with a snarl, *"you're* the one who decided to activate a portal to another dimension."

"Yeah?" Cat shoots back, "well *you're* supposed to be an adult and yet, here you are, arguing with a child."

Catra refrains from letting a nasty hex pass her lips and, instead, she releases the binding spell and takes satisfaction in watching Cat awkwardly flail about as she floats back down to Catra's level. And when Cat seems like she might go off in the wrong direction, Catra grabs her by the collar and keeps her upright with a single hand.

"Look," Catra says after a moment of having Cat glare at her, unbelieving, "I'm being honest. My...my *mum* told me to meet her at the center of the Bermuda Triangle so I could—"

"The bloody *triangle?"* Cat exclaims in awe.

"Let me finish." Catra huffs. "And yes, the center of the triangle. I met her there but I ended up staying longer than I should have, and then the triangle's magic warped reality a bit. It made me wanna to stay in the eye of the storm so I rushed up to follow my mum but...I found the portal to your world instead."

Cat settles down as she seems to find the truth in Catra's words. Cat looks away and mutters, "Adora and I thought those rumors were bullock...I touched the mirror to prove it but, ever since that night I've had this *static* in my head...it was like my brain's been searching for a channel, if that makes any sense." Cat shouts into her hands, "of course it doesn't make any sense! I'm talking to a version of myself from an *alternate* world. This is insane, I'm going mental…"

Catra's magic vibrates, catching the teens attention. Catra holds up her right hand that's now laced with magic and offers with a blank expression, "I can erase your memory if it'll make things easier for you."

Cat's face goes pale, put off by such a display of power, but she doesn't make a show of shrinking away. Instead, Cat replies with

a shaky, “no thank you...I’d like to remember this in case it happens again.”

Catra lowers her hand and says with confidence, “it won’t.”

“What are you gonna do?” Cat asks, eyeing her doppelgänger with worry.

“I’ll close the portal with a sealing spell,” Catra says with a shrug, “this way no one will be able to jump into your realm and vice versa.”

Cat asks worriedly, “do you even have enough magic for that? This place has been draining your core since you stepped through the portal.”

Catra snaps. “How do you—”

“Where did you think I went when you slipped into my world?” Cat explains, “I’ve been stuck in this in-between—forced to watch you screw with my life. Adora, in *Gryffindor.* Please.” Cat mutters the last bit in disdain.

Catra’s magic flares to the surface but even this small show of power has her body slumping to the side as drowsiness overcomes her. *Damn it.* Catra forces her emotions to simmer down so her magic will follow. Even so, she can’t help but let off some steam by clenching her fist; a small ounce of magic generates in her hand. It’s all she thinks she’ll be capable of doing without passing out.

Catra turns to the portal she’d just escaped from, in the center she can see a blurred silhouette—it’s likely Cat’s version of Adora, she’s patiently waiting by the mirror for her lover to be returned. The thought of her alternate life makes Catra think about her own. She thinks about Bow and Glimmer and how much her secrets have impacted them, she thinks about the unopened letters from Frosta piled up on her drawer, she thinks about the times she ducked Scorpia’s invitation for a visit to her loft, and

most of all she thinks about how she foolishly lost herself in a life that didn't belong to her.

I got myself in this situation, how could I have fallen for such a juvenile trick?

A rush of emotions shoots to the surface as she recalls her final moments with her mother. And even though she was a wolf in sheep's clothing during her visit, she can't deny how comforting it was to have Cat's life. Even if it was only a few hours. Many of the things Cat had—Catra's wished for them during her darkest days.

Catra's resolve begins to slip but, as if sensing her apprehension, *Adora's* magic reaches out to her once more—it desperately tries to find a way to renew a connection that was once lost.

"Hey," Cat takes her silence as a bad thing and tries to cheer Catra up saying, "I didn't mean it like that, I know you didn't have a choice in this."

Catra wholeheartedly threw herself into the portal but she doesn't bother correcting Cat's misinterpretation.

"—and, look, I'm just glad it was *you* who found the portal." Cat realizes, "things could've ended up really badly if someone else found it."

"Go."

Cat frowns. "Seriously? I was trying to be nice, you arsehole."

"Cat." She says, "it's time for you to go home."

Cat's eyes flick to Catra's hand as she summons pure magic within her palm. Cat hesitates before asking, "what's gonna happen to you once the portal is closed?"

"I'll probably fall…I won't have enough magic to keep myself afloat."

Cat argues, “that’s crazy! You can’t—”

“Don’t worry.” Catra sends her doppelgänger a grin full of false confidence. “I’ve gotten out of worse situations.” The power within the triangle lashes out, swiping more magic from Catra’s core—it sends her into a sweat. She feels like toppling over but image is everything so she manages. Catra doesn’t know if Cat believes the display or not but Cat ends up sending her a nod in confirmation.

Cat swims up to the mirror with Catra behind her with her magic ready. Cat reaches out for the portal but before she leaves she turns to Catra one more time and says, “thank you.”

Catra smirks. “Don’t go touching any more magical mirrors, I might not be around to save your arse next time.”

Cat sticks out her tongue as retribution but it’s good mannered. And, with one final look, Cat turns around and slips through the portal so she can continue living her life. Catra waits for Cat’s silhouette to grow further from the mirror before she lets her expression fall. Pure fire races through her veins as the triangle lashes out—seeking to take whatever remains of Catra’s magical core.

Adora’s magic is a constant force around her as it begs Catra to return.

“I’m sorry, love. I can’t right now.” Catra whispers to herself as she channels all her remaining magic in her hands before pressing her palms to the surface of the portal.

A white light shoots out as Catra’s magic forcibly seals the portal shut. The oblong cavity buckles under the sealing spell and slowly begins to cave in. Catra’s body takes most of the damage; sweat builds on her brow as her limbs begin to wither and shake as she puts her all into this spell. *This might be my last,* Catra thinks, *might as well give it everything I have.*

Catra fights against her trembling limbs and shouts—anything to drive her magic forward. She transfers her magic to the portal faster than the triangle can drain her core but, ultimately, each option has the same result.

When the last of her magic slips from her palm there's a brief moment where Catra is fixed in the air—she's in the eye of the storm, embraced with silence and the vision of her sacrifice as the portal dissipates as if it had never existed in the first place. And knowing she's corrected her mistake fills her with joy. At this moment she's not thinking about the people she's hurt or the life she's left behind—she's at peace. But, not soon after, the world continues to spin and—

Catra *plummets* to the sky.

15

The wind is a force to be reckoned with and Catra is in no position to fight against her fate. She falls with her stomach facing the ground; her arms are outstretched like a false deity who was foolish enough to think that she had any control over anything. She's flown too close to the sun and now she's paying the price.

As Catra approaches the ground her consciousness begins to slip. But, while she's still able, Catra finally lets go and does something she should've done a long time ago. And so, with her decision made, Catra embraces what she once feared and lets her eyes slip close. All the while, Adora's magic rejoices and takes the granted opening. And as Catra falls—

Adora's magic embraces her.

16

When Catra comes to, there's a light shining in her eyes that has her flinching backwards. She gives herself a moment to adjust before she looks around the white walled room she finds herself in. There's a pillow beneath her head and a bundle of blankets that cocoon her but it's not enough to dampen the sting that

shoots through her as she tries sitting up. *You fought in a war,* Catra reminds herself and forces her body to move against the pain until she's sitting up with her back to the headboard.

Catra unconsciously tries to gather magic in her palm so she can assuage the soreness but she's startled to find her magical reserves near the point of depletion. There's a tiny *spark* but it's nothing compared to what she was able to summon in her prime. The thought of being helpless this way sends her into a panic. Catra's breathing picks up—her chest getting tight—as her thoughts spiral onto infinity. But just as she's about to crash into the water and drown—a comforting trace of magic engulfs her.

The familiar magic stays with Catra even as her breathing slows to a normal rhythm. *Adora,* she easily recognizes her girlfriends signature and silently thanks her for the assist. But when she notices movement to the right, Catra finds she doesn't have to offer silent affirmations when Adora's physically at her side.

Catra's face softens as she takes in Adora; her girlfriend is slumped over the side of the bed with her face cradled between her arms. There are dark circles under Adora's eyes but she still looks peaceful as she slumbers.

"She's been here all night. Refused to leave, actually."

Catra looks up, surprised, when she finds Perfuma leaning against the wall with a black notebook in her hand as she jots something down. Catra's mind runs wild—trying to piece together a sound conclusion—when, suddenly, her memory of the last 24 hours returns. She grips her fist into the bedding and thinks with a bitter frown, *of course they'd reach out to the best healer they know.*

"Is Scorpia here too?" Catra asks, sullen.

Perfuma puts her book down and picks up a flask with amber fluid inside. She walks over to Catra saying, "no, Glimmer stressed the importance of keeping this visit discreet."

Good. Catra nods. *I've already bothered Scorpia enough during Mara's trial.* She thinks back to the brief kidnapping incident and shudders thinking about what might have happened if it went South.

"I'll need you to drink this." Perfuma hands over the vial and says, "it's a potion that'll help you deal with the pain. Now, be careful because it—"

Catra downs it in one go.

"—tastes like crap."

Catra's face twists at the vulgar taste. It burns the hairs in her nose and the insides of her throat, but she takes the discomfort as a welcome distraction. Catra hands the flask back to Perfuma and then relaxes back into the headboard with a groan.

Perfuma sets the flask away and clears her throat. She continues her earlier line of thought saying, "Melog would've stayed with you but they were a wreck when Adora carried you in. It took Bow *and* Glimmer's binding spells to keep them down. They would've rampaged otherwise."

Catra nods. "Our connection's been on and off these days so it isn't easy for them…not knowing what's going on with me."

"I think a lot of us can relate to that." Perfuma says without malice.

Catra changes the subject and asks, "where are we?"

"London's Unspeakable hideout, the infirmary department to be exact." Perfuma thinks for a moment before she explains, "I think it was Frosta who suggested it. She said you planned on coming here with Alin and the other missing person's anyway so…two birds one stone. Seahawk was the one who used the Floo Network to get me."

Catra mutters, "sorry to inconvenience you."

Perfuma shakes her head. “You could never. We’re *friends,* Catra. It was no problem. And you should’ve seen the shape you were in,” a shudder passes through Perfuma but she catches herself quickly and says, “but let's not think of what could have been. All that matters is that you’re safe now.”

Catra looks down and flexes her fingers, she unconsciously tries to summon magic but the process takes excruciating work and she’s only able to manage a spark. Catra thinks sullenly, *I don’t feel safe without my magic.*

It’s almost like Perfuma reads her mind. “Your magic will return to you, don’t worry. You just exhausted all your reserves, well—the *triangle* stole it…but you’ll be back to normal in a few days as long as you rest up and allow your magic to restore itself naturally. So no moving around, got it? I want you in bed for the week.”

Catra feels a spike of magic grow near at a raging pace. She turns to Perfuma with a sheepish look and says, “I apologize in advance.”

Perfuma frowns. “For what—”

Bam! The door slams open, startling Perfuma into drawing her wand, as a purple blur shoots into the room. Bow and Glimmer are close by, their frantic screams rouse Adora from her slumber. Adora barely has time to process what’s happening as Melog collides into Catra. The magical creature is so excited that their body turns transparent and, upon the collision, Melog teleports them through the infirmary walls.

They fall through various mediums until they land in a dimly lit hallway. Catra falls on her back with a grunt. Melog doesn’t give her time to catch her bearings as they bump their head into hers and purr so strongly it shakes Catra’s entire body. Melog is a mess of whimpers and mewls and all Catra can do is wrap her arms around their figure as a tear slides down her own face.

Catra nuzzles into Melog's neck and whispers, "me too buddy…I missed you too."

A sharp squeak along the floor alerts her just before Adora rounds the corner looking frantic. Catra doesn't bother wiping her tear away because she knows Adora is fully attuned with her emotions. And it's really a double edged blade because Catra feels utter shame rack through her when she takes note of the *fear* Adora has—fear of Catra never coming back.

Has she always felt like this?

"Hey, Adora." Catra says, trying her best to smile.

Adora chokes out a wet laugh and slides to the floor and presses a lasting kiss to Catra's mouth. Adora pulls away with a sob and then cradles Catra in her arms. Catra ducks her head into Adora's bosom while her girlfriend strokes her back in a random pattern.

Adora whispers, "when you didn't come back I thought—"

"I know." Catra doesn't need words when the purest of bonds connects them.

After a long moment in which they sit together in a stifling silence, Adora asks, "do you want to go back to bed? You should really get some rest."

"No, no…I've been in that bed for *hours* and I think I'll rip my hair out if I go back in there." Catra smiles at the soft snort that gets from Adora before she asks, "can we stay out here for a second? I don't think Melog plans on letting go anytime soon."

"Of course." Adora carefully pulls them out from the center of the hallway until their backs are pressed against the cool wall. And they sit there for a long moment, just embracing one another and basking in their renewed connections. But, ultimately, it's Adora who breaks the silence when curiosity takes a hold of her.

"What happened out there?"

Catra bites her lip. “A lot of things.”

“I’ve got time.”

Catra recounts all that she remembers; from her meeting with her mum, to her life as *Cat,* and to her sacrifice up in the in-between. By the time she’s finished Adora’s jaw is nearly on the floor; it works open, then closed, and then open again as she tries to form words. In the end, all she manages is—

“Shit.”

Catra snorts. “I know. It’s insane.”

Adora frowns. “So…where’s your mum now?”

Catra looks up at the ceiling. “Back at work, I guess.”

“And…the portal is closed for good? No more slips, right? We won’t have to deal with another version of Prime sneaking into our universe.”

Catra shudders at the thought and says, “I used everything I had to close the portal. No one’s coming. It’s over.”

Adora runs a hand through her hair muttering, “that explains *this* then.” Catra looks over as Adora pulls out a white envelope from her coat pocket. She hands it to Catra explaining, “the protective shield your mum put up to block us from the triangle went down—probably after she left—so Melog and I rushed inside without a second thought. I was freaking out, both of us were, because we couldn’t feel your magic but…I kept trying to send mine out to you hoping you’d hear me. And when all felt lost, I felt this *huge* burst of energy from you.”

“When I was closing the portal.” Catra realizes.

“Exactly,” Adora says, “so I followed the source. Melog carried me up and there you were…falling from the sky…we caught you just in time and rushed you to the ship. You were so pale when we put

you on the bed below the deck—all your magic had been stripped from you and it was causing your body damage. Glimmer did what she could until we got Perfuma to help."

Catra wipes away the tears from Adora's face when she gets choked up.

"Anyway," Adora mutters, "I took off your coat because you had a fever and…this letter was inside. I haven't opened it or anything but, I thought it was strange because there's nothing addressed on it."

"Thank you." Catra says, taking the envelope with a shaky hand.

When Catra doesn't open it Adora asks, "aren't you gonna read it?"

Catra grips the envelope tighter. This is the last thing she has left of her mum, if she reads the letter now then she won't have anything. So, Catra shakes her head and tucks the letter into her pocket for later. She mutters, "I'll read it another time. I just wanna be with you right now."

Mwr. Melog huffs, bumping their head into Catra's stomach as their fur grows jagged. There's a curse threatening to slip from her tongue but she lets it fade away. Melog's been through a lot, not knowing if Catra was alive or not, so she pushes back her frustrations.

Catra rubs Melog's head, "of course I haven't forgotten about you."

When Catra looks up, Adora's watching her with glossy eyes. A lump grows in Catra's throat because she knows whatever words leave Adora's mouth will ultimately lead them into a conversation they've both been dreading for a while now.

Adora grabs Catra's hand and starts off by saying, "I love you."

Catra's stomach tosses and she replies instantly. "I love you too."

Adora ducks her head and stares at their laced fingers. "Look, I know I'm not really the person to say this but…it *sucks* when you keep things from me. And I know I'm guilty of doing it too—it's not easy with our jobs—and I thought I could be okay with not telling you everything but I don't think I'm in that mindset anymore. I get that you wanted to find your mum and how you thought you were protecting us, and yourself, by keeping it a secret but when you disappeared behind that barrier—and I couldn't follow you—it *hurt."*

Something sharp passes through Catra's chest—the emotion is a mixture of Adora's and her own.

"And then when you went to the other universe, it was like you *disappeared.* I didn't know what to think, I didn't know if you were *alive,* but I kept sending my magic out with hopes that I'd reach you."

Catra presses Adora's hand to her chest and promises, "you did. I'm right here."

Adora nods furiously, blinking away tears as she tries to convince herself.

"Adora," she says resolutely, "you know I'm not going anywhere, right? *You're* my family."

"I was worried you wouldn't wanna come back, after you met your mum." Adora hesitates, "did you *want* to stay? In Cat's life when you were there."

Catra snorts. "It was a special kind of torture, I'll admit it. Seeing Cat having what I always wanted growing up…but something was always *off* about it, I never could've stayed and been satisfied completely. There was too much *fluff."*

Catra's brow bunches up as she mutters, "I think all the bad things that happened to me weren't *great,* but they've made me who I am. And I've done a lot of good things with all the bad I've been given: I helped take down Prime—something I wouldn't

have been strong enough to do had I not sook power to prove Weaver wrong; my friendship with Bow and Glimmer is solid because we actually *experienced* things together that helped us find common ground instead of us getting along instantly; and you and I took a *dozen* steps backwards but…we *always* find our way back. And I'd like to think, because of what we've gone through, that our relationship is stronger for it."

"Plus," Catra smirks at the memory, "you were in *Slytherin."*

Adora jerks her head and exclaims, *"what?"*

"I know, right?"

The air is slightly less tense but Catra continues because if she doesn't, she fears she never will.

"...and I know you've been wondering for a while," Catra's voice is hoarse as she says, "about why I broke our connection that year."

Adora's body goes still but Catra continues.

"A lot was going on back then: the school was under reconstruction after Prime destroyed the place when he stormed inside looking for us, and, even though we beat him, we had to deal with the aftermath of fame—something *none* of us asked for."

"You were given the worst of it," Adora says with a pinched face. She says in a rush, "I'm so sorry for leaving you to deal with all of that. If I would've stayed then they wouldn't have made you the face of the school and then…"

Catra shushes her. "You did what you had to, I just," she stumbles, "...I was hurt. When you said you were going to the Auror Academy I thought you were leaving me behind—that I didn't fit into your life, that I was holding you back—so…I locked you out. I justified it as *protecting* myself but I was just running away and I should've just talked to you about it."

"I should've talked to *you."* Adora urges, "after we defeated Prime we never talked about the kiss, and my acceptance into the academy seemed like a good way to get your attention…but it didn't work out the way I planned. And without our bond, I didn't know how you *really* felt—I just assumed you didn't want this the way I did. The way I *do."* Adora continues before Catra can object, "now, I know that's not true. But, I also know this bond can't last if we're not honest with each other. So, I'll wait for you to be completely open to me—I don't care how long it takes."

Catra shakes her head. "You don't have to—"

"I *want* to." Adora says firmly, "you've been patient with my career and now it's time for me to return the favor. I'll be with you for as long as you'll let me. Just, promise me you'll take a few weeks off before jumping back in again. Alright? Your magic still needs time to—are you *laughing?"*

Catra holds her stomach as she laughs harder than she has in months. In her periphery she notices Melog looking over at her with their head tilted to the side like a confused pup. When Catra finally gets control of herself she turns to Adora and holds her face within her palms and confesses, "you don't have to worry about that."

Adora's eyes go cross—a consequence of Catra being so close—so she pulls away for some space. Adora frowns, "what do you—"

"I almost *died,* Adora." Catra says in a frantic whisper, "I almost lost everything—almost lost *you.* I've wasted so much time tiptoeing around my feelings for you—our bond has been severed for *years,* all because we couldn't be honest about what we wanted. I don't want to live like that anymore—with all these secrets between us. I don't know what will happen with my job, all I know is that I want to spend more time enjoying my life. It's not like Cat's but…it's *mine.* So, until I decide what path to take—I'll cool down a bit and take things one day at a time."

Adora barely waits for Catra to finish her speech before she rushes over and kisses her until they're both out of breath. Adora backs away and softly bumps their foreheads together. In the space they've created, Adora whispers, "it doesn't matter what we do—just as long as we're together."

Their moment is short lived as Bow and Glimmer awkwardly come around the corner wearing sheepish expressions. But, based on the tears in Bow's eyes, Catra suspects the duo has been close by for quite some time. *Damn it,* Catra bunches closer to Adora with a helpless sigh, *all my guards go down when I'm around her lately...I'm going soft.*

"Sorry to interrupt," Bow says, "but Perfuma told us to come get you so you can rest."

"She's persistent when she wants to be." Glimmer adds with a shudder.

Bow nods frantically, nearly on the edge of combustion, so Catra lets Adora and Melog help her to her feet. Despite her protest, Adora keeps Catra's arm wrapped around her shoulder as they journey back to the infirmary. The silence is comfortable but there's something building in Catra's stomach that is quickly assuaged by a surge of Adora's magic. It gives her the courage to say:

"Look, I'm really—"

"Don't." Glimmer shuts her down quickly with a dangerous glint in her eye.

Bow agrees with a fragile grin. "This week has been *a lot,* and right now we're just glad you're okay. Let's not focus on anything else right now."

"Plus, I want you to be able to put up a good fight when I kick your ass." Glimmer adds with a grin.

Catra snorts with a grin of her own. “Please, I can take you even with my magic drained.” She and Glimmer slip into a familiar battle of wills but settle down once they reach the infirmary. Perfuma sends Melog a burning look but the magical creature isn’t put off by it—almost oblivious. They curl up by Catra’s feet while Adora squeezes in on Catra’s left in the bed. Bow and the others say they’ll check in later and soon Catra’s left alone to listen to Adora’s soft snoring; her girlfriend tried to stay up but exhaustion quickly took over.

With some time to herself, Catra pulls out the letter with a shaky hand. And while Adora might be asleep, Melog is still there to offer comforting purrs as she unfolds the paper. To her surprise, there’s no *letter* tucked away inside the envelope and, instead, Catra finds a polaroid—the edges are yellow and murky, emphasizing the effect of time. The picture itself shows a younger version of her mum—likely in her late twenties—with an unfamiliar man who wears a broad grin similar to Catra’s. In the picture, the man holds a sonogram image up to the camera while her mum leans on his shoulder with a soft smile that appears out of place for such a strong figure.

A tear lands on Catra’s arm and she quickly wipes the rest away, but not because she’s ashamed. She just doesn’t want her vision impaired as she takes in the picture. Catra traces her finger over the man's features until it becomes too difficult a task. With a shuddering sigh, she turns the image over but is halted when she finds a message written in pen. The sloppy scrawl reads:

C'yra and Ezra D'riluth—expecting (1997).

And, right below their names, written in elegant cursive is a final message:

I know your life isn’t ideal, but I hope you can find peace—and satisfaction—with the one you’ve been granted instead of holding onto what could have been. And, no. I didn’t know you would follow after me, but I knew there would be a possibility and—with your earthly ties weakened in the center of the triangle—I also

*knew there was a possibility of you jumping between realms. But, like I said before: you're **my** daughter. I knew you'd find your way back home (thank Adora for me, I'm forever in her debt).*

And please don't go around intentionally breaking your vows just to come see me. I fear Merlin won't be as forgiving the next time around, and I'm sure he isn't a fan of the stunt I pulled so I'm sure he'll be keeping a close eye on me moving forward.

Then again, who knows, maybe one day—if you play your cards right—you might end up here with me.

Until that time comes, I wish you the best.

Love, Mum

Catra reads the note a few more times before she lays on her back with the polaroid pressed to her chest. A warm feeling fills her stomach and, with Adora and Melog at her side, she feels at *peace.* And while she doesn't know what the next couple days will bring—

Catra plans on living *her* life.

Chapter End Notes

> Sorry for the late update, I planned on posting last week but I'm working on a personal writing project so these updates will start to vary in frequency. Anyway, here's some stuff I want to point out for this chapter:
>
> I wanted to create an opportunity for Adora and Catra to slowly shy away from work. The funny thing is, neither of them really cared much for their occupations (to the extent Glimmer and Bow suspect) and they were just using it to protect themselves from heartbreak. They still want to help people and do good, but they also understand they have to help themselves—by saving their relationship—before they can be of use to anyone. For Adora it's easier to see her stepping away from work because she won't completely be

done; she'll have Mara's position and oversee things from a macro-perspective. The end of Mara's arc helps Adora with the transition as well as knowing people like Frosta will take on jobs in the Ministry having pure intentions. I'd like to believe that the quartet closing the Bermuda Triangle case was somewhat of closure for Adora.

With Catra she gained closure on her family and learned that even though she doesn't have Cat's life—she ultimately has everything she needs and she shouldn't waste it. But this also has an impact on Adora: she became somewhat spooked when Catra's magical trace disappeared (bringing up those fears of Catra never coming back). They each have dangerous jobs but I think this particular mission showed them just how bad it can get; they only just realized this because normally they do missions on their own but this time they're leading one together. It's fair to assume they only care about each other's well being and not their own so when Adora saw Catra's condition it really marked her realization that: "we can't keep doing this forever".

They've been fighting their entire lives and, while the issue won't be fixed right away, they're slowly realizing there's more to life than constant conflict.

Adora starts to question their lifestyle in Chapter 18: "Into the Lion's Den" when she says, "...your job demands sacrifice, it's something I understand—I'm an Auror, Catra. There are things I can't tell you but it's part of our work…if you're actively seeking a reason for me to be put off by this then maybe you should consider whether this job is fulfilling your needs."

And, subconsciously, Catra starts to question it as well. She realizes that—yes, they're workaholics but, again, it's only because they've been using it to distract themselves from heartache. Then an opportunity to reopen their bond presents itself and suddenly giving Adora partial truths because of her work limitations becomes less important as

she worries about how long Adora will be willing to settle for them.

Anyway, two more chapters to go!

Thanks for reading.

...Since We Last Spoke?

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

17

There's a draft in the room, it slides across the floor and bites at her ankles until it works its way up to her neck. Adora does a full body shudder before she wraps her arms around herself like a mother swaddling her infant; she whispers a quick warming spell beneath her breath and sighs, relieved. Moments ago she felt like an eskimo embarking on a new ice mount, but now she tastes hot cocoa—like the mix Bow used to make on the coldest winter nights at Hogwarts. Adora would huddle by the fire in the Gryffindor lounge with Bow, Glimmer, and the others. She wishes she were there—no. Not there, not exactly. She still pictures the fire—and her friends, and, of course, the cocoa—but she also imagines Catra at her side, and Melog too, as they bask in each other's company. Yeah, that's what she wants right now. It's a much better scene than where she is right now.

Adora's shoulder's slump at the reminder.

She's in a room that smells of potion mixtures and raw wood materials, the ones found in marsh areas and used to concoct the most brutal spells. The space is akin to the waiting area at a doctors office, devoid of warmth or familiarity, even the walls are painfully laid bare, painted cream white, without a scuff in sight. Adora sits on a wooden stool that makes her arse numb, and pulls her left hammy taunt like the strings on a fine tuned guitar; one of the legs on the stool is clipped too short so she has to use her left leg to keep her posture up without toppling over on the tiled floor. There are cabinets lining the tops of the walls, nearly grazing the popcorn ceiling, each with a trace of a spell hovering over it—a protective measure to keep unwanted eyes from catching a glimpse of what lies inside. Adora shifts her gaze to the

work desk on her left; it's a black countertop with a wood cabinet section beneath it. Atop the workspace are empty beakers being used as paperweights, but what stands out the most is—

Swish. The eyeball inside the jar floats within an ominous green fluid—it follows her wherever she goes, just like the eyes in those paintings used in horror films. Red veiny lines wrap around the socket, akin to a viper ensnaring its prey; it sends chills down her spine. Adora looks away and stares hard at her blurred reflection in the shine of the floor. She chews at her nails even though they recede back into their bed, a sharp taste of iron makes her jerk her hand back as if she'd been slapped. Her breath stutters as she looks at her fingers, they're numbs, gnawed raw like the ends of an amputated leg. She doesn't bother healing them, sometimes she likes to feel *something.* It's a habit she's trying to break, but it hasn't been easy. She and Catra have actually taken some time off from their work schedules for a real holiday—dragons and scheming on the side explicitly excluded—but they still miss the rush of battle. Although, with Perfuma's help, they're working on finding a healthy in-between.

Watching muggle television has helped tremendously. They often live vicariously through the characters on horror shows, feeling a similar rush. It got to the point where Catra purchased a flatscreen to put up in the bedroom so they could binge *Dexter.*

Footsteps echo behind the door, Adora quickly wipes the blood into her pants leg then hides her abused hands in the pocket of her coat. Entrapta waltzes back into the lab with a clipboard and a pen handy; there's a streak of blue ink splattered across her face, like warriors paint. Adora doesn't think Entrapta cares much for the trivial issues that plague most women—things akin to appearance, or fashionable dress—so she does her best to keep from fussing over the ink splatters. Adora assumes she must look the same when she's out on the battlefield, but her streaks often allude to a hint of iron and a dash of fear depending on the state of her victim.

Entrapta stops in the middle of the room and looks down at her clipboard, the abrupt move sends her bulky work goggles sliding down her face but she's quick to brush them back to their resting place atop her head with the effort of a child pissing off their older siblings. She's muttering to herself, some science mumbo jumbo that makes Adora's head spin.

"Alright, I've adjusted those bolts on the freezer door so the temperature won't be acting wonky anymore. It would be terrible if the head thawed out before I could take a proper sample and do a thorough examination…" Entrapta looks up and asks eagerly, "Do you want to see the head before—"

"I'm good. Thanks." Adora says.

The head she'd been referring to was the Prime clone she and Catra used as their trump card for Mara's trial. With the remnants of Mara's magic leftover on the carcass, it was easy to declare her guilty for attempted murder and, eventually, treason. Adora's not afraid of the clone—she doesn't have any superstitions about touching it and causing some wild chain reaction that leads to Prime's revival…very specific what-if situation that's she's definitely *not* worried about (although, when she told Catra the same verbatim her girlfriend gave her a stifled smile so Adora doesn't think she believed her).

But the truth is the truth. Even if she has to beat it into her skull ten times over.

Adora clears her throat and asks Entrapta if she's gotten any further in her research. Entrapta's waning smile fills Adora with dread. *You knew this was a possibility,* she chides herself.

"I've run the data over a dozen times and the outcome is always the same, unfortunately." Entrapta tells her, "I've had the results for a month or two now, and I would have told you earlier but—"

"I was on trial for murder and treason." Adora shudders at the memory and says with a small smile, "I get it."

Entrapta hums. “I was actually going to say that you were hopping from country to country while you were on vacation and that long distance communication is *way* too complicated to get around if you want to reach someone in the Bermuda Triangle. But, tomato—tomato.”

Adora rubs her eyes and mutters, “So I’m stuck with him.”

Entrapta confirms that she is correct. “There’s nothing we can do about your connection with Prime, it seems to be a persistent force—probably his last strand of life that *refuses* to give up. It seems like he’s putting all the magic he has left into holding you captive.”

His last fuck you, Adora shakes her head, *what a sore loser.*

“Like any other Horcrux, only in the event that you die—”

“Will Prime be destroyed.” Adora says. It’s something she’s known since she was a student at Hogwarts so it’s not so shocking to think about but, then again, how else would someone cope with being a living vessel?

“Wait,” her curiosity peaks, “what about children? If I ever get pregnant will his magic be passed on to them?” The idea grips her heart in a vice.

Entrapta considers it. “With you, one hundred percent. With Catra —”

Adora’s face goes hot at the thought.

“—you two have rekindled your magical bond—”

“Wait,” Adora frowns, “how do you know—”

“—Scorpia writes me letters and Perfuma spilled the beans to her.” Entrapta continues her previous train of thought saying, “Because your bond is mended, your magic is somewhat *one—connected.*

So there could be a possibility of your child having a link to Prime in the scenario where Catra carries."

Adora hunches over in her seat, it fucks with her equilibrium and sends the stool swaying so she grips the sides of it with her hands, palms turning white as they bite into the wood, as she steadies herself. When she's on good footing again Adora allows herself to sulk once more. Passing this burden on to her child is not something she wants to do. But, at the same time, she's always pictured starting a family of her own—to correct the harsh traces that Weaver plagued on them by creating something *beautiful* and *loved.* A way to prove that their environment didn't ruin their chances of having a healthy future.

"...dora."

She holds up a finger and quietly apologizes to Entrapta while she retrieves the two-way mirror from her jacket pocket. A warm feeling encases her when she's greeted with mismatched eyes and a sea of freckles. Adora asks her to repeat her earlier question if she had one.

"No question," Catra looks over her shoulder, self-consciously, then turns to the mirror and confesses softly, "just wanted to check in on you. What's going on…oh, shut up Snowflake." Catra flips who Adora assumes is Frosta off.

Entrapta walks out the room, not because she wants to give her privacy but because she wants to get back to her lab and social situations make her skin itch sometimes. Either way, Adora appreciates it.

"Full house?" Adora asks.

"For me, yeah." Catra says, "I've got Lonnie and Frosta with me, we're questioning Allister about where he got those dementors he sent at us. Remember, the ones from his house?"

Adora recalls the bitter taste in her mouth when her soul was on the verge of being sucked away right before Catra rescued her

from despair. She still gets nightmares about that night, but they've lowered in intensity since she moved into Catra's flat. Adora has a suspicion that Catra is using her magic to cast her nightmares away; the idea fills her chest with warmth.

"Anyway, I'm trying to work on not getting my hands dirty as much with the day to day proceedings so I'm multitasking."

"You've got us doing all the work!" Lonnie argues in the background.

Catra shoots back, "I'm *delegating."*

Adora laughs. They share a few more words, just nonsense that doesn't go anywhere but fills her with joy just about the same. They decide to cut things short when Frosta almost blasts Allister's toes off when her spell goes haywire.

"I'll see you at home?" Catra asks.

Adora blushes. "See you then."

Catra looks over her shoulder before she says in a rush, "I love you."

Adora's face feels like it's on fire. "Love you too."

The room is lit up by a single bulb that flickers inconsistently and bathes them in an odd shadow thanks to the spider webs bannered below the ceiling like a hammock. Catra's nose twitches as she holds back another sneeze when the sharp scent of ash burns her nose. It's making her eyes burn too, if she focuses on her reflection in the glass she'll find a red tint gathering in the whites of her eyes, but she can't cause a fuss, this is Frosta's interrogation. It's just unfortunate that Frosta has a preference for fire spells when it comes to matters such as this.

A green flash lights up the room as Frosta cripples Allister with another spell to his stomach that causes him to shudder and

convulse until he's falling over as much as the magical bindings will allow him. He looks defeated, hunched over in the wooden chair with his arms binded at his sides by an invisible force marked in Frosta's magic. His bangs sway, odd strands are stuck together by sweat while the rest is askew. Catra looks through the glass divider as Frosta gears up for another spell, spinning her wand the way she's likely seen Catra do a dozen times over right before a fierce battle. This time, she doesn't fumble with the wand—she pulls the move off perfectly.

Catra's ear twitches as Lonnie walks up beside her. "She looks a lot like you. Don't you think?"

The spell slashes at Allister's arm and sends blood streaking across the gray floor. Catra's nose bunches up, it's better than another fire spell so she can't complain. And the bulging of Allister's eyes sends a rush through her veins. Catra has to stomp down the urge to let her magic come out to play. *You're only supervising,* she reminds herself, *this is Frosta's case now.*

Lonnie repeats her earlier question with a bit of attitude.

Catra shrugs. "How the hell should I know?"

Lonnie rolls her eyes. "Fine, that's actually fair. It's not like you've seen yourself in moments like this."

Catra thinks about the tournament replay clips they used to play all over the school the day after one of the trials. She remembers a gruesome one of her standing over an opponent with blood splattered across her face, her body hunched over as she heaved in selfish breathes, with a feral look in her eye. Micah and Adora were the only ones who could calm her down after a match—everyone else who approached her only added fuel to the fire. Catra's throat swells up, she turns her back to Frosta and faces Lonnie's depressed mug.

Lonnie's face wrinkles like the skin around someone's fingers after a long bath. "...shit, I'm sorry—"

“Will everyone stop apologizing when they mention that stupid tournament? I’m not a porcelain doll—I won’t crack under the tiniest pressure.” Catra can confidently say that for certain now. She adds, “Besides, I’ve been through tougher shit than that, don’t you know?”

Lonnie’s face smooths over, pressed clean like a newly made bed. She snorts. “Yeah, I think I’ve been through some tough shit too. Faking your death counts right?”

“I think it’s number one on the list.” Catra smirks.

The green flare from Frosta’s spell lights up the torture chamber with such brightness it has them turning their backs to the scene. Catra and Lonnie face the adjacent brick wall, the red paint looks darker under the green flare, even the shadows morph into a wonderful assortment of patterns and symbols. For a moment Catra feels like she’s at a light show, at awe with the performance, before the flare dies down and the sullen red brick glares back at her. A chill passes through the room and sends her shivering, she rubs at her arms and gathers magic into her palm to warm herself up. If she focuses enough, she can pretend Adora’s holding her.

Mwr. Melog, fresh in their natural form, bumps into her leg with a purr.

Catra looks down at them and smiles softly. “Yeah, we can get Chinese food this time around. It’s your turn to pick.”

Melog lets out a cheerful chirp, they rub against Catra’s leg to show their appreciation. Normally she’d get pizza after a night like this, but she hasn’t had any since the night that spell collided with Finn’s chest. It’s gotten to the point that whenever she walks past a muggle pizza store, her body trembles. But, she’s learned to stop blaming herself for something out of her control so, it’s not all bad.

Lonnie looks at her. “You can head out if you want.”

Catra whips her head to Lonnie with a frown. “What?”

Lonnie pivots her body to her, leaning against the cool glass, with a nod. "You said you were stepping away—that you trusted Frosta and I to handle the heavy lifting—so you should go. I'm sure Adora would be thrilled."

Catra's face goes warm so she hides it in a nearby shadow. "Adora's tying up some loose ends of her own right about now… and I want to see this one through, even if I'm not leading the case."

Lonnie hums. "How long are you two on Holiday for?"

Catra drums her fingers along her arm. "We plan to have an entire month dedicated to slowing down, but...with us, who knows?"

"Is slowing down a must?"

"Yes." Catra says.

Lonnie raises an eyebrow, mouth agape.

Catra chews the inside of her mouth. "What happened to me at the Bermuda Triangle was too close of a call, okay? Adora was down there calling out for me for Merlín knows how long while I was off living a fairytale—trapped in another dimension. We *need* this month to just...exist."

Lonnie nods. "And after the month is over? What then?"

Catra slumps back into the glass. Another green flash lights up the room. "Adora's going back to the field for a supervisor position overseeing the Junior Auror cadets, it'll be nice practice for when she takes over as the Director of Magical Security. And me...I'll keep my supervisor role, I'll look over certain cases that piqued my interest but I'll try to stay within the confines of the UK."

Catra doubts she'll be heading back to the states any time soon. Not if she can help it.

“Wow.” Lonnie smirks. “That’s as good as settling down for you two. Are you becoming a *housecat* now?”

Mwr. Melog taunts with a gruff that sounds awfully close to a laugh.

Catra’s eye twitches. She snaps her head to Lonnie with a glare. “Yeah? And what about you? I can’t see Ro and Kyle being okay with having you back in the field so soon. This is the first time they’ve let you out of their sights since the trial, right?”

Lonnie’s throat bobs. “It is, yeah.”

“...shit,” Catra sucks her teeth. “I’m sorry, I shouldn’t have said that.”

Lonnie holds up her hand. “It’s fine. To be honest, Ro and Kyle are still a little shaken up,” her voice trembles, “and sometimes Lucy asks me, *‘Mommy, are you going to leave again?’* but…”

Catra looks away and gives Lonnie time to steady her voice so she can form her words.

“I’m not going *anywhere,* not again. So I get it—about you needing to take this month to yourself to enjoy your life without having to look over your shoulder every five seconds. I’ve worked hard these last three months convincing my family of that, and it wasn’t easy, it’s still an uphill battle, but they can’t lock me up forever. I think they know that, so this is the first step…Kyle and Ro looked like they wanted to drag me back inside this morning but they *didn’t.* They trust me not to get in too deep and I’m not going to betray their confidence.”

“The same goes for me.” Catra bumps shoulders with Lonnie and offers a pinched smile. “I don’t mean to give you a hard time, I’m just making sure this situation works for you. I don’t want to do anything to tear you away from your family…not again.”

Lonnie punches her in the arm. “Shut up, arsehole.”

Catra's eyes go wide as Lonnie grabs her by the lapels of her jacket and pulls her in until their faces are close enough that she feels Lonnie's breath ghosting over her face.

"You didn't tear me away from my family, you *saved* my arse. When Mara had someone follow me in that bar—when I found out I was being followed—I knew my days were numbered. I took a chance and called you through the fireplace and you acted fast and you saved my life. It might've taken me away from my family temporarily, but it was a safe bet in making sure I got back to them with the threat neutralized and I…I don't know if I've ever thanked you for what you—"

"Lon." Catra grabs her hands and pries them off her lapels. "You're family. I'd do anything for you guys, and I know you'd do the same so don't thank me for something that should be expected of me."

"But—"

"No buts." Catra adds with a snort, "Besides, Merlin knows you've saved my arse dozens of times back at Weaver's place."

"We're *good."* Catra reiterates when Lonnie doesn't loosen her grip.

After a moment, Lonnie nods. The fight leaves her shoulders and she slumps back against the window divider. She tries to stir the conversation back to where they left off. "I let Ro and Kyle know that I'll only be supervising this little excursion of yours, and that Frosta's the one who'll be doing all the heavy lifting."

Catra says, "Okay, but if it ever becomes too much for you—"

"Catra. It's fine. They knew what I was like before they started a family with me. And like I said, I'm only acting as the supervisor—if Frosta needs help or has questions she can come to me—and then we'll go to you *only* if the situation seems dire. We've got this."

“I know you do.” Catra says.

The door opens with a *squeak* as Frosta walks in with a chilling smile, Allister’s blood stains the hem of her shirt—it’s wrinkled and mussed, like she got into a tussle. There’s a maniac look on her face, it’s cemented in her widened eyes, and Catra finally understands what aspect of Frosta mirrors Catra in her younger days. “I got an address out of him, it’s for one of the middlemen who helped supply Allister with those dementors. Apparently they live—”

“No, no, no.” Catra covers her ears to block out the rest of the information dump. “Write it up in your report to share it with Lonnie after I’m gone, I don’t trust myself not to jump into the rabbit hole on this if I’m given a clue.”

Frosta makes a show of zipping her mouth shut. When the air clears she gets an annoying look on her face that has Catra clawing at her pants legs. “So...how’s the wife?” Frosta smirks, cheeky.

Catra nearly chokes, her life could have been taken and meanwhile Lonnie isn’t bothering to hide her laughter, Melog’s cracking sly comments, and Frosta’s standing with her arms crossed looking damn proud of herself. There was a time where Frosta wouldn’t dare to crack a joke like that—the confidence she’s gained from her missions are backfiring on Catra, but she’s had years of practice so she snaps back just as quick—

“Speaking of significant others—how’s Alin doing? I’m sure he loves having you look after him so he must be pretty sour, not having you around as much as he’d like to.”

Lonnie snorts.

“W-What?” Frosta’s face turns bright red and it fills Catra with maniac glee. “A-Alin and I are just—business acquaintances! I helped rescue him from the Bermuda, he just trusts me is all…”

she starts fiddling with her fingers, eyes going wide as she begins questioning all things that make up the universe.

"Leave the kid alone before you make her combust." Lonnie says, slapping Catra on the shoulder playfully.

Catra shrugs. "She shouldn't try beating me at being a smart mouth."

"Yeah, that's obviously a losing battle." Lonnie chides.

Catra gives her the finger before she grabs Frosta by the shoulders. "All jokes aside…I'm proud of you, Snowflake. And I'm counting on you to make sure Lonnie doesn't fuck this up—"

Lonnie holds up her pointer finger. "Right here."

"—Allister may be the key to finding the whereabouts of more Prime loyalist groups so I'm trusting you to be on top of this. If you need help you can cultivate your own team, just make sure they're cut out for what the job entails. And remember, if you need anything—"

"You're only a Floo station away. I know." Frosta blinks her eyes rapidly, Catra pretends not to see the gloss that covers them. "I should be the one thanking *you.* I was just a stupid kid when I first met you—remember?"

"How can I forget?" Catra laughs at the memory. "Adora and I were called to Angella's office after some silly spat we were having—"

"A *spat?* You two were having a full on *duel* in the hallways!" Frosta says, laughing so hard tears stream down her face. "You were aiming for Adora when I got in the way—your spell nearly grazed me when Glimmer pulled me out of the way. I think my life flashed that day."

"To be fair, I *planned* on stopping it before Glimmer got in the way." Catra says, not knowing if it's a lie or the truth. She wasn't

as skilled as she is now back then so she can't say for sure if she would have been able to stop the spell, but she had planned on *trying.* "...we got our ears yelled off as usual, but thankfully we were saved by the Triwizard Tournament contestant announcement."

Huh, that tournament did her *one* favor, at least.

Frosta says, "I was staring at you during Angella's entire spiel. All I could think was, *I want to be as strong as her one day."*

Catra's eyes start to sting. She ducks her head, blinking fast, before she looks up with a steady smile. "You're a lot stronger than you think, Snowflake. And you'll only get stronger, I know it. There's no one I'd rather pass the baton to."

Frosta hugs Catra tight and whispers a few more words before they part. Catra shares a look with Lonnie—no words can be spoken to fully express all that they've been through so she doesn't bother tainting the moment with fumbled ramblings. With a final look to her team, and one more to Allister's defeated form—slumped over in his seat with blood seeping from the gash on his forehead—Catra leaves the room with Melog at her side.

Her curiosity about the case is put to rest as she walks forward.

18

Catra's flat smells of garlic and peppers, the smell slaps her in the face as she lets herself inside. She kicks the front door closed and hangs up her coat, damp from the torrent of rain, and toes off her boots to let them fall with a depressed *thump* near the coarse welcome mat Bow insisted on purchasing. *You need to liven up your flat! Make it seem…lived in.* was what he had said with a cheeky Glimmer at his heel. Catra mutters a few choice words for Glimmer as she walks into the kitchen that's separated from the living room by a countertop divider; she waves a hand, casting a spell to carry her grocery bags along for the ride. The heated

floors toast up the soles of her feet and fight off the night chill until she's feeling nice and warm.

"Thanks for watching the pot, chef." Catra says, petting Melog, who's lounging in one of the stools placed at the countertop.

Melog purrs under her touch, sending vibrations through her palm all the way to her elbow in a wonderful chain reaction. *Mwr.*

She could have used her magic to stir the pot while she was out, but Melog likes having a task to do these days now that everything in their lives is moving a bit slower. But, now that she's back, and now that Melog is dragging themselves to nap in the windowsill, Catra casts a spell on the utensils. While the groceries arrange themselves accordingly, Catra picks up the letters she grabbed from the mailbox and sits on the couch to shuffle through them.

The first couple are from the Ministry—some begging her to look into their cases, some asking for her expertise, while some are just highlights from the day to day excursions—the next one makes her pause. It's from Rosie. Catra opens it fast but takes her time reading through it; she smiles when she gets to the part about Rosie's mum loving the previous lunch outing the three of them had, and she laughs a little bit too hard at the silly retelling of an embarrassing moment Finn had once. Catra has to take a minute to calm her breathing—for the memory of the spell ripping through the air, colliding with his chest, to fade—before she continues reading. There's a bitter taste on her tongue, one not even a brillo pad could rub clean, but the letter ends on a high and she's glad to see that Rosie's doing well despite it all. The last letter is from Frosta, it's a quick summary, limited in detail for Catra and Adora's sanity (and temptation), about Allister's case. From what she's given, she can tell it's going well and she forces herself to believe that knowing that is good enough for her. For now, at least.

Catra calls an empty wine glass and a bottle of red to her while she writes back to Rosie and Frosta. She folds up the letters once

she's finished and sets them somewhere safe so she can bring them to the owlery once they've opened. Adora keeps pestering her to get an owl but Melog doesn't like to share and Catra isn't looking forward to coming home one day to feathers gnarled up in Melog's teeth or having them scattered across the floor like a pillow fight gone wrong.

Catra takes a sip of wine. The rich taste engulfs her taste buds, leaving them numb, as the fruity scent wafts up her nose. She closes her eyes to bask in the moment when there's a sharp *clang* outside from the metal gate enclosing her property, it causes her to jump. The glass slips from her hand and falls to the floor, it shatters. With a sigh, she waves a hand to silently piece it back together. She half expects a piece to be missing, like last time, but when she holds up the glass—all the cracks are *filled.*

Mwr. Melog taunts from the windowsill, hanging upside down with one leg slouched over the edge.

Catra sets the glass on the table harder than necessary. She shoots her familiar a glare and hisses, "I have *not* gone soft!"

Though, she fails to admit that there was a time where she wouldn't have leapt out her skin at the smallest sound. Her monthly sessions with Perfuma have helped tremendously, but she still has trouble realizing it's *okay* to relax from time to time. That the world isn't always out to get her. Besides, she fared better than Adora during the first week of their holiday; her girlfriend nearly tossed an old lady on her back when she got too close to them at the grocery store. They're still sending Mrs. Wilkin's flowers to make up for the scare. Poor thing, her blood pressure's risen since the incident.

"Surprise!" Adora announces as she lets herself in with the key Catra gifted her with. Bow and Glimmer rush in after her, shaking from the roaring wind that nearly sucks the door closed for them with a *slam.*

“You know I hate surprises.” Catra says, arms folded as she glares up at Adora.

“That’s why I planned one for you.” Glimmer taunts, helping herself to some of the potatoes Catra has cooking on the stove top.

Bow cheers. “You’re using the mat I got for you!”

“Yeah, well…” Catra trails off, shrugging.

Melog leaps from the windowsill to rub at Bow’s leg with a gentle purr. Catra looks away, face flushed, as Bow’s expression brightens. *I need a familiar that won’t rat me out by wearing my emotions on their damn sleeves.* Who’s she kidding, no other familiar would be willing to put up with her attitude.

“Don’t be mad.” Adora wraps her arms around Catra’s hip and pulls them in until their bodies are flushed. “They thought it was a good idea to have a movie night…I think they’re trying to make up for lost time. You and I have been busy in the past—”

“Understatement!” Glimmer shouts from the kitchen.

“—so it’ll be nice for us all to be together.”

“Yes.” Bow says, “And preferably without dragons or dementors being involved. Something low stakes for once.”

Adora winces through the silence. “Are you mad? You’re mad. This was a bad idea—I’m sorry we’ll just go and then—”

Catra cuts her off with a deep kiss. She pulls back, placing a chaste one atop Adora’s nose. “Don’t be an idiot, though, I know it’s a difficult task for you.”

Adora pouts, face flushed. “You’re really okay? I know how much you like your space.”

Catra ducks her head, smiling. "It's *our* space now...and yeah, I'm okay. Besides, a low stakes night sounds great."

Adora bites her lip, stifling a grin. "You sure?"

Catra nods. "Positive."

"Can you two stop being gross so Bow can give the brat her present?"

Catra lets the dig slide only because she's curious. "Another present? You don't—"

"I want to." Bow says, smiling, as he gives her a gift bag.

Catra digs inside and pulls out a black lined picture frame that's small enough to prop up on the dining room table. She frowns. "What's this for?"

Bow confesses, "For the picture your mom gave you…I thought it might be nice, for you to have it framed somewhere. And I got a smaller frame in case you didn't feel comfortable putting the picture out here for all your guests to see, this way you can maybe put it in your room—or somewhere personal."

Catra's throat bobs. "Thank you. I love it, honest…I'm just gonna put the picture in. I'll be right back but I'm good with whatever movie you guys pick, and the food should be done in five minutes." Glimmer works on getting the plates ready while Bow and Adora get the movie set up. Catra slips into her room in the back and pulls out the polaroid from where she had it tucked away in her bottom drawer by her bed.

The bed is cleanly made, a sharp indicator of Adora's constant presence because Catra's more inclined to leave her sheets askew. The sheets wrinkle under her weight as she sits on the edge of the mattress with the polaroid clasped in her hands. She lets the tear slip before she frames the image of her parents celebrating the days leading up to her birth.

“Hey.” Adora manages to get the jump on her as she pokes her head into the bedroom. Catra wipes her eyes with the sleeve of her shirt and carefully straightens her posture as Adora sits beside her. Adora brushes a stray strand of hair from her face and asks, “You alright?”

Catra picks at the loose string hanging from the comforter. “What are you, my therapist?”

“Nope. Perfuma would make you hold the talking stick before you could answer a question.”

Catra laughs. “She definitely would.”

Adora bumps shoulders with her and lowers her voice, “I’m serious…and I know you’re sick of people asking you that question but, I feel like I have to…”

Catra’s throat bobs. “I’m not going anywhere.”

Adora crosses her arms, her fingers twitch anxiously as her hip. “I know—and I trust you. I just…”

“Old habits die hard, I know.” Catra looks at her and promises, “But you don’t have to worry about me disappearing on you. And I *am* okay.”

Adora looks down, brow furrowed as she hugs herself tighter. “I know this isn’t the life you imagined for us—it’s not as exciting as the things you’re probably used to—”

“Hey.” Catra wraps her in a tight hug and whispers with conviction, “There’s nowhere else I’d rather be right now. Being here—being *present* with you—is *enough.* Remember what Perfuma said?”

Adora steadies her breathing and nods. She repeats verbatim, “We have to find other things in our lives that fill us with purpose __”

"If we don't, we'll get mournful when the *one* thing we're purposeful about fails us." Catra says, "I find purpose whenever I'm with you—no matter what we're doing, whether it's dismantling the Ministry's hierarchy or sitting on the couch watching muggle entertainment."

Adora's laugh fills Catra with warmth—it nearly overflows.

"You're *enough."* Catra says.

Adora kisses her hard, when she pulls back she promises, "You're enough for me too."

They sit there for a long moment, embracing one another as their tears subside. Adora helps Catra to her feet, she looks down at her girlfriend and cups her freckle ridden face in a delicate hold. Their foreheads brush as Adora says, "Now, let's go back out there before Glimmer guilt trips Bow into making us all watch a Romcom. I know how teary eyed you get towards the end of them."

In their own little bubble, separated from the rest of the world, Catra has the freedom to confess with an embarrassing whine, "It's just so *moving* sometimes! They had to go through *so* much just to get where they are."

Adora's teasing grin slips into something softer. "Yeah, I guess it hits a little too close to home for us, huh?"

There's a crash from the living room that has Catra and Adora reaching for their wands and rushing towards the sound with their spells geared and ready. They find Bow on his back, face twisted up in pain as he holds the back of his head. "Ouch."

"What's wrong?" Adora asks, frantic.

Glimmer peers in from the kitchen, "I think Melog thought they saw a mouse or something, they got all red and went zipping around the room—nearly almost took out the couch—they tripped Bow by accident during the fuss. Are you alright, love?"

Bow rises with a stagger and gives her a thumbs up, though he still appears nauseous. "I'm…swell…"

"They thought they saw a *mouse?"* Adora asks, lowering her wand as a grin spread across her face.

"Don't." Catra whispers to Adora but there's nothing that can stop the sly grin that stretches.

Adora sends a tickling hex Catra's way when she tries to tackle her to the ground. Her stomach is filled with fluttering butterflies that make her burst out laughing; Catra falls to the floor in the fetal position as Adora walks over her crumbled form. "Catra had a similar encounter with a mouse back when we lived at the orphanage." Adora informs them, barely holding in her excitement.

Bow's eyes light up. "Ooh! Are we getting a cute backstory?"

Glimmer's face scrunches up. "I'm not into cute backstories—not when I've seen what Catra can do with those claws…but, I'm always up for an *embarrassing* backstory."

"Adora." Catra says through her teeth. She tries to rise to her feet when Adora adds a little extra power to the tickling spell, it makes her topple back over. Tears burst from her eyes as her laughter grows louder.

Mwr. Melog looks down at Catra, shaking their head as she suffers a terrible fate.

I'm not getting soft! Catra uses their mental connection to rebuttal because she can't get herself to stop laughing.

Adora's grin widens. "It's a mixture of both."

Glimmer dashes to the living room. "I'm in!"

"Me too!" Bow exclaims.

Catra summons magic in her palm and presses it to her stomach when she gets the chance and dismantles the spell. In the nick of time she wrestles Adora to the floor, cupping her mouth to keep her from revealing one of her biggest embarrassing secrets. Bow and Glimmer join the tumble—although, she's not sure if it's to stop their roughhousing before someone gets hurt or to stop their roughhousing so Adora can retell the story. Somewhere during the tussle, Melog joins the fray and sends them all toppling over.

While the golden quartet laugh at Melog's antics, the moonlight in the bedroom peeks in from the blinds and casts a blue glow over the polaroid Catra now has framed on her desk—it shines in the darkness as the quartet bickers amongst themselves.

Chapter End Notes

I haven't posted in a while because I've been busy with studying and now I'm working on a personal writing project but I've come into some extra time. This week I've been low on creativity. I think studying for so long will do that to a person, so writing this chapter is me getting my feet wet again—back into the flow. I realized I'm terrible at describing scenery/five senses so I'm trying to get better at that, but it's hard knowing when to get into detail without it being boring. But, practice will help.

I'm not sure when the final chapter for this will be up because I outlined it to be relatively lengthy and I also plan on posting the Prequel: "The Champion" the same day this final chapter drops so it'll take some time, but it'll be worth it. I promise.

Anyway, I thought it was funny how Catra had Allister tied up at one of her properties since they caught him at his barn and how she avoided getting charged with kidnapping during the trial. Also, this title plays into the first chapter "How Longs it Been…Since We Last Spoke?". And sorry if this didn't have a lot of meat to it but this was me just tying up loose ends so there wasn't much to include in this chapter.

The last chapter will be the Epilogue and it'll be a bit of a time jump, so fun stuff to look forward to. It'll be bittersweet though. And the last bit of my take on the story will be posted in the notes section of the final chapter.

This is by far my favorite story I've written on this site because I feel like my storytelling/plot was the best it's been. It definitely holds a special place in my heart and has motivated me as a writer and I'm glad you all have enjoyed it.

As always, thanks for reading.

Epilogue - Next Generations

Chapter Notes

Adora = "Ma"
Catra = "Mum"

See the end of the chapter for more notes

0

The Vessel

Finn Grayskull-D'riluth shoved the looming double doors open and stalked out of the Great Hall with his fists clenched at his side. Gryffindor robes buckled in the breeze as he walked briskly through the hallowed halls, muttering an array of curses under his breath.

The sound of the double doors opening again echoed behind him. "Finn! Slow down!"

A sharp squeak bounced off the walls when Finn spun around. He looked up at Stormy. Despite the height difference, Finn put on his most menacing glower. "Why'd you stop me?" his voice cracked in frustration. It was an annoying trait he had picked up from his Mum.

Stormy's brow bunched up. "You're kidding, right?"

"I almost—"

"Got *expelled* ."

Finn rolled his eyes. "C'mon. I would've gotten a slap on the wrist, at best." Being the golden boy had its perks.

Stormy pressed his hands together, as if he were about to pray, and brought them up to his nose. His bulking shoulders lifted,

then fell, as he sighed. When he looked back up, there was a crinkle in the center of his eyebrows. It's been his tell ever since they were kids.

Great, Finn thought, *I'm about to get a lecture.*

"Look," Stormy lowered his hands, "just because your parents—"

"Don't." Finn snapped. "That's got *nothing* to do with it."

"It has *everything* to do with it." Stormy threw his arms up in frustration. An angry-red blush was working its way up to his nose. He looked so much like Aunt Glimmer when he was pissed. But Finn had seen Stormy in diapers, so he wasn't threatened. "Look, I get it, believe me, I do—it sucks having these *expectations* looming over your head. But just because someone says something about you doesn't make it true."

"So, what?" Finn scoffed, "I'm supposed to let it go? I'm supposed to let Xavier talk shit about things he clearly has no clue about?"

In all honesty, Finn didn't know why he was getting so upset. Xavier wasn't the first person to try and belittle Finn in front of everyone. As the prodigal child of Hogwarts, Finn had high expectations people wanted him to abide by. And they *always* compared him to his parents.

If Finn scored the winning goal in the Quidditch match, someone had to remind him that his Ma, Adora, had won the championship cup (in her *first-year* , nonetheless). And if Finn got caught pranking an upperclassman who had it coming, he had to sit in the Headmistress's office and listen to Angela rant about how his Mum, Catra, pulled a similar (more ghastly) prank in the past.

It was exhausting.

So when Xavier got in Finn's face, spouting the usual bullshit, he couldn't sit back and take it. But it was more than that. Something else—something *darker* —had fueled Finn to act the way he did. He could tell in the way that *darkness* clawed at his throat,

demanding to be set free. And of course his Ma had warned him about feeding into it, but Finn was weak, and *tired* , and he almost *snapped* . For a moment (it only took one), the darkness slipped past his lips and consumed him from the outside.

A particularly brutal spell had been making its way off Finn's tongue, but Stormy had stepped in to stop the homicide.

"Xavier's just pissed you scored a goal off him in the match yesterday." Stormy said. "Let em' talk. You know the truth, that's all that matters."

Finn felt his shoulders droop. He looked away. "It's just so… *annoying* ."

"I know." Stormy placed his hands on Finn's shoulders and squeezed, softly. "Just, *try* and ignore it."

Finn looked up at him. "How do *you* do it? Not let it get to you? And with that annoying smile."

Stormy shrugged. "I know I'll never be perfect like my mum and dad. They set the bar so freaking high. It's hard to get kudos for acing all your classes when your parents literally helped save the entire wizarding world from destruction…but I've stopped trying to compare myself to them. This is *my* life, y'know? Only *I* can live it."

Finn nodded. Stormy had a good—

"Ye—ouch!" Finn rubbed his throbbing forehead, "Why'd you flick me?"

"Cuz you said my smile was annoying." Stormy crossed his arms, frowning. "You're lucky that's all you got. My mum says my smile makes even Angel's cry."

"Course she'd lie and say that." Finn laughed. "You've got a smile *only* a mother could love."

Stormy's sneakers squeaked against the tiled floor as he lunged forward and caught Finn in a headlock. "Take it back," he demanded, tussling up Finn's hair with his elbow.

"Never!" Finn tried to paw at the arms engulfing his neck, but he knew it was no use. Stormy, despite his magical prowess, participated in a strict exercise routine. So the lock he had on Finn's head wouldn't be undone so easily. And Finn wasn't in the position to reach for his wand, so he flicked the sensitive skin on Stormy's neck with the tip of his tail.

Stormy let out a sharp gasp. He shot his head back and started laughing so loud the noise bounced off the walls. The abrupt movement caused Stormy to topple backwards, and Finn had no choice but to follow.

Finn wasn't sure how long they sat on their backs laughing up at the ceiling. But the moment was dashed by the sound of nearby footsteps.

A shadow fell over them. "What're you idiots doing this time?"

Stormy scrambled to his feet, red in the face, and made quick work of fixing his wrinkled Gryffindor robes. "H-Hey Flora. We weren't…n-nothing's going on."

Finn took his time and slowly sat up with his arms propped up behind him. It was a familiar scene: Flora catching them doing something stupid, and then Stormy getting flustered in his attempt to rectify things.

Here we go, Finn thought with a sigh.

Stormy's had a crush on Flora for *ages* . Finn honestly didn't get the appeal. Don't get him wrong, Flora was great. She had freckles splattered across her slim face with eyes the color of the forest. And while her fiery red hair had been frizzy and problematic growing up, it had long since smoothed out into something much more manageable. Today she had it tied back

into her classic french braid. The red settled well against her Slytherin attire and made her stand out in the best way.

But, no matter what, Finn would always see her as his childhood friend. The one he had bath time with when they were toddlers. The one he ran to when Aunt Perfuma was on the search for Finn after he accidentally over-watered her flowers (ever since then, he's been *terrified* of that woman).

The same applied with Stormy. Although, he had changed a lot over the years too. It took a while, but Stormy looked a lot like Uncle Bow. But he definitely acted a lot more like Aunt Glimmer when he was upset.

The dreadlocks Stormy had grown out over the years usually fell just a little past his ears, but he had them tied back into a high bun so they wouldn't get in the way during spellcasting. There were also two star designs buzzed into each side of his shaven head.

"Please." Flora rolled her eyes. "It's never nothing with you two." Flora held out a hand for Finn. "Come on then, let's get moving."

Finn took the hand Flora offered and stood. He dusted the grim off his robes, "Moving? What for?"

"Haven't you checked the time?" Flora gestured to the clock hanging high above a stack of silver lockers on their right. "The train should be here soon." The train she referred to was the Hogwarts Express. Summer vacation had finally arrived so students were all packed and ready to enjoy their break away from school.

Finn didn't need to worry about missing the train. His mums would be picking him up from the Floo Network system on campus. Something about his Mum saying, *I don't do public transportation.*

"It's time already?" Finn frowned.

Flora shot him a smirk. “Disappointed?”

“Why would I be?”

“Save it, Finny—”

“Hey!” Finn’s face flushed. He looked around, grateful to see that they were the only ones in the hallway. “ *Don’t* call me that here.” Being a hybrid-cat had its benefits and pitfalls. On one hand, he had enhanced senses and deadly instincts that could get him through the roughest situations. But, on the other…he had fluffy ears, and an even fluffier tail. It was hard to garner fear and respect when those two things were fighting against him. And if people found out about his childhood nickname? No one would ever take him seriously. “I have a reputation to uphold.”

“For real?” Stormy’s eyes glinted mischievously. “Last week you nearly tripped down the stairs because you thought you heard a mouse nearby.”

“You *swore* to never talk about it!” Finn had no clue where his aversion to mice came from.

Stormy shrugged. “Flora’s family.”

“Exactly,” she squeezed between them and draped her arms over each other's shoulders, “there’s no secrets between us. Which is how I know you’re gonna miss this place.” She looked at Finn, knowingly. “You act like you can’t stand it, but I know you love Hogwarts just like the rest of us.”

Finn couldn’t argue. “Duh. I get to learn all kinds of spells.”

Flora’s smile fell, just a bit.

Stormy shot Finn a glare.

“And,” Finn said quickly, “I get to see you guys. That’s why it’s the best.” It wasn’t a *complete* lie.

Flora's smile returned to its bright glory. She hugged them so tight their faces brushed hers. "This summer is gonna be awesome! And I finally got my license for apparition so I'll be able to pop in anytime!"

"You actually *passed* ?" Finn asked, outraged.

"Why so surprised?" Flora huffed.

"Last time you tried to apparate me somewhere I nearly got my tail chopped off."

Flora threw her hands up, "That's in the past!"

"Tell that to my medical records," Finn muttered under his breath.

"She has gotten a lot better," Stormy said in her defense. "So? What should we do first this summer? *Oh* ! I heard about this town in Romania that has these burrows that lead to all kinds of places. But, we might need to keep a locator spell on hand. I heard their disappearance rate is worse than Bermuda's. Or how about—"

Suddenly, the ground shook beneath their feet. Finn lurched to the left and kept his footing by latching onto one of the Ravenclaw tapestries hanging above a row of bleachers. Stormy and Flora latched onto each other, ducking their heads as gravel slipped out from the newly formed crack in the wing-arched ceiling above.

Finn looked up at the crack with narrowed eyes. Another mini-earthquake came. The crack in the ceiling ripped out further. *Something's going on upstairs* , Finn thought.

"What the *hell* was that?" Stormy asked, eyes wide.

"No clue." Finn grabbed his wand from the inside pocket of his robe.

Stormy shook his head. "Finn—"

“This is *our* school. It’s *our* job to defend it.” Finn took off, running around the corner and towards the flight of stairs that led up to the second floor. Finn heard footsteps close behind him, but he kept his eyes forward. A massive crowd of students came tumbling down the stairs. Their eyes were wide and frantic. Even the color from their faces looked like it had been drained.

“You.” Finn grabbed a Hufflepuff underclassman by the collar of his robe and pulled him close. He asked the kid what was going on, but words alone couldn’t break the faraway look that was glossed over his eyes. Finn snapped his fingers and raised his voice, “ *Hey* ! What’s going on? Talk to me.”

The kid flinched as if a bucket of ice had been sent down his back. The faraway look in his eyes faded. He licked his chapped lips. They trembled when he spoke. “M-Monster…it got Davie…we tried to help but…oh Merlin. It’s my fault. It’s all my fault.” Tears raced down the kids face. He balled up his fist and started slamming the butt of his palm into the side of his head. “I’m so weak…weak, weak, *weak* …”

“Gimme your hands. You’re not weak.” Finn said, voice firm and unyielding. “Is Davie alive? Did you see…” he couldn’t finish his train of thought.

The kid shook his head. “I-I don’t know…it got him by the leg and dragged him somewhere…I don’t know if…”

“Listen to me. I’m gonna go up there and take that arsehole down, alright? And if Davie’s *alive* , then I’ll do whatever it takes to save him. Got it?” Finn knew the importance of promises, so he wouldn’t ensure something he couldn’t. He couldn’t promise Davie would make it out alive, but he could sure as hell do whatever it took to save him.

“You won’t make it.” The kid slipped out of Finn’s hold and squeezed his fingers into Finn’s shoulders. The smell of blood wafted under Finn’s nose. “Just one *look* at it makes you want to

claw your eyes out…I only caught a glimpse of it and it made me want to pass out."

"What did you see?" Stormy's voice startled Finn. He and Flora must've managed to push through the crowd because they were standing on Finn's left.

The kid kept his haunted gaze on Finn. "I saw *antlers* , and a hunched over form made of *bones* so dark they reminded me of the night…and claws so long they scraped the floor with every step it took."

" *Wendigo* ." Stormy said, sounding breathless.

If Stormy said it was a wendigo, then Finn would believe him. Uncle Bow had taught Stormy all he knew about magical creatures. While other kids got bedtime stories about princesses who lost their slippers, Stormy got tales of marvelous beasts who lurked in the shadows (even though the most dangerous ones were the ones who hid in plain sight).

Finn looked at Stormy. "How do we stop it?"

A protest seemed to be itching on Stormy's tongue, but he stopped. Probably figured it would be better to help Finn. He knew, no matter what, Finn would race off into danger. So, he might as well do so with the right information. "The heart is the best way, but it's harder to get to. There's a layer of see-through bone harder than Teflon that protects it." Stormy said. "But fire works too."

"Don't even *think* about setting Hogwarts on fire." Flora hissed. "Even being the golden child won't save you from what Headmistress Angella would have planned for you if you touched her school."

"The heart it is." Finn shoved the kid down the stairs towards the rest of the crowd. "Go tell the Headmistress there's a wendigo on the loose." The kid hesitated. " *Now,* Hufflepuff!" When the kid

finally went off to do as he was told, Finn started racing for the top of the stairs once more.

When Finn reached the top, he stopped. His nostrils flared as a ghastly smell filled the air. A smell mixed with blood and pure *death* . The kind of smell one would expect from a rotting corpse. Without his say so, Finn's hands started trembling. He took a shaky breath and slowly turned towards the crippling scent. A sharp gasp nearly escaped his mouth.

There was a trail of blood on his right, marking the polished floors in a dangerous hue of red and black. It looked like somebody had been dragged across the floor.

Crack! A spine tingling sound echoed off the walls. It sounded like the cracking of bones, but there was no scream to follow. Finn squeezed his wand. Maybe it *was* too late to save Davie.

" *Please,* " Flora grabbed Finn's elbow and whispered, "tell me you have a plan."

Finn swallowed his fear and followed the trail. "We get the heart."

The trail led them to a dead end hallway. Even the lights had given up, barely offering them any coverage as to finding out what that shadowy figure hunched in the corner looked like. Finn almost didn't want to do it, but he raised his wand and whispered, " *Lumos* ."

" *OhmyMerlin* ." Flora's voice cracked.

The light revealed the wendigo hunched over with its face buried in Davie's split open stomach. A gaping hole, outlined with jagged tears, allowed blood and organs to spill out into the floor. But the wendigo didn't care for any of it. Instead, it used its canines to dig into Davie's ribcage. It latched on tight and then pulled until the ribcage came ripping out Davie's chest.

It tossed the ribcage over its shoulder without a care. *Clank!* Finn's knees trembled as the carcass of bones landed a few inches

from his feet. Blood splattered from it and marked each of them on their pants leg. A long lasting reminder of their failure.

Flora squeezed Finn's elbow. He wasn't sure if she was trying to get him to pull back because he couldn't take his eyes off the wendigo. Not when it was finally reaching for what it had been after—Davie's *heart* .

Finn felt the familiar chill creep down his spine right before the voice whispered in his ear, *you're really going to let that beast take his precious heart? You couldn't save the boy, but you could ensure his remains are intact so his family can give him the proper burial.*

The wendigo's claws left a deep gash in the wall as it reached out to grab the heart. It was disturbing, how a creature of such violence was attempting to handle his mauled victim's heart with *care* .

Coward, the voice taunted, *you're just going to stand there and let this happen?*

"I can't move my legs," Finn whispered.

Let me help you. The chill from his spine moved to grip his shoulders. Ma had assured him that Prime was dead. At least, in the physical sense. But at that moment, Finn swore it felt like Prime's hands were clutched at his shoulders just as clear as his voice echoed in his ears. *Just let me in…*

The heart sat in the dip of the wendigo's hand. It had what it desired, but it paused. Stormy and Flora's breath hitched as the beast cocked its head at them like an intrigued puppy. Finn felt bile rise to his throat. The wendigo didn't have a face made of flesh. It looked like it did at one point, but the flesh had been ripped clean off, the muscle too, leaving nothing but a cavity carved in with bone. In the center were two tiny, button-like eyes that glowed bright blue. A spark flashed in its eyes. It made Finn's stomach churn. *Oh no…*

The heart fell to the floor and the wendigo rose to its fullest height. The gnarled antlers scraped the ceiling as the wendigo slowly walked towards them. Its eyes locked on Finn, curious.

Flora's nails dug deeper into Finn's arm as the wendigo picked up its pace. Finn squeezed his eyes shut. He was pathetic. He made a huge show of being able to handle the situation, but all he managed to do was get his friends in danger. *I'm not strong enough* . Finn leaned into the feeling of Prime's cold hands grabbing at his shoulders.

Finn wasn't strong enough. But, he knew Prime was. And his magic could help, if Finn just—

" *Fiendfyre* !"

Pure heart engulfed the room, washing the feeling of Prime's cold hands away. Finn opened his eyes and gasped, " *Mum* ?"

Mum stood in front of them, dressed in her usual work attire: a loose fitting white shirt tucked into a pair of black trousers, equipped with black combat boots. A powerful torrent of fire was shooting from her wand, slamming right into the wendigo's chest. The attack sent the beast flying through the air, its back colliding with the wall behind it. Mum's spell didn't falter even as she glanced at them over her shoulder. She looked them all over, her mitch matched eyes quickly assessing the situation before she looked back at the beast. "Arrows, mind getting the kids outta here?"

"Got it covered, Cat." Uncle Bow suddenly loomed over them. His close presence filled Finn's stomach with ease.

"Dad," Stormy said, breath hitching with relief.

Uncle Bow pulled Stormy into a hug. "I'm here, bud."

"Sparkles," Finn followed his mum's voice, "help me out with this binding spell." She didn't look like she was in need of any help, but, then again, it's been a while since she's been in the field.

Well, that Finn *knew* of. Sure, there were stacks of unopened letters from the Ministry begging Mum to look into their cases. But he knew her thirst for mystery led her to dip her toe into at least one or two of those requests.

Aunt Glimmer appeared out of a cloud of glitter, right at Mum's left flank. "Where should we send it? Bermuda?"

"Nah," Mum said, "they don't need this monster lurking around while other creatures are actually trying to reform themselves. Let's send it to Pandora's box. See how handles the *true* evils of the world."

Aunt Glimmer took out her wand. Before Finn could watch the masters in action, Uncle Bow pulled him away with Stormy and Flora. Uncle Bow led them into the Gryffindor sitting room. The room was empty, most of the students were probably at the train station so they could enjoy summer break, but Finn spotted a familiar head of blonde speaking to the Headmistress in the center of the room.

Finn ducked out from Uncle Bow's hold. " *Ma* !"

" *Finny* ." Ma leaned down and pulled him into a tight embrace. She pulled away and cupped his face. "Are you okay?"

Finn felt tears prickle in his eyes. "It's all my fault…"

"Finny—"

"Davie's *dead* , all because I couldn't do *anything* ."

"It's *not* your fault, Finn." Headmistress Angella beat Ma to the punch. She walked over to them with her arms crossed at her chest. A frown wrinkled her features. "It would seem that the fault belongs to Mr. Axel."

" *Xavier* ?" Stormy asked, shocked.

Headmistress Angella nodded with her lips pursed. "It would appear that he didn't take too kindly to Finn scoring that goal over him at the last quidditch match. And when he couldn't get a rise out of you this morning at breakfast, he went out of his way to see what you'd do in a situation like this."

"That *arsehole* ." Flora snapped.

They all turned to stare at her, shocked that the daughter of Perfuma and Scorpia could emit such *fury* in just one word.

Flora flushed under their eyes and ducked her head. "Apologies for my language, Headmistress. But it just…infuriates me, that Xavier could be so *stupid* . Davie is…" a withered look crossed her face. And when it looked like it might consume her, Stormy stepped in to wrap his arms around her.

Flora gladly took cover into his chest.

"Believe me," Headmistress Angella said, eyes hotter than lava, "you're not the only one who's livid."

The doors leading into the sitting room slammed open. Finn slipped from Ma's grasp when he saw his other mum speed walking into the common room with Aunt Glimmer at her heels.

Finn met her halfway.

"Finny." Mum pulled him into a hug so tight Finn had to gasp for air. She pulled back, just as quick, and reached out. But, for a split second, she pulled back, nose scrunched up in disgust as she glowered at his Gryffindor robes, but she powered through. "No injuries…good. You okay?"

Not really. "Yeah."

Mum didn't look like she believed him. He was grateful when she didn't speak on it. "So?" Mum kept her arm around Finn's shoulder and turned her attention to Headmistress Angella. "What happened?"

Headmistress Angella explained the situation and how Xavier was to blame.

Mum shook her head. "Where did this kid even get a wendigo from?"

" *That's* a question for the Auror department." Ma supplied. "But don't worry, the moment we heard about the wendigo I got in contact with some nearby Auror's. They were able to sense Xavier's magical signature on the wendigo's trail and then followed it right to him. They should have him in custody as we speak."

"Wendigo's have been banned from London for *years* . Ever since the massacre in 09'." Uncle Bow said. "I hope this Xavier kid has a good lawyer."

"And answers about where he got that creature from." Aunt Glimmer added.

"Let's just be grateful he's a novice spellcaster."

"Love," Ma asked, voice soft, "what do you mean?"

"Think about it, Dora." Mum said, "This kid was after Finn. It only makes sense that he wanted to send the wendigo *after* him. Right before Glimmer sent it away, I caught a whiff of a failed tracking spell. It smelled a lot like Finn's magic signature."

Ma clenched her fists at her side. "I'll add attempted murder to the list."

"This is going to be a nightmare." Headmistress Angella rubbed her temples. Suddenly, she looked as if she had aged by decades. The hunch in her shoulders was telling. "Great…as if parents weren't already worried about sending their children to Hogwarts. My job is to *protect* them. How can I convince their parents I'll do just that when I allow things like this to happen."

"It's not your fault, mum." Aunt Glimmer grabbed Headmistress Angella's trembling hands. "And you're not alone. We've got your

back, no matter what."

Ma nodded. "And we don't exactly know what we're dealing with yet. So, for now, we'll try and cover this up until we have an idea of what the truth is."

Headmistress Angella frowned. "And when do we have the truth?"

Ma sighed. "We'll deal with it when we get there."

After Finn calmed down, Ma had one of her Junior Auror's take his statement. The same with Stormy and Flora. After that, the school was evacuated so a group of wide eyed Auror's could storm the place and begin their investigation.

"I made your favorite."

Finn snapped out of his thoughts. The apparition to the Floo Network Station had passed like a blur. He almost startled when he realized he was stepping out of the fireplace that led into their wide living room. Now that he thought of it, Finn could smell Shepherd's pie coming from the kitchen.

He smiled, softly. "Thanks, mum."

"Of course." His mum kissed his forehead, gently, then pushed a loose strand of blonde hair out of his face. "Go wash up. I'll fix you a plate."

Finn hesitated. "How long is Ma gonna be at the school?"

"Not long." Mum straightened up their shoes by the door then made her way into the kitchen. Her tail flicked lazily across the carpet as she disappeared behind the double door.

Finn puffed out his cheeks and released the air. *Mum never tells me anything about Ma's work.* It drove him crazy sometimes. But,

other times he appreciated it. He knew both of his mums had jobs that got… *intense* . So, maybe it was better if he didn't get involved.

Mwr. Melog jumped out from their usual lounging spot on the windowsill and rubbed their back along FInn's leg. They were clad in their Tom-cat form. *Mwr…*

Finn scratched Melog behind their ear, sighing. "I *know* she's doing it cuz she cares."

Melog looked up at him. *Mwr.*

"I wasn't *pouting* . And if you're just gonna tease me, then you can get someone else to scratch behind your ears." Finn ignored Melog's taunting and went to clean up for dinner in his room. *I swear,* he thought, *sometimes it's better not knowing what that cat's saying.*

No one had a logical explanation for why Finn could understand Melog. Well, Aunt Entrapta had an answer with a ton of big words that made Finn's head hurt. But, she explained the gest of it. Because Finn's magic was connected to his mum's, like her, he could communicate with Melog. It was something that drove Ma crazy. On her paranoid days she *swore* they were all talking about her in Melog's tongue. But Finn reassured her that Melog was just around to make sly comments about Mum that had Finn spitting out his drinks.

Finn desperately wanted a familiar. But, if his familiar cracked jokes on him the way Melog did to Mum…then he'd rather pass.

Finn changed out of his school robes and exchanged them for a shirt and sweatpants. On his way to the kitchen he found Mum knocked out on the couch with Melog curled up on her stomach. Finn rolled his eyes. *She's definitely working on another case.* It's the only time she took random nap bursts. Nevertheless, Finn found a blanket and covered the hybrid duo before helping himself to dinner.

It was weird sitting at the island counter alone. Someone was usually by his side. If it wasn't one of his mums, or Melog, it was Stormy or Flora. Or Uncle Bow and Aunt Glimmer. Sometimes even Aunt Frosta would stop by. Finn liked her the most. She was always willing to answer any questions he had about his mums. Namely, about all the adventures they got into when they were his age.

Finn was nearly done with his dinner when he heard the front door open, then close. "Ma?" he called out.

There was shuffling heard from the living room before Ma came waltzing into the kitchen. "I'm back." She let down her ponytail. Blonde hair fell past her shoulders and swallowed her collar. "Oooo, Shepherd's pie. You gonna share?" Even though she asked, she was already grabbing a fork and plate from the cabinets.

"No way, Mum made this for *me* ." Finn half-teased. He wasn't opposed to sharing, but Ma had a big stomach on her.

"I'll just have a slice."

Finn narrowed his eyes at her.

"I promise."

The hunched in Finn's back smoothed out. "Fine." His mums had *never* broken a promise with him.

"Thank you." Ma sat across from him and fixed her plate. "You okay?"

Finn dug his fork into his food, frowning. " *Yes* . I'm still okay." He was *sick* of people asking him that. Finn looked up at Ma, "How were Stormy and Flora?" With all the chaos, he hadn't gotten a chance to say goodbye or regroup with them.

"Fine. Aunt Perfuma came by to pick Flora up to go home. And Stormy went with Aunt Glimmer and Uncle Bow, of course. They

were a little shaken up, but they'll be okay." Ma said, "They're only an owl away whenever you want to talk to them. Or, you can always invite them to stay over."

"I know." Finn muttered before he gathered the courage to ask, "What's gonna happen to Xavier?"

Ma didn't falter as she took another bite. "I don't know yet. I've got Aunt Frosta on the case and—"

"But she's an *Unspeakable* ." Finn exclaimed. "Is it really *that* bad?"

A dark look crossed over Ma's face. It sent a chill down Finn's back. "Wendigo's are crafted from the darkest form of magic. They nearly destroyed everything. They're *supposed* to be locked away in Pandora's box but, somehow, Xavier got his hands on one. This case goes farther than anything a Junior Auror would be qualified to solve."

Finn frowned. "So it's something Mum would get her hands on. *If* she were still working."

" *If* ."

Finn sighed. Ma had a great poker face, so he couldn't gauge where this was going. And he didn't know much about Pandora's box. Just that it was meant to hold all the evils of the world. But he had no clue where this *box* resided, or how Aunt Glimmer and Mum were able to access it to send the wendigo back.

If it's a place for all the evils of the world then, Finn thought, *could I send Prime's magic there?* Maybe then, Finn would be freed from the hold Prime had over him.

"I need to talk to you about something else."

Finn looked at Ma's plate. She had hardly touched her food. "What's wrong?"

She laced her fingers and placed her chin on top of them. "Your mum told me she felt Prime's magical signature seeping off of you right before she casted her fiendfyre. Is that true?"

Finn ducked his head. "Ma—"

"Is it true?" she asked, softly.

"...I'm sorry."

Ma sighed heavily. "Finn, I *told* you, you can *never* —under *any* circumstances—let Prime convince you into using his magic."

"I just wanted to help," Finn's voice trembled. The tears he struggled to keep in early that morning were running down his face.

"Finny." Ma got out of her seat and walked around the island to pull him into a hug. She rested her chin on top of his head. "Look, Prime feeds off of you, like a host—"

A vessel. That's what Aunt Entrapta called it. Another holding place, just like all of Prime's other Horcruxes.

"He is nothing." Ma pulled away and cupped his face. "You hear me? He's *nothing* . Only a coward hides away in a *child* . Only a coward sits and waits until you're vulnerable to strike you down."

"But I'm not," Finn stuttered, "I'm not *strong* enough."

"You are."

"No." Finn shook his head. "Not like you…"

Her face crumbled. "You don't have to be like me."

"How can I not when *everyone* expects me to be?" Finn snapped. "Davie just *died* all because Xavier wanted to test the golden child. And of course I failed to do anything but just stand there and watch him be *devoured* right in front of me."

“Hey,” Ma said softly, but stern, “what Xavier did? That’s not on you.”

“But I was the *cause* of it!” Finn’s claws shot out so he balled up his fists so he wouldn’t lash out and do something he regretted. The smell of blood hit the air, but he welcomed the metallic scent just as he embraced the pain in his palm. “Davie’s dead because Xavier wanted to test the ability of the golden child, and I…I couldn’t deliver.”

Sometimes, Finn felt like he didn’t *deserve* to have his parent’s last names.

“You’re at school so you can learn to master your magic, not so you can throw yourself into danger.”

Finn whimpered. “Everyone expects me to be a hero—”

“You’re not.”

Finn flinched. He tried to back away, but Ma grabbed him by the shoulders and locked eyes.

“Your mum and I fought the battles— *we* were the hero’s—so *you* wouldn’t have to be.” Her eyes were begging him to understand. “Being a hero…it puts so much pressure on people. And you’re just a kid. So you should be a *kid* . Because your mum and I? And Aunt Glimmer, and Uncle Bow? We didn’t have that luxury. We lived our childhood looking over our shoulders, just waiting for the next shoe to drop. It consumed your mum and I so much that, when it was all over, we started *craving* that crippling feeling, because we didn’t know anything else. The war—the fighting, the *death* —was over, but your mum and I continued to race towards danger.” Tears welled up in her eyes, “And I…I don’t want you to *ever* feel like that. Because that’s a hard hole to dig yourself out of.”

Finn cleaned the snot from his nose with the back of his sleeve. “I get that but, I still have to be ready, Ma. Prime’s magic is *inside*

me.” Finn whispered, “I know you said you fought those battles so I would have to, but…one day I’ll have to. Right?”

Ma’s face nearly crumbled. Her throat bobbed as she swallowed back whatever emotion tried to crawl out her throat. “Hopefully it won’t ever come to that.”

“You guys won’t be here to protect me forever.” Finn argued.

“That doesn’t mean you’ll be alone.” Ma said, “You’ve still got Aunt Frosta, and Aunt Glimmer and Uncle Bow—and *so* many others.” She laughed, “And Stormy and Flora? They’re *never* letting you leave their sight once classes start up again.”

Finn frowned. “I know they won’t but…I don’t want them getting hurt. All this *darkness* follows me and…”

“Hey, I know it feels like you can’t let people in, because you’re worried they’ll get hurt, but things will be worse if you don’t let them in. Trust me. This isn’t something you want to do alone.”

Finn hugged himself. He couldn’t meet her eyes. Shame swelled in his gut. He couldn’t believe he almost let Prime get to him like that. “I’m sorry…I shouldn’t have—”

“It’s okay.” Ma hugged him.

“M-Maybe you should keep an eye on me? To make sure I don’t give in to him.” Finn wasn’t sure he could trust himself anymore. “Something that’ll alert you whenever I get that urge, or something I can use to contact you when I’m at school, like that two-way mirror you and Mum have.”

“Finny.” Ma tilted his chin to look up at her. How she could look at him with such faith and reassurance, after what he almost unleashed, was beyond him. “You don’t need a mirror. You *are* the mirror.”

Finn’s breath hitched.

“ *You* are what connects your Mum and me.” She explained, “We share the same blood. The same *magic* . Whenever you feel like you’re alone—whenever you feel like you’re about to give in—just close your eyes, and press your hand to your chest. Like this. Then breathe, and feel the magic racing through your veins.”

Finn did what she told him. He furrowed his brow. “It feels like…I can *feel* yours and mum’s magic signatures.” Finn looked at her, “How?”

“Remember the bond I told you about? The one that connects me to your mum? The same applies with you. So, if you ever need us, just reach out through our bond.”

“Is that how Mum knew about the wendigo about to attack me?” Finn asked, “Because she felt my emotions through our bond?”

Ma nodded.

Finn was about to ask how come he never felt it before. But then he thought back on his years at Hogwarts. He thought back to his first day in class, how he felt overwhelmed when, all of a sudden, a sense of *peace* engulfed him. Dozens of other memories flashed behind his eyes. The tears were welling up in his eyes again. Ma was right. Even when they were gone, his mums would find a way to protect him.

“I’m sorry.” Finn wiped his tears away.

“Stop apologizing. You have nothing to be sorry for, Finny.”

“I messed up. Well, I *almost* did. But I won’t do that again. From now on, I’m only gonna rely on *my* own power.” Finn said, “I *promise.* ”

Ma kissed his forehead. “I know you will.”

“That means you gotta teach me all kinds of new spells this summer.”

“Finny,” she sighed, “power doesn’t come from having an arsenal of spells at your disposal. It comes from mastering what little you have.”

Finn booed her. “You sound just like my DADA professor.”

“They’re right. You’re only a fourth-year. You should master the basics first.”

Finn crossed his arms, frowning. “But Aunt Frosta told me that Mum already knew *fiendfyre* when she was a *third-year* .”

Ma rubbed her temples. “And Frosta wonders why she’s not invited over,” she muttered under her breath.

“What was that?”

“Nothing.” Ma grabbed her half-eaten plate. “Let’s finish this up and then head to bed. It’s been a *long* day.”

Finn looked at the Shepard's pie. He almost wanted to hit himself on the head. “I should’ve known…Mum *always* makes my favorite when she sends you in to talk with me.” They shared a laugh. It lightened the heavy mood, but it quickly returned when Finn thought about his actions again. He thought he had realized, a long time ago, that he couldn’t be like most kids. Despite what his parents wished for him, one day, he would have to lead the next generation. So, until that day came, he had to make sure he was prepared for whatever awaited him. And he wouldn’t do it alone. While his parents were still alive—and for however long Stormy and Flora decided to put up with him—Finn would *thrive* .

“Ma.”

She looked up at him, a large chunk of pie stuffed in her mouth. “Hmp?”

“I meant what I said. About using my own power.”

Ma smiled. “I know you did.”

Finn wouldn’t let Prime get the best of him. *Never* again.

With that promise, Finn decided to delve deeper into the confines of his magic all while being under the protection of his parents. He knew he had big shoes to fill but, one day, when the need arose, Finn hoped the demeanor—and *power*— of his parents would be something he could *mirror.*

Fin.

Chapter End Notes

Thanks for sticking with me for this one, it’s been a great ride!

The next “chapter” of this will be called “Roll Credits” (it’s just my analysis of the story, with some hidden Easter Eggs in there). I’ll be going over what the key aspects of the story were, and where my head was when I was writing each chapter/interlude. If anyone's interested in me making that let me know and I'll post it sometime later.

If you plan on skipping “Roll Credits” (or if I end up not posting/making it) then I’ll summarize the conclusion here: In life, there aren’t always going to be happy endings. I wanted this story to have a bittersweet ending because it was realistic and tied into the theme. Sure, Catra and Adora got together, but there’s still always gonna be the threat of Prime coming back via the Horcruxes (Adora and Finn). And since they’ve passed on their magic to Finn, their child will have to carry the burden when they’re gone.

There’s always going to be a battle to be fought. But, we can still have beautiful moments and long lasting relationships while we’re fighting our way out of the storm. It’s all about making the best of what you’ve got. With Catra, she had to be willing to let her guard down and trust the people around her. For Adora, she had to learn how to stop going in alone (something she tries to teach Finn).

Also, if anyone’s curious: Finn is a fourth-year, Stormy is a six-year (acts like Finn's older brother), and Flora is a second-year (she’s the youngest, but she’s a lot more mature then both of them combined).

And I know I said I’d post the Prequel the same day as this chapter, but I’m gonna space it out instead. I would have written it but I know you’ve all been waiting for this final chapter so I wanted to get it out there. The prologue for the Prequel is basically outlined so it won’t take long to post it. I might post the new series by Friday or Saturday night. So just keep an eye out for it. It’ll be called, "Exploits of Power: The Champion."

Anyway, I hope you all enjoyed the ride. The "Roll Credits" section will be posted on some other time if anyone's interested in me making it.

As always, thanks for reading.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!